**so sceptical of love**

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# so sceptical of love

by arlelynx

Summary

Mydei doesn't think much of it when his class is one minute late.

But as the clock on his wall ticks away, signalling that now—after losing himself in deep thought over how to handle today's lesson—it's currently ten past the hour, he finally starts getting suspicious. It's normal for classes to overrun on occasion, gods, even he's even done it before. However, it's an entirely different thing when it's this much time that's gone by without any prior notice. Mydei pushes his glasses back up onto the bridge of his nose, as they've gradually slid down while he was staring at the worksheets on his desk.

He sighs, glancing at the clock once again. *Two more minutes*, he promises himself, and then he'll go figure out where the hells his class has disappeared off to.

# Chapter 1: chapter one

Chapter Notes

hi everyone! ヾ(≧▽≦*)o i've been teasing this fic for a while now on twitter, but it's finally here! the teacher x teacher au, hehe~

in this fic, mydei is 39 years old and phainon is 26. if that icks you out for whatever reason, don't bother reading lol. it's an age gap romance!!!

anyway, thank you so much to nina for editing, and midnight for cheering me on! couldn't have done this without you both!!!

this fic is almost completely finished being written, so i'll (try to) follow a 1-3 week upload schedule depending on how things go in between chapters.

thank you so much everyone, hope you enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

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He sighs, glancing at the clock once again. *Two more minutes*, he promises himself, and then he'll go figure out where the hells his class has disappeared off to.

In the meantime, he busies himself with sifting through worksheets. He might as well organise them now for when his class *eventually* turns up, after all. Mydei is beginning to get worried after this amount of time without hearing anything—he knows that nothing will have happened to them as long as they're on school grounds, but to not even get an apology or explanation email from their current teacher is making him feel slightly annoyed. Mydei checks his email inbox again one more time just to be certain, but no, there's still nothing new in there. Whoever they're with must not be aware of the time, or they're lacking in the competence area. He can't think of any teachers that he knows personally that fit either of those categories, which mystifies him even more to the situation.

The school day starts at 8:45 am, with form room ending at 9:00 am, and then leads immediately onto the first lesson of the morning which lasts an hour. Mydei at least knows that his class is already grouped up together for all their lessons, which can only mean that whatever is holding them up is happening to them all at the same time.

With another glance at the clock on the wall to check how much time has passed, he frowns when he sees that it's gone way past the original two minutes he allotted himself beforehand to wait.

At this rate, by the time the students arrive, the lesson won't even be worth teaching. He'd have no choice but to put on a history documentary of the topic they're studying this month—the Great Okhema War—which, as it turns out, the only copy he has exists in the form of a VHS tape that can

only be played on an ancient TV set that's currently collecting dust in the store cupboard at the back of his classroom. Mydei's pretty sure the set is about as old as some of his student's parents now—a fact that pains him to consider—but the department head has constantly and consistently refused to invest in newer versions of the curriculum material, so this is just what he has to work with.

Mydei sighs and runs his hands through his hair, pushing the light greying strands back into place which had come loose during worrying from his high ponytail. It falls right back down into his eye, showing he'd clearly not put enough wax in his hair this morning while styling it. Everything feels like it's going wrong today: his shirt feels too tight, his trousers too short, all despite being sure—no, *knowing*—he'd washed them on the right settings. He's not hopeless with household chores despite what some people may assume of him, especially his father who still relies on housekeepers to do most of his chores for him. His trousers feel a little tight around his thighs, but he's lucky that the kids are usually too busy staring at the interactive whiteboard or their books to notice how today, they cut a little too high above his ankles to be passed off as fashionable.

He knows he can't sit around doing nothing for much longer, so he sets off towards reception to enquire about his student's whereabouts.

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"Mr Kremnos?" Aglaea, the receptionist, says as he approaches her. She stops typing, the quick *clack clack clack* of her long fingernails coming to a stop. By the looks of the kid sitting in the waiting area sweating bullets, it's probably a late arrival she's noting down.

"Could I get the timetable for 11B? They've not turned up yet and it's been over twenty minutes," Mydei explains.

Aglaea looks concerned hearing that, her face creasing slightly as her eyebrows knit inwards. She nods, and begins clicking around the school's computer software to see what she can find.

"Mr Kremnos, I've found them. They're here in East Block's hall. It seems like they have P.E right now…" She squints slightly at the screen, leaning in closer as if to get a better look at some small print. "Hm, alright. I see. They've got a new teacher it seems, and from what I recall, today is his first day."

Mydei sighs. He feels like he's been doing a lot of that recently. They've all been there on their daunting first day of teaching, disorganised and trying to figure out everything all at once—but he's never heard of something quite like *this* happening before.

"Thanks, I'll go grab them now," Mydei replies, waving at Aglaea quickly as he leaves.

Aglaea tilts her head in goodbye without another word and goes back to typing, calling the student over so she can finish up the form for being late. Mydei heads off and wanders back down the corridor he's just come through. He's already in East Block, so the hall is only through a set of doors opposite him. He'd walked past it as he came towards reception, but he was so distracted by his own internal frustrations he didn't notice anyone even in there.

This time, as he gets closer, he realises that it is, in fact, in use. He speeds up, already seeing his class through the windows crowding around a large trampoline as someone jumps on it. It's clear as day that they're still in the middle of a lesson, and not even changed out of their P.E kits yet either. Adding that all up in his head can only mean that by the time they've cleared out and are back in their school uniforms, his period will be over and they would've missed the entire thing, all due to this new teacher's infuriating incompetence.

Even worse is that they're nearing exam season too, which is only a few months away at this point, and it's approaching so fast that even Mydei is beginning to feel the pressure of needing to cram in as much as possible to make sure he's covered all he can in order to prepare them. Studying a Great War is no small feat, and it takes a lot of time to unravel everything that happened—every cause, every consequence, every shifting alliance, and every turning point that shaped the course of the conflict. It isn't just memorising some dates or names; it's understanding why events unfolded the way they did, how the reigning leaders made their decisions, and what the outcome meant for the world that followed.

For exams, they'll need to be ready for all of it: the long-term tensions that set the stage for the war, the immediate triggers that pushed nations past the point of return, and the social and economic impacts on the populations involved. And Mydei knows that if they're going to pass—*really* pass, not just scrape by—they'll need to move beyond surface-level facts that they're currently at and learn to see the war the way the history exam paper markers will expect: as a complex, interconnected web of decisions, mistakes, ambitions and pressures. It's a lot to absorb, he knows, and even for his brightest students, the clock is ticking away for them.

Thinking of all this causes the anger in him to peak as he pushes the doors open, letting them bang against the wall from the force. He's prepared himself as much as possible to yell at the newcomer for not only wasting his time, but the student's time too, and that his irresponsibility is jeopardising their exams, and—

Every ounce of fight that he had leaves him in a single breath as he catches sight of the other teacher.

He's showing the students how to do tricks on the trampoline, from back flips to twists in mid-air that land him on his behind before letting physics do the rest and bounce him back onto his feet again. The grin on his face practically lights up the entire room, joyful laughter echoing in the large space as he clearly continues to enjoy himself. The teacher's soft, unstyled hair swishes and moves in a way that seemingly defies gravity each time he jumps a few feet into the air, two strands on the top of his head bouncing along with him cutely. He looks *young*, a lot younger than Mydei was expecting, which must mean he's potentially not only fresh on the job, but fresh out of university and teacher training too.

Mydei feels hypnotised at first, just by the way his body moves, practised in every way that shows how talented he is—so much so that it distracts Mydei from taking in the rest of him, too busy watching his performance. His mouth goes dry instantly from how much *skin* is on show—because he's fairly certain that the uniform the teacher is wearing would be dress coded immediately if he was a student instead. The shorts he's wearing are *tiny*, barely reaching mid-thigh, while everyone else has to wear knee length pairs. He's even altered his t-shirt as well, rolling the sleeves up to his shoulders and tucking them in so his arms are completely revealed.

Mydei doesn't think much to his build at first, but it's there when he flexes —*muscles*, so many, in his arms and legs and clearly in his torso when his dark blue shirt lifts up as he jumps around, too many abdominal muscles to count for the split second that they're on show for. Sweat completely covers his whole body, making his pale skin practically glisten silver to match his hair under the bright lights of the hall.

The kids look just as enraptured as Mydei feels as they all watch him finish his routine with a graceful flourish, light catching on him like he's stepped out of some half-remembered dream. His smile is so wide and bright that it steals the breath from Mydei's lungs, and the edges of his vision become softer, blurring, as though the world itself is quietly falling away until the only thing left in focus is the younger teacher—luminous, effortless, and too far away for him to do anything about it.

For a suspended moment, time seems to hold its breath with him. Then the sudden, exuberant applause from the students shatters the spell, pulling Mydei back to the present. The other teacher only makes the moment more surreal by dipping into a playful bow, thanking the children with that brilliant smile—as though he can't help but indulge them even further.

Mydei's earlier ire comes back in full force. Honestly, no matter how hot, charming, or… *stunning* the new teacher is, it still doesn't excuse how late he's made his students for his lesson. He crosses his arms over his chest, wincing internally at how tight his shirt feels across his biceps and shoulders with the movement. He'll have to check his washing machine's settings again when he gets home, maybe he put them on for too long of a wash…

Mydei clears his throat loudly, both to snap him out of his own thoughts and because no one has noticed him yet, still looming in the doorway. He forces a practised unimpressed look on his face when the teacher's attention finally snaps towards him, and *oh*—he was not ready for such a blazingly bright look aimed at him. The teacher's eyes are blue, so blue, with a pattern around his irises that he can't quite make out from so far away. It makes him want to get closer, to lean into his space and really see what's going on behind them.

The teacher watches him for a second, eyes wide and mouth gaping, before his mouth slams shut and confusion takes over, as if he's forgotten where he is.

"Oh, sorry! Were we too loud?" He yells, grinning and looking exactly the opposite of *sorry*.

His words cause the students to look over. "Mr Kremnos!" They all gasp at the same time, and they all look suspiciously sheepish at his sudden presence in the hall. He watches as a few of them glance up at the clock behind him on the wall that hangs above the doors. Ironically enough, it's the biggest clock in the whole school, impossible to miss or not be able to read no matter how bad your eyesight is. He knows his students are at least smart enough to be able to tell the damn time, and going by their guilty reactions, they had just chosen to ignore it and see what they could get away with.

Well, he won't be letting that slide, that's for sure. Mydei narrows his eyes at the other teacher, "Could you please tell me the time, Mr…?"

The teacher looks puzzled by his question and makes his way over, possibly so they don't have to yell across the room anymore. He bounds over the trampoline like an overly excited puppy, those silly two strands of hair still bobbing up and down, and comes to a stop when he's on the edge of the blue padding. He jumps down, landing with another preformative flourish that makes Mydei's lips twitch slightly.

"Just Phainon is fine," The teacher—*Phainon*—replies.

"So?" Mydei encourages when this *Phainon* isn't going to answer his other question.

Phainon runs a hand through his hair to tame it back down, and Mydei gets a waft of his scent. The smell of sweat mixed with deodorant should make him cringe and take a step back, but instead he wants to take a step forward. His eyes lock onto a stray droplet of sweat as it makes its way down Phainon's neck, only stopping in its tracks when it's absorbed into the neckline of his t-shirt. It's then that Mydei realises he's got a tattoo on the side of his neck, a blazing sun, and he for some reason wants to trace the outlines of it and see if he can feel them under his fingertips.

Mydei feels as though he's being reeled in hook, line and sinker for this man just from him standing there and looking at him. He tries very hard to claw back the iron will he's famous for around the school grounds, taking a deep breath and letting his eyes flutter closed briefly before he readies himself for another look at Phainon. He needs to ignore all the thoughts of how strong Phainon's thighs look, or how nicely defined his biceps are, or the sultry way his eyes curve up as they watch each other, all in order to continue this conversation.

Mydei clears his throat to distract himself as the silence stretches on.

"So… What?" Phainon finally asks in confusion.

Mydei feels his eyebrows twitch in annoyance. Trust him to find someone that's exactly his type, but is clearly lacking in the common sense department. "So, *Phainon*, would you like to explain to the year head why my students have missed their entire lesson, or should I?"

The previous bemusement in Phainon's expression completely disappears as his eyes flick up to the clock behind Mydei's head. "Oh shit—I mean, sugar! Oh sugar! Frick, I didn't realise it was that time already!" Phainon garbles, an utter train wreck that Mydei can't seem to look away from. Phainon's skin turns a pretty shade of pink, making him look even more flushed than he was when he was physically exerting himself.

Mydei doesn't even have it in him to be horrified by the language coming from a teacher while still in front of students, too occupied with the feeling of an oncoming headache as his temples twinge painfully.

"I really am sorry, um, Mr Kremnos," Phainon begins, his demeanour now matching his words as he uses the name the students said earlier. "Kids, go get changed now, quickly! I'll deal with putting the equipment away."

The kids all scarper out of the hall without wasting another second, giving Mydei nervous side glances as they run by. He's not a *scary* teacher by any means—or at least he hopes he isn't—but he's worked extremely hard to earn a healthy level of respect from everyone by using a firm approach to boundaries and methods. Despite this, some of the students still feel overly anxious towards him, and he's pretty sure it's more down to the fact that he rarely smiles or laughs above anything else.

"Phainon, you have to have at least one member of staff in each changing room to supervise them. Are Nikolas and Cipher even in the office right now?"

"Uh…" Phainon looks overwhelmed at his simple question. "I can go find them! I'll hurry the kids up, so you can all head back to your classroom."

Mydei pinches the bridge of his nose before pushing his glasses back into place. "You can't just leave the equipment unattended! I'll stay here while you go check in the office, and then Nikolas and Cipher can come deal with cleaning up instead. I think you and I need to have a little chat." He clicks his tongue in annoyance, feeling like he's lecturing a toddler.

Phainon looks like a wilted flower, drooping around the edges and even those strands of hair that he assumes usually stick up are curled in sadly. He makes a sorry sight overall, one where Mydei almost wants to console him and pat him on the head. Instead, he inhales quickly and surely, as seeing the way Phainon's relaxed aura has disappeared completely doesn't make him feel as righteous as he thought it would.

He leaves Phainon to stare at the floor with his thoughts for a moment, allowing Mydei to look over him again. He feels his heart rate pick up as he takes him in. He knows he shouldn't, but he can't help himself as his eyes rake appreciatively over Phainon's body and face. He has a broad set of shoulders, leading down to slim hips that are only emphasised by how tightly his t-shirt sticks to his skin. Mydei crosses his arms over his chest and shakes his head, demanding himself to remain professional. Tiny pinpricks of embarrassment erupt over his body when he realises that Phainon is staring at his biceps that are practically bulging out of his shirt at this point due to it having shrunk. He knows how ridiculous he must look because of it, but the attention on them makes him subconsciously flex his muscles.

Mydei watches as Phainon's pupils dilate as he swallows, his Adam's apple bobbing with the movement. If Mydei was ten years younger, and they weren't in the middle of a work domestic, he'd probably take that reaction and bask in it with a sly grin. Right now, though, he's only one year away from turning forty, and with his greying hair and crow's feet that are starting to set in despite his ritualistic skin care routine, he hesitates. There's some form of *interest* in Phainon's eyes, that's for certain, but it's probably nothing more than friendly admiration. He knows Phainon's type—gym obsessed (just like him), loud without much substance (not like him at all), and worst of all, probably straight (*definitely* not like him).

Mydei exhales, reeling himself back into 'teacher mode' to stop any more damning thoughts from flooding in. He's still on duty after all, and he isn't being paid to check out hot, younger men in his area, no matter how much he wants to appreciate the teacher before him.

"Phainon, you need to go make sure that Nikolas and Cipher are with the kids now. I'll supervise the hall until you're back."

Phainon jumps, his whole body reacting like he's been electrocuted. His ears turn red, and they look so warm they're practically glowing. He nods vigorously, running out of the hall without another word.

Mydei grits his teeth, frustrated at himself. He should've just stayed in his classroom, minded his own business and sent out a few enquiring emails from the safety of his desk chair instead. The kids would've arrived eventually, he assumes, and then he wouldn't have had to meet Phainon who is already turning his brain to mush.

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It doesn't take long after Phainon has sorted everything out with Nikolas and Cipher to have all the students safely herded off towards the history department by one of the TA's from the art department upstairs. Mydei waves them off and tells them to sit tight in his classroom until either the bell rings, or until he rejoins them.

Phainon hides behind him like a scared child, somehow completely covered by Mydei's slightly bigger frame. He's acting as if he's quiet enough then maybe Mydei won't notice him and can get away from the incoming lecture. Just as his class disappears out of sight, Mydei rounds on Phainon immediately and pins him to the spot with a glare.

"Office. Now." Mydei demands, storming off towards the P.E office. As much as he'd love to chew him out right then and there, some students are milling about and he doesn't want it to become any more of a spectacle than

it already is bound to be with his class being notorious gossips. Even if he doesn't personally report it, word alone will get back to the year head and headteacher, causing them a whole load of trouble either way.

Mydei can't help but feel a little queasy at the thought of the headteacher—his *father*—calling Phainon in to berate him for his mistake.

"Look, Mr Kremnos, I'm really sorry…" Phainon trails off, unsure, as soon as the office door shuts behind them. Nikolas and Cipher are handling the equipment now, so thankfully they're alone in the room.

Mydei breathes out harshly from his nose, placing his hands on his hips as he turns his back towards Phainon. He needs to try and calm down, and he can't handle this properly if he's angry. He reminds himself that he can make or break Phainon as a new teacher with how he reacts, and he really doesn't want to do anything that'll cause harm in the long run. Mydei remembers how impressionable newbies are, even he was back in the day when he first started with only his father's tutelage behind him—and he doesn't want to knock Phainon's confidence so badly that he's left with nothing to support himself.

Mydei starts slowly: "I understand that you're new. We all make mistakes, I still make them even now and I've been teaching for as long as some of these kids have been alive for. However," Mydei steels himself and turns around to face Phainon again, and the sight of his slumped shoulders makes his heart clench against his will. "*However*, making students miss a whole lesson without any prior warning, especially this close to exams, cannot be tolerated."

Phainon nods, shoulders caving inwards even more so than before with the weight of his words. The fight in Mydei completely disappears, as if someone blew out a candle. "I'm guessing this was your first class completely unsupervised?" Mydei asks him.

Phainon looks up, his gaze hesitant, but he nods to confirm.

Mydei shakes his head, more at himself than at Phainon. "I'll see what I can do. You won't get fired, if that's what you're worried about."

This time, Phainon's shoulders slump with relief.

Mydei continues, "Thankfully, the kids are safe and they were looked after the whole time. It's not as though you left them unattended for any period of time, correct? We just might need to work on adjusting their timetables for next week to double up on history and no P.E, but I'll liaise with their form tutor to handle that."

Phainon stays quiet, his gaze lingering on Mydei's face as though he's searching for something there. Mydei isn't sure what he's looking for—pity, maybe, or some gentler kindness—but he knows Phainon won't find either. After a long moment, Phainon's expression softens and he offers him a small, sincere smile. The sight of it stirs something in Mydei's chest he thought he'd forgotten how to feel, unfurling quietly inside him like a flower waking to the sun.

"I'll still have to report this, though," Mydei says, stomping down on the feeling inside his chest. "You'll probably be called into the head teacher's office to discuss it, but that's about it."

"Shouldn't I be the one to say something? It was my fuck up, after all," Phainon says.

"Stop swearing on school grounds," Mydei snaps, rolling his eyes behind his glasses. "I said I'd deal with it, so I will."

Mydei hopes Phainon doesn't argue. He's too exhausted after all the emotions he's been going through within the last twenty minutes since meeting the younger teacher. And he still has a full day ahead of him, much to his dismay.

"But—" Phainon begins, but Mydei waves him off.

"You can just buy me a drink as an apology for all this," Mydei says before his brain catches up with him. He feels his cheeks warm at the forced offer, and he can't tell whether he hopes that Phainon will say yes or no to him. Saying yes would only mean one thing—spending time together outside of a school setting. Saying no would save him *a lot* of trouble, but something deep within Mydei's gut swirls, something small yet no less dangerous: *hope*.

Phainon's eyes light up at that, "I used to be a bartender, y'know? How about I *make* you a drink instead?"

Mydei raises an eyebrow, suddenly feeling like he's about to play right into one of Phainon's whims. *Hope* continues to bubble low and silent inside of him as he answers, "What if you're a shit bartender?"

A shocked laugh leaves Phainon at the curse word, but he doesn't call Mydei out on it. "No way! I was the best in town, people used to flock just to see me mixing," He raises his hands in the air to imitate using a cocktail shaker, but paired with the cheeky grin on his face and the way his hands are circled around an imaginary object, the action just makes something hot pull behind Mydei's navel instead. Repulsed with himself, he shoves that feeling as far down as it can possibly go, never to see the light again if Mydei can help it.

"You're not from here, then?" Mydei questions, genuinely curious. He's not surprised, he supposes—Phainon has *small town guy* written all over him, having not succumbed to the big city's pressure yet to conform. People like him stick out like a sore thumb when they first move to Okhema, and Phainon is no different.

"Oh, uh, no. I'm from Aedes Elysiae, a small farming village. I only moved here a few weeks ago."

Mydei tilts his head to the side, "Never heard of it."

"I'd be more shocked if you had!" Phainon says, laughing.

"Look, then I'm going to say this to you now for your own good," Mydei begins, seriousness dripping from his words. Phainon's eyes widen and he looks minutely shocked at the tone change, but Mydei continues, uncaring: "Word gets around extremely quickly about people here, but especially if you're new—always assume everyone knows everyone, okay? You need to make sure nothing like this ever happens again."

Phainon rubs the back of his neck sheepishly at the warning. "Why do you make it sound so threatening? It's just a small city."

Mydei sighs, "It's precisely because we live in a small city that it's like this, and I don't want your reputation ruined on your first day over something like this."

"Oh," Is all Phainon says. He looks a little taken aback, but he clearly understands now. "Okay, fine. How about I pinkie promise it won't happen again?" Phainon holds up his hand, sticking his little finger out.

Mydei stares down at it, considering his choices. "I'm not some child that needs placating," He snips.

It's not a no, per se. He could easily reject it and ignore Phainon's offering, but that'd probably lead to him looking sad again, which Mydei doesn't want. Not because it makes *him* feel bad or anything, of course, but just because that's a lot more of a nuisance than happy Phainon.

"Never said you were, Mr Kremnos," Phainon replies, waggling his finger around. "C'mon, don't leave me hanging."

So, after a few seconds, he indulges Phainon and hooks his own pinkie around the other's.

"What am I going to do with you?" Mydei murmurs under his breath, but it's clear from the grin on Phainon's face that he heard. Phainon tightens his finger around Mydei's and gives it a firm shake before letting go.

"Yeah, yeah. You can go back to your class now. You've got…" Phainon looks at the clock on the wall beside them, "Nine minutes until the bell rings."

Mydei narrows his eyes at him, but there's no real heat behind it. "I wonder whose fault *that* is."

Phainon doesn't reply, instead he's laughing as Mydei walks past him. He lets their shoulders brush against each other despite there being plenty of space for them not to, and the touch alone sends a *zing* of pleasure down his spine. He already wants to turn around again, just to get another look at those blue eyes and pale skin, but he keeps walking instead.

Admittedly, their paths will probably never cross again. They're in two completely different departments, and at opposite ends of the school. They won't even see each other during weekly assemblies as neither of them are form tutors, and the P.E department shares the same block as the art rooms

upstairs, so they have their own separate staff room to use rather than the general one near West Block. Unless Phainon wants to make the six minute walk across the school grounds to use it, then the chance of them bumping into each other is practically non-existent.

*It's probably for the best,* Mydei tells himself as he reaches back for the door handle, ready to pull it shut behind him. He's halfway through closing it when, without warning, the door is wrenched open from the other side. The sudden force jerks the handle in his grip and sends him stumbling backwards with a sharp gasp, completely thrown off guard. He flails for balance, but instead collides hard into something behind him—going from the loud *oof* he hears, he assumes that something is Phainon.

The impact knocks Mydei even more off centre than before, sending a fresh wave of chaos through the moment as the world tilts in an instant of startled, breathless confusion. Phainon exclaims in surprise again, the momentum of Mydei clashing into him making him stagger back too. Phainon reaches up to steady him, grabbing a hold of him by his biceps.

It works, and finally Mydei is stable as his heart races a mile a minute at the shock, stunning him silent. He can't do anything but blink owlishly behind his glasses as he tries to get his brain to stop rattling around inside his head from the flurry of quick movement.

He's somehow back inside the office now, the door wide open from where it was flung back against the wall. Phainon seems equally as shaken as he feels, but instead of silence he begins laughing nervously. Mydei's back is completely flush against Phainon's torso, so much so that he can feel every ridge and bump of muscle and each shaking breath he takes as he calms

down. Phainon squeezes his hands around Mydei's biceps in what he *thinks* is supposed to be his attempt at comforting him, but he still doesn't let go.

Mydei clears his throat, desperate to get out of Phainon's hold and away from his curious hands, but Phainon cuts him off before he can say anything.

"Whoa," Phainon whispers, sounding distracted as the tips of his fingers dig into Mydei's skin through his shirt. "You're seriously ripped, Mr Kremnos." His touch toes the line between pain and pleasure, and it makes something blazing hot churn inside his stomach.

"Phainon," Mydei grinds out, hoping the younger teacher will hear the warning in just his name alone and let him go. He can't tell if Phainon is making fun of him or just being incredibly obtuse to their positioning, and living up to his earlier assumption of him being loud without much substance between his ears.

He doesn't get a reply, but instead feels an appreciative sigh brush past his ear that makes goosebumps ripple across his body. Mydei's eyes widen and his lips part in shock as his cheeks turn red, and he has to leave immediately before he does something stupid. Something stupid like pushing Phainon up against the stupid door and pinning him there, forcing him to keep those stupid wandering hands to himself so Mydei can do something else even *more* stupid, like lean in and—

Phainon practically throws himself back suddenly, but thankfully Mydei has plenty of core strength to stop himself from falling back again. He stands up

straight, brushing invisible lint off his shirt; a motion that he only does to help ground himself after he feels his whole world has been turned on its axis.

He glances over his shoulder to glare at Phainon for his reckless actions, but he's so red in the face it almost looks painful.

"I, um, just wanted to say thanks. For having my back on this."

Mydei grits his teeth and wills his own blush to disappear already, and for his treacherous beating heart to *stop*. He faces forward so Phainon can't see his face, and they're far away enough now that there's no way he'll be able to hear his heart racing. "Just make sure the drink you make me is extra good."

Phainon laughs, and while he still sounds embarrassed, the tension in the room dissipates. "Alright, deal. You'll have to tell me what stuff you like so I can make it for you."

"Hmph," Mydei says, already beginning to walk out the room. "You'll have to take a guess for yourself. Good luck with your next class." He finishes, not bothering to wait for Phainon to reply as he briskly makes his way back to his classroom.

He makes it back to his classroom within record time, practically skidding through the doorway, and the moment he steps inside, the silence hits him. His students sit frozen, unnervingly well-behaved, and not a single one of them dares to make eye contact. He thanks the TA as they slip out—finally freed now that he's returned—then he turns his attention back to the room.

They're all in their assigned seats for once, which would be impressive if they didn't look like they were waiting for a firing squad. Their backs are so straight it's almost painful to look at, every kid braced for doom as if he's about to announce a mass expulsion of the entire class.

Mydei sighs softly and presses two fingers to his temple, rubbing slow circles in an attempt to chase away the tight band of tension already forming. He can feel the beginnings of a headache lurking—one of those unwelcome ones that seem to appear more and more often these days, triggered by barely anything at all. Getting older, he's learned, means migraines don't need dramatic reasoning anymore; they just show up uninvited at the slightest hint of disorder… and, frankly, he teaches plenty of that.

"Can someone tell me your P.E teacher's surname, please?" Mydei asks once he's standing in front of them all, his hands now settled low on his hips.

The class all look between themselves, a few of them putting up their hands shakily. Mydei points at a random one.

"He's called Mr Khaslana, sir," She says quietly.

Mydei nods in thanks and continues, "I'm guessing you all knew Mr Khaslana's class had run over." He doesn't get a response to that, which he was expecting. "To be clear, none of you are in trouble. It's Mr Khaslana's duty to manage his time better, not yours. So you can all calm down."

It's clear that's what the students were hoping to hear, and their spirits lift immediately. Suddenly, the room is buzzing with activity.

"We were just having fun, Mr Kremnos! We would've felt bad if we had to cut him off," One of the students says, making Mydei's eyebrow twitch. Why do they make it sound like their teacher is an overly energetic dog rather than a fully grown adult?

"And he was hot," One of the girls at the back chimes in, causing her friend group to all begin giggling and talking amongst themselves. The volume in the room suddenly skyrockets with the debate surrounding Phainon's looks, everyone apparently needing to add in their agreements to the statement.

Well, Mydei can't disagree with what they're all saying, but he isn't going to let it slide, either.

"Alright, save that kind of talk for break time!" Mydei says, raising his voice to be heard above the student's chattering. Phainon has caused more of a stir than Mydei originally thought, but looking at their faces it was a *good* thing instead. They haven't looked this carefree since they were freshly back from the summer holidays, so seeing them all buzzing with

something that isn't nervous energy about exams has Mydei's heart softening a little.

The bell rings a few seconds later, signalling the end of his class. The students all begin to stand up to leave, but Mydei holds his hand up.

"I didn't say you could all leave just yet. Sit back down."

The class harmonises in their groans at being kept, but they all sit back down dutifully anyway.

Mydei rolls his eyes at their dramatics, "You'll all have to make up for the lesson you missed today—" An uproar cuts him off, but he shushes them immediately. "Gods, I'm not asking you all to stay after school. I don't want to stick around with any of you either."

That garners a few laughs, of which Mydei is secretly very proud of. Maybe the laid back atmosphere of Phainon's lesson has rubbed off on him as well.

"We're closing in on exams now. Whilst physical activity is important, you don't have any studying for that to do. Next week your timetables will be altered, and instead of P.E you'll be coming straight here for a double lesson. I'll let your tutor know and they'll send out the temporarily amended sheets to you all."

The class remains silent, some bobbing their heads in understanding, but most of them are clearly waiting to see if Mydei has anything else to say.

"Alright, clear off, you lot. I'll see you on Wednesday."

The class bustles with noise and movement, their voices layering on top of each other as they all shout their goodbyes and various farewells until his classroom is empty again. Mydei watches as the last one leaves, the door slamming shut behind her. He flops down into his desk chair, leaning back in it so he can stare up at the ceiling.

He already wants to see Phainon again.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

let's be friends on twitter/x!

# Chapter 2: chapter two

Chapter Summary

> His eyes scan over the document a few times, cataloguing every conflicting period or times where they're both free. Maybe he can come up with an excuse? Like suddenly visiting Cipher who he's best friends with (her words, not his) and have an impromptu catch up with her while Phainon is in the P.E office at the same time. Then, they'd get talking, and then—
>
> Ah, who the fuck was he kidding?
>
> A wave of grounding realisation washes over him as it suddenly sets in what exactly he's been doing: sitting in bed before 8pm, going crazy over a timetable of a guy he'd only met *once* and who is, he assumes, practically half his age.

Chapter Notes

> yippee chapter two is here! thanks for all the love on chapter one, i really appreciate it and it means so much to hear that people are already invested in these two's love story ♪(^∇^*)
>
> thank you so much everyone, hope you enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Oh, Mr Kremnos, good morning. You're early today," Aglaea says from behind the receptionist desk.

Mydei nods at her and rubs his cold hands together, wishing he brought his gloves with him. He'd left them at home and hadn't thought about how chilly it was this morning until he was already in the car and starting the

engine. He'll live, he supposes, as he can just turn the heating up in his own classroom until he thaws back out again.

"Good morning," He greets, walking over to her to sign in for the day.

"Actually, if I could have a moment of your time, I have something for you," Aglaea says, standing up elegantly from her seat as she turns around to grab something from the printer beside her. Mydei's eyebrows rocket upwards in curiosity—it's not often, if ever, that Aglaea ever stops him for anything more than a quick 'good morning' greeting, and certainly not for anything to give him.

She pushes the glass screen open between them and slips a piece of paper over towards him. Mydei looks at her before looking down at it, and his eyes widen when he sees that it's a timetable. "Oh, is this the new one for my students?" He asks.

"No, I'm afraid not. That's going out later today. This is Mr Khaslana's timetable."

Mydei frowns at her in confusion but picks the timetable up anyway, peering down at it over his glasses to read the bold print. The name at the top reads *Phainon Khaslana*, confirming it is indeed his timetable. "Has he already lost his?" Mydei asks.

"No," Aglaea replies simply. "I thought you'd might want to have it."

Mydei pauses, glancing up at her curiously. "Why's that?"

"Well," Aglaea begins, sitting down again in her desk chair. "Mr Khaslana has been around here a few times asking after you, so I gave him your timetable. I hope you don't mind—"

Mydei shakes his head, mind racing. Phainon was *looking* for him? What for? Why? And how does that correlate to Aglaea giving him Phainon's timetable? "I don't mind, I just don't understand."

Aglaea hums, a small smile curling at her lips. She always seems like she knows something he doesn't, and this time it's a lot more obvious than usual. "I think he's looking for a friend, and you're the perfect person to guide him."

"*Me*?" Mydei says incredulously. He puts down the timetable and slides it back over to Aglaea, "I don't need this. Shred it."

Aglaea pushes it back towards him. "That'd go against the wasteful printing policy. It's already there, so just take it. Maybe you'll be able to sync up on your free periods together."

"You—" Mydei sighs sharply, a twang of pain going through his temples. He lets his shoulders drop, and takes back the piece of paper, handling it like gold. "Fine."

"Thank you, Mr Kremnos. I hope you have a great day," Aglaea says, perfectly pleasantly.

Mydei nods, "You too," And takes his leave, staring down at the timetable in apprehension.

---

The afternoon following Monday morning's fiasco goes smoothly. Mydei doesn't bump into Phainon at any point—not like he wants to anyway, he has to keep telling himself—but he's starting to get *restless*. Every time he gets a glimpse of the colour deep blue, the same shade as Phainon's P.E uniform, his heart rate doubles immediately until it falls again when he realises it isn't him.

Currently, he's drafting the email to send to the headteacher and the year head to officially inform them of what happened yesterday. He finds the year head's email quickly, Miss Caenis being relatively near the top of the contact list. He scrolls further down until he reaches K, watching the cursor hovering menacingly over his own father's name next to the 'headteacher' title. Mydei isn't sure if Phainon has an email set up just yet, and can't find him on the staff contact list either. He knows he can just Cc Cipher in instead and ask her to let Phainon know, but as he sits there staring at the blank email, he finds that he just wants to see Phainon even more.

There's technically nothing stopping him from doing that—especially after this morning. He feels the paper timetable like a lead weight in his pocket,

burning a hole through his trousers and singeing his skin with shame. He sighs, removing his glasses for a few moments to rest his eyes before he forces himself to finish the email. In the end, he copies Cipher in and leaves a note at the bottom to let her know to pass it onto Phainon whenever she can.

He wants to show his father that he's capable in his role, that he can fix not only his own mistakes but other's too without needing any guidance. He hopes that whatever he's managed to type out in the email lessens the blow for both of them. The risk of being called into the office makes him feel a little off centre, but the thought of Phainon going in there alone makes him feel even worse. He presses send quickly and relaxes back into his chair, and tries to ignore his brain shouting at him to seek the younger teacher out and his impending headache.

He's not going to listen to that little voice no matter how loud it tells him off.

---

Subject: Late class

To: Eurypon Kremnos, headteacher / Caenis, year head

Cc: Cipher, P.E teacher

—

Hello all,

I'm emailing to report an incident which occurred yesterday morning. During first period, Mr Phainon Khaslana accidentally ran over the allotted time and disrupted my lesson so nothing was taught. We are altering the student's timetables next week to rectify this issue by doubling up on history and reducing their P.E lessons temporarily.

Thank you,

Mydei Kremnos

History department @ Chrysos Secondary School

(Cipher, if you could let Phainon know about this email and its contents, I'd much appreciate it.)

---

Mydei sits in bed, the covers pulled up to his waist as he stares down at the offending piece of paper. He hadn't found the courage to open it up on school grounds, too paranoid that for some reason it would cause Phainon to burst through his doors and interrogate him on why he has a copy of his schedule, despite it not even being *his* fault that he has it in the first place. Honestly, what was Aglaea thinking?

The lamp on his bedside table is probably too dim for reading now, especially with how bad his eyesight is getting, but he perseveres. At this point in his life, Mydei honestly thought ageing would be the least of his troubles. By now, he'd hoped to have settled down with a husband and a

legion of cats and be happy enough with his partner to be distracted from the silver streaks in his hair and his aching bones.

That's all he really wanted, despite how much his father had tried to drive him away from it to focus on his career instead. He always expected Mydei to take over the school as the next headteacher, or at least become a member of the board so the family could remain holding the majority of influence over it like they'd been doing for the past fifty years.

That vision had never suited him, nor interested him, no matter how many times he tried to bend and break himself in order to make it happen—all to satisfy his father. It hadn't interested him when he was a child, being brought up to be a strong leader, and it hadn't interested him when he started teacher training either, too focused on wanting to get his degree for becoming a history teacher instead. That's where his real passion lies—in history, in what it tells the future generations and how it shapes the world. He loves working with his students too, old enough to behave but still young enough to have a chance to change.

In the end, the only thing Mydei is still willing to give his father is to remain in the education sector, but he rescinded his agreement of taking over. Regardless, as Mydei is practically forty and the other doesn't seem to be slowing down well into his sixties, it doesn't look like something is going to happen anyway. His father seems to run on nothing more than spite and greed to keep his title of headteacher, and the oversized and extravagant leather chair he sits on in his office is nothing short of a 'throne'.

Well, it seems that neither of them get what they want in the end. Mydei doesn't have a husband and cats, and his father doesn't have a willing heir. So as far as Mydei's concerned, they're even.

He brings Phainon's timetable closer to his face, squinting at the small font and tilting it more towards the light so the shadows don't completely hide it. Mydei isn't even sure what he's going to do with this knowledge anyway. He could know Phainon's whereabouts by heart and it still wouldn't change a thing—the fact that they'd maybe only have a few chance encounters over the years but nothing more. He's not willing to go out of his way to 'bump' into Phainon or orchestrate anything unnatural, no matter how much he's tempted to.

His eyes scan over the document a few times, cataloguing every conflicting period or times where they're both free. Maybe he can come up with an excuse? Like suddenly visiting Cipher who he's best friends with (her words, not his) and have an impromptu catch up with her while Phainon is in the P.E office at the same time. Then, they'd get talking, and then—

Ah, who the fuck was he kidding?

A wave of grounding realisation washes over him as it suddenly sets in what exactly he's been doing: sitting in bed before 8pm, going crazy over a timetable of a guy he'd only met *once* and who is, he assumes, practically half his age.

Mydei groans, covering his face as if to block out the shame. He winces at how smudged his glasses are going to be from that, so he tosses them along with the timetable vaguely in the direction of his bedside table before turning the lamp off. He ignores the sound of his glasses hitting the floor as he burrows under his duvet.

Mydei's shame from that night doesn't ease off, and it only gets worse as the days pass until it's finally Friday.

He climbs out of his car, flinging the door shut and locking the door behind him before he realises he's left his satchel in the passenger seat. He sighs, pressure building up behind his eyes from lack of sleep and the sharp spike of anger at his actions. He's already *done* with the day, wanting to go home and snuggle up under a blanket and read a good book. He's glad he mostly has free periods today so he can ruminate in peace over his woes. Mydei walks around the other side of the car, unlocking it again before snatching his bag up with a little bit too much force than was needed. Mydei finishes it off by slamming the car door shut even harder than before.

"Damn, what did the car do to you?" A voice comes from behind him, making him jump slightly. He turns around quickly on the balls of his feet, heart pounding from the scare until he catches sight of who it is—and then his heart is pounding for an entirely different reason.

"Uh oh, what's that look for? Are you still mad about Monday?" Phainon winces, and all Mydei can think about is the fact that he's in those stupid tiny shorts *again*, even in the middle of the coldest spring they've had in decades. Phainon's legs are completely bare, and the only thing that can provide him any amount of warmth is the socks that come up to mid-calf and the thin hoodie he's got on, but even that's left undone.

An icy wind whips around them, and Mydei shivers even under a thick winter coat and scarf.

"Uh… Mr Kremnos?" Phainon says hesitantly, adjusting the strap of his backpack that's slung over one shoulder. With his other hand, he waves it in front of Mydei's face. Mydei snaps out of it, but in a knee jerk reaction he glowers at Phainon. "Alright! Sorry, I'll go." Phainon throws his hands up in surrender, taking a few steps back to leave.

Panic instantly sets in within Mydei's stomach, making it feel as though he's standing on the precipice of a ravine with nowhere to go but forward. "No, wait," He pinches the bridge of his nose and scrunches his eyes shut to give himself a few moments to gather his thoughts. "It's just been a rough morning."

Phainon hums as if he understands, but the sound is distant from how far away he is now. He looks unsure if he should approach again. Mydei makes the decision for him and presses the button on his car keys to lock his doors before he takes a step forward, closing the distance spanning between them.

Mydei realises this is it—the chance he's so desperately been waiting for; the one where he finally has Phainon in front of him and hopefully willing to stick around to chat for a bit.

"How have your classes been going?" Mydei asks, figuring this is the safest bet to start a conversation.

Phainon grins, his face brightening as he sheds the previous uncertainty. "Good! No one's been late since, at least. I even have a timer set now so that I don't run over again." He laughs, clearly still embarrassed by what happened.

Mydei raises an eyebrow, slightly impressed. "Very forward thinking of you, Mr Khaslana."

Phainon's cheeks turn rosy at his praise, a small smile forming on his face instead of the beaming one. It's no less blinding though, making Mydei's insides feel like they've been scrambled up and left all out of place.

"Oh, thanks. I made a joke to Cipher about it, but she said it was actually a good idea. The kids make fun of me for it every single time, but I suppose that's how they are at that age!"

Mydei feels every unpleasant feeling in him slip away from being around Phainon—this morning's stress and the hours he spent tossing and turning agonising over what he should do completely washes away in the face of Phainon's sunny smile. It warms him up from the inside out, making his thick coat and scarf feel like too much now that he's here. Sweat pinpricks at his hairline.

"You say that, but you can't be much older than them," Mydei replies.

"Hey, I'm not *that* fresh out of school. I'm 26, which to them means I'm practically in my grave," Phainon says, chuckling lightly.

Mydei scoffs, "You haven't heard anything yet until they start making fun of you for turning grey."

"Are you going prematurely or something?" Phainon asks, tilting his head slightly to the side. It's clear that delicacy isn't one of his strong suits.

"I'm 39, Phainon. I think I'm well within my rights to start going grey," Mydei replies, shaking his head slightly, his braid swishing to and fro with the action. He prefers to keep his hair up in a bun while he's at work, but today he decided to leave it down and do his tried and true classic braid up for comfort.

Phainon blinks a few times at him, cheeks reddening. "Oh," He says softly, more to himself than Mydei. "I think it suits you, y'know? You've got that whole suave gentleman vibe going on. Plus, I can barely see it, your blonde hair is already so light."

Mydei doesn't want to touch that with a ten foot pole. Phainon is *26*—that's 13 years between them, which is how old the majority of his students are.

"Anyway," Mydei begins, trying to change the topic while ignoring the jittery feeling in his stomach. He looks Phainon up and down in continued bafflement. "Aren't you cold? Why are you wearing *shorts* when it's barely even two degrees out?"

Phainon rolls his eyes as though he's being told off by a parent, and Mydei belatedly realises he's slipped into the tone he uses with naughty students.

"I would ask if you're warm, but considering how terribly you've tied your scarf, I'd be surprised if you said yes."

"Excuse me?" Mydei replies, eyes wide as he reaches up self-consciously to touch his scarf, "What's wrong with it?"

Phainon stares at him dead on, making Mydei bristle at the judgement. He wants to argue, to settle into the challenge that's clearly being presented to him by the younger teacher—but he has to remind himself that *he's* the older one, that he's supposed to be setting an example and leading the other. Still, he grits his teeth, but his eyes go wide in shock when Phainon makes a grab for his scarf. It catches him off guard when he uses the grip on it to haul him a few steps closer, their shoes nudging each other as their chests bump. It reminds him of Monday when he'd gone falling back into Phainon's chest like some fair maiden swooning, and a frustrated red blooms across his cheeks at the thought.

"HKS!" His mother tongue curse word slips out on accident, and Phainon looks up at him in shock.

"What was that? Hai—" Phainon tries to repeat it, but the intonation is all wrong.

"*HKS*," Mydei repeats slowly, cutting him off. "It means *scoundrel* in Kremnoan."

"Oh?" Phainon grins cheekily, giving Mydei's scarf a few playful tugs. "I'm a scoundrel to you?"

"You're definitely *something*," Mydei responds gruffly, clicking his tongue in annoyance.

Mydei stands stock still, but Phainon shuffles backwards a little to give them both some room. It's too late to do anything, so Mydei stays where he is, staring at Phainon instead as there's not really anything else to look at, not that he's complaining much.

He's usually a lot more precise about his appearance, almost to a concerning degree, but this morning was one thing after another and he'd just chucked the apparent offending item on without thinking too much about it. Mydei definitely hadn't thought he'd bump into anyone this early, let alone bump into *Phainon* specifically.

Phainon begins fiddling around with the material, unravelling it carefully before redoing it. "Do you still need your mother to dress you or something?" He asks teasingly.

"My mother's dead," Mydei replies flatly.

Phainon's hands pause in their movements for a split second, but he carries on after as if nothing happened. Mydei cringes internally, unsure of why he said it so bluntly and harshly that it inadvertently shut Phainon out. It was going so well, too, well—he thinks it was, anyway; despite cursing at the younger teacher.

"Sometimes Cipher likes to do it for me, though."

Somehow, that's worse than anything he could've said. He should've just stayed quiet and let the moment pass, but now Phainon probably thinks he's a pathetic old man who can't do anything by himself, and—

Phainon's hands are shaking so much that he can't carry on, and Mydei realises he's *laughing*. At *him*.

"What a baby! Maybe I swooped in at the right moment to save you from this dreaded scarf then, hm?" Phainon says, and his eyes practically glitter with mischief in the low early morning sun.

"Cipher likes messing around, and that includes disrupting my appearance," Mydei deadpans, ignoring the burning of his cheeks as Phainon continues to crack up.

"She always ruffles my hair," Phainon replies, pouting slightly. "But that's how she shows her love, right?"

"We assume so, yes," Mydei says, a small smile forming on his face as he remembers how she used to do that with Castorice, their literature teacher, before they got together, figuratively and literally pulling on her pigtails to make her notice her.

"Alright, Mr Kremnos, I think your scarf is almost all ready to go," Phainon says, glancing down at it again to do any finishing touches, tidying up the knot so it sits nicer against the base of his throat.

Mydei can't stop looking, eyes trailing slowly all over Phainon's face. From this angle, Mydei can see how long his white eyelashes are as he looks down, fanning delicately across his lash line. He spots a little dip in the skin between his eyebrows, so small that at a distance it wouldn't be noticeable, but from this close he can see the scar clearly. Mydei wonders where it came from—how long he's had it for, what caused it. He also wonders if he traced his fingertips across it, would he be able to feel it under his touch? Or is it so shallow that he wouldn't feel it at all?

He suddenly feels overheated, and he's not sure if it's just because his scarf is done up properly now or because of his wandering thoughts. Mydei had hoped that the next time he saw Phainon, the things he felt during their first meeting was just a fluke—that he was just caught up in a multitude of other emotions and things got horribly crossed along the way. As he watches Phainon, though, with his little furrow between his brows and the slight pout he has on as he concentrates, he feels that pull begin to bubble up again.

Phainon glances up at him, startling Mydei out of his reverie. He's finally finished tying his scarf, giving it a few satisfactory pats before moving backwards, once again broadening the distance between them. Mydei hadn't

realised how *warm* Phainon was pressed up against him until it's gone, causing a chill to set in. Phainon gestures his hand towards the scarf to make Mydei look at it, to which he can only blink down at it in awe at how nicely it's tied. He wasn't expecting that.

"You still owe me a drink," Mydei says instead of thanking him.

"*You're welcome*," Phainon replies, stressing the words sarcastically. "I'm sure you win all the ladies over with manners like that."

"I don't—" *like women*, is what he wants to say, but he's cut off by Cipher as she comes barrelling out of the reception doors and runs to them within record speed.

"Phainon!" She yells, skidding to a stop beside them. "What are you doing out here? We have a department meeting in five minutes!"

Phainon's eyes widen in shock, making it clear that he'd obviously forgotten about it.

"Oh no, I thought that was next week. See you later, Mr Kremnos!" Phainon waves a hasty goodbye as Cipher grabs onto his wrist and drags them back into the building.

Mydei stands in the same spot for a few moments longer, letting their interaction settle in. Phainon is the human equivalent of a bull in a china shop—rushing head first through every interaction and leaving a mess of destruction and confusion behind him. At least, that's how it's been for both their meetings, Mydei surmises as he ponders on it. He's starting to feel like being out of his depth while around Phainon is going to become a common thing in the long run, if they ever meet again.

Mydei shakes himself out of it and looks down at his wristwatch, cursing under his breath when he sees the time. His morning routine is completely ruined from the impromptu meeting with Phainon, something that he can't even be mad about as he rushes towards his classroom, giving Aglaea a quick wave as he passes her. He now only has ten minutes instead of thirty to set everything up, which means cutting some corners and hoping for the best. He should be angry, he knows he should. He should be doing a lot of things—like probably holding a festering grudge against Phainon for causing him a slew of unneeded stress, but when he reaches to take his scarf off, he can't bring himself to unravel it.

It stays exactly where it is, firmly and neatly tied around his neck, tucked gently between the lapels of his suit jacket, even as his class comes flooding through the doors.

---

Done with the first half of the day, Mydei strolls into the staffroom for his lunch break. He gives the room a once over to see who's already in there, and spots Castorice and Cipher sitting at the corner table by the window, huddled up together as they look at something on Cipher's phone.

Mydei makes himself a cup of tea before walking over, taking his time to let the tea leaves steep in the hot water before taking them out. He dumps a few teaspoons of sugar into it and fills the rest of the mug with milk, putting it back in the mini fridge between the counters. He places the mug on the table before sitting down. Castorice and Cipher both look up at him at the same time, scarily in sync as usual. Mydei grimaces at the action before he peers over the phone they're both holding onto to see what they're looking at.

"Tut tut, nosey!" Cipher chastises, putting away her phone before he can see it.

"I don't care anyway," Mydei snaps back. Castorice smiles while Cipher frowns, and he mirrors Castorice's expression towards her immediately. "How are your students doing, Cas? They had mocks today, right?"

Castorice shrugs minutely, "Same old, as usual. They're still arguing over which sonnets they do and don't like, but at least they're passionate about it!" She clasps her hands together enthusiastically. "How about your students?"

"They're fine. Still struggling over some of the concepts which is to be understood—I'm still fighting the department head to try and get a damned DVD player into the classroom rather than that ancient thing we're still using. It's a nightmare." He takes a quick sip of his tea. "I offered to bring one in myself, but they threw a fit over electrical safety and said it had to be one they sourced themselves."

Castorice looks at him with sympathy, while Cipher gives him a Cheshire-like grin. "Are we competing for this now? I asked the office to schedule a bike trip around the local area so the kids could stretch their legs properly, but they said it wasn't relevant. We're having to use the track field instead to ride on."

Castorice and Mydei look at Cipher together before nodding. "I still think I win," Mydei says, to which Cipher sticks her tongue out at Mydei childishly.

"Mydeimos, why are you still wearing your scarf?" Castorice asks, staring at it like it's the most curious thing on the planet.

Mydei feels his ears go a little warm. "I'm cold."

Castorice and Cipher both glance at each other, communicating silently in a way that Mydei has forced himself to stop being jealous of. Despite their clashing personalities sometimes, they stick together like glue, and their way of speaking without any words is a learned skill with almost seven years of them being together.

"Uh huh…" Cipher says, unconvinced. "Did you get laid or something?"

"*What*?! No!" Mydei exclaims, voice too loud for the quiet room. He looks around, but thankfully no one else is paying them any attention despite his outburst. "Why would you even say that?" Mydei groans, starkly reminded that he hasn't gotten 'laid', as Cipher put it, in a long, long time.

He's clearly given them the wrong reaction because Castorice and Cipher now both look like sharks smelling blood in the water. Castorice squints at him accusingly, her eyes flickering between his steadily warming face and scarf. "It never usually looks that good."

"I dunno, maybe you're hiding hickeys? You usually leave a few buttons of your shirt undone unless you're wearing a tie, so…" Cipher trails off, imitating Castorice and surveys Mydei's appearance. "You're right. Did someone tie it for you?" The words drip with suggestion, much to Mydei's dismay.

Mydei clears his throat and sits up straight, correcting his posture the best he can and pushes his shoulders back. "Is it so unbelievable that I could've just tied it like this myself?"

"Yes," Castorice and Cipher both say at the same time.

"You both are awful," Mydei replies, deflating. "The new P.E teacher did it for me," He admits, giving in under their scrutiny. He knows Cipher especially wouldn't let up without a proper answer, and it's even worse with the addition of Castorice whose natural curiosity will lead her to hunt down the answer until she's satisfied.

Both their eyebrows shoot up their foreheads, clearly not expecting to have an answer so quickly.

"Are you talking about Phainon?" Castorice asks incredulously.

It's his turn to be shocked, "You know him?"

Castorice giggles, which is never a good sign. "I've heard all about *Mr Khaslana*, yes. My students all adore him and keep telling me about their lessons with him. They're just trying to buy time, but it's amusing nonetheless."

"Oh, I see," Cipher says suddenly, leering at Mydei. "So *that's* why you two were so cuddled up this morning, hm? He was—" She makes air quotes. "—*Tying your scarf*."

"That's quite literally all we were doing," Mydei shoots back quickly.

"Mhm, sure," Cipher drawls, winking at him. "You needed to be pressed up against each other for all that?"

Castorice's eyes start to sparkle, which means wherever this conversation is going is a *bad* turning. "*No*—"

"Oh, my," Castorice gasps, her hands flying up to her mouth to cover it. "You're blushing!"

"Because you two are embarrassing me!" Mydei says, flopping back in his chair, posture ruined. He sighs, tugging at the scarf to loosen it.

"No, don't take it off! I think it's sweet, don't you, Cipher?" Castorice says, giving her girlfriend a quick nudge with her elbow to encourage her.

"Yep, *real* sweet," Cipher says, eyes narrowing as her grin spreads. Mydei takes a sip of his drink, lukewarm now, and grumbles about it and Phainon being annoying under his breath. "So when are you gonna let him fuck you?"

Mydei gapes, freezing half-way while trying to put his mug down. "I *just* said he was annoying."

Cipher laughs as if Mydei had said something really funny, "Then why would you let him anywhere near you? Let alone let him tie your scarf?"

Mydei finishes putting his mug back down onto the table, albeit a little shakily. "He didn't give me a choice! He just did it without asking."

Cipher stretches her hand out suddenly, going straight for his scarf with a manic look on her face, her fangs out. Mydei doesn't think twice before smacking her hand away.

"Right, sure! I'll say again, when are you gonna ask him out?" Cipher asks, pursing her lips to fend off her smile.

"You changed the question," Mydei glares venomously at her. "Why did it go from *fucking* to *dating*?"

"I don't know, you tell me, little prince~" Cipher sing-songs vaguely.

Mydei hates his friends. No, really, he does. He swears it, because now even Castorice is laughing at him, quietly chuckling behind her hands as if he can't see and hear her both. He sighs, opening his mouth to defend himself when there's a knock at the door, cutting all the chatter out in the room. Mydei immediately assumes it's a student wanting to speak to one of them, but he doesn't bother moving as he hears one of the other teachers closer to the door get up to answer it instead.

He ignores the quiet sound of pleasantries as he focuses back on his friends, ready to down the rest of his tea before heading out back to his classroom to set up for later today.

"Um, okay. Hang on then. Mr Kremnos?"

Mydei turns around at his name, spotting a TA for the geography department by the door. "Someone's asking for you," She says now that she has his attention.

He nods, surprised that any student from his classes is bothering him during lunch time. He waits for her to move out of the way so he can at least get a glimpse of who it is before he gets up. The TA shifts a little, and Mydei catches sight of a pair of blue shorts that he's been conditioned to desperately seek out.

"Phainon?" He says, a little breathlessly, as he immediately stands up from his chair. Castorice and Cipher jerk backwards in their seats so they can peer around Mydei, and all the sudden attention makes the TA nervously run off back to her table.

Phainon stands there, in his stupidly tight t-shirt and his stupidly short shorts, looking somewhat *shy*.

"Hey," Phainon says, giving him a short wave before letting his arm drop back down to his sides.

"Is everything okay?" Mydei asks, walking over to the door, his terrible friends and his half-drunk cup of tea forgotten.

Phainon nods, but his face doesn't convince him of that answer.

"Do you need me for something?" Mydei questions when Phainon doesn't say anything else. They're both standing in the doorway now, and Mydei realises he's only an inch or so shorter than Phainon.

Phainon glances at him and then looks away, chewing at his bottom lip. Mydei is progressively getting more and more confused and concerned as time goes on, and it only doubles when Phainon mumbles something that he doesn't quite hear, only catching one word:

"Lost?" Mydei repeats.

"Yes, lost," Phainon replies.

Mydei stares at him, signalling he didn't hear the rest.

"I… got lost," Phainon says, barely loud enough to be heard, but Mydei finally catches it this time.

"You got lost?" Mydei parrots, feeling rather *lost* himself as to how that explains anything about why he was needed here in the first place.

"*Yes*, I got lost. How many times should we keep saying it? I've never had to leave East Block before," Phainon huffs, folding his arms.

"Alright. Where did you get *lost* trying to get to?" Mydei asks, purposely emphasising on the word just so Phainon would shoot him a glare. It works, and Mydei feels a grin curling at the corner of his lips.

"I got called in to see, um… Mr Kremnos… Senior…?" Phainon replies unsurely, stumbling over his words.

Mydei sighs, "You can just call me Mydeimos when it's away from the students. It's easier."

Phainon's whole visage brightens, his shoulders lifting up as his back straightens and a grin plasters itself over his face. "Sure, Mydei-*mos*!"

"No— no, you're saying it wrong. It's like this—"

Phainon laughs, cutting him off. "Sorry, sorry. You had such a serious look on your face it was funny. Is that why all the students are half-scared of you?"

"They're not *scared* of me, they respect me."

"They do," Phainon replies, his grin softening. "Hmm, can I just call you Mydei instead, please?"

Mydei sighs, adjusting his glasses on his nose. "Fine. If it stops you butchering my full name, then go ahead."

"Cool, Mydei! Anyway, I need to get to Mr Kremnos's room, and I know it's around here somewhere, and—" Phainon pauses mid-sentence, his expression turning stunned. "—Wait, why are you still wearing your scarf?"

Mydei feels a wave of humiliation go over his body, flustered beyond belief at being called out *again* over it. He rips it off, bundling it up into his fist before he chucks it onto one of the tables close by. The cold air that washes over his now exposed skin makes him shiver, and he regrets taking it off immediately despite being made fun of for it.

"I forgot," Mydei replies through gritted teeth, ignoring the howling laughter coming from Cipher behind him and tittering giggles from Castorice—he should've known those two would've been listening in.

He adjusts his glasses again when all Phainon does is raise an eyebrow at him.

"I'll show you where his office is. Follow me," Mydei shoulders past Phainon and starts walking down the corridor without waiting. Phainon makes a shocked sound and runs after Mydei, catching up with him quickly. They carry on down the long corridor, walking side by side.

"You were pretty close to it," Mydei says, taking a left when they reach a dead end. As soon as they turn, it opens out into a small waiting area with a large wooden door in the centre of the back wall.

Phainon glances around the space nervously, clear in the way he's worrying at his bottom lip with furrowed eyebrows. The air always feels different in this part of the school, Mydei thinks as his nerves sit on edge. He can practically feel his father through the door and walls, as if his presence over the years has seeped into the concrete and foundation of the building. It's rare now that he willingly comes down this far, so he looks around the area too, taking everything in.

The bustling sounds of the school grounds are completely gone as they're met with dead silence instead. The waiting room air feels stale, cloying and oppressive. Mydei knows it isn't just him who feels it—students and teachers alike always say it feels like they're walking to their death sentence when they're summoned here.

The walls are a dull blue colour, mostly covered up by framed photos and certificates that stretch from each corner from floor to ceiling. Only one wall is spared from it, but in place of the frames there's glass shelving units that are filled up with trophies and medals. Mydei knows that a big portion of everything here is of him, or from his achievements—the golden child until he fell from grace in his father's eyes. There's photos of him in every stage of lower education, on his university's graduation day and then on his first day as a teacher as well. There's even medals and trophies from school competitions he'd entered to make his father happy.

Mydei always aches when he remembers those days now, the memories full of desperation in needing to please his father that he would've—and did—do anything and everything that he was asked of. A heavy feeling settles in his stomach, taking the shape of needing to grab Phainon by his hand and run away as far as they can get from this room. He always thought it was strange how his father kept everything of Mydei *here* instead of at their family estate, but he'd long forgone the effort of questioning things his father ever did in favour of his own sanity.

He watches as Phainon steps further into the space, looking equally as unsettled as Mydei feels himself. His eyes rake over the walls, taking everything in. Usually schools will have this form of display at reception, or at least somewhere more accessible where everyone could come and admire it, but his father hoards these items like a dragon guarding his treasure.

Phainon wanders over to one of the walls, and Mydei winces at knowing exactly where he's heading. Phainon lights up almost immediately, his previously perturbed expression rolling off him like water on a duck's back. Mydei had hoped that his photos wouldn't have been spotted, their existence so tiny in the vast stretch of identical looking frames with hundreds of other faces in them.

"Look at your hair!" Phainon exclaims joyfully, turning around to Mydei to compare the photo from then to him now. His hair had been cut painfully short in that photo, the strands oddly curling out in all sorts of directions in a way he could never figure out to tame. After that, he vowed never to cut it short and grow it out to where it sits now, on his shoulders, mostly tamed.

Mydei sighs and walks over to where Phainon is standing, finding the photo in question quickly. He really does look small in it, his father standing next to him proudly and towering over him, his late mother on the other side.

"You definitely grew into it," Phainon says, turning his head to grin at Mydei, fluffing up the back of his short hair as if to prove a point. "I like how you have it now, though. Especially the braid. It's cute."

"*Cute*?" Mydei repeats, eyes slightly widening as the compliment settles deep within him.

"Oh, sorry, should I have said *manly* instead? You are very manly, Mydei," Phainon chirps, laughing as he nudges Mydei with his shoulder. Mydei glares at him, pursing his lips as he crosses his arms across his chest.

Mydei doesn't bother replying and just watches Phainon go back to looking at the photo until he spots more surrounding it that have Mydei in as well. The one above it seems to catch his eye in particular, it's one of him and Hephaestion gathered together, arm in arm, heads pressed together as they grin into the camera. Mydei had forgotten how *young* they were back in university compared to now, and his heart aches at the memories that come with it. He hasn't spoken to his friend in a long, long time. Not since…

"Who's that?" Phainon asks, pointing to the photo they're both looking at.

"My friend." Mydei says simply in response, suddenly too tired to go into detail.

Phainon hums, leaning forward to get a better look. "Are you guys still close? This photo looks fairly old."

"Not anymore," Mydei replies, shaking his head, melancholy filling his words.

Phainon seems to take the hint and doesn't ask any further questions, moving onto the more general photos that are littered about without Mydei in them.

"Hm, at least your hair grew out by then. You looked like a little acorn in that other photo."

"First my scarf, now my hair. Anything else you'd like to bring up about me that doesn't suit your tastes?" Mydei questions, eyebrow raising in challenge.

Phainon laughs in reply, waving him off as his eyes curve up sweetly with a grin. Mydei's heart thuds in his chest at the sight, the contrast of warmth radiating from Phainon against the frigid air in the room makes it feel like all his senses are finally waking up. He can't help but stare at Phainon in amazement—any weight that was on his shoulders from being here, thinking of his father and his past friendships, dissipates.

"Let me think on that first," Phainon jokes back.

Mydei lets himself smile, feeling even more hopeless when he notices that Phainon's eyes literally twinkle when he's happy. Mydei's stomach flips, tying itself into knots as a barrage of butterflies explode inside of him.

"Oh," Phainon says, his eyes searching Mydei's face. He sounds as breathless as Mydei feels. "You have a beautiful smile."

Mydei's smile slowly fades from his face as he looks wide eyed at Phainon. He can't remember the last time he smiled wide enough for his cheeks to ache, but now that they are, it's a familiar feeling he thought he'd long lost. Phainon's eyes continue to roam over his face, the gaze feeling like dandelion seeds against his skin as they stand in silence. The quietness cocoons around them, separating them from anything else in the world, the cold suddenly becoming warm as he stays there under Phainon's heated gaze.

It's only broken when the door opens, the sound like a gunshot in the newfound silence of the room. Phainon and Mydei startle, snapping out of their daze as they turn around to face the figure in the doorway.

"I thought I heard your voice, Mydeimos," Eurypon says, his voice stern and eyes set coldly. To anyone else, he looks like a harmless old man, what with his blonde-grey beard growing out and the soft set of his wilting shoulders, but Mydei sees the distant stare in his eyes as they watch each other from across the room.

Mydei clears his throat, straightening his posture subconsciously as he always does when faced with his father.

*Don't let anyone see your weakness*, his father used to say as he'd take Mydei's queen piece from the chessboard, knocking it down with a finality that was only equal to death. *Don't give your opponent anything to work with*.

Standing there, a few feet away from his father with Phainon at his side, he feels like he's preparing for battle.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

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if your comment is going to include anything about mydei's sexuality, don't bother. i hc him to be gay, and phainon to be bisexual, so that's what i'll stick to and what i'm always going to write. do not @ me and do not come to my strawpage and talk about coding, i'll just block and delete it. THANKS 👍

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let's be friends on twitter/x!

# Chapter 3: chapter three

Chapter Summary

"Ah! I forgot to do your scarf!"

"Leave it for today," Mydei says. If they take any longer then they both will be running far behind what they usually do.

Phainon pouts, his bottom lip jutting out slightly as his cheeks puff out, but he concedes quickly when he sees that Mydei isn't going to budge. He kicks the toe of his shoe against the pavement.

"Fine," Phainon says sulkily. It doesn't last for long, as he's shooting up straight and holding his hand out towards Mydei. Mydei stares down at it in shock for a moment—does he want him to hold it? Mydei begins to reach out, his own hand trembling, but then Phainon continues: "Give me your phone. I want to give you my number."

Mydei's hand freezes half way and it falls flat beside him, his cheeks burning with how easily he was about to hold the younger teacher's hand without saying anything or giving it more critical thought. He frowns, "Why?"

Chapter Notes

things really heat up during this chapter hehe, i'm super excited for everyone to read it!!

enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Father," Mydei says after a tense silence.

Phainon flinches, startling as he looks between the both of them with wide eyes. He must've known that they're related, at least, but perhaps not quite *how* closely related. Eurypon looks away first to focus on Phainon instead, a placid smile on his wrinkled face.

"You must be Phainon Khaslana?" He asks lightly, his voice giving away nothing.

Phainon gives Mydei one last glance and nods at Eurypon. "Yes, sir. I'm the new P.E teacher." Phainon replies, the politest Mydei has heard from him till now—all his natural, carefree and mischievous attitude has retreated for the time being.

He doesn't want his father to get into Phainon's head like he's done with Mydei over the years. To Eurypon, Phainon is nothing but fresh meat in the business who needs shaping and carving out to become the perfect piece to add to the puzzle. This is just a part of the first test, to see the potential in whether or not he'll succeed or fail. It's a blessing in disguise for his father to have gotten this opportunity so early on, to be able to step in and test the waters with Phainon.

Mydei knows how many of those certificates, medals and trophies come from the sports teams, so it's imperative that any new hire meets the standards his father has set out for them. They're all players in this game, even the students, despite them not realising it.

"Is this to discuss the incident earlier this week?" Mydei asks, playing dumb. He doesn't do it often in general, but sometimes it's easier to be this

way when it comes to his father's games. Especially ones that are only just beginning.

Phainon begins to walk towards Eurypon but stops as the tension suddenly skyrockets between the three of them at Mydei inserting himself into the conversation.

"That is correct. I think Phainon and I need to have a little discussion about it, yes?" Eurypon replies, his smile faltering slightly at Mydei's input, a detail that no one else would've noticed but Mydei himself. He's gotten good at reading his father after so long.

"Then I'll join you. I was there too, and we handled it together," Mydei says resolutely. He goes to move towards Phainon, but the look on his father's face makes him hesitate slightly.

"I am aware," Eurypon begins, his eyes as cold as his voice as they pierce through Mydei. "I received your email. I don't think there's any need for you to participate in the meeting, unless Mr Khaslana himself would like you to be present…?" Eurypon trails off, giving the illusion of choice when there's none at all.

Mydei doesn't care. He bulldozes through it, smashing it to pieces as he replies: "I think it's best that Mr Khaslana have another member of staff in there to support him," He says, not giving Phainon any choice in the matter himself.

Mydei walks past Phainon who's still frozen in place, eyes going between the two of them like he's watching a particularly riveting tennis match. Mydei looks at him briefly, giving him a sure singular nod before continuing forward towards his father's office before he's denied entry. Eurypon's gaze feels like the tip of a blade pointed at his throat as he brushes past him.

Phainon follows behind Mydei quickly, sticking so close that he can feel the heat radiating off of him. It sets off the chill that's sticking to his bones, thawing him out slightly. That's right—he's not on his own here. It's not *just* him to tackle the problem that is his own father, but rather he's here to finally defend someone else for a change. He's gotten so used to looking at his father in the eye and not seeing anything at all—no familiar affection, no hint of kindness or love—that it's almost strange seeing something curious in his eyes instead as he watches them both.

They all settle down quickly around Eurypon's desk, him taking his 'throne' while Mydei and Phainon take the two plain seats opposite. Two cups and saucers are laid out, Eurypon's cup is already full while the other is empty —a clear sign for Phainon to fill his own tea as a source of comfort, all a complete illusion. Out of spite, Mydei reaches over for the pot of tea and fills it up for himself, grumbling internally that there's no milk or sugar present to have with it. He'll live, he supposes, as he takes a brief sip of the hot drink to settle his nerves.

The room is brightly lit by a single overhead lamp, its glow pooling sharply across the polished floor. The walls are painted a muted light grey and feel almost bare, especially compared to the busy waiting room just outside. The only real decoration comes from his father's plants—dozens of them are cluttered along the walls in mismatched pots, their leaves spilling over in an attempt to soften a space that refuses to be warm.

On the opposite side, bookshelves and filing cabinets stand in rigid rows, forming a neat, uncompromising barrier beneath the wide window. The blinds are drawn tightly shut, letting in no trace of the world beyond and giving the room an enclosed, airless quality. It's clean, orderly, and efficient for business—exactly the sort of room his father would choose, and exactly the sort that Mydei has always felt too visible in.

"As we just mentioned, Mydeimos explained everything to me in an email, but I'd like to hear it from you directly, Mr Khaslana. Start from the beginning," Eurypon says, voice flat and demanding.

Phainon clears his throat, setting back his shoulders as he sits ramrod straight in his chair, and goes through everything that happened. He recounts every step of the incident and the aftermath as well.

"I really am sorry, Mr Kremnos. It won't happen again," Phainon finishes, his eyes and words earnest. "Mydei amended the student's timetables immediately and they won't have missed anything in the long run."

Eurypon raises an eyebrow, and the expression sends a ripple of unease through Mydei. His stomach tightens before he can stop it, and for a moment he wonders what exactly triggered that reaction. It's such a small detail, such a small thing, but his father is not one for those types of things. Was it the nickname, the casual address that he almost never allows people to do?

His father certainly never tolerated it. There were rules in that house—rigid ones—and names were to be spoken in full, sharp and formal, never softened. He was never *dad* or *papa*, only *father*. No pet names. No affectionate shortcuts. Nothing that implied warmth. Only his mother had ever broken that rule. She had given him little names in secret, whispered things—variations of *her prince*, *her heart*—words that wrapped around him like comfort as he went off to sleep, words he didn't understand the meaning of until he lost it all together. Remembering them now makes something swell painfully in his chest, rising up with a tenderness he's not sure he knows how to hold, let alone show.

Eurypon finally nods, "I truly hope that is the case, Mr Khaslana. Your accolades throughout university and your references were extremely impressive and they are what landed you this job in the first place despite no proper experience. So, forgive me if I'm a tad surprised we're having to have this conversation so early on."

Mydei tenses, knowing that tone of voice very well.

Eurypon continues, an almost serene expression crossing his face now, but his eyes are glinting like daggers in the dark. "How can we, as teachers, set an example to the students if we, ourselves, don't know what we're doing?" Eurypon narrows his gaze at Phainon, contrasting the stagnant smile on his face. "It may have been a small mistake to you, but I assure you that even something like this can lead the students to believe they have power over you in these situations. While they knew when the class should've ended, you did not. *Incompetence* is a difficult impression to get rid of, don't you think?"

"*Father*—" Mydei begins, but is quieted by the icy grin on Eurypon's face that shows off all his teeth, as though he's enjoying every moment of this.

"Let Mr Khaslana speak for himself, Mydeimos."

Phainon looks deflated at his father's words, but Eurypon just sits back in his chair, the leather squeaking slightly from the movement. He keeps that thing polished, Mydei is sure of it. Phainon sits there in silence for a moment, clearly digesting everything, mouth opening and closing as he tries to find the words.

"Well, I, uh…" Phainon stutters, unable to find his footing. Mydei can't say anything more without escalating the situation, so he reaches a hand over to place on Phainon's bare knee to give it a reassuring squeeze. He's glad the desk is high enough that the action is well hidden apart from a small shift in position.

Phainon's leg jumps at the contact, but the muscles relax quickly when he realises what it is. Phainon takes a deep breath to centre himself, but now instead of upset and flustered, he looks *determined*.

"Mr Kremnos, they're just *kids*.. I don't know what exactly you think they have going on, but they were just having fun and that's why they struggled to tell me that the class had overrun," Phainon says, almost talking through his teeth to keep his tone as polite as possible. Eurypon stares impassively at him, but Phainon holds his gaze, strong and sure.

"I see. So, how will we rectify it if this happens again? Should we punish the students to make it clear that they are also to share part of the blame?"

"What?!" Phainon's volume increases at the question, and Mydei clamps his hand down on his knee even harder to try and keep him in check. There's no use using anger against his father, after all. That'll only fuel him. Unfortunately, he's ignored, and Phainon looks poised to attack. "It was my mistake. If you dare—"

"*Phainon*," Mydei hisses out, cutting him off before he says something stupid and irreparable. Despite his feelings towards his own father, he's still the damned headteacher of the school they teach at. This is not a time to be throwing around threats, no matter how much Eurypon himself loves to do that.

Phainon's blue eyes are blazing hot as they turn on him, and they only become angrier. "Are you going to agree with him?" He asks.

Mydei falters. He hadn't even realised he'd started slipping into that familiar spiral—the one Eurypon's words always seem to drag him towards, even when they currently aren't meant for him. Apparently, he isn't as immune to them as he once convinced himself he was. But what hits him harder, sharper, is the sting of Phainon possibly believing that he's not on his side. That hurts more than any thought of standing up to his father ever could, more than any backlash he might have to face later on. It settles in his chest like a bruise blooming from the inside, unexpected and far too tender.

Mydei steels himself and straightens his back, turning to face Eurypon head on and sheds any hesitancy about speaking up. "Father, Mr Khaslana has taken responsibility for his mistake and has taken precautions against it happening again. I don't see the benefit in punishing the students when it's already been resolved, nor will I allow it."

Eurypon's eyes turn considering as he watches him, going from looking at Phainon and then back to Mydei. Mydei feels his stomach sink at the look; there's something worse than his father's wrath—it's his father's *interest*.

"I was just speaking rhetorically, of course. But I understand. I'm pleased to hear you're being proactive about it, Mr Khaslana," Eurypon replies, acting as if they're ganging up on him over nothing as he placates them. "It's always good to know where your strengths and weaknesses lie when you're in a new environment, don't you agree?"

"Yes… Sir," Phainon responds diplomatically, but his face is as bright as thunder clouds as he speaks. It's clear that his former ire hasn't quietened in the slightest, and neither has Mydei's.

Eurypon nods, and the tension in the room slowly and eventually ebbs away, leaving their cups of tea stone cold in its wake. "Very well then. I won't be taking this matter any further. The situation was dealt with quickly and sufficiently, and I assume you've ironically learnt *your* lesson about this?"

"I have," Phainon replies quickly.

Mydei quickly drops his hand from Phainon's knee, clearly no longer needing it to be there. He misses the warmth of his bare skin instantly though, misses the softness of it beneath his fingertips and the strength he felt in those muscles as they flexed with fury.

"Thank you for your time, Mr Khaslana. I hope you continue enjoying your time here and can achieve great things."

With that clear dismissal, Phainon doesn’t hesitate to stand up to exit. Mydei follows his lead, standing shoulder to shoulder with Phainon, figuratively and literally. He doesn't acknowledge his father any further and trails after Phainon so he can leave this horrible room and the man in it behind him.

He's one foot out the door when his father's voice stops him in his tracks. "Mydeimos, may I have a moment?"

"I'm sorry, father, but I have a lesson to attend to now," Mydei replies, not turning around to face him.

"What a shame. Maybe next time we can have a game of chess, hm?"

"Maybe," Mydei mutters, letting the door slam shut behind him.

Mydei looks up and finds Phainon watching him, worry etched plainly across his face. The sight only twists something tighter inside Mydei. He grits his teeth, fists curling so tightly that his nails bite into his palms. Frustration surges through him—hot, blinding—until he can barely think, let alone see straight. He has to get out. Now.

The waiting room feels like it's shrinking around him, the walls pressing in with their cluttered surfaces and their suffocating reminders of everything he's tried so hard to leave behind. Every shadow, every framed certificate, every photograph feels like an echo of his past he never asked to confront again.

He turns sharply to avoid bumping into Phainon and storms out, long strides carrying him through the waiting room before he can second guess himself. The moment he steps into the corridor, it's like bursting through the surface after being held underwater. Life rushes back to him in a flood—the bright chatter of students, the thud of footsteps, the distant laughter drifting in from the playground.

Mydei quickly inhales, a deep, trembling breath he didn't realise he'd been denying himself for the past half an hour. The air fills his lungs, clearing the fog in his head, grounding him back into a world that feels real and alive—one not ruled by his father's shadows.

"Mydei!" Phainon calls after him. Mydei slows down to a stop as the other teacher jogs up behind him. "Are you okay?" He asks when they're standing next to each other again.

"Shouldn't I be the one asking you that?" Mydei questions sincerely.

Phainon shakes his head. "I'll be okay. Your dad is pretty intense though, huh? Are the students here criminal masterminds or something?"

Mydei scoffs at that, folding his arms over each other as he tries to keep the smile off his face at the silly comment. He feels the fog lift even further now that they're both out of there, and it's just him and Phainon together.

"*Intense* is one way to put it," Mydei replies.

"Is he…" Phainon pauses, as if considering his words. "I mean, is he always like that? Even with you?"

Mydei sighs and looks away at the grimy carpet instead, not particularly wanting to answer that question. It'll open up a can of worms that he's still trying to shove back into place after that meeting.

"Never mind," Phainon says, and then he pats Mydei on the shoulder comfortingly. The action is startling, making him jump slightly, but the weight and warmth are a welcoming feeling. It makes him loosen up, his muscles unwinding and his shoulders sagging a little.

"Anyway, I totally fucked up in there, right?" Phainon continues, removing his hand to rub it against his forehead. "I just couldn't stand the fact he was

using the students against me over it. I shouldn't have yelled like that."

Mydei sighs, not bothering to tell him off for swearing again. He feels every one of his thirty nine years right now after dealing with his father. "You stood your ground, Phainon."

"I know! But… He didn't say anything I didn't already know, and I almost lost it because of that. It felt like he was reading me like a damned *book*."

"And what exactly does he know about you?" Mydei snaps, unable to help himself. He places his hands on his hips. He can't—he *won't*—let Phainon leave until he's removed everything negative his father had fed him during the meeting.

Phainon blinks at him in shock, clearly not expecting the sudden venom lacing the words. He shrugs his shoulders anyway, but it's obvious it's just an attempt to appear nonchalant.

"You're not *incompetent*, Phainon. Mistakes like that happen to us all, and it's about how we deal with them afterwards that shows where we really shine. You handled it fine and fixed the problem so it wouldn't happen again. Does that sound like incompetence to you? Or is there anything else you think you could've done?"

Phainon's eyes turn wide and glassy. He doesn't look like he's going to cry, but instead he looks overwhelmed by Mydei's words.

"Just… Don't let him win, alright? The students love you, and that's all that matters when it comes to things like this. You have their adoration *and* respect in such a short amount of time—I've never seen anything like it. You've left a lasting impression on them that they'll carry forever—and *that's* what they won't forget, not the fact that you were late one time."

Phainon carries on staring at him, lips slightly parted and eyebrows knitted. The silence coming from the younger teacher is beginning to unnerve him. Mydei knows he said a lot—probably too much, if he's honest, but he himself has been proven wrong by his own first impressions of Phainon, and damned if he's letting his father's same ones get carried on.

"Do you actually have a class right now?" Phainon asks, the question so sudden it catches him off guard.

"No, I don't. Why?" He asks.

Phainon grins, and the glassiness in his eyes clears up into something much brighter and more beautiful, like the clouds are parting ways to make room for the sun. "Wanna come help me set up the badminton courts?"

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Is this just you trying to get out of doing them yourself?"

"Maybe…" Phainon replies, grin turning cheeky as he drags out the word conspiratorially.

Mydei scoffs and shakes his head, albeit fondly, and the tension completely leaves his body, his budding headache even easing off.

"Is that a yes then?" Phainon asks excitedly, tilting his body forward so he can catch Mydei's gaze as he peers upwards.

Phainon's eyes are doing that horrible, cute sparkling thing like they did earlier when he was happy, and Mydei knows he doesn't stand a chance against such boyish charm.

"If this is your way of thanking me for having your back again, you need to work on it," Mydei says bluntly, walking off without another word.

"Hey!" Phainon yells indignantly from behind.

"You better show me where the nets are!" Mydei calls back, letting a smile secretly spread across his face while his back is turned. It only gets wider when he hears Phainon cursing and setting off running to catch up to him.

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After that, Phainon seems to be *everywhere*.

Mydei's earlier worries about never crossing paths with Phainon in the general staffroom are unfounded in the end, as every day since their meeting with his father, Phainon is there—either lounging on the worn leather sofa, or sitting on the table in the corner with Castorice and Cipher, laughing and chatting. It's clear that, for some reason, he finds the six minute walk across the school grounds worth it. He can understand Cipher making the trek to see Castorice as they're together, but what exactly does Phainon have here? Mydei supposes they've all become friends now, and he'd do the same, but still. Something deep in his mind nags at him, telling him there could be more.

The image of Phainon with his two best friends (their words, not his) makes Mydei's heart flip, something that is starting to happen far too often to be normal. Even as weeks go by, whenever Phainon smiles or laughs, Mydei feels himself rubbing at his chest as if that'll help ease up the spike in his heart rate.

Phainon is so expressive in everything he does—like the life inside him can't help but burst out, seeping through his pores as radiant sunshine because he has so much of it stored within that it can't possibly all be contained within his body. It seems to be rubbing off on people around him too that even the most stoic of teachers in the school are found cracking a small smile at Phainon's chatter in the staffroom. He's seemingly made friends with everyone as well, teachers and students alike, despite barely two months passing since he first started. Even Mr Anaxa, the most impassive and brusque teacher on the grounds, seems quietly fond of him as they tend to get into the most random of debates.

He enjoys watching Phainon interact with his friends the most though, the both of them having really taken to the younger teacher which doesn't surprise Mydei in the slightest. He always joins them a little late, favouring the first few minutes of his breaks to be making tea instead, but he never feels like he's intruding when all of them get together.

At first, apprehension curls tight in Mydei's chest as he watches it happen in front of him—how effortlessly everyone in the staffroom seems to gravitate towards Phainon, how naturally they gather around him as if drawn by some quiet sun. A part of Mydei, small and shadowed, whispers that he'll never get a moment alone with him again. It's a selfish fear, one he tries to bury before it can surface, but the emotion rises anyway, sharp and unwelcome.

And yet, somehow, despite all the voices and hands tugging for his attention, Phainon always finds him. Mydei barely has time to sink fully into that thought before Phainon's gaze catches his, brightening instantly. He'll excuse himself immediately from the group with gentle, apologetic smiles, slipping free of the crowd as if it were the easiest thing in the world, and cross the space to Mydei's side—like he was never meant to be anywhere else. Mydei wants it to be like that so badly he thinks he's going silly in the head with it sometimes.

Even worse—or better, if Mydei isn't thinking straight—Phainon had even taken to arriving at the same time as Mydei does in the mornings, admitting that the first time they bumped into each other in the car park was because he couldn't sleep so he thought he'd come in early to set up. He grumbles about it being early every single time, but he still jogs over from where he leaves his motorbike to the other side of the car park where Mydei waits for him. So maybe they're both as bad as each other.

They stand in front of Mydei's car, trading small talk as Phainon takes it upon himself to redo Mydei's scarf that he now does badly on purpose He'd originally wanted to wave the younger teacher off at first from doing it again, still holding onto the embarrassment from the first time it happened, but then Phainon had pouted at him…

…So, Phainon pulls his pathetic excuse for a knot completely loose and stares at it in concentrated silence until he's finally happy with the way it looks. Sometimes, if Mydei is lucky, Phainon's fingers will brush against his neck, making him shiver from the goosebumps that ripple out across his skin. He has to focus extra hard on making sure it's not obvious when his breathing begins to speed up when they're this close, and with the added contact. Phainon will always grin in satisfaction when he's done, giving it a few cursory pats to signal to Mydei that he can look down at it now.

Mydei never thanks him, but he always makes a cup of tea ready for Phainon when he comes bundling into the staffroom later on that day.

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Phainon is late today.

Mydei checks his wristwatch every few seconds as if that'll explain anything to him, but to his dismay it doesn't change the fact that he's freezing his ass off waiting for Phainon and that he isn't *here*. If Mydei thinks about it, Phainon could've possibly gotten tired of arriving early, realising that he doesn't need to get here just because Mydei does. Mydei looks down at his poorly tied scarf and feels a little—a *lot*—abashed that he had kept up with this for so long.

Mydei doesn't need to wait outside. He can easily go about his day, set up at his usual time before it had been changed by their early morning meetings. But he knows, deep down, that if he doesn't see Phainon first thing, he'll feel off for the rest of the day, even if he sees him at lunch time. *This* is his new routine now, much to his displeasure, and he doesn't want it to change.

He'll give Phainon two more minutes, just like he did when his class was late all those weeks ago. If he's still not arrived by then, he'll go inside and pretend like none of this ever happened.

"Mydei!" A voice calls out, and he looks up from his phone where he was pretending to do something other than just staring blankly at his home screen in order to look busy for the past five minutes. So what if he's a little late too and decided to stay an extra few minutes out in the freezing cold?

There's only one person that calls him that. Phainon's expression is stunned as he runs over, cheeks and the tip of his nose pink from the cold and his hair in complete disarray. "Why are you still out here? Have you been waiting for me?" He asks as he approaches, slowing down to a stop when they're close enough.

Mydei doesn't even think—his hand rises on instinct. He smooths Phainon's hair down gently, fingertips brushing through soft strands that slip easily between them. He lingers a moment too long, pretending to focus on straightening it when he's really memorising the feel of him, the quiet closeness, and the way Phainon tilts just slightly into his touch. Of course, once he's done those two stubborn strands bounce right back into place no

matter how carefully he tries to tame them. They're as persistent—and as endearing—as Phainon is himself.

"Is my helmet hair really bad?" Phainon cringes, placing his hand on top of Mydei's to feel where he was sorting out. Mydei swallows, licking his dry lips as his stomach flutters with the contact.

Once he's finished, he drops his hand back down at his side, his hand pleasantly warm in the face of the icy winds whipping around them. "It's fine now," He says, finding it impossible to look away from the way Phainon is gazing at him.

Phainon's face starts turning redder. Mydei curses in his head—he must *finally* be feeling the cold with how they're just standing around here doing nothing, especially considering he's still in those damn tiny shorts despite the school having a uniform kit with joggers.

Mydei clears his throat before he speaks. "Are you actually starting to feel the cold for once, Mr Khaslana? Your ears are turning red."

Even Phainon's knees begin to colour when Mydei glances down. "Um, yeah. I guess I am a little chilly." He says shakily.

"A *little*?" Mydei repeats incredulously. Either way, he shakes his head and looks back up at Phainon's face. He still can't understand how the teacher isn't constantly freezing, inside or outside, with how little he wears all the time. Although, Mydei can't complain too much as the view of Phainon's

toned legs and thick thighs is still just as enticing as it was the first time they'd met. He can still worry about his well-being, surely? "Let's get you inside."

They start off towards reception and Phainon begins to talk, recounting his morning.

"I'm sorry I was late. I had to break up a fight by the bus stop outside my house. They were still drunk from the night before and they were arguing over *nothing*, so fuc—freaking annoying!"

Mydei huffs a laugh at the attempt of censoring himself. "How did you get them to stop?"

Phainon grins and lifts his arm up, making a fist with his hand as he flexes his bicep underneath his hoodie. Mydei watches with bright eyes as he sees the material move. "I used my powers, of course!"

"You mean you bodily shoved them apart, yes?" Mydei rolls his eyes. "I'm surprised you didn't get involved in the fight yourself."

"Yeah, yeah, whatever you say, *Mr Kremnos*," Phainon mutters, then he suddenly stops walking, whirling around to face Mydei. "Ah! I forgot to do your scarf!"

"Leave it for today," Mydei says. If they take any longer then they both will be running far behind what they usually do.

Phainon pouts, his bottom lip jutting out slightly as his cheeks puff out, but he concedes quickly when he sees that Mydei isn't going to budge. He kicks the toe of his shoe against the pavement.

"Fine," Phainon says sulkily. It doesn't last for long, as he's shooting up straight and holding his hand out towards Mydei. Mydei stares down at it in shock for a moment—does he want him to hold it? Mydei begins to reach out, his own hand trembling, but then Phainon continues: "Give me your phone. I want to give you my number."

Mydei's hand freezes half way and it falls flat beside him, his cheeks burning with how *easily* he was about to hold the younger teacher's hand without saying anything or giving it more critical thought. He frowns, "Why?"

"So I can let you know if I'm going to be late again. I don't want you staying out here in the cold for too long," Phainon replies, making a grabbing gesture with his still-outstretched hand.

Mydei blinks at him from behind his glasses and fishes his phone out to give to him, the device automatically unlocking from Face ID. He hopes his heart isn't beating loud enough that Phainon can hear it. He feels like he's sixteen all over again with his first crush on a boy, although back then he'd be asking for a landline number or their email address instead so they could chat on instant messaging.

Phainon sticks his tongue out through his teeth in concentration as he types furiously into Mydei's phone. "There you go," Phainon says, handing it back, already locked. "Make sure you text me later so I have your number too."

"Will do. You better get a move on now, you need to get the gym set up for your second period."

"Alright, I'm moving!" Phainon says, taking a step forward before abruptly stopping again. He blinks, then frowns. "Wait, how did you know I have a gym session second period?"

Mydei startles, memories of that damned timetable that he *swore* he wouldn't memorise but ended up doing exactly just that come flooding back to him. He coughs lightly into his fist at his slip up, "Lucky guess."

It's not like Phainon can talk—he has a copy of Mydei's timetable as well! But he doubts that Phainon did anything with it more than a quick glance before chucking it away. Phainon narrows his eyes suspiciously at Mydei, but he thankfully relents quickly—sparing Mydei from any of that interrogation he'd feared when he first was given the timetable.

"Sure," Phainon acquiesces. Then, a small, almost shy smile appears on his face. "I'll… see you later? For lunch?" He asks, voice clearly hopeful.

"Yeah, sure. I'll be there as usual," Mydei responds, mirroring the smile.

Phainon grins at him then, spinning around on the balls of his feet so he's standing in front of Mydei instead of beside him. He clasps his hands behind his back, nodding slowly as he tries to bite back the grin. "Cool, that's cool. Seeya then, Mydei-*mos*!"

"You still can't say it right!" Mydei calls after him as he's already half way through the double doors of reception, and laughter is all he gets in return.

Mydei huffs a laugh and checks his phone, and if anyone is to ever ask why he's smiling like a fool at his screen when he sees 'Phainon ' saved in his contacts, he would vehemently deny doing it in the first place.

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By the time lunch rolls around, Mydei is practically vibrating out of his skin. He wants to see Phainon again after this morning. His students are obviously bemused by his restlessness, but thankfully they don't say anything. As soon as the bell rings, Mydei cuts himself off mid-sentence to let them go. They all look like they're being pranked at this point, not making any sudden movements as if waiting for Mydei to have his 'gotcha!' moment and then sentence them to a week in detention. Instead, he waves dismissively at them and encourages them out of the door as quickly as possible before making his way to the staffroom. He barely remembers to turn off the interactive whiteboard before he leaves.

He knows he'll make it there before Phainon, but he still goes as fast as he can without flat out running. Phainon will be dying for a cup of tea like he usually is when lunch comes about, so he's determined to have one ready for him.

When he first offered to make one for Phainon, the other teacher had cringed at the way he took it. Phainon takes his with a tiny splash of milk and nothing else, which Mydei had to get used to quickly as he always goes to put more milk in than hot water at this point. What was worse was when Phainon gulped down his drink in three swallows, wiping the back of his mouth with his hand despite there being paper towels right there on the counter top.

The cheap tea bags they keep in the staffroom are horrible—sour at best but powdery with a damp aftertaste at their worst. He's learnt by now to bring his own tea leaves in with a tiny metal pod to put them in as they steep. Thankfully, none of the other teachers drink tea as they favour coffee instead, minus Castorice who sometimes will help herself to his stash when he's not around. He knows it's her because she's the only one who likes drinking the fancy stuff that he does.

Mydei enjoys the routine of preparing tea for himself, measuring out the correct amount of leaves before leaving them to steep for the perfect amount of time. The current brand he uses says three minutes, which is one minute less than the other one he used before. It's curious, he thinks, how precise you can be to make the perfect cup. He's endured years of heckling from Cipher over it being pretentious, always calling him 'little prince' because of it.

Mydei should find everything about his and Phainon's tea exchange annoying instead of cute, but he just watches him silently each time with a faux grossed out expression as he sips delicately at his own tea. It always gets a laugh out of Phainon either way, so he keeps doing it, making their teas in matching mugs side by side.

He finally makes it to the staffroom in record time, trying to breathe in as much air as possible to slow down his racing heart. He does too much cardio for it to be because he's out of breath from the jog, so it must be because of his excitement at seeing Phainon again. He pushes open the door, the hinges squeaking obnoxiously from age, and frowns when he sees Phainon already there sitting on the sofa.

Phainon's head shoots up from where he was looking down at his phone, and beams when he sees it's Mydei.

"You're early," Mydei comments, having just about caught his breath when his heartbeat races off again at the sight of Phainon. He makes his way over, seeing that there's already two mugs of tea laid out on the table, though one is already half finished.

"Yep, for a change," Phainon glances between Mydei at the mugs that he's currently still staring at and laughs, the sound self-conscious. "I made us both tea since I got here first, but I don't know if it's any good. Mine was fine, at least. I used your little metal tea leaves contraption too!"

Mydei glances at him out of the corner of his eyes. Phainon laughs, "I washed it and put it away in its usual spot, don't worry your pretty little

head about it."

*Pretty,* Mydei mouths, stunned. He walks closer to Phainon and gingerly sits down next to him, already prepared for the heavy lean that would happen when he did. The cushions are so worn that they sink in the middle, making Mydei tilt in sideways closer to Phainon until their shoulders are pressed firmly together. Phainon turns his head when he feels the contact, and Mydei is so close to him that he could potentially count the amount of silver eyelashes he has, or maybe he could begin cataloguing the different shades of blue in his eyes instead. They remind him of *forget-me-nots,* beautiful and stunning at the same time.

Mydei's lips part as he really does consider doing just that, but Phainon's eyes drop to his mouth as if he heard the silent motion. His gaze lingers on his lips for a moment, too long to not go unnoticed but too short to really mean anything, before he quickly looks away and back down at his phone. He unlocks it, and there's a bunch of photos on a social media app that Mydei doesn't recognise as Phainon continues scrolling. Mydei doesn't use his phone that often outside of texting Castorice and Cipher, and ignoring phone calls from his father's landline.

"Who's that?" Mydei questions when he catches sight of a very muscular, very underdressed man posing in front of a gym mirror with equipment behind him. Something dark and unnamed flares up in this stomach at the sight.

Phainon shrugs and scrolls past, barely giving the guy a proper look. "Dunno. He posts good workout routines though."

Mydei adjusts his glasses so they sit more towards the tip of his nose, allowing him to stare down through them at Phainon's phone, not caring if he comes across as nosey or not. He's *intrigued* now to say the least.

"So you don't know him, but you have pictures of him on your phone?"

"On my phone—?! I'm on Instagram, I just follow him!"

Mydei points to another guy on Phainon's feed, a video where the guy is doing push ups. "What about him?"

"I don't know him either! I just like his protein shake recipes," Phainon says in confusion. "I don't know these guys personally, alright?"

Mydei nods his head and continues to watch Phainon scroll through, but he's scrolling so fast now that nothing is distinguishable. Mydei narrows his eyes as he sees a lot of skin coloured flashes as he goes by. "Why do they all have to be shirtless?"

Phainon stops scrolling, caught between two posts so that Mydei can't see either one of them fully.

"Because they're hot and they know it?" Phainon raises an eyebrow at Mydei's stormy expression as he hears that. "I don't know! I also take these sorts of photos when I'm at the gym, but mine are purely for tracking

progress. Most of the guys on here have to sell their routines for all the electrolyte powders they sell." Phainon laughs and shakes his head.

Meanwhile, Mydei's brain has completely blanked out at the thought of Phainon taking photos of himself like the men he's just seen—sweaty, pouting, and posing in a way that makes their bodies look good and enticing for the viewer. He can picture it all too clearly, Phainon shirtless with nothing but his tiny shorts on, flexing his muscles in the mirror as he takes a few photos for safekeeping. Mydei swallows thickly, something hot pulling behind his navel as his eyes trail down Phainon's chest, ignoring his phone in his hand until his gaze lands on his legs instead. They're so *strong*, toned and muscular, the hair on them so light it's as if he has none at all.

His brain barely comes back online when he hears Phainon speaking again. "They post some pretty good motivation quotes too. I like them the most," He shrugs one shoulder and starts scrolling again, the same jacked up type of men spanning the next few posts.

They sit in silence, Mydei half paying attention until one post in particular catches his eye when Phainon lingers on it too long. The man is still well built, about the same as Mydei with broad shoulders and a wide back, but he seems a lot older than the rest of the guys that Phainon seems to follow. His hair is black and cropped short, but it's obvious he's going grey from the thick streaks at his temples. He looks expensive, classy and done up in a three-piece dark green suit that compliments his dark skin tone and deep brown eyes. Mydei leans in closer, getting a waft of Phainon's masculine smelling deodorant as he goes, inhaling the scent of sandalwood and pine as he looks appreciatively at the suit the guy has on. It's definitely something he would like to wear, maybe without the waistcoat so he could have a few buttons open at the top to show off his tattoos, but that's the only change he'd make.

"What about him? What does he post?" Mydei asks, curious about the sudden change in content. He hums, contemplative. "His hair reminds me of mine."

Phainon startles and locks his phone immediately afterwards, chucking it onto the coffee table as his face goes red. "I can like these sorts of guys as well!" He says, but he's not looking at Mydei when he speaks.

Mydei's eyebrows fly upwards at the wording.

Phainon continues, almost muttering: "I don't *just* follow gym rats, alright? He posts like… Fancy photos of him travelling."

Mydei's face falls. So it's not about the looks then that Phainon likes—okay, that's fine—it's just the jet setting aspect that's reeled him in instead. He sighs and pushes his glasses back up his nose, glad he doesn't have to watch Phainon look at other men anymore.

"Why do you look so pissed off? You're even beefier than some of the guys I follow," Phainon says. He begins cooing at Mydei when he sees his expression sour even further, not wanting to talk about this topic now. Phainon lifts his legs up onto the sofa and tucks them beneath him, curling even more into Mydei's side.

Phainon laughs, reaching a hand up to tickle under Mydei's chin once he's settled in his new position, "You're buff too, don't feel bad!"

Mydei glares at Phainon and allows him to fuss over him like a petulant child for a few moments before smacking his hand away from his face. Despite that, he can't stay mad considering *he's* the one with Phainon's full attention now—not those random men online, nor any of the other teachers in the staffroom. He can hear Castorice and Cipher whispering behind him, but he doesn't pay them any attention as he wants to focus solely on Phainon while he has him to himself.

"Though, I guess for you, your physique is extra impressive, especially since—"

"Since I'm old?" Mydei supplies, peering down at Phainon with a flat look.

Phainon shoots up straight and Mydei instantly misses the weight of the other teacher pressed against him, his side now feeling cold and empty.

"I was *gonna* say for a history teacher! I promise, you don't look a day over thirty eight, Mr Kremnos," Phainon says, winking at him with a cheeky grin.

"You brat. I'll get you for that one later, so you better watch your back," Mydei replies, pointing at Phainon accusingly as he tries to keep his face as neutral as possible in fear of laughing.

"Is that a warning?" Phainon raises an eyebrow, but the grin is still on his face.

"If you keep saying things like that, it will be," Mydei cautions.

Phainon hums and gives Mydei a thorough once over with his eyes. "Is that a threat or a promise?" He asks, sticking his tongue out through his teeth, his expression pure mischief as they stare each other down.

Mydei feels the air in the staffroom thicken between them, yet again at the mercy of Phainon's taunts. "I can be threatening when I want to be, for a 'history teacher'" Mydei air quotes, a sharp smirk spreading across his face. "But where's the fun if I tell you beforehand?"

"I'm pretty good at hand to hand combat, so you're shit out of luck if you wanna take me off guard," Phainon says, voice sturdy and unwavering.

"Is that so?" Mydei begins, tilting his head to the side. "Aren't you the one threatening me now?"

"If you try anything, I'll have you on your knees before you can even blink."

"I don't think you can handle me," Mydei whispers, leaning in, almost jeering at Phainon. "I'm a bit of a handful."

Phainon's hums again, jaw clenching, muscles jumping in his cheeks. He looks *radiant*, blazing hot and ready to fight, to take down Mydei with the touch of his hands. Instead, it's the touch of his gaze that flattens Mydei to the sofa, as he looks him up and down again but this time *slower*. More purposeful. Phainon takes his time with it, propping his elbow up on the back of the sofa cushion and presses his chin onto his knuckles to support his head as his eyes flicker between Mydei's pecs that are obvious even through his shirt, over his biceps and then down to his thighs before making his way back up to Mydei's face.

"Pretty sure I could win against you either way," Phainon says slowly after finishing his evaluation, each word dripping with something Mydei can't quite place.

"I'm not so sure about that, Mr Khaslana," Mydei shifts around, folding one of his legs up onto the sofa so he can face the younger teacher properly. He mirrors him even further by propping his head up on his knuckles using the back of the sofa too so he can look at him the same way Phainon did.

Mydei's eyes dart over him—slowly, deliberately, making sure his gaze is as hot and heavy as he feels—taking in every inch as though he has all the time in the world to commit Phainon to memory. His eyes travel from tousled hair down to the tips of his trainers, lingering far longer on each place than he intends. It's so hard to look away, hard to draw his eyes back up when there's so much to look at before him. The dark blue P.E shirt and matching shorts look almost absurd on the other teachers, he thinks, but on

Phainon the colours warm his skin and highlight the silver-white trim and the neat embroidery of the school logo as if it was chosen just for him.

And of course, Phainon has his sleeves rolled all the way up to his shoulders again, exposing smooth skin and the kind of lightly defined muscle that Mydei's eyes trace over without permission. His shorts, already so short to begin with, are hitched up even further with the way he's folded his legs beneath him—leaving his thighs almost entirely bare. The sight sends a quick spark of *want* through Mydei's chest, sharp enough to steal his breath away.

He forces himself to remain composed, but it's difficult with Phainon sitting there so nicely for him, posed and still as a statue as if he's basking in Mydei's attention. Every detail seems designed to pull him closer, to test the limits of his restraint.

"I think you'd go down first, you look a little too easy," Mydei says finally, having finished taking his fill of Phainon for now.

Phainon's eyes flare dangerously at his words. The leather beneath them squeaks with movement as Phainon leans forward, not backing down from Mydei trying to one up him. The sofa cushions dip even lower in the middle, making them practically fall into each other, their noses almost brushing from the sudden closeness.

"Wouldn't you like to know," Phainon whispers, his words sending puffs of warm air over Mydei's lips.

Mydei's heart is crashing against his ribcage. A cruel smile spreads over his face—it's been so long since he's had his buttons pushed like this, and he doesn't want to disappoint.

"You'd have to do something worth me knowing first," Mydei replies, voice cold. It's a bold-faced lie—Phainon just has to walk into a room and Mydei would be there, wanting, curious and desperate to know everything. The gravitational pull he feels towards Phainon is too strong to deny himself of, and he just wants to be within Phainon's orbit at all times, no matter what.

Phainon bites down on his bottom lip, "Yeah? Like what?" He says, the words so breathy and hitched that Mydei feels his whole body tremble. His eyes zero in on Phainon's lips, watching the action with rapt attention. They look so soft and pretty, just like the rest of him when he isn't running his mouth. The way his bottom lip is slightly swollen from worrying at it means it would be so easy for Mydei to lean forward and capture it with his own mouth.

They're still so close that he hears it when Phainon swallows, the sharp click of his throat making him look back up to meet his gaze. Phainon's pupils are completely blown out, breathing turning rabbity the longer they watch each other. Mydei lets his arm drop down from his face to lie across the back of the sofa, his fingertips brushing against Phainon's elbow that's still propped up. The muscles in Phainon's arms twitch from the touch—the action so subtle he wonders if he imagined it.

Mydei's whole body is ablaze, the pit of his stomach swirling and tugging dangerously. There's only a few inches between them, the space so small and so vast at the same time. He can imagine them sparring at the gym—heavy handed, grappling and pawing, shoving one another down onto the

mat before being pushed back, neither one of them quite winning against the other. It'd be so *fun*, the challenge, the fight, the dire need to prove himself an equal against someone as strong as him.

"Phainon…" Mydei murmurs, the name heavy in his mouth with how desperate he feels. Phainon's lips part open, showing Mydei a glimpse of his tongue. His hands are itching to touch him, to press his thumb against his swollen bottom lip and see if Phainon opens up sweetly for him—he wants to see how far Phainon will let him go, see how much he can take in his mouth until it's too much, see who will back down first.

He wishes Phainon would touch him too, wishes that his hands were as curious and busy as his eyes that are roaming all over him, lingering on his clavicle between open buttons and the way his thighs are spread across the sofa, practically inviting him in. He wants and wants and wants, but it's too much, too little, too soon that it almost pains him.

The sound of a stack of papers being slammed down on a table makes them both jump out of their skin, leaping away from each other in fright. Phainon blinks rapidly, his skin rosy, and his chest heaving like he's just been fished out from being submerged underwater for too long. Mydei knows he's not faring any better, his hearing going in and out with how much blood is rushing through his veins.

"I, uh—" Phainon's voice breaks, which makes his cheeks glow an even brighter red. "Class. My class. It's time!" He stutters. Mydei barely understands what he's saying but nods along anyway.

"I'll see you later," Mydei says, words thick and cloying in his mouth. He clears his throat and halfheartedly gives Phainon a wave goodbye as he sprints out of the room.

As soon as Phainon has left, Mydei glances around the room without really seeing. He catches Castorice's gaze—which is glowing and glittery—and then he looks at Cipher who is scowling like she's just seen something revolting.

"Gods, the fucking stench in here after that," Cipher snipes, waving the papers in the air like she's wafting away a bad smell. Castorice nods sympathetically, and Mydei just stares at the door Phainon had left through forlornly.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

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let's be friends on twitter/x! (btw definitely check out the promo post for this series, it's got amazing art by criimsu included on it!! so give it lots of love okay?? hehe )

# Chapter 4: chapter four

Chapter Summary

His thoughts are cut off when there's a knock at his driver's side window, making him jump. He quickly hits pause on the music before it can get going again and he looks to his right, spotting Phainon there. Phainon's leaning over, peering through the car window at him as he waves a hand and a handsome smile appears over his face. Mydei's lips curdle at first, nerves still hitting him slightly, but then they flatten out into a tense smile of his own.

Phainon laughs, the sound muffled through the window, then he pulls back slightly to breathe fog onto it. Mydei's eyebrows raise as he watches on in confusion until Phainon draws a little smiley face into the condensation, quickly disappearing as soon as it comes. But nonetheless it existed, and before Mydei knows it he's smiling properly again, all tenseness and bundling nerves gone.

"You're looking extra pretty today, Mr Kremnos," Phainon says through the window, gesturing with his hand the line of his smile.

Chapter Notes

aaack i'm so sorry for the delay on getting this chapter out! i've not been very well so i kinda dropped off the face of the earth lol. but here's chapter 4, and with it technically their first not-date... HEHEHE

thank you so much to everyone who left lovely and amazing comments on this fic so far. i re-read them to cheer me up and it worked wonders fr... hopefully the next chapter won't take as long to get out as this one ^^;;;

enjoy reading! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei's phone buzzes on the counter just as he's dropping a ladleful of pancake batter into the pan. The sound has become familiar—expected, even—ever since he and Phainon exchanged numbers. Yet it still makes him pause in that same soft, startled way every time, a quiet flutter in his chest as if he hasn't quite adjusted to the fact that someone like Phainon keeps choosing to reach out to him.

He puts down his ladle and spatula and picks up his phone, grimacing when he realises he's still got a bit of flour on his hands. Mydei dusts it off quickly, taking a moment to smile at the blue heart which is still there. He's not entirely sure why Phainon added it—maybe he's gotten used to adding emojis next to his own contacts—but it makes a small smile appear on Mydei's face either way, a tiny, private one he'd never show anyone else or tell them the cause of it. It weirdly means a lot to him to have a bit of Phainon's personality show, even here, and especially now when the notification lights up his dim kitchen like a personal sunrise.

Their conversations have slowly taken on a rhythm of their own, woven into the fabric of his days: Phainon sending blurry photos of the moon at ungodly early hours, or voice notes where he rambles about lesson plans, or half-sarcastic texts complaining about staff briefings he still forgets to attend half the time if it wasn't for Cipher reminding him about them. And Mydei… Well, he's surprised by how easily he replies. He doesn't send any voice notes back—he has no idea how that part of his phone works, and he's too prideful to ask at this point—so he just reacts to the messages with a thumbs up and types his reply instead.

He especially likes the voice notes, where he gets to hear Phainon's voice through his tinny speaks and hear his laugh—always *ha ha ha*, each one separate, but it always sounds so genuine and full bodied that he figured out how to replay the notes so he can listen to it again and again in the privacy of his own home.

The pan sizzles beside him, a reminder that it shouldn't be left alone for too long—but surely he has a moment. *Just one moment*, he tells himself as he finally unlocks his phone, and it opens right up into their text messages.

**Phainon [06:36 am]**

i'm hungryyyyy

Mydei huffs a laugh and gives a quick glance over to the pan on the stove, and subtly turns down the heat just a little, just in case. He turns back to his phone and begins typing:

**Mydei [06:37 am]**

Then eat.

**Phainon [06:37 am]**

dont have anything in lol i forgot to pick smth up last night :-(

Mydei's brow creases. How is a P.E teacher supposed to work a full day of exercising without eating? That's completely ridiculous.

**Mydei [06:38 am]**

Do you have anything for lunch at least?

**Phainon [06:38 am]**

granola bar :-D

**Mydei [06:38 am]**

????

Is that it?

**Phainon [06:39 am]**

it'll be fineee i'm just complaining lol

He sighs, then looks between the pan and his phone, and an idea begins to form.

**Mydei [06:41 am]**

I'll make you something.

**Phainon [06:42 am]**

[Voice note]

Mydei lifts a hand up to his face to lightly cough behind, but also so he can hide the small smile on his face that's appeared, despite the fact that no one else is here. He presses play on the voice note, already preparing himself to hear Phainon's loud voice destroy the quiet in his kitchen.

"*Mydei! Will you really?! I didn't know you could cook*!"

Mydei scoffs at the incredulous tone.

**Mydei [06:43 am]**

Don't sound too surprised. I love cooking.

**Phainon [06:43 am]**

i'm sonxcicited

so excited**

Mydei's small smile blooms into a full, helpless grin—but it shatters the moment he inhales and catches the acrid scent of something *burning*. His heart lurches, and he drops his phone onto the counter with a dull clatter and scrambles for the spatula, flipping the pancake just in time. He breathes out in relief when he sees it's only a shade darker than he'd prefer… Tolerable, maybe, for himself. But for Phainon? Absolutely not. He can't give Phainon anything less than perfect—not when it's coming from him.

He lets the other side cook as he mentally rearranges his own breakfast plans. He has enough batter for four pancakes total, which is fine because he can split the amount in half and they can have two each. They're fairly large ones, anyway. So, a couple of pancakes with syrup on the side to avoid them getting soggy during transit and then also some berries should be sweet and warm enough to start the day off without being too sickly.

But lunch—that's a whole matter entirely. Something comforting? Something fresh? Something that will make Phainon smile the way he does over text? Mydei scratches the back of his head in thought, being careful not to pull out any hairs from his half up half down style. He then slides the slightly overcooked pancake onto a separate plate—the plate reserved for himself. His phone buzzes again, bright and insistent, but he refuses to look. Not until he gets these *right*.

The pan sizzles softly as he pours in more batter, the smell turning warm and buttery almost immediately. He watches closely, eyes narrowed in focus and spatula at the ready, waiting for the tiny air bubbles to rise and burst—his signal to flip. Each pancake after the first one turns out perfectly golden brown, pillowy in the centre and with crisped edges that flake off if you dare touch them.

Only once he's finished plating the two sets of pancakes does he finally let himself breathe. The kitchen is warm with the sweet scent of sugar and soft, rising batter, the air thick as he breathes it in. But he can't linger too long—he needs to get moving if he wants any chance of making it to school on time. He grabs a tupperware box from the cupboard and carefully tucks in two perfectly fluffy pancakes into the larger compartment, treating them with far more reverence than any breakfast should probably warrant.

Next, he fills a small pot with golden syrup, watching it pour like honeyed sunlight before sealing the lid tightly. Then come the berries—raspberries, blueberries, strawberries and blackberries—scattered all over the pancakes in a handful of bright colours. Hopefully Phainon likes them all, or they're both shit out of luck with this one. Still, Mydei smooths a thumb along the edge of the container once it's all packed away and sealed, and something warm and fluttery emerges in his chest as he imagines the younger teacher opening it later.

Mydei shakes his head, snapping himself out of it quickly. He doesn't have time to be standing here daydreaming, he needs to get a move on and get cooking so he can be out of his front door on time.

He steels himself and begins the walk over to his fridge, opening the door to peer into. He spots a few ingredients that *could* work… And then an idea hits him.

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Mydei isn't entirely sure how he managed to cook two sets of breakfasts *and* prep two lunches—all while still squeezing in enough time to scarf down his own—but somehow he pulls it off. By the time he's locking the front door behind him, he's still miraculously on schedule. If he keeps this pace, he'll reach the school grounds right around the same time Phainon does. The thought alone gives him a tiny little anticipatory bubbling in his chest.

The drive helps settle him. Titan's Mercy—one of the heavier metal bands he secretly adores—blasts through the speakers as he pulls into the car park,

the deep thrumming of bass vibrating the steering wheel. He bobs his head in time with the beat, fingers tapping out a rhythm against the leather as he eases the car into his usual space. The distortion-heavy guitar riff cuts through the morning quiet, steadying his beating heart and grounding him.

For a moment he sits there, letting the last few chords fade into the hum of the engine. He glances at the passenger seat where the neatly packed boxes rest in a carrier bag, and something warm and nervous coils low in his stomach. He hopes the pancakes didn't cool too much. He hopes Phainon likes the berries. He hopes—

His thoughts are cut off when there's a knock at his driver's side window, making him jump. He quickly hits pause on the music before it can get going again and he looks to his right, spotting Phainon there. Phainon's leaning over, peering through the car window at him as he waves a hand and a handsome smile appears over his face. Mydei's lips curdle at first, nerves still hitting him slightly, but then they flatten out into a tense smile of his own.

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"You're looking extra pretty today, Mr Kremnos," Phainon says through the window, gesturing with his hand the line of his smile.

Mydei's smile drops and forms into a scowl immediately, which only makes Phainon laugh harder. Mydei cuts the engine and grabs his satchel and carrier bag with the food in and opens the door, not caring that he slams it straight into Phainon's knees. Phainon jumps back, mumbling curses, but he never raises his voice at Mydei for it.

"Flatterer," Mydei mutters as he gets out of the car, shutting the door behind him and locking it swiftly.

"What was that?" Phainon asks, rubbing his knees and wincing. "That really hurt!"

"Stop being dramatic," Mydei replies and holds out the carrier bag. His own lunch is stored safely within his satchel. "Here."

Phainon stops messing around and stands up straight, eyes wide and curious as he gently takes the bag Mydei is offering him. He peers into it, not quite opening it up fully, to see what's in there. "Is this…?" He trails off, sounding slightly awed.

"It's your breakfast," Mydei says. "And lunch."

"You seriously made me food? I thought you were kidding since you never replied to me!" Phainon exclaims, blinking a few times in shock. "Thank you!"

"It's not much," Mydei feels the need to say. "But it'll keep you full for the day and full of energy—"

"Like I need more of that, right?" Phainon cuts him off, winking and poking Mydei in the shoulder playfully. "But no, seriously, thank you. I really appreciate this."

"…You're welcome," Mydei says eventually, the words making a light flush settle on his cheeks that he can easily blame on the cold weather if asked.

"What did you make me?" Phainon asks, shifting his weight from foot to foot, clearly excited.

"You'll have to wait and see," Mydei replies vaguely, and holds back a chuckle when Phainon frowns at him. "You should head in early so you can eat your breakfast and let it settle before your first period."

"Let me do your scarf first then," Phainon says, shuffling the bag up to catch on his inner elbow as he holds it out of the way.

"No need," Mydei waves him off. "I'll only be taking it off in a few minutes anyway."

"I know," Phainon says, but his hands are reaching up to undo Mydei's scarf. "But let me do this for you."

"You've already said thank you for the food," Mydei points out, holding his chin higher so Phainon can tie the knot easier.

Phainon is efficient at redoing his scarf now. His fingers work quickly, undoing it and smoothing it out before flipping it over itself and tying it around in a thick knot that doesn't easily come undone.

"There, done!" Phainon says, eyes narrowing in concentration as he finishes up. He pats over it like he always does before pulling away, dropping the carrier bag from his elbow down into his hand.

They head towards the reception doors together, their footsteps crunching softly over the thin layer of frost still clinging to the ground in the early morning's dew. Mydei steps ahead just enough to pull one of the glass doors open, holding it for Phainon. The younger teacher slips past him with a quiet, grateful bow of his head, his shoulder brushing lightly against Mydei's arm as he goes through.

The moment they step inside, a gentle wave of warmth greets them, a welcome contrast to the sharp, whistling wind behind them. The air inside carries the faint smell of polished floors and morning coffee drifting from behind the receptionist's desk. Mydei lets the door swing shut behind them and watches Phainon exhale, a soft puff of lingering cold dissolving into the heated air.

"I'll see you at lunch time?" Phainon asks, turning to face Mydei.

"Yeah, you will," Mydei replies softly, nodding at him.

Phainon grins at him, holding the carrier bag up between them. "I shall report back swiftly about any critiques or comments I have." He says in a faux-posh accent, ending it with a laugh.

"Oh, Mr Kremnos, Mr Khaslana," Aglaea says from behind the desk. She waves at them briefly.

"Good morning," They both say at the same time, their voices accidentally harmonising.

Aglaea looks up at them from her computer screen, a small, almost secret smile blossoming on her face. "It's good to see you took my advice, Mr Kremnos." She says.

Mydei bristles, remembering her telling him that Phainon *needed a friend*, or someone to guide him, and it's clear as they stand next to each other that they've become just that within a short amount of time.

"Advice? What advice?" Phainon asks, looking between them curiously.

"Doesn't matter," Mydei mumbles, grabbing onto the arm of Phainon's hoodie and encouraging him to start walking again. "Now get to work."

"Hey! I need to eat my delicious, homemade breakfast first," Phainon says, puffing out his chest and giving Mydei a confident smirk. "Made by the famous Mr Kremnos himself, did you know, Miss Aglaea?"

She hums, those eyes of her all too knowing as they pierce through Mydei as though they're seeing all his secrets and reading through them all. "Stop bragging and go eat then." Mydei says, his pull on Phainon becoming stronger until he's practically dragging him across the floors further into the building.

"I can brag all I want!" Phainon says, his smile so wide his eyes are almost shut, mooning closed sweetly. "Seeya later, Miss Aglaea!" He shouts as Mydei hauls him away from reception.

---

Mydei rarely brings his own lunch to work, preferring a large breakfast to carry him through the day and relying on a rotation of healthy snacks to bridge the gap in between—munching on them during breaks or sneaking a bite between classes while students shuffle in and out. So by the time lunchtime rolls around and he wanders into the staffroom, he isn't particularly hungry. The room smells faintly of coffee and someone's reheated pasta, the usual midday hum of exhausted teachers filling the space.

Beside him, Phainon is perched on the edge of his chair, eating the pomegranate seed salad Mydei packed for him this morning like it's the best meal he's ever had. He's been muttering to himself words that Mydei can't quite catch, and making indecent sounds as well as taking huge bites. He's already asked several times, but yet again he lifts his fork expectantly.

"Are you *sure* you don't want any?" Phainon asks for what has to be the millionth time at this point, voice muffled around a generous bite.

"I am very sure," Mydei replies with a huff of amusement, raising both hands in surrender to ward off the incoming forkful.

Phainon frowns like it's a personal tragedy and pointedly scoops up more lettuce, more feta, more pomegranate seeds until his fork can't carry any more, and then he shoves it in his mouth without an inch of decorum. He moans around the utensil, his eyelashes fluttering slightly as he chews, his blue eyes going in and out of focus as they turn hazy with delight. It's… Well, it's enough to set off something dark swirling around in Mydei's stomach, yet also something light tugging at his chest that sets it fluttering. Mydei continues watching him, trying (and failing) to stop the warm feelings rising at how earnestly Phainon is enjoying something he made for him.

He leans back in his chair, arms crossed loosely as he lets himself indulge in the moment—a quiet lunch, the soft clinking of cutlery, the way Phainon's knee keeps bumping lightly against his under the table like he's forgotten how close they're sitting.

So no, he's not hungry. He's plenty full just watching Phainon, his expressions changing like the Okhema weather as he finishes off his lunch, sitting back with a huff of contentment.

"I think that was the best thing I've ever eaten," Phainon says, rubbing his stomach happily. "Wait, no, maybe it was the pancakes you made me for breakfast… Ugh, they're both so good!" He turns to Mydei, eyes blinking at him imploringly. "How do I get you to make me dinner, too?"

"Ask nicely," Mydei replies, but then he rolls his eyes behind his glasses when Phainon perks up far too much.

"I can beg, I can totally do that," Phainon says far too quickly and earnestly, putting his hands up like a dog's paws as his eyes round out and turn dewy. "*Please*, Mydei? Mr Kremnos? Can you make me dinner?"

Mydei smacks him upside his head.

"Ouch!" Phainon exclaims, hands going straight to the back of his head where the sting should still be. Mydei made sure it wasn't *too* hard to hurt, but definitely enough to make him wince. "So cruel to me, Mydei!"

"Stop shouting," Mydei says, then he breathes in deeply, steeling himself. "I actually have a question for you."

"Oh?" Phainon's arms drop onto the table, any pain in his head suddenly forgotten. "What is it?"

"I was wondering…" Mydei trails off, shifting in his seat. "If you'd like to accompany me and my class to the National War Museum next week?"

"Was the food a ploy of buttering me up into saying yes?" Phainon asks, laughing. He shakes his head, "Playing chauffeur? Sure, that's fine by me."

"More like a chaperone," Mydei corrects. "We need another teacher to even out the student:teacher ratio, so I thought if you'd be up for it then you can come along."

Phainon blinks at him. "If I don't go, will you not be around for the whole day?"

Mydei tilts his head to the side, "Yes. I'll be gone for the full day."

Phainon sniffs and crosses his arms, sitting back in his chair again. "I'll definitely go then. Who would I hang out with at lunchtime?"

"Cipher or Castorice?" Mydei supplies, eyebrows raising.

"But I like hanging out with *you* the most," Phainon says so quietly that Mydei almost misses it, then he sits up again, packing away his tupperware.

Mydei's mouth parts slightly, but no words come. Phainon's honesty knocks the breath out of him, leaving him feeling strangely exposed—like he'd peeled back a little too much of himself just by asking the question. Because he thinks the same too, he likes spending time with Phainon the most, more than he ever expected after his first impressions of him. But they're long gone, long proven *wrong*, and he feels silly for having ever thought them in the first place.

Phainon is more than just an exercise obsessed young man. He's excitable, genuine, funny and silly all rolled into one, and although those qualities usually rub Mydei the wrong way and cause a clash in personalities, this time he's merely endeared towards it instead. Phainon knows when to be serious, when the situation calls for it and Mydei can tell he's adjusting, but then there's also times where he can openly be himself—loud, bright and endlessly charming.

The realisation warms his cheeks, a slow, blooming heat that he wishes he could stop. Still, he's grateful that Phainon agreed to come along. It means more moments together, more chances to fall into easy conversation and get to know him past being a P.E teacher. Even if most of their time will actually be spent corralling students and keeping chaos at bay, at least they'll be doing it side by side. Well, and Professor Anaxa will be there too, plus a few teaching assistants that volunteered as well…

Mydei sighs and pushes his glasses up the bridge of his nose, settling them higher up. "I'll forward the itinerary to your school email so you can have a read through it."

"I think I have it set up now… I went down to the I.T department the other week and got them to put it on my laptop."

Mydei nods his head, taking a sip of his tea. It's still slightly too hot, but it feels perfect as the heat slides down his throat, warming him up. "That's good. Makes it easier than sending it to Cipher, at least."

"Talking about me, are we?" Cipher's voice echoes from behind them, making them both jump.

Her and Castorice walk up to them, taking a seat opposite them at the table. Cipher's smirk is spelling out so many bad things for Mydei—full of mischief and havoc. "What are we discussing?" She asks.

"Nothing," Mydei says at the exact same time that Phainon says: "A museum trip!"

Mydei suddenly feels a headache coming on, a twang of tension going through his temples.

"Oh, a trip, hm? Just you two, or…?" Cipher trails off.

"It's with Mydei's class," Phainon explains, "I've never been to a war museum before…"

"Hah! You always invite *me* to come with you, now I'm being replaced?" Cipher says dramatically, although any ire in her voice is completely void with the fact that she's grinning, her fangs pointing outwards.

"I don't *always* invite you," Mydei says, but Cipher bulldozes straight over him:

"As soon as the new pretty boy is in town, I'm suddenly forgotten about, hm?" Cipher cajoles.

"You think I'm pretty?" Phainon asks, batting his eyelashes sweetly at Cipher while wiggling his fingers under his chin.

"Why don't we ask Mr Kremnos?" Cipher replies, then all eyes are on him, zeroing in. "Do you think our resident pretty boy lives up to the hype, Mydeimos?"

"I—" Mydei begins, looking between Cipher and Castorice while not daring to look at Phainon while put on the spot. He feels a blush warming his cheeks, turning them crimson. He sighs, the fight leaving him almost immediately. "Yes, I think you're pretty, Mr Khaslana." But it comes out too soft to be stern, too honest to be a lie, too *everything* that it feels like he's exposing his still developing feelings right then and there.

He braves it then, turning around to face Phainon, who's looking at him with round eyes and a gaping mouth. He's red up to the roots of his hair, turning his skin a dusty rose colour instead of the pale tone it usually is. Phainon laughs, a stilted *ha ha ha*, and scratches the back of his head as he looks down at the table top.

"Thanks, Mydei," Phainon says, although he sounds rather shy. "You'll all let it go to my head if you carry on."

Cipher coos at him and reaches across the table to pinch his cheeks, yanking his poor face around left and right before letting go. "You didn't blush when *I* called you pretty! What's with this favouritism that's going on lately? I'll start feeling left out if you're not careful."

"Sorry, Cipher," Phainon says, not sounding sorry at all as he rubs his swollen cheek. "But I *really* wanna go to the museum, so I'm not swapping places this time."

Cipher rolls her eyes, then nudges Castorice with her elbow. "You seeing this shit, Cas?" She asks.

Castorice nods enthusiastically, her hands clasped together underneath her chin as her eyes *sparkle*, bright and wide. "I think it's lovely."

"We've lost her," Cipher mutters. "Anyway, are you going to the National War Museum again?"

"Yes," Mydei replies. "I think this is the ninth year in a row we've gone now, but it's always a hit with the kids."

"How do you not get bored of it?" Phainon asks, pushing off from the table to rock back on his chair. Mydei sighs and grabs the backrest and shoves him back down so all four legs touch the ground.

"Don't make me tell you off like you're one of my students," Mydei grouses. Phainon laughs, but doesn't do it again. Instead, his leg starts bobbing up and down, restless. "I'm not saying it *isn't* boring, but the museum is pretty good at switching up exhibitions and such. They're doing a display on the Great Okhema War this time around, which is what we're studying."

"Oh! Cool, that sounds interesting," Phainon replies.

They don't get a chance to chat anymore as the warning bell rings, signalling there's five minutes left until classes end and that it's the end of lunch. They all stand up, gathering their stuff as they begin to shuffle out towards the door.

"Phainon," Mydei calls, and the younger teacher stops, turning around to face him. "Make sure you check your emails later, okay? I'll send you all the details, so I don't want any excuses if you're late."

"I won't be late! C'mon, Mr Kremnos, have some faith in me," Phainon says sulkily, kicking the toe of his shoe into the carpet.

"Even if we leave at seven in the morning?"

"Even if— Wait, seven?! That's so early, are you serious?" Phainon asks, mouth open in shock.

Mydei chuckles lightly and pats Phainon on the shoulder, "I suppose you'll have to wait and find out." And then he walks away, leaving Phainon standing in the staffroom for a few moments longer.

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The day of the museum trip dawns in soft watercolour hues, the early morning sky stretching open in delicate pastels as the lazy sun is barely in the sky. Mydei arrives while the morning is still tender, the air cool against his skin and carrying the faint scent of dew on grass. Sunlight gathers slowly at the edges of the school roof, warming the bricks in a washed out pale, golden glow.

The school grounds feel almost enchanted at this hour—hallways hushed, floors gleaming without any scuff marks on, every sound amplified by the quiet. The coach is already there waiting for them, and as Mydei stands outside the doors for it, he sees students arriving in groups as it gets closer to the departure time. They all seem a little sleepy still, their smiles hazy as

they greet him and clamber onto the vehicle, their excited murmurs muted. Mydei lets it surround him, the gentle chaos, but his eyes keep flickering towards the front gate, waiting for a familiar figure to arrive.

He checks his wristwatch—there are still twenty more minutes before they have to leave, but his nerves won't settle. He rocks his weight from one foot to the other, rubbing his hands together to chase away the cold that clings stubbornly to the morning air. The kids are all bundled up in thick winter coats and scarves, the sight of them dressing sensibly for once pleasing him. Every few seconds after checking his watch again Mydei pushes his hair behind his ear, only for the strands to slip loose again in a restless little loop that betrays just how impatient he's getting.

Mydei tells himself he's being ridiculous—there's no reason to feel this keyed up—but that doesn't stop his pulse from jumping at every set of approaching footsteps. Mydei glances up when he sees Professor Anaxa and the teaching assistants approaching, all gathered around each other as they're clearly in the middle of a heated debate.

"Good morning, Professor," Mydei says when they're close enough, and nods in greeting towards the TAs.

They all chime a *good morning* back and get onto the bus, taking their seats near the front away from the students. Mydei looks at his wristwatch one last time—ten minutes to go. All the students and teachers seem to be here, they're just waiting for a certain *someone* to appear and then they can finally set off. The noise inside the coach is steadily getting louder as the students wake up, gossiping and chatting amongst themselves with excited giggles accompanying them.

"Mr Kremnos!" A voice shouts, and Mydei perks up immediately, the frown creasing his features suddenly disappearing as he spots Phainon up ahead entering the gates, a few students surrounding him.

"Mr Khaslana, you made it," Mydei says, his happiness radiating through his words at seeing Phainon.

Phainon's dressed differently today. No shorts this time, but a pair of dark blue joggers that cling to his thighs before loosening around his calves. The change shouldn't affect Mydei as much as it does, yet he still gives Phainon a slow, appreciative once-over, quietly cataloguing the new look in the private archive of his mind. He looks *good*—unfairly good—in the school's winter P.E kit, the deep blue making his eyes seem even brighter.

Still… Mydei can't help the faint tug of longing for those tiny shorts Phainon usually wears, the ones that show off his legs so shamelessly. The joggers make more sense in this weather, and for once it seems like Phainon is starting to feel the cold like the rest of them. He's even got his hoodie zipped up to the top, his backpack firmly set on his back rather than loosely held over one shoulder.

"Kids, get on the coach. We're leaving in a few minutes," Mydei says, but he doesn't look away from Phainon who's watching him too, gesturing to the open doors for them to glide past him, clambering up the steps and into the vehicle.

"I see you're finally dressed for the weather," Mydei comments once the students are out of ear shot.

Phainon laughs brightly, scratching the back of his neck. "Yeah, well, I wasn't sure how much time we'd be spending outside today."

Mydei hums, "Not too long, probably just for a wander around the museum grounds and to eat lunch."

"Lunch—! Shoot, I forgot about that. Do they have a café there?"

Mydei purses his lips and sighs, "Don't worry, I packed extra. I had a hunch you'd forget."

"No way! You're seriously a life saver, Mr Kremnos," Phainon says, awed.

Mydei sighs and then notices that Phainon's hair is a bit of a mess, with what he assumes is a mixture of the wind playing around with it and also helmet hair. He reaches up to sort it out, wanting to feel those soft strands again, but he's stopped by a voice:

"Are you two done?" Anaxa says from the top of the coach's stairs, his one eye peering down at them with disdain as his arms are folded across his chest.

"We're coming," Mydei says back, dropping his hand before it ever had a chance to land and glancing at Phainon quickly before he climbs the steps and onto the coach, the sound of Phainon's footsteps behind him.

Mydei pauses at the front of the coach, letting his eyes sweep over the rows of seats. Most of them are already filled—clusters of students talking loudly, swapping snacks, or dozing against the windows. The back is a packed sea of chatter, but now that Anaxa has sat back down, there's one open space beside him. Mydei heads towards it, grateful for the safe, neutral option.

But before he can reach the seat, one of the students pops up like she's been waiting for her moment. Her friends behind her push and shove her into place until she slides neatly into the spot beside Anaxa, and flashes Mydei an apologetic, almost guilty smile.

"I have something I want to discuss with Professor Anaxa," She announces, as if that settles everything. "There's a free spot next to Mr Khaslana, though!" Her friend group bursts into giggles.

"Alright, settle down," Mydei says, eyes narrowed at them in suspicion. He's slightly baffled by their odd behaviour, but nods anyway at them. What else can he do?

He turns back to assess the aisle again—and that's when he realises she was telling the truth: the only open seat left is the one beside Phainon. The younger teacher sits by the window just behind the driver, the morning light

spilling over him in a soft glow as he fiddles absently with the strap of his bag.

Mydei exhales slowly. It's not that he doesn't want to sit next to him. It's that he's not entirely convinced he can handle being that close for an entire coach ride—shoulder to shoulder, knees brushing with every bump in the road, surrounded by the soft warmth and the scent of his masculine deodorant that he smells of that always seems to unravel him a little too easily.

Still, there's no avoiding it now. Mydei squares his shoulders, steels himself, and starts down the aisle towards Phainon. He hesitates for a heartbeat when he gets there, fingers tightening around the strap of his satchel as he stands, waiting to be noticed. He can feel the warmth creeping up his neck already, anticipation and dread tying themselves into tight, fluttering knots in his stomach. Of all the spare seats that could've been left, of course it had to be this one. It's not even like he's not used to sitting next to Phainon—he *is*, he does it all the time during lunch breaks now, but something about this feels closer, more personal.

Phainon looks up barely a split second later, and his face brightens instantly. That gentle, earnest smile spreading across his lips in a way that makes Mydei's heart falter in his chest. The sunlight streaming in through the window illuminates his hair, turning it a glowing silver, almost pure white, and for a ridiculous second, Mydei forgets how to breathe.

"Oh, looks like you're stuck with me!" Phainon says, scooting his bag onto the floor to make room. The teasing lilt in his voice is gentle, almost shy, but his eyes linger a moment too long on Mydei. "Hope that's okay."

Mydei forces himself to move, lowering into the seat with stiff, careful motions as if the smallest misstep might give him away. The space between them isn't much—barely a few inches—and he's acutely aware of the warmth radiating from Phainon, the faint scent of clean laundry and something spiced rising every time the younger teacher shifts, which is *a lot*. He's fidgeting.

"It's fine," Mydei murmurs, clearing his throat. "More than fine."

Phainon's knee brushes his, perhaps on accident, but he doesn't pull away, not immediately. His gaze flicks down, then up again, searching Mydei's face with something unreadable. The coach lurches into motion then and the student's chatter gets to an all time high, to which Anaxa yells at them all to be quiet. It doesn't quite work, but the sound gauge does drastically lower after that.

"Good," Phainon says quietly, as though afraid to be overheard despite everyone else in their own little worlds. "I like sitting next to you. I thought you'd abandoned me then for Prof Nax."

Mydei raises an eyebrow, "Do you call him that to his face?"

"Of course I do… *not*," Phainon chuckles. "I overheard the kids calling him that and he went ballistic at them, so I don't care. It's just less of a mouthful than his full name."

"You seem to struggle with full names, don't you? You still can't even say mine," Mydei replies, dropping his satchel on the floor between his feet.

"I can! I've been practising," Phainon says, and then he sits up straight and turns his shoulders towards Mydei, coughing lightly into his fist. "*Mydeimos*."

Phainon's voice goes all low and almost… *sultry*, as the younger teacher waggles his eyebrows at Mydei once he's said it. It's still not quite perfect, his slight farmer accent getting in the way of saying it right, but it still makes something fuzzy and static go through Mydei's spine.

"Wrong," Mydei says, just to spite him. His stomach swirls dangerously, and he fears if he hears it again, he might need to lie down for a moment.

Phainon harrumphs and mirrors Mydei's posture, folding his arms across his chest. "I'll get it one day, just you wait."

"I don't doubt that," Mydei says, chuckling lightly as he can't help it.

"Are you excited for the trip?" Phainon asks, changing the topic.

Mydei nods, relaxing back into the seat a little. "More than I thought I'd be. I'm looking forward to seeing the refurbishments that they've been working on since last year."

Phainon perks up at that, shifting towards him with genuine interest. Their knees brush again, but neither of them flinch away. "What kind of refurbishments?"

"Well…" Mydei begins. "They've redesigned the Great War wing. Expanded the trench reconstruction, updated all the interactive panels, and added new primary-source stations. Supposedly, the lighting and sound design are more immersive now too. Less outdated diorama, more walking into a memory."

Phainon's lips part in awe. "That sounds incredible. I've never been to a museum with that kind of setup before." His shoulder bumps Mydei's lightly as the coach turns a corner. "You'll have to tell me what's new and what's not. You know more about this than I do, I'm just here for fun."

"No, you'll be here to learn, too," Mydei assures. "It's hard not to when you're completely surrounded by it all. It's fascinating stuff, and I'm especially excited to see how the students react when we go into the interactive exhibits."

"Is there any stuff on antiques?" Phainon asks, tilting his head to the side. He looks like a curious puppy.

The coach hums along happily, joining onto the motorway after winding through smaller residential streets. The trip to the museum is about forty minutes on a good day, but with early morning traffic they could be looking at some delays. Mydei hopes that isn't the case, but that only means he gets

to sit next to Phainon for longer. Now that he's calmed down and thought about it, it's actually a *good* thing. They're friends now—at least, he hopes so—after spending lunchtimes together, so their chatting is familiar by now.

"Antiques? I… I think so," Mydei scrunches his face up in contemplation. "I'll have to check the leaflets when we get there to see. Why do you ask?"

"I love antiques," Phainon answers honestly, and his whole body brightens up, his eyes glistening. "I have a small collection of my own at home, little trinkets and such that I've picked up over the years. You never know what you can find in those tiny eclectic shops on the high street and markets!"

Mydei blinks at him in shock, having not expected this little hobby at all. "Well then, I definitely hope that they have some you can look at when we're there. I know they have plenty of things that were found on the battle ground—such as broken pots, machinery, and jewellery. Does that interest you?"

"Yes, definitely!" Phainon holds his hands in front of him, and they're clenched into fists like he can't contain himself. "Oh, I really can't wait now." He says, his leg bouncing up and down.

Mydei sighs fondly and places his hand over Phainon's knee to stop it from moving. Phainon looks down at it and then back up at Mydei, a sheepish smile coming over his face. "Sorry, I'll try not to do that."

"I don't want you exhausting yourself before we've even gotten there," Mydei explains and removes his hand, the warmth from Phainon's leg radiating through his thick joggers and onto Mydei's palm.

Phainon huffs a laugh, "Sure thing, Mr Kremnos," He says lightly, and then pulls out his phone from his pocket and starts typing.

Mydei takes that as the end of the conversation, and he settles back into his seat, adjusting his glasses slightly before he relaxes fully and watches the outside world from the front window.

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The museum doors glide open with a low hum, and the group filters through into the grand entrance hall—its ceiling stretching high above them like the open sky, banners of faded regimental colours hanging in long, solemn rows. Dust motes swirl in the shafts of light spilling in through the skylights, the air warm with the scent of polished wood and old parchment. Mydei inhales deeply; this place always feels like stepping into history itself, as though the walls still remember the echoes of the stories they protect.

"Alright, everyone," Mydei calls, his voice carrying easily in the vaulted space. The students gather, forming a loose semicircle around him. Even the teachers drift closer—Phainon included, standing just slightly behind his shoulder, listening with visible curiosity as his eyes wander around the museum's entry hall. "Stay with the group and keep the noise to a minimum. This isn't like last term's field trip—you're standing in a national archive of our past. Treat it with respect."

They nod, and Mydei leads them towards the first exhibition hall. The doors open into a dimmer room, lit by soft golden lights that cast a warm glow over the displays. The walls are lined with murals depicting sweeping landscapes—mountains cracked by artillery fire, plains scorched into mosaics, and cities swallowed by toxic fogs. Beneath them, glass cases display relics: dented breastplates, shattered blades, handwritten letters, and ration tokens worn smooth by touch.

"This," Mydei begins, his voice lowering reverently. "Is the Hall of Origins—the beginning of the Great War of Okhema." He gestures to the panoramic mural stretching across the left wall where two armies are painted mid-charge, weapons raised. "Most people think it started with the assassination of High Regent Cerydra, but that was only the spark. The tensions had been simmering for decades between Oleinus Highlands and Okhema City."

The students edge closer, whispering amongst themselves. Mydei lets them off, they're clearly digesting everything they're hearing—it's stuff they already know, but he's more so doing it for the Phainon so he can learn about what he's teaching too.

Mydei continues, "Trade disputes, border conflicts, political sabotage… Oleinus and Okhema had been playing a dangerous game for years. Cerydra's death was just the moment the world finally flipped."

Phainon listens with wide eyes, his shoulder brushing Mydei's whenever the group shuffles forward. Mydei pretends not to notice the warmth radiating from him, or the steady presence by his side, but he can't help but look at

him through his peripheral vision. He can't afford to get distracted—especially not in front of the students and other teachers.

Mydei leads them to the next display: a massive, circular projection table. With a soft hum and a quiet click, it lights up, displaying a three-dimensional map of the world as it was a century ago—fractured into colour-coded alliances.

"This map shows you the alliances at the start of the war," Mydei says, tapping a small panel. The hologram shifts, highlighting borders in flashing lights. "The Pact of Twelve—here—banded together in response to the Oleinus advance. But as the war dragged on, loyalties… Shifted." He presses another button, and the borders scramble again. Some of the students gasp, their eyes as wide as Phainon's.

"Whoa," Phainon whispers under his breath, just loud enough for Mydei to hear. Mydei turns his head towards him and grins, sharp and pleased.

"Interesting stuff, huh?" Mydei says. "The Great War wasn't just battles like most lead you to believe. It was mostly political unravelling. Families divided, and decades of treaties undone in months."

They move deeper into the hall. Mydei guides them to a towering display: a full skeletal depiction of a Dromas. Mydei goes to open his mouth to explain what it is and how they were used during the war, but Anaxa beats him to it.

Everyone turns to him when he begins to speak, his index finger pointing upwards as he explains: "The dromases were a peaceful species. They were created by Georios, the 'Titan of Earth'—one of the Twelve—who helped during the Great War battle against Oleinus. Warriors rode on the backs of dromases, who were said to have such a powerful stomp it could take out thirty to fifty enemy warriors in one go."

Phainon whistles, looking up at the Dromas that towers above them. "I've seen pictures of them, but it's something else in person! They're *huge*!"

"They really are," Mydei agrees, standing next to Phainon while Anaxa rambles on. He's got the attention of the kids at least, so that's all that really matters. "They were breathtaking. Terrifying, but breathtaking. Thankfully though, they had very mild natures outside of battle."

"No way, seriously? Like… A pet?"

"Exactly like a pet, they were domesticated, after all," Mydei says.

As they chat, the students wander closer, carefully studying the bones. Mydei catches a few of them sketching it for later notes. Pride swells subtly in his chest—this is the part of teaching he lives for: the spark of *genuine* interest.

They continue through the galleries—past preserved uniforms, war-time poetry etched into metal sheets, and diaries sealed behind thick glass. Mydei's voice softens when he reads aloud from one:

"*If morning comes and we still stand here, then I shall write home. If dusk comes instead, tell them I didn't run.*"

A hush falls over the group, even the teachers stopping their chattering in the back. Phainon steps closer again, eyes wide and dewy as he peers over the display, his eyes scanning the scribbled words laid bare in the diary.

"Fascinating," He says quietly, to himself more than anyone else, Mydei assumes. "This is stunningly preserved. And the words…"

"Hm, has it caught your eye?" Mydei asks, leaning into Phainon's space so they can both look at it together.

"I'm trained in looking out for treasures, Mr Kremnos," Phainon says, drawing back slightly so he can turn his head and look at Mydei. They're suddenly close, closer than before, their noses almost brushing from the lack of space between them. Mydei's breath hitches, and he implores himself to not look down at Phainon's lips. He instead stares into his blue eyes, and sees a slight reflection of himself in them. "And I think I've found one." Phainon finishes, looking directly at Mydei still, never taking his eyes off of him.

Mydei feels a flush building on his cheeks, warming them. He clears his throat and breaks their eye contact first, staring down at the open diary. "It is a rather beautifully bound book."

"Who knows," Phainon replies vaguely, humming as he smiles softly at Mydei before he rocks back onto the balls of his feet and turns around to the rest of the class. "Where to next?" He asks, and the spell between them is broken.

"Alright," Mydei begins, clearing his throat as he wills his cheeks to cool down. "Let's head to the next hall. There's still the Reconstruction Wing and the Hall of Fallen Cities to go through before lunch."

The students eagerly follow, their phones all out as they take photos of the displays for later, their notepads full of facts and tid-bits they've picked up along the way.

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Lunchtime rolls around quicker than expected, and as students and teachers alike scatter across the outdoor benches, Mydei somehow ends up sharing a table with Phainon. They sit opposite each other beneath a pale spring sun that offers more light than heat, and Mydei silently curses himself for not bringing a flask of hot tea to enjoy with his sandwiches. Instead, he has to make do with a lukewarm bottle of water he grabbed from the café earlier, turning it between his palms as if friction alone might warm him.

Across from him, Phainon is happily demolishing the sandwiches Mydei prepared that morning, his enthusiasm almost comically earnest. The quiet chirping of birds fills the silence between them, blending with the distant chatter of students. Mydei keeps his gaze on his own lunch, pretending not to notice how Phainon stuffs his cheeks full until he looks more like a startled chipmunk than a grown man. But every few moments, despite

himself, Mydei glances up—just to make sure Phainon's enjoying his food, of course. No other reason.

"Gods, you're a messy eater," Mydei comments as he takes a gulp of water. He winces at it and quickly puts the cap back on. He whips out a handkerchief from his jacket pocket and leans over the bench, wiping away crumbs that are dusted around his mouth. Mydei clicks his tongue and gives his napkin a few flicks to get rid of the debris.

"It's because you make such good food," Phainon replies, a big silly grin on his face. His eyes shine in the sunlight prettily.

"They're just ham sandwiches," Mydei remarks, taking a bite of his own. He filled it with plenty of ham, mayonnaise, lettuce and tomatoes because he thought it might be more filling than a plain sandwich would've been.

"Mmm, but I only usually get the cheap stuff from the supermarket. You probably get thick cuts from a deli counter, right?" Phainon says, polishing off the last bite of his sandwich. He sighs happily, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand.

Mydei cringes and offers his handkerchief out to Phainon again, who happily takes it and rubs it over his mouth until it looks sore. He really is like a child sometimes, Mydei thinks, albeit strangely fondly. It's kind of cute, he admits against his will.

"I do," Mydei says, a little embarrassed at being so easily seen through with his shopping habits. "Good ingredients don't always make a dish, but it's nice to go all out sometimes."

"Agreed," Phainon nods, "Although I don't know much about cooking outside of making salads… I still think about the one you made me the other week."

"I can send you the recipe if you'd like?" Mydei asks, already getting his phone out to text Phainon the full thing.

"Sure! Thanks, Myd— Mr Kremnos," Phainon replies, stumbling on his name.

Mydei doesn't say anything and doesn't call him out on the almost slip up, and graciously accepts his handkerchief back from Phainon. "It's almost time to get going again," Mydei says after he's sent Phainon the text with the recipe in for the pomegranate seed salad he'd made him.

"Aw, but it feels like lunch only just started…" Phainon replies, pouting slightly.

"It's free time for the students, so you're welcome to stay here for the next hour or so while we all go back inside," Mydei says flatly, already knowing that Phainon will protest.

"No, no! I'll come back in, I wanna take a look at the relics," Phainon says, shaking his head. "I saw some cool ones in the entrance, so I'll probably go straight there first."

"I'll join you, then," Mydei says, then pauses. "If you don't mind…?"

Phainon laughs, waving his hand. "Of course I don't mind! Maybe you'll know all about them and can teach me." He says, resting his elbows on the edge of the table as he places his chin in his palm. Phainon looks up at Mydei through his lashes, "You're really cool when you're in the *zone*."

"You mean when I'm blathering on about history?" Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow.

"No! I'm serious, that passion is super cool. I like it," Phainon says. "I like passionate people."

Mydei clears his throat and shifts in his seat slightly at the praise, not really knowing what to say or do. "It's just how I've always been." He finally settles on saying.

"I can tell," Phainon replies, and his smile is small but no less genuine or bright. "So teach me more, Mr Kremnos."

The way he says his name… Mydei shivers slightly, a tingle going down his spine. "Sure," He replies simply, clearing his throat. He gathers their rubbish in his hand and gets up from the bench, jogging over to the trash can further away on the field. He dumps it in and takes a moment to steady himself, breathing in and out deeply before he turns back around and makes his way over to Phainon again.

"It's time to get moving," Mydei says, packing away the tupperware he brought with him back into his satchel, dumping his water bottle in there. He'll pop it in the fridge once he gets home so it's actually drinkable for him.

"Class!" He shouts, and everyone turns their heads towards him. "It's time to get back into the museum. It's free time, so you're allowed to wander around for an hour before heading back onto the coach. Behave, don't get lost, stay on the museum grounds and *don't* be late, okay?" He warns.

Everyone nods and starts getting up from the benches, packing away their lunch stuff swiftly until they're all following Mydei back into the building like little ducklings. He huffs a silent laugh at that thought, and Phainon looks at him quizzically. He shakes his head and they continue onwards until they're standing in the entrance hall again.

They form a loose semicircle around Mydei again, waiting for further instructions. "Like I said, behave and remain respectful. I'll see you all back here in an hour. Go enjoy yourself, the gift shop is still open so if any of you brought any change, go have a look!"

The students and other teachers all dispatch, wandering off immediately all in different directions. Mydei sighs and hopes there will be no trouble when it comes to gathering everyone back up again in time for the coach home. He doesn't want to be stuck here after closing time looking for rogue students who lost track of time.

"Coming?" Phainon asks him, smiling.

"Lead the way, Mr Khaslana," Mydei says, gesturing out into the hall.

Phainon laughs—bright and boyish—and starts walking ahead, hands tucked into the pockets of his joggers as he leads them deeper into the gallery. Mydei follows a step behind, watching the way Phainon's head turns left and right, his hair swishing with the movement and those two silly strands on top bobbing along. He's clearly drinking everything in with curious, eager eyes. It's endearing, painfully so, and Mydei lets himself admire him for just a moment longer before refocusing on the displays.

They stop in front of a row of tall glass cases—three of them to be exact, each lit from above so that the relics inside glow faintly in the warm museum light.

"Ah, these are interesting," Mydei comments as soon as he recognises them.

Phainon steps closer too, leaning forward slightly, palms braced on the railing as he peers inside. "What are they?" He asks, voice hushed as if the artefacts might wake if he's too noisy.

Mydei joins him at the railing, their shoulders nearly brushing as he places his hands on top of the cool metal, their pinkie fingers touching. "These," He begins, trying to keep his voice neutral as their contact makes his heart begin to beat faster. "Are personal effects recovered from the Battle of The Black Tide. They belonged to soldiers from both sides."

The first case holds a battered metal canteen, dented and scorched, rusted around the rim. Its straps are frayed, one side torn off completely. Beneath it lies a set of dog tags—two fused together by fire, the writing on them no longer legible. The next one holds a broken pocket watch, the glass surface shined and bright, glinting in the overhead light as if it still works. The third case displays a letter, opened and undelivered.

"Some hard hitting stuff," Phainon remarks, lifting his other hand to point at the letter so their pinkies are still touching. "I still can't believe how long that's survived. How long ago was the battle, like, almost two hundred years ago, right?"

"Correct," Mydei says, nodding firmly. "But there's much older stuff in this museum, on the top floors. Then you're going into ancient times. Would you like to see?"

"Sure!" Phainon says excitedly, and then he's pulling away, the warmth from his shoulder and hand disappearing along with him as he begins to briskly walk off, almost breaking into a run towards the stairs.

"Mr Khaslana!" Mydei calls after him, refusing to run within the museum. "No running!"

"Oh, shoot, yeah," Phainon says, skidding to a stop. He turns around and waits for Mydei to catch up, rubbing his neck sheepishly.

"Do I need to hold your hand like a child so you don't go running off again, Mr Khaslana?" Mydei reprimands, voice stern and eyebrows furrowed.

Phainon giggles—*giggles*—and holds his hand out towards Mydei, palm up. "You can hold my hand if you'd like, Mr Kremnos."

Mydei pauses, looking down at Phainon's large hand being offered to him. His eyes trace over the lines on his palm, the smooth skin not giving away any secrets. He wants to take it, wants to reach out and entwine their fingers together, wants to feel their skin brushing against one another without having to be squirrelled away subtly. Without thinking, he lifts up his hand until their palms are hovering over each other, his fingertips brushing against Phainon's. Then, suddenly, he comes back to himself and snatches his hand away, accidentally clipping Phainon's palm with his fingernails.

"Ow!" Phainon exclaims, looking down at his palm with a frown before he lets his arm drop down back beside him.

"I'm sorry," Mydei says quickly but honestly, his hands hovering outwards as though to grab Phainon's hand and inspect it himself for damage. He doesn't, though, and lets his arms down, his shoulders sagging.

"It's fine, it didn't hurt," Phainon says, offering him a placating smile. "Although I can't say I'm in a rush to offer my hand to you again, Mr Kremnos." He laughs.

Mydei rolls his eyes and begins the walk up the stairs, listening to Phainon cackling behind him.

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By the time the museum trip winds down, darkness has descended upon the sky. It's even colder than before, as each breath Mydei takes, a puff of clouded air comes out in return. The students are still somehow buzzing with chatter, but their energy is starting to fray around the edges as he catches a few of them yawning after such a busy day. Mydei watches them pile onto the coach in waves, their laughter and shouts mingling with the occasional groan of tired limbs. Phainon helps shepherd the last few stragglers, giving gentle reminders about hurrying up and some playful nudges as he goes.

Once everyone is settled, Mydei takes a seat near the front, and Phainon slides in easily next to him. The sun is completely gone now, but there's still some streaks of gold in the sky, lingering. The warmth of the coach is welcome as he settles down. The hum of the engine mixed with the quiet murmurs of exhausted students all creates a lullaby of some sorts, and he's not surprised when he looks over to face Phainon that the younger teacher's eyes are drooping sleepily, his head nodding back and forth as he tries to fend off sleep.

"Have a nap," Mydei whispers, startling Phainon slightly. He looks over at him, half-lidded but no less bright.

"I think I'm gonna have to," Phainon slurs out, rubbing one of his eyes with his fist. He leans back into the plush coach chair and closes his eyes, but almost immediately his head lolls to the side, landing on Mydei's shoulder.

Mydei tenses, nearly jumping out of his skin, but he tries to keep any outward reaction to a minimum as he feels the steady rise and fall of Phainon's breath. He can't believe he's out cold already, just like that? He's almost jealous, having to spend most nights tossing and turning until sleep claims him. Maybe Phainon just has nothing to worry about, or maybe he feels safe right now, curled up into Mydei's side. Mydei feels his own eyes begin to droop with fatigue, but he stares ahead instead of at the top of Phainon's head even as the strands tickle his cheek. He doesn't want to fall asleep, he wants to continue feeling the warmth and weight of Phainon resting on him, watch his eyelashes flutter slightly as he dreams and his lips part and close again.

Before he knows it, Mydei's head rests atop Phainon's, and he's fast asleep.

…

"—lana, Mr Kremnos!"

Mydei grumbles, face scrunching up as voices infiltrate his sleep. He adjusts himself in his spot, settling down again.

"Mr Kremnos? Whoa, they're seriously flat out right now."

Then there's a click of a camera and a flash going off behind his eyelids.

"Stupid! You forgot to turn it off!"

Mydei's eyes instantly open, and he realises he's surrounded by a gaggle of students, all of them peering at him and Phainon—who is still snuggled into his side, and Mydei's cheek pressed on top of his head. He sits up straight, jarring Phainon awake with his sudden movement. He adjusts his glasses frantically, eyes blinking and wide as everything sets in.

The coach isn't moving anymore.

"Are we back at the school?" Phainon asks from beside him, his voice droning from just having woken up. It's deeper than usual, Mydei notices, but he shakes himself out of it as the bunch of students are still there, watching them.

"Whoever took a photo, delete it immediately or you're all going in for a week's detention," Mydei declares, raising his voice so the entire coach can hear him.

The students all spring into action, laughing loudly and running out of the coach, sprinting away without giving Mydei a chance to reprimand them again for their shenanigans.

"Those kids…" Mydei grouses, more to himself than to anyone else, but Phainon still laughs.

"Sorry about sleeping on you, Mr Kremnos," Phainon says as he gets up, shuffling out of his seat and into the aisle.

Mydei sighs and picks up his satchel from the floor, joining Phainon in the aisle. It's a tight squeeze, their fronts pressed together, but neither of them move as they're now alone on the coach except for the driver who's on his phone.

"No problem," Mydei says gruffly, then he slides over and past Phainon, trying not to think too much about the contact until he's safely off the coach. He turns around to Phainon who's climbing down the steps and jumps the last one, landing on the pavement with a *slap* of his trainers.

"I'll see you tomorrow, Mydei," Phainon says, waving at Mydei.

"Mhm, tomorrow," Mydei says and watches as Phainon begins to walk off towards his bike. He breathes in the night air, cold and soothing, and calls after the younger teacher: "Get home safely!"

Phainon turns around and walks backwards, giving Mydei another big wave with his whole arm this time. "You too!" And then he's running through the car park, leaving Mydei on his own.

Mydei scratches his cheek, still feeling the phantom tickle of Phainon's hair against it.

Chapter End Notes

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

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let's be friends on twitter/x! (although i'm no longer really active on there anymore LOL oh well, maybe i'll return...)

# Chapter 5: chapter five

Chapter Summary

> Phainon's eyes narrow in on him immediately after his answer, glittering with mischief. He prowls back over to where Mydei is still standing by the doors, making Mydei feel like he's being hunted down by a wild animal. Once Phainon is close enough to do so, he reaches a hand up to place on his shoulder. The touch is so light Mydei can barely feel it through his suit jacket, but it still sends shivers down his arm regardless. Phainon hums to himself, eyes contemplative as he drags the fingertip of his index finger down from his shoulder, stopping when he reaches the middle of Mydei's bicep.
>
> "What if I want to see these in action?" Phainon asks coyly, wrapping his fingers around his arm, but they barely begin to cover any of the circumference.

Chapter Notes

> thanks for everyone who's sticking around and reading this whenever i update it, you're the reason i'm still writing this fic despite everything else
>
> enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Oh, hells!" Mydei yells into his empty classroom, scooting back his desk chair so he can survey the damage he's just caused. He glances down at his now ruined white shirt that's been completely soaked in coffee, and the only emotions at seeing such a mess are defeat and exhaustion. Thankfully, he'd been lounging back in his chair so it *just* missed the paperwork on his desk. It would've been a literal nightmare to explain to his students about how their work was ruined because of his own carelessness.

Because that's what this was—carelessness. No one had bumped into him, no one had knocked it over on accident, *no*—he'd just completely missed his mouth because he was thinking of a certain white haired teacher. Mydei's brain won't stop replaying what happened the other week in the staffroom, images going around and around over and over again. It haunts him in bed at night and well into the daylight hours, too. He can't get it out of his head how *willing* he was to kiss Phainon in the middle of the room, right in front of his co-workers that he'd forgotten were even there in the first place. It was like everything had narrowed down into a pinpoint on just them, the rest of the world falling away from focus as he watched Phainon watching him.

If Phainon had asked him to do anything in that moment, or had pushed a little harder, Mydei would've done it—and that scares him, but even worse he would've *wanted* to as well. He would've kissed Phainon if he'd asked nicely, or rudely, or just plainly demanded. He would've thrown away his dignity (however little is left after all this) and would've kissed that damned mouth to get him to *shut up*.

"Gods damn it," Mydei curses, realising he's zoned out again thinking of Phainon. The coffee on his shirt is still there, unfortunately, and has now cooled down so that it just feels uncomfortably sticky against his skin. It then occurs to him that the only place in the school that stores spare clothes is the P.E department—which means if he wants to be stain-free for the rest of the day, that's the only option he has.

Mydei goes through Phainon's timetable in his head as he tries to confirm where he could be right now. If he remembers correctly, Phainon should be in a lesson, so thankfully he won't have to worry about bumping into him while in this sorry state. He's not sure he could look the younger teacher in the eye if that was the case. Mydei sighs, long and suffering, and puts his

suit jacket on to try and hide the majority of the stain as he begins the walk over to East Block.

He's practically shivering once he reaches the office, the wind completely cutting through him due to the wet material making it feel like ice against his skin. Mydei knocks on the door and waits.

"Come in!" A voice says, and Mydei pushes the door open to the office, not sparing the other person a glance as he turns around to shut the door behind him.

"Do you have any spare shirts?" Mydei asks, beginning to turn around.

"Mydei?" The voice that let him in earlier says, and Mydei feels a flood of dread run through him when he realises who it is.

He turns around fully to Phainon, facing him head on, who's sitting at a desk looking at Mydei with wide eyes and concern plastered across his face.

"What happened?" Phainon questions, staring at directly at the wet patch that his suit jacket couldn't quite cover.

"…I spilled my coffee," Mydei says, trying to push back on feeling any shame as he's face to face with the cause of the accident.

"Did you burn yourself?" Phainon asks, shooting up from his seat to rush over to Mydei. He raises his hands up as if he wants to touch and check, but very thankfully he keeps those wandering hands to himself for once. Mydei isn't sure he can handle Phainon touching all over him right now, even if it is out of concern.

"No, it was lukewarm. I just came here to ask if you had something I could change into."

Phainon tears his eyes away from Mydei's chest to look at his face instead. "We should do. Miss Aglaea had a clear out of the lost and found the other week and donated a few pieces to us. I think it's mostly all kids sizes, though…" He trails off, then he clicks his fingers. "I wonder if one of Nikolas's t-shirts is in there. Let me check."

Mydei nods and follows Phainon over to where they keep the lost and found box. Phainon heaves it up onto the desk and they sort through it together, but each item they come across near the top seems to be either pairs of shorts or joggers, none of which will help Mydei in the slightest.

"I swear we had one…" Phainon says to himself, sticking his arm right into the bottom of the box so he can grab the lower buried items. He grins, clearly having latched onto something promising, and yanks it out quickly. "Here it is! It should be okay," Phainon holds it up to show Mydei, but when they both see the whole thing, they both go silent in shock.

"Phainon," Mydei grits out through his teeth, eyes narrowing. It only earns him a nervous laugh in response. "I can't wear *that*."

"Why not?" Phainon asks, handing it over to Mydei to take as he tries very hard not to laugh. "I think it'll be a perfect fit!"

"Yeah, for a *toddler*! Why is his shirt so small?!"

"Oh, leave it alone! He must've had a washing mishap," Phainon replies, jutting his bottom lip out slightly. He briefly pulls the shirt back and holds it up again by the shoulders, pulling at the material. "It's still super stretchy at least?" He reassures, though he doesn't look convinced by either his own words or demonstration.

Mydei considers shoving the shirt up where the sun doesn't shine just so he never has to look at it again, but he really doesn't want to spend the rest of the afternoon stinking of stale coffee and having a physical reminder of what a dumb-struck idiot he is at the moment. His shirt is beyond saving right now until he can get home and hand wash the stain out, so he snatches the shirt out of Phainon's hands in a huff.

"It's not my fault that you're fuc— *freaking* huge, Mr Kremnos! You can borrow one of my hoodies instead if you'd like?"

"No," Mydei chokes out, refusing to walk around topless and only in Phainon's hoodie that will smell of his masculine deodorant and remind him of Phainon even more than he already is, making his distracted mind a true

danger to society. At least the shirt he's currently holding is freshly washed and smells of nothing but generic detergent.

Phainon shrugs his shoulders at the blunt dismissal and sits back down at his desk, putting the lost and found box on the floor for now.

"Are you—" Phainon begins when he sits back up, but cuts off with a sudden squeak. "What are you doing?!"

Mydei has shucked off his suit jacket and placed it neatly on the desk as he works on undoing his shirt buttons, and he's about to unbutton the final one when he stops at Phainon's outburst. He pauses, hands stilling, eyebrows raising.

"Getting changed?" He says, taking off his shirt. He grimaces when he gets a clear view of how large of a coffee stain he has on his chest—he's not even sure how the hell barely half a mug of coffee could make such a mess, but he's just glad it's dried off now. "Do you have any paper towels?"

"Uh—" Phainon is bright red, his cheeks so warm they're almost glowing. "Yeah." He finishes, sounding practically robotic.

He stands up and grabs some kitchen roll on the side counter, walking over to Mydei as he rips off a few sheets. Phainon balls it up and leans in, and Mydei's eyes widen as he realises what he's going to do before he can stop it. Phainon dabs at Mydei's chest with the paper towel, and his touch is

gentler than he expected, not letting the rough surface rub raw against his skin.

"You're lucky it wasn't hot or you'd be straight down to Hyacine's office," Phainon says as he works on getting the coffee off his chest, and Mydei stares resolutely ahead so he doesn't have to think about the way Phainon's hair is tickling his skin from being so close.

"Good thing it was practically finished so there wasn't much left in the mug," Mydei says, glad his voice doesn't shake when he speaks.

Phainon hums, and Mydei can't help but shiver when he feels the warm air brush against his chest. He feels his nipples pebbling, growing hard in the coolness of the room and Phainon's touch. Mydei clears his throat, but before he can speak he's cut off:

"Your tattoos are *awesome*, by the way," Phainon says, his voice full of awe. "How far down do they go?" He asks, poking Mydei's bare hip where one of the red swirls disappears into the waistband of his trousers. He then hooks his fingertip into the waistband, tugging at it suggestively.

Mydei grits his teeth, swallowing down a gasp. "All the way down. I have them all over my body."

Phainon glances up at him through his lashes, lips parted and eyes shining with curiosity. "Can I—"

"I'm not taking any more clothing off just for you to look," Mydei replies sharply, his ears warming at the thought. This is already humiliating enough as is.

Phainon pouts, cheeks puffing out childishly. He harrumphs, pulling back his hand with the paper towel in. "Fine, I guess." He gives Mydei's chest a once over quickly, not lingering. "The stain is mostly gone now, you'll have to shower the rest off later."

"Thanks for your advice," Mydei replies, rolling his eyes. He shakes his head as Phainon turns around and chucks the paper towel into the bin across the room like he would a basketball.

"Nice! I got it in!" Phainon says, fist pumping in sheer joy.

Mydei scoffs, but it comes out more as a soft laugh instead much to his dismay. Phainon grins at him over his shoulder and makes his way back to his desk, flopping down into the chair. "You're still going to get changed here?" He asks, gesturing to the shirt and then to Mydei.

Mydei snatches it up from the desk, glaring at it resolutely. He doesn't want to put it on, but the other options available to him aren't going to happen. He knows he's being petty—childish, even—about denying wearing Phainon's hoodie which is clearly the better option, but he's got an image to uphold and his sanity to work on. The t-shirt should be the same dark blue as Phainon's P.E kit, but instead the colour is so faded it looks like it's been through a few bleach baths. Seeing this, Mydei suddenly doesn't feel too

bad about that one time a few weeks ago where he messed up his own washing by accident.

"Well I'm not exactly going to go into the bathrooms looking like this," Mydei snarks. He'll have to try and get this thing on eventually, what with goosebumps rippling across his skin from Phainon's gaze and the coldness in the room, and there's no way he's putting his dirty shirt back on now.

Mydei peers down at the offending item over his glasses, giving it a few tugs at the seams to see if it really is stretchy. It moves easily with the pulling, so maybe it *will* fit despite being a few sizes too small. He adjusts his glasses higher up his nose and stretches the neck over his head so it doesn't catch on them. The stitching makes a suspicious ripping sound once he gets it further down, but then there's just enough give that he can actually move enough to get his arms through the sleeves.

"Are you sure this is the only shirt left?" Mydei wheezes, wrestling with it to try and get it over his chest. It digs uncomfortably into his pecs, making them half bulge out at the bottom and feel like they're being compressed on the top half. The hem is scraping right over his hardened nipples too, which makes him jerk from the sensitivity. It's like a whole body workout trying to get this t-shirt on, but once it's over the swell of his chest it goes down easily over his slimmer torso.

Mydei stares down at his body with disdain, feeling absolutely ridiculous in it. It's clinging horribly to each ridge and bump of his body, and doesn't even reach the top of his trousers either, leaving a thick stripe of skin bare around his waist. He scratches over his stomach, feeling the hair from his happy trail. The cold air makes him shiver, and he hopes Phainon isn't about to make fun of him for looking like an old fool.

Even though he's done and the t-shirt is on, Phainon doesn't say anything at all, but a weird noise comes out of him which makes Mydei glare at him, adjusting his glasses as they were knocked askew in the fight to get the item over his head. Phainon quickly wipes his mouth with the back of his hand and doesn't meet Mydei's gaze.

"That funny, hm?" Mydei asks, completely miserable in his new attire. He can't even move his shoulders too much in fear of the t-shirt completely ripping in half on him. He's just glad he can slip back into his suit jacket soon and do up all the buttons so his skin doesn't show, and after that he's only got two more lessons to suffer through before he can forget this ever happened.

"Huh?" Phainon finally answers, looking weirdly flushed and fidgety. "I think it looks fine."

"I look stupid, I think is what you mean to say," Mydei deadpans, eyes thinning at the slight curl of Phainon's lips. He must be trying to keep his laughter at this debacle inside, and that's why he's acting so suspicious. His arms feel like they're losing circulation with how tight the sleeves are around them.

"No!" Phainon says, going to stand up but he quickly sits right back down again and blushes even brighter. "It just… Y'know… Really emphasises…" He gestures over his own chest, making it look like as if he's holding two watermelons in his hands.

"*Mr Khaslana*!" Mydei shouts, humiliation roaring through his body at the mere suggestion of— of—!

Phainon finally loses it like Mydei knew he would and begins slapping the desk with his hand as he cackles away, eyes shut tightly and mouth wide open as he laughs so loud it echoes around the room.

"Your stripping technique could use a little bit of work!" Phainon laughs, his eyes shiny with unshed tears from how hard he's still laughing.

"You *little*—"

"Why are we talking about stripping?" Cipher's voice suddenly comes from behind Mydei, making him spin around in horror to look at her.

Cipher blinks down at Mydei's tiny shirt and seems equally as horrified. "What the fuck are you wearing, little prince?"

Mydei groans and runs a hand through his hair, making sure not to catch it on his braid. It smooths down a few odd ends that were sticking up from when he was getting changed. "I spilled coffee over myself."

"Right," Cipher says, dragging out the word sceptically as she looks between him and Phainon. "Still don't get what that has to do with stripping."

"Because he took his shirt off right in front of me!" Phainon exclaims, his laughter finally quietened down.

"So?" Cipher asks. "You're both boys, who cares?"

"I didn't say— I don't *care*—" Phainon stutters, scratching behind his ear sheepishly.

Mydei clicks his tongue in annoyance. "What are you doing here?" He asks Cipher.

"Oh, me and Phainon usually go on break around this time," Cipher replies, purposely ignoring Mydei's glare directed at her from that new piece of information.

"Well, don't let me keep you," Mydei huffs, turning back around to snatch up his ruined shirt from the desk.

"Are you *sulking*?" Cipher whispers through her teeth as Mydei walks past her. He doesn't answer, but pauses in the doorway, feeling very silly that he actually *is* sulking. *He* wants to take more breaks with Phainon, too.

Cipher sighs and rolls her eyes, shaking her head at him. "Phainon, are you ready to go?"

"Um," Phainon glances down at his lap, lightning fast, and then back up to Mydei and Cipher who are both watching him. "In a minute?"

Cipher's face looks like every part of her life force has been drained out of her at his answer, leaving her cheeks looking slightly hollow to match the dead look in her eyes. Mydei furrows his brows, eyes darting between them as the silence stretches out with their silent communication.

He clears his throat, no longer wanting to be stuck in between… whatever is going on right now. "I'll see you tomorrow, Phainon."

Phainon looks away from Cipher and beams at Mydei, his eyes curving up sweetly as he does so. "Yeah, definitely," He replies, cheeks slightly flushed and the ends of his hair curling.

Mydei's heart clenches at the adorable sight but he shakes his head and leaves. As he's walking away, he hears Cipher's voice coming through the door:

"Seriously, Phainon?" Her tone is so flat that Mydei can vividly picture her signature deadpan look that still sends a chill down his spine when it's aimed at him, as it usually means *trouble*.

Mydei has taken to wandering around the East Block today. He doesn't *hope* for anything, especially not a quick glance of Phainon, but his heart is beating steadily in his chest either way at the thought. He'd scrunched up and shoved Phainon's timetable at the back of his drawer in his bedside table once he got home the day of his slip up, but later on that night he'd sheepishly fished it back out to smooth over it and folded it up neatly. After another close inspection, the majority of their lessons overlapped, but every other Friday when Phainon was in class, Mydei had a free afternoon.

Of course, Mydei knows he should be using said free afternoon to catch up on his own work—like marking student's homework or drafting up his lesson plans for the week after—but his feet end up taking him on a journey to outside the P.E hall instead.

Mydei makes sure to stay just out of sight through the windows. He doesn't want to get caught; the curious gazes from passersby are already enough to put him on edge and he's moments away from storming back to the history department and forgetting this ever happened. But then he catches sight of silver-white hair, the two strands on top of his head bouncing as he walks, and Mydei is completely rooted to the spot. He just wants to watch and admire in a way that doesn't require any probing questions—he's gotten good at ignoring the ones coming from himself, at least.

Phainon seems extra excited today. His hands are flying around and his facial expressions are exaggerated in a way he knows will make the kids laugh. That type of genuine joy in teaching has become rare, Mydei thinks, so much so that as he watches it take place right in front of him, he finds it almost bizarre. He knows he'd been like that once—*happier*. He would guide his students through the curriculum with a youthful enthusiasm that

had been lost to time, although back then he would always be working on more and more exciting ideas to change the way they could learn.

Phainon's lessons seem just as vibrant as he is—a beaming smile on his face as he walks the students through the plan for the session, or as he demonstrates the activity. Even when he's concentrating and has a more serious look on his face, the kids seem to naturally mirror his energy; surprisingly the quieter kids that Mydei struggles to encourage to participate in group discussions join in here as well. Phainon commands everyone's attention without really trying, his laughter and instructions echoing around the hall, spilling out into the rest of the building where Mydei can hear them clearly.

Mydei has to admit to himself that after almost fifteen years of doing the same job day in day out, he's felt himself burn out slowly but surely. He still loves what he does—and despite his father originally pushing him into it, it's actually the only thing he'd ever do. Watching Phainon teach makes him feel hollow and full at the same time, and he can only hope that Phainon never loses his spark the way he did.

Mydei drags himself out of his thoughts as they begin taking a turn into a topic he wasn't expecting to mull over when he just wanted to see Phainon for a bit. He scrunches his eyes shut, a kaleidoscope of colours bursting behind his closed eyelids with the force of it. He rubs the bridge of his nose with his thumb and index finger, feeling the tension slowly seep out with the pressure.

"Y'know, you can just ask to see me instead of lurking outside, Mr Kremnos," A voice suddenly says, making Mydei jump out of his skin.

"Gods!" He exclaims, knocking his glasses clean off his face as his hands jolt from the scare.

"Oh shoot!" Phainon yells, scrambling after them to where they've slid a few metres away. Mydei is too shocked from the abrupt interruption to congratulate Phainon on censoring himself.

Phainon laughs—soft, breathy, a little nervous—as he bends down to pick up the fallen glasses. But instead of handing them back, he hesitates only a heartbeat before stepping closer. Mydei barely has time to inhale before Phainon lifts the frames with both hands, sliding them gently into place over Mydei's ears. His touch is feather-light, almost reverent with the amount of concentration in his face.

The laughter is gone now; Phainon's expression shifting into something quieter, more intent. As he adjusts the glasses, his fingertips skim across Mydei's temples, warm against his skin. He pauses when he notices a stray lock of hair caught beneath the frame, and—slowly, deliberately—he brushes it aside. His knuckles graze Mydei's cheek, sending a faint, electric feeling down his spine.

Phainon doesn't say anything, so Mydei doesn't, either. Phainon's face is close enough that he can see every detail: the faint flush painting his cheeks, the way his lashes lower, fluttering, as if he's afraid to meet Mydei's eyes too directly, the soft parting of his lips as he exhales a shaky breath. Mydei's own pulse stutters in response, something deep and gentle curling around his ribs like unruly vines.

Phainon's fingers linger a moment too long near his jaw, unsure and trembling, and a tension between them hums like a taut string. When Phainon's hand finally falls away, Mydei almost leans forward without meaning to, caught in the gravity of the younger teacher.

"There we go, all done," Phainon whispers, as if he's trying not to break the silence between them even as he speaks.

"Thank you," Mydei breathes out, the first grateful response he's ever spoken towards Phainon. He's too stunned to stop it from rolling off his tongue, too caught up in how much he wants to kiss Phainon that he feels stupid with it.

Then, Phainon is stepping back, their bubble bursting. Mydei feels shocked awake by it. Phainon rubs the back of his neck and dips his head forward in an apologetic manner, "I thought you'd heard me open the doors…"

Mydei averts his eyes too, staring down at a spot just past Phainon's legs. "…I wasn't *lurking*," He finally answers and chances a look at Phainon, but immediately looks away again when he sees the younger teacher raise an eyebrow.

"Sure," Phainon acquiesces easily, *too* easily. He shrugs his shoulders, "What *were* you doing then?"

Mydei's mind goes completely blank—a combination of having to answer a question he wasn't prepared for and his brain is still reeling from the gentle, soft touch of Phainon's hands. His usual talent of putting on a good poker face completely disappears as he stands in front of Phainon.

"I was— Ah, I was going to see Aglaea about something," Mydei manages.

Phainon crosses his arms over his chest, shifting his weight onto his left leg so his hip cocks out. Mydei can't help but immediately trace the curve of his body, the slender waist leading down to his thick thighs.

He's saved by one of the students popping her head out of the door, a gaggle of them crowding behind her. "Sirs, are you done flir—"

"Mr Khaslana! Are you coming back?" Another student cuts her off before she can finish, poking her head above the crowd, elbowing everyone else out of the way.

Phainon waves them all off, "Get back into position! I'll be back in there in a sec," He turns to Mydei. "Would Mr Kremnos do me the honour of joining the rest of our lesson?"

"I really should be getting to see Aglaea," Mydei says, but then Phainon's face falls and he looks like a sad, kicked puppy, and— "But that can wait until later." Mydei finishes, shoulders slumping in defeat.

Phainon beams at him, grin plastering across his face, and he walks over to shoo the students away so he can hold open the double doors for Mydei. He waits until they're both safely inside before he launches into the lesson as if there was never an interruption in the first place. Mydei hovers awkwardly by the closed doors, unsure of what he should do now while trying to avoid meeting the gazes of the students peering curiously between him and Phainon, like they're adding something up. He plots his revenge by making sure the next time he sees them, they'll have a sudden surprise mock exam to do without any external materials to help.

"—Would Mr Kremnos like to come help me demonstrate?" Phainon's question rings throughout the hall, making Mydei zone back in from his evil masterminding.

Mydei finally takes notice of the rest of the room, spotting a large amount of blue and grey coloured mats spaced out across the floor. The students stand in pairs, but Mydei didn't hear the first part of Phainon's sentence, so he's still unsure as to what they're doing for today's activity.

"I don't think I'm in the right attire for that," Mydei responds carefully. His designer black suit isn't exactly the right kind of clothing for any form of physical activity, no matter how much he enjoys it. He doesn't particularly want to spend the rest of the day in sweaty clothes either if he does join in —plus, the coffee incident a few days ago was enough to make him even more cautious about keeping his clothing clean while at work.

"You'll be fine! We're winding down now, actually," Phainon places his hands on his hips and puffs out his chest. A few girls and boys giggle. "So it'll only be one round of trust fall exercises before they gotta shoot off."

Visions of him falling back into Phainon's arms ricochet around his brain, only getting increasingly dramatic as more flood in. He must've watched too many K-dramas with Cipher and Castorice over the past few months because he can vividly picture cascading flower petals with a barrage of ad logos popping up as he and Phainon look dreamily into each other's eyes in slow-mo. Actually, why is *he* the one doing the falling when he could easily catch Phainon, too?

Something must show on his face because Phainon looks a little concerned. Mydei blinks a few times to shake himself out of it—he's a *grown man*, not the main character caught up in a shoujo romance plot. He nods weakly at Phainon, feeling a little too shaky after his thoughts to safely agree to catching himself in Phainon's arms.

"Maybe I should leave this one to the professionals," Mydei suggests.

Phainon's eyes narrow in on him immediately after his answer, glittering with mischief. He prowls back over to where Mydei is still standing by the doors, making Mydei feel like he's being hunted down by a wild animal. Once Phainon is close enough to do so, he reaches a hand up to place on his shoulder. The touch is so light Mydei can barely feel it through his suit jacket, but it still sends shivers down his arm regardless. Phainon hums to himself, eyes contemplative as he drags the fingertip of his index finger down from his shoulder, stopping when he reaches the middle of Mydei's bicep.

"What if I want to see these in action?" Phainon asks coyly, wrapping his fingers around his arm, but they barely begin to cover any of the

circumference.

Phainon's pupils visibly dilate, the beautiful blue being swallowed up by black. His lips part ever so slightly so he can moisten his dry lips with his tongue. Mydei clenches his jaw, feeling the muscles in them jump from the sudden pressure. He wants to see Phainon's hands wrapped around something else and watch as his broad palms and long fingers stretch out over it, but he quickly clears away that thought like unwanted cobwebs before it can fully develop, especially considering he's in front of students. Mydei knows he's being baited, but it's *working*.

A student coughs.

"Fine, you're on," Mydei replies, shaking Phainon's grip off of him as he shrugs off his suit jacket, draping it neatly over a stack of chairs nearby. Phainon's eyes still seem blazing hot as he watches Mydei unbutton the cuffs of his sleeves so he can roll them up to his elbows. Something dark and wanting swirls in the pit of Mydei's stomach at being watched, but it only builds when Phainon's eyes curve up, satisfied in a way he knows that he's won this round. Mydei feels his blood boil with the need to grab Phainon by the back of his neck like a naughty puppy and hold him down to teach him a lesson until the cocky attitude is all but gone.

Phainon lets out a whoop of joy when Mydei comes to stand next to him, uncaring or unknowing of the intensity of Mydei's gaze on him. They stand on the mat at the front of the class and Phainon gestures to the students to sit down so they can watch the demonstration.

"Alright! Thanks to Mr Kremnos for helping me out here," Phainon nudges him in the side and winks at him. "We'll only be doing one round of this as we're a bit pushed for time—but the gist of it is that one of you will go first, fall, and then swap with your partner who will then fall too."

Some of the students nod in understanding, so Phainon continues:

"If Mr Kremnos would like to do the honours…" Phainon bows and exaggeratedly gestures his hand out to show Mydei where to go. Mydei sneers at him as they swap places, but the poorly disguised grin he gets as a response only makes the heat inside him flare up again.

Mydei breathes in, readying himself to catch Phainon in his arms. Thankfully, there are no falling petals or ads rolling across the screen as he looks at Phainon getting ready. "Ready?"

"Never been readier," Phainon replies, but then when he falls back suddenly, Mydei's eyes widen and his arms reach out lightning fast to catch him. He shouldn't have bothered because Phainon begins wailing, placing the back of his palm against his forehead like he's a delicate maiden swooning into the arms of her lover.

It's worth the humiliation of having to put up with it to see the reaction from the students—giggles ripple out across the crowd, and there's a restlessness that instead of feeling antsy to leave, just feels rather *excited* to stick around. Mydei has only been here for ten minutes and he can already tell how well and truly Phainon is adored by the students he teaches.

After that, Mydei pushes Phainon back up straight, smirking when he stumbles forward a few steps from the force of being almost shoved back upright. Phainon turns his head over his shoulder and pouts at Mydei, eyes narrowed in faux annoyance. Now, it's Mydei's turn to fall.

He turns around to address the class first, "I don't want to see any repeats of what Mr Khaslana just did, okay? Remain sensible." He warns, making the class grumble.

He watches Phainon with trepidation clear in his eyes, even behind his glasses, hesitancy bubbling away at the idea of falling backwards. He should remain confident and poised in front of the class, but he can't help but worry—he's all muscle mass, and can hit like a tonne of bricks when he becomes a dead weight. It's not that he doesn't think Phainon is strong, he *knows* he is, but still.

Phainon must see the uncertainty in his eyes because he holds out his arms and makes grabby hands in encouragement. "C'mon, Mr Kremnos, be brave! I'll never drop you."

Mydei doesn't want to set a bad example in front of the kids. After all, this entire exercise is about *trust*, and he can tell that the students have been paired up sensibly within similar heights and body mass. Phainon knows what he's doing, he has a good eye for it, so it must be the same in this case too. It's then that it hits him—Mydei *does* trust Phainon—possibly too much considering the amount of time they've known each other, which isn't long at all but is surely growing day by day, so he bolsters his resolve. He prepares to fall back, feeling stiff as a board when he does.

Phainon catches him so easily, effortlessly lugging him back up right without even a minor tremble of his arms. The sheer amount of strength it shows makes Mydei's stomach somersault.

Phainon smirks at him, patting him on the shoulder. "See, I told you it'd be fine," He says quietly, the words just for Mydei.

Mydei doesn't know why those words mean so much to him.

Phainon doesn't linger on him for long—he claps his hands once to gather the student's attention. "With that done, you guys go ahead. No arguing over who goes first! If you can't decide, just do rock, paper, scissors, okay?" He surveys the class. "I'll be watching you all, so be on your best behaviour, please." He points two fingers at his eyes before pointing them at the students, scanning the whole crowd with the gesture.

Everyone seems to work like a well oiled machine after that—only a few games of rock, paper, scissors are needed until the class has completed the exercise. Phainon cheers loudly once they all finish as the students all stand still and silent, waiting for the next instruction.

"Great work, everyone. No one got hurt, mentally *or* physically, so I'd say that's a job well done!" Phainon says, smiling when the class laughs back at his joke. "You can all head out now. Me and Mr Kremnos will handle clearing up. Mr Nikolas and Miss Cipher should already be in the changing rooms, so go straight there."

The students say their goodbyes, some lingering afterwards as if they want to come up to either of them and ask something, but ultimately they're all dragged away by their friends until everyone has cleared out. It leaves Phainon and Mydei alone on their mat, but only for a second before Phainon rushes off towards the chairs laid out on the sides of the hall. He bends over and turns off the little digital alarm clock he has set up to signal the end of the lesson.

"Why do I have to help you clear the mats away?" Mydei grumbles, but he doesn't hesitate to help anyway. He follows Phainon's lead once he's back from resetting the timer, grabbing the opposite end of the mat to stack it against the wall.

Phainon chuckles at his contradicting words and actions, but wisely doesn't say anything about it. They work in silence, and they're almost finished when Mydei sees the class walking past the hall windows on their way to the next lesson. When he looks back, he spots a hairband on the floor, making him frown. Usually the item isn't worth keeping in lost and found, but maybe Phainon could put it aside for anyone who comes looking for it? He walks off from Phainon to go pick it up—he'll hand it into the P.E office once they're done.

"Last one and then you're free," Phainon calls from across the hall.

"Just a second," Mydei says back, bending over to grab it from the floor.

A strangled sound comes from behind him, making him startle. The sudden rush of blood to his head makes him dizzy when he springs back up, turning

around to face Phainon. He catches the younger teacher's eyes flickering back up from where they were focused on his ass, his expression akin to being caught red handed doing something he shouldn't have.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Was there something there?" He asks, and the question seems to make Phainon's entire body go red as he flinches.

"Shut up," Phainon shoots back, storming over to the last mat.

"What? No, seriously, was there?" Mydei feels wrong-footed by Phainon's visceral reaction.

He'd assumed that Phainon was laughing at him again, like when he spilled coffee all over himself. He's suddenly very concerned that he's accidentally sat on a piece of chewing gum somehow and not noticed. Kids are disgusting and unfortunately, it's happened to him before. Mydei twists at the waist to check if there is anything there, but all it does is result in his back cracking in multiple places with the movement. He winces at the noise, but doesn't see anything on his ass that shouldn't be there.

"Oh, right… Uh, no there wasn't?" Phainon replies, looking away while his voice gradually gets higher towards the end. That just makes Mydei think that he's taking the piss and that there *is* something stuck on his trousers after all. He pats over his behind just in case, but all he can feel are the slits for his pockets and nothing else.

Mydei narrows his eyes at the back of Phainon's head and lets it go for now, putting the hairband in his pocket before walking over to finish their job. He goes to grab onto one side of the mat, but Phainon stops him.

"Wait, I'll take that side. I don't want you walking backwards," Phainon says. Mydei relents without complaint and watches Phainon begin to make his way across the mat.

Just as Phainon takes his first step, the tip of his trainer catches on the curled up edge, and he goes flying forward.

"Phainon!" Mydei yells in shock, flinging his arms out to try and grab him before he breaks his nose face planting the floor—he's not sure even the mat could save his face with how hard he's careening forwards.

Phainon tries to find his balance again by windmilling his arms around as he stumbles, but the full brunt of his weight slams into Mydei either way. Their foreheads knock together as they fall into each other, making them both yelp with pain. Mydei loses his footing with the sudden clash, completely taken by surprise, and all he can do in a panic is wrap his arms around Phainon's waist protectively as they fall backwards.

They land with an almighty *slam*. None of them move for a moment, but everything *hurts* with the impact immediately after landing. Of course it's just Mydei's luck they fall away from the mat and not onto it. Gods, he's going to regret this later on when he can barely move because his back is sore. He blinks his eyes open once his head stops spinning, panic surging when he feels Phainon on top of him.

"Are you okay?" He asks promptly. His arms are completely locked up around Phainon from fright, squeezing him tighter than is probably comfortable. Mydei forces his arms to loosen and moves his hands to place on Phainon's shoulders instead.

He gives Phainon a little nudge, trying to get him to sit up so they can assess the damage, but Phainon doesn't move. His face is buried in Mydei's chest, hiding his expression completely away from him as Mydei tilts his head to try and see if Phainon's eyes are even open.

"Did you pass out? Do you feel dizzy?" Mydei asks in concern when he gets nothing back.

"I'm okay," Phainon slurs, finally responding. His voice is muffled from his position, and instead of getting up like Mydei expects, he snuffles into Mydei's shirt, his nose practically nuzzling between his pecs.

Awareness slams into him then, and Mydei is suddenly *very* conscious that he has a wriggly, very much awake Phainon lying right on top of him. Their bodies are pressed together from their chests to their shins, completely lined up. He's sure that Phainon can hear, if not *feel*, the way his heart begins to slam against his ribcage at the realisation.

"Phainon?" Mydei says, the name coming out strained.

Phainon shuffles his head to peer up at him, one of his cheeks pillowed on top of Mydei's chest. "You're comfy," Is all Phainon replies with, rubbing his cheek against the area as if to demonstrate his statement.

Mydei's face spasms with every emotion known to man as he can feel his nipple hardening under the stimulation. He curses himself for being so sensitive there, but he can't help it. His chest just seems to *feel things* more than the rest of him. Mydei suddenly wishes he had hit his head hard enough to have knocked him out cold instead of having to deal with this.

"I saved your life and I get called *comfy*," Mydei says flatly, the words filtering through the dazed fog in his head. He's trying to wrangle his emotions back into submission when Phainon chuckles, the rumbling of his chest feeling like a cat's purr, which only makes Mydei even more frazzled than before.

"Yeah, yeah. I guess I owe you another drink for being my knight in shining armour again?" Phainon bemoans sarcastically.

"Too right," Mydei replies, unable to keep the corners of his lips from ticking upwards despite how much of a mess he feels inside, even more so when Phainon begins to laugh.

He slides his hands down Phainon's back until they settle at his waist instead, steadying him so the sudden laughter doesn't throw him off. Mydei can't help but catalogue the inward curve his palms took as his shoulder blades narrowed down into his waist, his hands practically spanning the whole of Phainon's back until the tips of his fingers almost touch. Mydei

bites down on the inside of his cheek to stop him from saying something highly inappropriate—he knew Phainon's waist was small, he's constantly showing it off in that tight t-shirt of his, but feeling the real thing beneath his own hands is a completely different experience. He unconsciously tightens his grip, acting on nothing but instinct, desperation clawing at his throat.

"*Ah*," Phainon gasps, high and whiny at the pressure.

They both go stock still, staring wide eyed at each other. Phainon opens and closes his mouth a few times, his face gradually getting redder with each passing moment.

Mydei's face creases. "Did I hurt you?" He asks, loosening his grip at the thought. Phainon shakes his head, the tips of his ears turning red now.

"*Oh*," Mydei continues, and Phainon looks at him with a panicked expression on his face. "I didn't know you were ticklish."

Phainon's jaw snaps shut as he blinks rapidly at Mydei. "Yep, that's exactly it. You got me."

Mydei raises an eyebrow, mischief and plotting clear on his face.

"Don't you dare…" Phainon warns, his body tensing up again.

Mydei bites down on his bottom lip to try and keep a straight face. Phainon narrows his eyes in another warning at him, and his body looks poised to escape. However, now that he's gotten used to it, Mydei quite likes the feeling of Phainon on top of him, his warmth leeching in through his clothes and settling in his bone marrow, making a home of it there.

Mydei grins wolfishly as he caresses his sides, revelling in the way Phainon's whole body jerks like he's been electrocuted, a gasping wheeze leaving him.

"You—! Stop it!" Phainon screeches, wiggling around on top of Mydei when he doesn't let up on tickling him.

They both wheeze with laughter, Mydei's deep and rumbling whereas Phainon's is light and bold, especially as it borders on hysterical as he fails to try and get a hold of Mydei's hands to make him stop. Phainon's expression contorts into something that is half joy and half betrayal.

"Your *face*," Mydei gasps out, his eyes mooning shut with how wide he's smiling. Phainon wails pitifully, but is finally able to grab a hold of Mydei's hands, pinning them to his sides to stop them moving.

Phainon can barely keep his balance with how much Mydei is shaking with laughter, which just makes him laugh even more. "Mydei-*mos*!" Phainon whines, still pronouncing it slightly wrong. Mydei can hear the smile in his voice so he doesn't bother letting him know just yet. "Is this bullying? Why are you being so mean to me?! Stop laughing!"

"Don't report me to my father, please," Mydei wheezes. Phainon cackles loudly at that, which sets Mydei off until they're both teary eyed with it.

They settle down after a few moments, their laughter filtering out into panting breaths as they lay there on the floor. Mydei's back is aching already, sore and bruised, but he doesn't make any move to shove Phainon off.

"Has anyone told you you're really dumb, by the way?" Phainon asks out of nowhere, breathless as he tries to catch his breath too.

"Can't say anyone has said that to me," Mydei replies honestly. "So why are you?"

"Not telling," Phainon says, and Mydei relinquishes hold of Phainon's waist with one of his hands to reach up and flick his forehead. It's not a harsh flick, more of a tap, but it still makes Phainon frown as he lifts a hand up to rub at the sore spot. "See, I told you, you're a *bully*."

Mydei rolls his eyes, "Hardly. A light flick is enough to call me that now, hm?"

"Sure is," Phainon replies, grinning. He begins to move, sitting back on his knees so he can sit up straight, all while straddling the tops of Mydei's

thighs. He places his palms over Mydei's chest to help him balance, cupping his pecs.

Mydei looks up at him, breath catching as Phainon's shadow falls over him. His eyes widen, taking in the sight—Phainon leaning close, hair falling forward in soft curls and flicks that frame his face. It's grown out slightly since he first joined the school, and there are little strands that stick up in every direction, only adding to that effortless, boyish charm that Mydei secretly finds devastating.

One of the ceiling lights is blocked by Phainon's head, casting his features into a gentle shadow while illuminating the strands of hair from behind. The glow catches on every strand, turning them almost golden somehow, like a faint halo crowning him. It's unfair, Mydei thinks distantly—how someone can look so heartbreakingly beautiful without even trying.

Phainon's hands are still resting over Mydei's chest. Right above his heart. Mydei can feel it pounding away—hard, insistent, impossible to hide—and he knows Phainon must feel it too. There's a few seconds where neither of them speaks, suspended and heavy with something that hums between them, warm and unspoken.

He can't move, pinned to the floor not just by Phainon's weight on top of him, but also by his unyielding gaze. Mydei's hands slide down from his waist to settle on his thighs instead, feeling the muscles beneath his palms flexing subtly at the touch as he spreads his fingers over the material of his shorts. Phainon hums to himself, shifting his hips slightly to get more comfortable. Mydei inhales sharply, his whole body winding up tightly at the movement.

"I know I said I could get you on your knees, but I think I like this better," Phainon says, tongue peaking out of the corner of his mouth. "You look pretty on your back."

Mydei *trembles*, a lance of white hot arousal going through him. Gods, what he would let Phainon do to him in this position—it's almost physically painful the way his gut twists and his navel tugs. He swallows thickly, picturing Phainon working the buttons of his shirt open, freeing his chest, those hands getting busy touching and feeling him up, littering kisses all over him as he goes. He tightens his grip up on Phainon's thighs, letting his fingertips dig into the fat and muscles without caring how hard he was pressing. All Phainon does is grin down at him, wide and feral, and Mydei snaps.

He throws himself into motion, using the momentum of taking Phainon by surprise to roll them over until he's the one looming on top instead. Phainon lands on his back with a surprised sound, the wind being knocked out of him. Mydei slams his hands down either side of Phainon's head, holding himself up. His glasses are barely hanging on with the change in position, dangling precariously off his face by the tips of the curved arms hooked over his ears.

"Nothing to say?" Mydei goads, satisfied when he doesn't get an immediate response. "I thought you said you couldn't be taken off guard?"

Phainon is looking up at him, dazed and flushed all the way from the top of his cheekbones to the tips of his ears and all the way down his neck, his mouth open in shock.

"Y'know, I thought it would take a few dates to get you like this, but maybe you'll let me off?" Phainon asks, words razor sharp despite how out of breath he sounds. His eyes are blown so wide there's practically no colour left in them, just endless depths of black that threaten to pull Mydei in closer, close enough to breathe him in, for their foreheads to touch and for their noses to brush against each other.

Mydei feels it dawning on him, slowly at first and then all at once when he realises he's caging Phainon in with his hands, one of Phainon's legs hooked around his waist while the other one sprawls wide open on the other side of him. Phainon's arms are spread up above his head limply, not having any chance with the sudden change in position to grab a hold of anything.

Phainon smirks while Mydei is distracted and wraps his leg tighter around his waist, using the leverage to try and switch their positions again. Mydei quickly snaps out of it and stops the movement halfway, but they still tumble over to lay on their sides, face to face instead. They tussle even more to try and regain the upper hand, but Mydei manages to capture Phainon's wrists in his hands so he can't shove him over anymore. Phainon just tightens his leg around Mydei's waist as a last resort, them both now being equally as trapped from moving. The action brings their crotches dangerously close to each other, and Mydei goes deathly still at the threat of them accidentally brushing against one another. Phainon relaxes minutely when he realises that Mydei has given up, smirking at him in victory.

"*HKS*," Mydei grinds out, face flushed as he pants, unable to think of anything else to say.

"Calling me a scoundrel again, are we?" Phainon cackles. "How about a draw?"

They watch each other, their eyes trailing over each other's faces amidst the mutual stalemate. Phainon's gaze feels like a trail of fire licking at his skin, as if searing the path his eyes take into his skin permanently. His whole body tingles with the sensation, his toes curling in his shoes with it. He wants to be on top of Phainon again, to feel his firm thighs beneath him, to feel his chest heaving, breathless and beautiful. He wants to sit in his lap like he was *born* to be there.

"Just this once," Mydei replies eventually, bottling everything up in favour of bathing in the grin Phainon gives him at his answer. He lets go of Phainon's wrists just as the other unhooks his leg from his waist.

"Guess I still owe you two drinks then," Phainon jokes.

"Obviously," Mydei replies, rolling his eyes.

Mydei aches to reach out, the longing tugging at him so sharply it feels like it leaves teeth marks in his heart. He wants to cup Phainon's face in his hands, to trace the elegant slope of his cheekbones, to feel the warmth of those soft cheeks rounding beneath his palms—as if his touch alone could keep him safe, held, *cherished*. The desire is overwhelming in its simplicity. It would be so easy, painfully easy, to close the distance between them. All he has to do is *move*—just one step, one breath, one reckless leap—and risk everything he's ever guarded for the smallest chance that Phainon might lean into him instead of away.

But instead, he clears his throat. "Let's get up. We still need to put the last mat away." Mydei says and pulls away reluctantly, ignoring the way his heart is protesting at him, screaming to go back, to gather Phainon up into his arms like he so desperately wants to.

Phainon's face falls slightly, but it clears up quickly as he begins to get up as well. Phainon offers Mydei a hand, waggling it right in front of his face while he's still trying to figure out how to stand up without putting too much stress on his knees.

"C'mon, old man," Phainon cajoles lightheartedly.

Mydei glowers at him, but grabs the outstretched hand and is soon back on his feet, another display of Phainon's pure strength. Phainon laughs at him when he dusts himself down, feeling absolutely filthy after rolling around on the floor for so long. Phainon then playfully kicks him in the shin when he starts taking too long, so they hurry up and put the final mat away without any more fanfare.

"When do you want your drinks?" Phainon asks now that they're done, hooking his thumbs into the waistband of his shorts casually.

"I'm free tomorrow," Mydei says, even though he technically isn't. His father had asked to see him, but he can easily just phone up the landline and say something has come up and he's no longer able to make it. His father has heard all sorts of excuses by now—and Mydei doesn't know whether he believes them or not, but he never calls him out on it.

Phainon nods, "I have a place in mind. It's a bit far out though, it's by the coast. Is that okay?"

Mydei nods in surprise. He lives near the coastal line of Okhema anyway, so he's looking forward to whether or not he recognises the place.

"I'll text you the details later then?" Phainon asks.

Mydei hums, nodding. Hope blooms in his chest, its roots taking place superficially in his heart. "I hope the offer to show off your bar tending skills still stands, too?" He asks.

Phainon snorts, waving him off. "You bet! I'll make it so you'll never be able to have a drink made by anyone else but me."

Mydei chuckles fondly, folding his arms over his chest. "Bold words. You still haven't guessed what I like to drink, have you?"

"I sure have," Phainon puffs his chest out confidently. "Pomegranate milk."

Mydei's jaw drops. "How—"

Phainon laughs, "Cipher told me. Don't worry, I'll make sure the bar we go to has some of everything so we can try a variety and see what else you like, yeah?"

"Yeah," Mydei says, breathless all over again.

"Okay, cool," Phainon says, then looks down at the floor before looking back up at Mydei through his lashes, "Then it's a date?"

Mydei's heart expands, the roots of hope burying themselves deeper and deeper until there's no way to get rid of them.

"Sure, a date."

Chapter End Notes

sorry for taking so long to update Q_Q i left the fandom due to Reasons™, and honestly my heart isn't really in with writing at the moment - so it's been a rough one i promise i WILL finish this fic though, even if it takes me ages to do it!! (a.k.a i'm writing whenever i'm not catching up with one piece LOL)

i've seen a lot of discourse online about ongoing fics and how little people want to support them, which has honestly been incredibly demoralising. please, if you're reading this and enjoying yourself, it would truly mean the world to me if you left a comment/kudos showing your love! that's how writers gain motivation to carry on. thank you!!!! ☆

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anyway with that over HEHEEEE i hope everyone liked this chapter! things are finally starting to move in the right directionnn next chapter will be their 'DATE'!!!!!!!!!!!!

# Chapter 6: chapter six

Chapter Summary

**Phainon [06:47 pm]**

[Image Attached]

it's you

**Mydei [06:47 pm]**

That's a tennis ball with a smiley face drawn on it.

**Phainon [06:48 pm]**

yeah but i gave it your little face tattoo

it's ur son now :-D

Chapter Notes

HI EVERYNYAN!!! i'm back :D

this is my favourite chapter ngl, a lotttt of love and labour went into it from writing to editing (thank you again nina!) so i really hope you all enjoy this one

enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When he first got Phainon's number, he'd only sent a quick and simple 'Hey, it's Mydei.', to which Phainon had reacted to the message with a blue heart

emoji that matched his contact name. It must be his *thing*, Mydei thought at the time. Seeing it again, directed at him, made Mydei feel like he was walking on air for the next three days straight. Usually, Mydei prefers calling—hearing the other person's voice rather than having to read their words inside his head, but he's found that with Phainon, he doesn't mind it. He can *hear* his voice in his head whenever he reads his texts, loud and clear, and especially when he puts little emojis next to everything.

He sinks deeper into the sofa cushions, legs tucked up beneath him and hidden under the warmth of a soft blanket as he opens his messages log. The book he'd been reading lies abandoned beside him, half slipped between the cushions where he carelessly dropped it as soon as he heard his phone buzzing with a text message. The room around him is dim and quiet, lit only by the yellowish glow of the lamp beside him, but the brightness on his screen—and the thought of Phainon—fills the space with its own kind of warmth.

As soon as he sees what Phainon's sent him, Mydei can only stare down at his phone, biting the inside of his cheek in a desperate attempt to hold back his laughter. The effort lasts all of two seconds before the laugh bursts out of him in a fast, breathy rush.

**Phainon [06:47 pm]**

[Image Attached]

it's you

**Mydei [06:47 pm]**

That's a tennis ball with a smiley face drawn on it.

**Phainon [06:48 pm]**

yeah but i gave it your little face tattoo

it's ur son now :-D

**Mydei [06:48 pm]**

Is this a new way to insult me and my tattoos?

**Phainon [06:48 pm]**

no i thought it was cute

not that i think ur cute or whatever… the tennis ball is

ur handsome tho

very strong and stuff

hahaha

**Mydei [06:50 pm]**

Keep digging, Phainon.

**Phainon [06:50 pm]**

ok sorry

you and the tennis ball are both cute

HAPPY?

**Mydei [06:51 pm]**

Very.

Is that how you spent your afternoon instead of working?

**Phainon [06:51 pm]**

not hearing a 'thank you' for creating such a masterpiece???? :-(

**Mydei [06:52 pm]**

You're avoiding the question.

**Phainon [06:52 pm]**

ur so mean to me

i did it on my break actually lol

**Mydei [06:53 pm]**

How well behaved of you. Good boy.

Phainon doesn't reply, even as almost twenty minutes pass after he's sent the last text. Mydei assumes the conversation is over, and goes to put his phone back down so he can resume reading his book, but something nags at him. He *wants* to keep talking to Phainon, even if that means starting a whole new conversation or forcing himself to continue the same one.

Mydei doesn't do things by halves, so he texts Phainon again:

**Mydei [07:13 pm]**

Thanks for the art work.

**Phainon [07:15 pm]**

i'm keeping it btw

**Mydei [07:15 pm]**

I don't get a say in the custody of my tennis ball son?

**Phainon [07:16 pm]**

no :-)

**Mydei [07:16 pm]**

Tell him I love him then.

**Phainon [07:16 pm]**

he says he loves you too

Mydei isn't expecting the swooping feeling in his stomach at reading those words, and even though he *knows* it wasn't Phainon saying it to him, he still has to spend the next few minutes in silence until his heart and brain calm down. He clears his throat a few times to try and rid himself of thinking more about that, and feels silly that even for a split second he had wanted Phainon to say that he loved him too. Mydei sighs, glancing down at the book by his side. It's truly a losing game he's playing tonight, he thinks as he gets up from underneath his blanket to clamber into bed instead. His silk sheets greet him immediately, his bare skin sliding across the smooth, cool surface until he's gotten himself comfortable.

He picks up his phone again and unlocks it back into his and Phainon's chat. He sees that he's received another text while getting situated.

**Phainon [07:18 pm]**

oh also before i forget

[Location Pin]

tomorrow at 7?

Mydei taps on the link and watches as it opens up in his maps app. Once it loads, he can tell immediately how close it is to the seafront, and it's only a short walk away from the pier in the area too. He doesn't tend to explore

that general vicinity much since it's on the opposite end of the city, but the bar in the review photos looks nice and relaxed. It's quite different from the places he frequents on his own or with Castorice and Cipher, but he's still looking forward to going despite the change—especially since it's somewhere Phainon picked, and the fact they'll be together as well definitely sweetens the deal.

**Mydei [07:20 pm]**

Looks good. Is there a dress code?

**Phainon [07:20 pm]**

no wtf lol

just casual ig

**Mydei [07:21 pm]**

Okay.

**Phainon [07:21 pm]**

? do the places you usually go to have one?

**Mydei [07:22 pm]**

Yes, mostly.

**Phainon [07:22 pm]**

so fancy

do u even own a pair of jeans lol

**Mydei [07:23 pm]**

Of course I do. I'm not that uptight. Is that what I should wear tomorrow then?

**Phainon [07:23 pm]**

if you want!

**Mydei [07:23 pm]**

:D

**Phainon [07:24 pm]**

nevber thought i'd see you using emojis lol

never*

**Mydei [07:24 pm]**

:)

**Phainon [07:24 pm]**

:3

Mydei furrows his eyebrows at that one. He's not sure he's seen Phainon use it before, but he's definitely sure Cipher has—he's just never bothered to ask what it was supposed to mean or be.

**Mydei [07:25 pm]**

I'm afraid I don't know that one.

**Phainon [07:25 pm]**

it's a kitty

Mydei turns his phone on its side so he can see it from a different angle. It takes a few moments of moving his phone around and bringing it closer and further from his face until he can finally see where Phainon is coming from.

**Mydei [07:26 pm]**

Cute. :3

**Phainon [07:26 pm]**

oh my gods i'm screenshotting this and sending it to cipher lol

"Why does Phainon have Cipher's number?" Mydei mutters to himself, his mood faltering at the idea of them texting without him knowing. He knows they've gotten close enough to spend their morning and afternoon short breaks with each other, a fact in which Mydei still swears he's not jealous over, but it still stings a little. He adjusts his glasses in annoyance, frustrated at himself for feeling this way over his two friends.

**Mydei [07:27 pm]**

Glad I could entertain.

**Phainon [07:27 pm]**

yay

**Mydei [07:27 pm]**

I think you would look nice in a suit.

**Phainon [07:28 pm]**

that was random

i don't own a suit though

**Mydei [07:28 pm]**

You don't?

**Phainon [07:29 pm]**

nah why would i need one

**Mydei [07:29 pm]**

Every man needs a good suit.

Maybe I'll take you to one of my bars sometime, just in case I don't enjoy your drinks.

**Phainon [07:29 pm]**

guess you'll never see me in a suit then bc you're gonna LOVE my drinks >:-)

anyway why aren't you in bed

Mydei glances at the clock on his bedside table, the red digits signalling it's just turned half past seven.

**Mydei [07:30 pm]**

I am.

**Phainon [07:31 pm]**

[Incoming Call]

Mydei gapes down at his phone, shooting up straight so he can sit properly against his headboard instead of slumping against his pillows. He winces when the fast action strains his back—it's still sore from this afternoon after tumbling around on the floor that he'd had no choice but to put multiple heat patches wherever he could reach to help soothe his muscles as soon as he'd gotten home.

He waits a few minutes to see if it stops ringing, but it keeps vibrating in his hand, his ringtone blaring out across his bedroom. Phainon really *is* calling him. Mydei shakily presses the accept button and holds the phone up to his ear.

"Hello?"

"Are you actually in bed right now?"

Mydei pauses at being cut off, but also at the question. "Yes, why?"

"I was just gonna make an old man joke, but you're doing it for me!" Phainon says, breaking out into the loudest laugh he's heard from the younger teacher.

"Hey!" Mydei exclaims as the spluttering laughter filters through his speakers. He's not sure if he's offended or just happy that he's made Phainon laugh—even though it's at his own expense. "Did you call me to laugh at my old bones?" He grouses.

Phainon coos at him down the phone, still laughing. "I swear I didn't. I just thought this was easier than texting, but thanks for the laugh anyway."

"Glad I could be of service again," Mydei rolls his eyes as a fond smile crosses his face. He doesn't bother dimming it or hiding it away, safe in the privacy of his own home.

He's also relieved that whatever awkwardness formed from them first speaking properly again after they'd finished clearing up the P.E hall this afternoon isn't there. Mydei is hardly willing to admit that being on top of Phainon has been on his mind since, their positions suggestive in a way that makes him feel very ashamed of doing that on school grounds, even though it was just play fighting. But something else, something deeper, something more feral that he barely answers to nowadays purrs at knowing their fighting would be *fun*. Even though Mydei is holed up in bed with an aching back and creaky knees, he doesn't regret it at all.

He clears his throat as his skin prickles with heat at remembering the way Phainon felt beneath him, and he's glad when Phainon begins speaking again:

"I actually called to talk about tomorrow," Phainon says, the humour in his tone melting away into something softer. "I'm… really excited to see you."

Phainon's voice sounds different through the phone—gentler, but no less boyish, like he's trying to keep his words just between him and Mydei, and he feels so close that Mydei can practically imagine lips ghosting across his ears with each word.

"Me too," Mydei replies, and for once he's glad that they can't see each other because he's still having a hard time keeping the sappy smile off his face. "You better leave the kid at home, though."

"The wh—? Oh, you mean Mydei Junior?"

"You couldn't have called him literally anything else?" Mydei says flatly, an eyebrow twitching in annoyance.

"Why not? Is that name already taken?" Phainon says, and Mydei can hear the leer in his voice as he says it and he can picture him waggling his eyebrows at the same time too, his eyes twinkling with mischief.

Mydei scoffs, "Put it this way— even if I did name it, I don't think it'd be called *Junior*."

Phainon goes so quiet that Mydei thinks he's been hung up on. But when he checks the phone call, it's still ongoing, the little timer ticking upwards. "Are you okay?" Mydei asks, concerned.

"Yes!" Phainon practically squeaks, "I— uh, accidentally muted my phone, sorry." He clears his throat and his tone evens out again as he speaks once more: "Do you seriously go to bars where there's a *dress code*, by the way?"

Mydei sighs quietly, "You do realise that this city is full of retired old people with too much time and money on their hands, right? It's either bars or the communal baths they frequent, so of course there's a dress code."

Phainon huffs a laugh, "I bet you fit right in, too. You probably sleep in a suit."

Mydei glances down at his bare chest, and then even lower to where he can see the waistband of his silk sleeping trousers peeking above his quilt. "No, I wear pyjamas." He says.

"You do realise this is only fuelling the old man rumours, yeah?" Phainon chortles.

Mydei bristles, "What, you don't sleep in pyjamas? And what are you imagining— I'm not sat here in a gown and nightcap!"

Phainon howls, the combined sound of him slapping his thigh in elation is enough to make Mydei pull his phone away from his ear, waiting for the younger teacher to settle down again. His laughter continues to echo through his speakers, his phone vibrating slightly with the volume even as he turns him down quickly.

"Oh my gods, that was *great*. Do you own those though? Wait, no— you're probably in some fur-lined plaid set instead!"

"I actually get too hot in that sort—" Phainon's laughter cuts him off with the insinuation that Mydei *has* worn them at some point. "But generally, I favour silk pyjamas. Happy now?"

"*Fancy*. Very proper of you," Phainon says, his voice wobbling slightly as he's clearly fending off more laughter.

Mydei snorts. "Definitely not. I had the heating on earlier, now it's too warm for the shirt and robe, so I don't think I'll be allowed into any bars in this state."

The line goes silent yet again, but as he goes to check to see if they're still connected again, Phainon's voice filters back through the speakers. "— fuck, shit, sorry, I muted again," His voice cuts in and out, clearly at the tail end of some very impressive expletives. He sounds winded, his words a little shaky.

"Did something happen?" Mydei asks.

"Nope!" Phainon says a bit too loudly. He chuckles, the sound nervous, "I, uh— I have to go! I hope you sleep well!"

"Phainon?!" Mydei shouts after him, but the call is actually disconnected this time.

He blinks owlishly at his phone until the screen goes dark and his reflection stares back at him. Maybe it *is* time to go to sleep.

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"Cipher, help me," Is the first thing Mydei says as soon as he hears his call being connected.

"What?" Cipher replies groggily, "What fucking time is it?"

"It's five past seven. I need your help," Mydei replies.

"Someone better be dying, dead, or—"

"I'm meeting up with Phainon tonight for drinks," Mydei cuts her off.

The screech that comes down the phone line makes him flinch away. He patiently waits for Cipher to calm down as she spews Dolos profanities until she finally stops and he hesitantly puts the phone back to his ear again. He's pretty sure they're still ringing from his conversation with Phainon last night.

"Fucking *finally*! Oh my gods, Cassie, wake up right now. Mydei and Phainon are going on a date!"

"It's not—" Mydei can distantly hear Cipher waking up Castorice, yelling to him that he's now on loudspeaker. "*Cipher*! Stop, it's not a date."

"What do you mean it's not a date?" Cipher's voice emerges again, closer than it has any business being. Mydei's pretty sure that it's not a poor phone line causing the static, but Cipher's heavy breathing instead.

"I *mean* it's not a date, it's just a way for him to pay back a few favours I've done for him," Mydei explains, pacing up and down his bedroom.

"You and I are going to have a very nice, very long conversation about this later. You've been mooning over him for *months* and now you're telling me it's not a date?!"

"I've not been *mooning*, gods," Mydei snaps, rolling his eyes as he pauses in his steps.

"Mydeimos, my little prince, I'm begging you to think about my feelings here too! Why isn't this a date? You're meeting him for drinks, and then seeing where the night takes you, right?!"

"Where did you pull that scenario out of? Your ass? It's just a friendly co-worker get together, that's all."

"Then invite me along," Cipher says bluntly.

"No way," Mydei retorts.

"See! Wait, Cas— just go back to sleep actually, Mydeimos is being a fucking idiot. False alarm," Cipher says, the sound of rustling as she seemingly gets out of bed and closes a door behind her comes through the line, so Mydei waits in silence to gather his thoughts before Cipher starts talking again.

Cipher sighs once she's situated, which immediately isn't a great sign. "Do you *want* it to be a date?" She drawls.

"…Yes, I do," Mydei admits, voice small as though he's said something he shouldn't have.

"Then why can't it be one?" Cipher asks.

"We're not like that," Mydei replies simply because it's *true*. They're good friends—close friends now, he assumes—but that's all, even though his feelings are running miles ahead of him and he's not able to catch up to them to wrangle them into submission.

Cipher scoffs at his answer. "Okay."

"Okay? Is that it? No lecture or motivational speech that inevitably turns into you just insulting me?" Mydei says, eyebrow raised.

"Nope," Cipher says, and Mydei can imagine her inspecting her sharp nails out of boredom. "You'll have to pay extra for the lecture and speech, but I'll give you the insults for free. Maybe you should get your brain checked as well as your eyes, hm?"

"I was only joking about the insulting thing," Mydei says through gritted teeth, rubbing his forehead in frustration. "Can you at least help me pick what to wear?"

"Why didn't you say that earlier? Tell me where you're going!"

"A little place on the coast," Mydei says, and then explains further as he forwards over the location to Cipher so she can have a look.

Cipher suggests a few clothing items, but he shoots them down immediately. "Fine, we'll leave the leather trousers for another day… How about you just go simple then? A t-shirt with a jacket, and then a pair of jeans?"

Mydei hums in response, opening his wardrobe doors to look through his clothes himself. He spots a few potential items, like a few band t-shirts he's kept since he was in university, and a couple of pairs of jeans that are slightly worn. Not *everything* he owns is designer or 'fancy', a fact which he knows Phainon would be shocked to hear about. He snorts a laugh and ignores Cipher's questioning sound at the noise.

"You don't think I should wear a shirt instead?" Mydei asks. A t-shirt and jeans sounds almost *too* casual, and he doesn't want Phainon to think he didn't try or anything when they meet up.

"And have you out and about with it undone down to your belly button? Absolutely not! You'll kill Phainon before the date even begins!"

"Not a date," Mydei corrects immediately before the rest of the sentence sets in. "Why would seeing my chest kill him off anyway? He's seen me topless before, I don't look *that* bad."

Cipher curses him out, not bothering to cover any of it up. "That's not the issue. Put the black shirt *down*, little prince."

Mydei sheepishly lets go of the clothes hanger he was holding onto with said black shirt. "How about a band t-shirt, a pair of jeans and a leather jacket?"

"Ooh, very *rock star*, even in your old age," Cipher jokes, but she sounds happy at his suggestion. "Wear your hair up tonight, and make sure you do your braid extra nicely. Put in some serum that Cassie got you for your birthday last year."

"Sure thing, boss," Mydei says, rolling his eyes at the demands being fired at him.

"And then you can top it off with all your gaudy gold jewellery!" Cipher says, laughing.

"Now you're starting on my jewellery?" Mydei says, glancing at the rings, necklaces and bracelets he has on his accessories tray on his dresser. He usually only wears his mother's signet ring, but perhaps tonight he could go all out with some more. "They're *vintage*."

Cipher's cackling laugh echoes down the phone line, and it's the final straw. Mydei hangs up on her and chucks his phone on his bed, far away from him. He storms off into his en-suite bathroom, ignoring how much his phone is buzzing from Cipher calling and texting him as he starts up the shower.

Mydei spends the next few hours pacing around his penthouse, or sitting out on his balcony trying to calm down by watching the ferries and yachts come and go in the docks. It's barely even midday and he's ready to go—dressed up, fed and watered, and now all that's left is to dot on a bit of cologne and drive there and that'll be it.

But he's restless because he wants to see Phainon *now*. He wonders what Phainon's doing—if he's just as nervy as Mydei is or maybe he doesn't care much at all; their *friendly get together* only meaning as much as that sounds. Stupidly, Mydei wishes he could have him right here with him—out on the balcony, curled up next to each other on his swinging bench as they watch the ocean glisten in the warm sunlight. It's so peaceful on this strip of the coastline, and it's all Mydei can see as he looks onwards in a vast expanse of water and nothing else.

Despite this area being popular with tourists, Mydei is high up enough in his top storey apartment that it all disappears amongst the sound of the breeze and the quiet squeaking of metal springs as he swings back and forth in his chair. It's extremely soothing, and he's glad he bought this thing even if it was a little pricey. He enjoys sitting out here when the sun is about to set as he reads a book, the weather mild and pleasant enough that he can get away with wearing a thin jumper and shorts.

The more he thinks about it, the worse he feels. Having Phainon right next to him would mean inviting him into his apartment—his *home*—and guiding him through the bedroom and out through the French doors to be able to get to his balcony. The thought of Phainon being in his living space, let alone in his *bedroom*, even if just for a split second, sends Mydei into a tailspin.

Mydei scrubs his hands over his face, thankful he doesn't need to mind his glasses as he's opted for contacts today. He lets the darkness of his palms over his eyes try and calm him, the sound of the ocean and the breeze assisting in the only way they can. It's easier to want Phainon in a purely physical way—only having to think about tearing his clothes off and having a good few hours together and then moving on—but wanting something *more* than that is a completely different thing, and a game he hasn't played in a while.

He hadn't been lying to Cipher when he told her that it wasn't a date—it *can't* be. It was just a figure of speech, that's all. They could've said 'it's a plan' and it would've meant the exact same thing. But he also hadn't been lying when he told Cipher that he *wants* it to be a date anyway, despite all his hang ups and concerns.

Mydei feels past his prime now. Just a grumpy old man who's trying to keep up with the energetic, almost fresh out of university graduate. He can't hide the way he's ageing, with his silver strands that thread through the blonde, his crow's feet and his aching knees, but he doesn't find it anything to be ashamed of. Well, most of the time, anyway. Being near Phainon has brought out more sides to him than he thought was possible—especially considering he's almost forty now and hasn't acted like this since he was a teenager. If Phainon even liked men to begin with, it wouldn't be him; it'd be one of those young gym fanatics that he follows on Instagram, or at least someone whose knees don't crack every time they stand up, and someone who isn't going grey all over.

Mydei leans back in his chair, letting the soothing back and forth movement of the swing relax him and get him out of his own head. There's no denying there's attraction there, especially for him, but he's still not entirely sure

about Phainon. Sometimes he feels it—the spark between them that's so strong it feels impossible to think that it's not mutual, but Mydei isn't the type of man who likes to assume without concrete facts.

His phone starts buzzing again, taking him out of his reverie. Mydei considers ignoring it—it's probably just Cipher or Castorice trying to get a hold of him after this morning—but he supposes he should at least reply to get them off his back while he stews for a while. Mydei pulls out his phone and it's not until he's pressed on one of the random notifications that he realises that it's not Cipher or Castorice texting him, it's *Phainon*.

Mydei's heart rate is probably breaking a world record right now, and he's very glad that he's sat down as he watches an influx of photos arrive. He taps on each one, taking his time looking and marvelling at how talented Phainon seems to be at photography. He hadn't expected that, and maybe he's biased at this point, but all the photographs are beautifully coloured and framed in a way that makes him feel warm, a small smile appearing on his face as he swipes through them all as they come.

There's one of a blue morning sky, not a cloud present. Then there's one of a cat that's sprawled out on the pavement, showing its belly and wanting fuss. One of a sandcastle he assumes Phainon built—it even has little windows and spires, along with a photo of a massive ice cream cone that's practically overflowing with scoops of different flavoured ice creams with a massive bite taken out of the side. Last of all, one that Mydei can't seem to swipe past even when he tries, is a photo of Phainon himself.

Mydei almost drops his phone when it sets in what he's looking at, and he shoves his face so close to the screen that he goes cross-eyed and fogs up his screen as he breathes harshly.

In the photo, Phainon is relaxing on the beach, wearing nothing but a yellow loose vest top that barely covers anything up and a pair of knee length board shorts in the colour purple. He didn't even know they made clothes in such colours, and it's an especially garish combo to put together, but Mydei supposes that he could've just thrown together the outfit in a rush?

Anyway, all Mydei can see is miles of bare skin as he takes in the rest of the photo. The hems of the vest are all pulled and worn, and the neckline is so low that it makes his collarbones visible. It's then that Mydei spots something he's never seen before: another tattoo. It's a simple one, a clean semi-circle line made of gold that dips down his chest. One of the straps has fallen off his shoulder, too loose to stay up, and it feels like Mydei shouldn't be allowed to witness this—the strong corded muscles of his arms flexing and contrasting with his delicate decolletage.

Phainon's leaning back on his forearms, elbows digging into the sand to support his weight. He's got one leg stretched out, the other bent at the knee in a way that allows his shorts to gape loosely around his thigh teasingly. The sun that's beaming directly on him makes him positively *glow*, and there's a thin layer of sweat covering his pale skin from the heat.

Mydei's heart *aches* with how beautiful Phainon is; the half-lidded, serene expression on his face with the tiniest smile accompanying it is almost too much for him to handle. Mydei swallows down pooling saliva in his mouth a few times, despite his throat feeling drier than ever. He doesn't even have to be beaming wide with a smile to glow, it seems.

He only comes back to himself when he realises that someone else has clearly taken the photo, causing a terrible spike of jealousy. Who is close enough to see Phainon like this? Who's Phainon even smiling at—the person behind the camera? Questions like this continue flooding in until shame overtakes it, especially since he realises the photo has come with a caption: *my sister took this one lol*

Mydei shakily taps on the photo to enlarge it, barely resisting the urge to pinch and zoom in on every pixel as he hovers his finger over the save button. He wants to set it as his lock and home screen wallpaper so he can see it every time his phone lights up, or when he's scrolling through his apps looking for the one he wants to use. As a compromise, he allows himself to use the photo as Phainon's contact photo instead, and even in the form of a tiny circle at the top of their conversation, it doesn't dim how utterly radiant Phainon is.

Mydei's phone chimes with another text message, and his heart almost beats out of his chest at the thought of another photo of Phainon coming through. Much to his dismay, or his saving grace, it's just a normal text.

**Phainon [12:13 pm]**

hey, don't leave me on read :-(

**Mydei [12:13 pm]**

Sorry. I was still looking at the photos.

**Phainon [12:13 pm]**

send me one back

Mydei freezes at that. Should he take a photo of himself and send it over? He's not a very skilled 'selfie taker', as it were, so instead he opens the camera to take a photo of the scenery instead. The photo catches his balcony railing, the black iron contrasting against the cloudless blue sky that stretches on endlessly, melting in with the darker ocean before him.

**Mydei [12:16 pm]**

[Photo]

Here.

**Phainon [12:16 pm]**

whoa nice! i love it

which one of mine did you like the best? :-)

Mydei could lie. He could blag his way out and say it was the cat, or say how much he loves looking at the clear blue skies on a warm day too. Maybe, even, he could say that he wishes he could have a bite out of Phainon's ice cream cone, and ask him which flavour was his favourite. All those would be safe, pleasant ways of striking up a conversation without too much risk on his behalf.

But this time, he wants to tell the truth.

**Mydei [12:18 pm]**

The one of you.

His face heats up as soon as he presses send, and he wishes he could take it back. But then his phone is vibrating again, and he peers down at the screen to see Phainon's reply.

**Phainon [12:18 pm]**

thank you

Mydei replies before he can think better of it.

**Mydei [12:19 pm]**

❤

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Mydei's palms are sweaty and everything feels too warm despite the AC being on full blast in his car. He's sure that if he looks in his rear-view mirror right now he'll look as awful as he feels—clammy, overdressed and underdressed at the same time, and wide-eyed. He can barely focus on the

road as pin pricks of perspiration flare up all over his body the closer he gets to the bar.

He's relieved that finding a parking space is relatively easy. The car park is desolate except for a few cars and bikes dotted around, so he slots into one that's further away than the rest, taking his time to make sure he's completely straight and within the lines. The sound of gravel beneath his tyres as he finally settles the car makes his stomach jump. Mydei can't remember the last time he felt like this—so nervous and queasy feeling that he almost wants to back out. The only thing keeping him here is reminding himself that this isn't actually a date, despite him wanting it to be, and that this is going to be the same as when they hang out on school grounds. It's always easy between them, the give and take, the banter, the back and forth, so why would that change now just because they're not at school?

He and Phainon are co-workers. Friends now, for sure, considering that they've spent every single lunchtime together for the past couple of months, and Phainon still keeps making the six minute walk across campus just to see him there. That, and the fact that they text almost daily helps too. That all means something at least—something *big*—regardless of anything else or any other unwanted feelings he's been slowly developing for the younger teacher. And after all, he's excited to see Phainon outside of work for once.

Mydei's curious about so many things: what will Phainon be wearing? Will it feel the same as when they see each other at work or when they text, or will it be awkward now that they don't have either of them as a buffer? What if Phainon really *is* a shit bartender, and Mydei has to suffer through rounds of poor quality drinks and then make an excuse to leave as soon as possible? But then what does he do if Cipher is right—that he sees where the night goes, and then they end up closer for it?

Mydei turns the engine off once he's finally parked, hoping it'll turn off his brain along with it. He can't move, bound to the leather seat, and he grips the steering wheel tighter until the force leads it to creak underneath his grip and his hands start to hurt. He feels rooted to the spot with unease, his mind in a tumultuous mess. Mydei knows he can't stay in here forever, so he gives himself a few seconds to collect himself, breathing in and out rhythmically until his heart rate slows again. He's never usually this nervous about anything, so it's jarring him even more than usual at how shaken he is over this.

The cold air that hits him as soon as he opens the door makes him shiver, goosebumps rippling across his arms underneath his leather jacket. He'd forgotten how freezing it gets at night right by the seafront; he's too used to the calming ocean breeze of the docks now to adjust to anything else quickly.

He glances around the poorly lit area, catching sight of the neon lights of the pier that's at the bottom of the hill. The lights illuminate only the tiniest surrounding area despite how bright they look, leaving the majority of the beach hidden in total darkness, a mystery. Mydei can just about hear the sounds coming from it though—a cacophony of music and voices being carried towards him through the wind, settling deep in his bones. It's jarringly noisy compared to the stillness at the top of the hill where he currently is, as the high street shops are all shut down for the night and no one else is around. It's just him. He wishes he could hear the sound of the ocean's lapping waves instead, so they can help calm him down.

**Mydei [07:01 pm]**

I'm here.

The text is read immediately, making his eyes widen slightly.

**Phainon [07:01 pm]**

just walking there now, almost there. wait outside for me pls :-)

Mydei's stomach flips as he presses on the message to give it a thumbs up. He wanders over to the entrance, stepping up onto the patio deck outside. It's a bit cramped with how many benches and tables they've managed to squeeze in, but during the tourist packed summer season he supposes it's necessary. He perches on the edge of one of the benches, thankful it hasn't rained today so it isn't wet. Mydei hums to himself, glancing around at the greenery and added foliage to make the place look more welcoming. It's a quaint sort of bar, one of the more homely ones that he's been to, and he's looking forward to seeing the inside now that he's finally here.

Mydei's phone buzzes again and he checks it, holding back a chuckle when he sees it's Cipher texting him furiously, already asking for updates about his 'date'. He silences his phone and pockets it, and after that it doesn't take long for the sound of someone walking over the gravel pathways to appear. Mydei shoots upwards, almost stumbling from the force, but he rights himself as Phainon slowly comes into view, closer and closer.

"Mydei!" Phainon greets, jogging the last few steps to make it to Mydei quicker. He throws his arms around his shoulders, tugging him forward. Mydei immediately hugs back, shocked, but it doesn't stop him from wrapping his arms around Phainon's waist to pull them even closer together. He wasn't expecting a *hug*, they've never done that before.

Phainon is so *warm*, warding him against the outside chill. It takes everything in him not to just bury his face into the crook of his neck and breathe him in. He's not sure how that'll be received, and he'd rather not risk it.

"Whoa, you look cool as heck," Phainon says as he pulls back a little, leaving one arm wrapped around Mydei's neck as he stares down at his clothing, the other one coming up to tug a few times at his leather jacket's lapel.

"It's vintage," Mydei says proudly, but he hopes Phainon can't tell how strained his voice is. Their faces are so close that Phainon's styled hair tickles against his forehead, the hair wax in it smelling deliciously fruity.

Phainon laughs and steps away completely, leaving Mydei's arms to drop down feebly by his sides, now without anything to hold onto.

"Of course it is," Phainon replies, his eyes sparkling even in the dim light. "You're not wearing your glasses either!"

Mydei feels the sudden phantom weight of the frames on his nose, and the urge to nervously adjust them makes his hands twitch. "I thought I'd give contacts a go tonight." He replies, watching Phainon nod in approval.

"You look…" Mydei begins, but words fail him. He gives Phainon a once over, taking in the white trousers with a black strap tied around his thigh, a golden pin on the front of it. It's unexpectedly *sexy*. He's wearing a thick

blue jumper and a jacket, and a nice pair of boots to go along with it. He looks like a *supermodel*, what with his perfectly styled hair that's quaffed just right, and his pretty pale skin that's slowly turning pink the longer he stares. Mydei clears his throat, standing up straighter as he directs his gaze back to Phainon's eyes. "Good. Very good."

"Oh, thanks!" Phainon beams, giving Mydei an obvious once over, eyes sticking to his chest where the Titan's Mercy logo is plastered across it. "Cool shirt too, I used to love that band as a teen."

"Used to?" Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow. "What's wrong with them now?"

"Nothing! Nothing at all, I went through a bit of an 'emo phase'," He uses air quotes. "As a teen, so I was into the really heavy hitting stuff. Now… Not so much, heh."

"Maybe I'm still going through my *emo phase* then, as you put it," Mydei says sceptically, wanting to defend his favourite band.

Phainon laughs, patting Mydei on the shoulder as he looks over him again, his eyes seemingly lingering everywhere this time—from his chest to his stomach, down to his thighs and calves and back up again. Mydei clears his throat and wishes he had his glasses on in the hopes they might hide how warm his face is starting to feel the longer this goes on.

"Remind me to show you a pic of me as a kid when we're inside, you'll see what I mean then," Phainon says, finally dragging his eyes off of Mydei's body and onto his face. "C'mon, let's head in. I'll introduce you to my friends who own the bar." Phainon grabs Mydei's wrist and drags him inside the building.

Mydei feels the warmth rush over him the moment they step inside, a welcome contrast to the biting cold that had seeped through his jacket and straight into his bones. He exhales, shoulders relaxing as the door swings shut behind them, muffling the spring-summer wind and replacing it with the low hum of conversation, clinking glasses and the soft crackle from a fireplace tucked in the far corner.

Phainon's hand is secure around his wrist, not too light and not too strong, the perfect balance as Mydei follows him through the tightly packed space. The bar is cosy in a way that almost feels nostalgic: amber lights hanging low over each table, the wood darkened with age and polished to a warm sheen, with mismatched chairs gathered around. A faint scent of citrus and worn leather lingers in the air, threaded with the richer notes of coffee beans and spiced rum.

They weave between a couple of occupied tables, slipping past patrons bundled in scarves and thick sweaters, already settled into their evening conversations. Mydei catches himself glancing at Phainon's profile in the warm light as they move, struck by how the glow softens his features and highlights the curve of his smile. It sends a quiet flutter through him, unexpected but not unwelcome.

As they reach the bar, Mydei spots two bartenders chatting lazily between orders, their sleeves rolled up and cheeks flushed from the heat inside. The

counter is scattered with rustic coasters and puddles of drinks that'd sloshed out, still waiting to be cleaned.

"Theron! Dorian!" Phainon calls, using his other hand that isn't holding onto Mydei to wave at them. The guys behind the bar perk up immediately and shout back in greeting.

They eye Mydei curiously as they arrive in front of the counter, the scent of beer filling his nose as they come to a stop. Phainon lets go of Mydei then, dropping his wrist in favour of gesturing to one of the stools further along the bar at the end so they can sit down together. Mydei feels his face fall as Phainon's hand leaves him, instantly missing the heat from Phainon's skin against his.

"Who's this?" One of them says, looking less than impressed when he meets Mydei's gaze.

"Oh, this is Mydei. He's—"

"So *this* is the famous 'Mr Mydei Kremnos' we've been hearing about?" The older looking one cuts in, leaning forward over the counter top to leer at Mydei. He waggles his eyebrows a few times at Phainon, who only glares back venomously.

The unimpressed one suddenly looks interested. "You didn't say he was *this* hot."

"He definitely *did*, you just weren't listening."

Phainon's face turns panicked, eyes wide and mouth gaping open as his hands come up to wave furiously in front of him, clearly at a loss for words. His friends give him positively *evil* looking grins.

"I hope you've only heard good things," Mydei says gruffly, feeling as though two vultures are watching him.

"Yup, definitely good things. Especially about your—"

"*Dorian*!" Phainon yells, red up to the roots of his hair. He points towards the opposite end of the bar, "Someone wants to order."

Dorian heaves himself up straight and glances towards where Phainon is pointing, where indeed, someone is waiting to order. "Alright, I get it. I'll leave you two alone. You know where everything is, so knock yourself out," Dorian says and wanders off.

The other guy, who now Mydei assumes is Theron, gives him a considering look before waving at them and following Dorian.

"Sorry about them, they're so damn annoying sometimes," Phainon says, scratching under his chin nervously.

"I can see why you're friends then," Mydei shoots back.

Phainon looks affronted by his words, "If I didn't promise you the best drinks of your life, I'd spit in them instead."

"Too bad," Mydei says, relaxing into his stool as he rests his hands on the lip of the counter top. He smirks over at Phainon, "I'm into that."

"You—!" Phainon splutters, going red all over again. It's sweet, Mydei thinks, and he wants to reach out and touch his cheek to see if it's as warm as it looks. "Fine, whatever!" Phainon hops off the stool and walks around the other side of the bar, stopping once he's right in front of Mydei. "Guess I'll be your *annoying* bartender for tonight then, Mr Kremnos."

"Back to Mr Kremnos are we?" Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow.

"I thought you'd like it. It takes a lot to please you, doesn't it?"

Mydei hums, propping up his chin on his palm so he can look up at Phainon, purposely trying to look coy. "I don't know about that. I'm pretty pleased with the handsome bartender I've got right now."

Phainon's mouth does a funny, twisty thing like it doesn't know what to do, until it finally settles on a shy smile. "Your charm isn't going to get you a discount tonight."

"Oh, I suddenly have to pay?" Mydei asks.

"I expect tips at least," Phainon says, winking mischievously at him, and then he starts laughing when Mydei rolls his eyes.

"You better make it worth my time *and* money, then," Mydei replies.

Phainon's whole body seems to buzz with the challenge given to him. His face takes on a determined note and his shoulders set back, and within seconds he's spinning around to face the shelves of alcohol as he gets to work.

Mydei watches him in silence, in awe of how he moves behind the bar. He sees what Phainon had meant when he proclaimed to be the 'best in the town', and he can understand why people would crowd around just to watch him. The fluidity and confidence by doing his job oozes off of him, all charm and good looks. But he's different now than when he teaches a class —his face is smooth, devoid of emotion and his eyes watch his hands like a hawk, measuring and mixing ingredients with inhuman precision. It's clear he takes pride in his talent, and the easy showcase of it makes Mydei a little hot under the collar.

"Lemon or orange?" Phainon asks, coming to a temporary standstill.

"Lemon," Mydei replies, nodding his head.

Phainon twists a slice of lemon peel he gets out of a glass jar and places it in the stout glass before sliding it over across the bar towards Mydei.

"An Old Fashioned?" Mydei asks as he picks up the glass to inspect it.

"I thought it'd suit you," Phainon replies, sticking his tongue out childishly.

Mydei gives him a flat look and takes a sip, letting the taste of whisky and bitters fill his mouth. He feels it settle in his stomach, leaving behind it a trail of spiced warmth.

"Good?" Phainon questions, eyes wide and hopeful as he sounds slightly breathless.

Mydei pretends to contemplate for a few moments and takes another sip as if to deliberate his judgement. He hums, finally replying: "I guess you'll have to be my own personal bartender from now on."

Phainon grins, shoulders sagging in what seems like relief. Was he really that tense over if Mydei would like his drinks or not? "Would I be paid well?" He asks.

Mydei places the glass down and reaches into his back pocket to grab his wallet. He opens it, bypassing the section with his debit and credit cards in and goes to where the wad of notes are. He picks out a thick section of them in offering, and Phainon's eyes widen as he looks between the notes and Mydei's face.

"Is this enough?" Mydei asks, sliding the credits across the bar. Phainon blinks a few times in shock but doesn't reply. Mydei scoffs and picks them back up again, shoving them into the tip jar nearby instead.

"I was only kidding…" Phainon says faintly, trailing off as he stares at the full tip jar.

Mydei shrugs, taking another sip of his drink. It's really good, even if he's not usually a fan of whisky, but the fact it was made for him by the person he likes, well… "The service is worth it," Mydei says, smirking at Phainon over the rim of his glass.

Phainon makes them both drinks after that, definitely more than he'd originally promised Mydei, and slides them all over in one big mountain so he can settle down on the stool next to him. Theron and Dorian are still steering completely clear of them, sticking to the opposite end of the bar so they're out of earshot.

Mydei likes this feeling—where he and Phainon are in a bubble of their own, away from the drunken patrons and questionable looks he's still getting from the bartenders. This way, it feels like they're squirrelled away, as if it's only the two of them in the entire world. The peace between them settles like a warm blanket over him as they both savour their drinks in the quiet for a bit.

Phainon has already finished one of his drinks, a fruity looking cocktail, when he speaks: "I need to show you that photo of me from when I was a teenager." He shuffles around on his stool and grabs his phone from his coat pocket, face pinching in concentration as he scrolls through his gallery. "Ah, here it is!" And then he's turning his phone towards Mydei.

Mydei has to blink back against the brightness of Phainon's screen—it's a lot brighter than his—but when it finally comes into focus, he has to bite down on the inside of his cheek to stop himself from laughing. It's Phainon—albeit a very young one—posing in the mirror, wearing a ratty oversized black hoodie with one hand over his eye, where purple bangs poke out between his fingers. His eyes are still the same, blazingly bright, but his cheeks are fuller and he looks a lot shorter.

"You had *purple hair*?" Mydei exclaims in awe.

"Just the front, the rest was black. Took me *ages* to grow out when I decided I wanted to go back to my natural hair colour," Phainon replies, and then he takes back his phone to swipe to the next photo. "See, I'm wearing Titan's Mercy merch in this one. I went to see them in concert one time and dragged my dad along with me."

Mydei peers down at the screen again, and this time it's Phainon hiding his face away from the camera, but the purple and black hair sticks out at all odds and ends. He's wearing a Titan's Mercy tour t-shirt and low hanging jeans with a studded belt slung across his hips.

"Wow," Mydei says, nodding encouragingly at Phainon while still not trying to laugh. "I'd say you look a lot better now than you did back then."

"Obviously! I want such a snot-nosed kid, always wanting to be someone I wasn't just to please everyone around me. I even called myself *Flame Reaver* online to look extra cool. Took me a while, but I got outta that and then realised I wanted to knuckle down and do something *good*, y'know? And that's how I ended up with teaching."

"Impressive," Mydei says, and he means it genuinely. It takes a lot of guts at such an age to break free of other's expectations and finally go down the route of your own wishes. Mydei takes a gulp of his drink. "I'm afraid when I was that age, we didn't have phones to take photos with. I think I have some printed out ones of me as a kid, but that's in the family's photo album at my father's house."

"Aw, I wanted to see baby Mydei. You dress like a rock star now, so how did you dress as a kid?" Phainon asks, tilting his head to the side. His hair shifts with the movement, shining in the dim lights. It looks so soft, even with wax in it.

"Primly. Properly. My father always made sure of it, especially after my mother passed away and I had no one else in my corner," Mydei says

matter-of-factly.

"I'm sorry," Phainon says, pausing briefly. "About your mother."

Mydei waves him off, "No need to apologise. It's in the past."

"Still," Phainon begins. "It's still in *your* past, and you must miss her a lot."

"Free therapy *and* free drinks? You sure know how to treat a guy," Mydei replies, grinning. Then, he shakes his head when Phainon doesn't do anything else but scoff. "I do miss her," He clears his throat as he takes a swig of another drink that Phainon prepared for him. This one is lighter, sickly sweet around the edges, the sugar tickling his throat as he swallows it. "Oh, I like this one."

Phainon beams at him, clearly not going to push him over discussing losing his mother, which he's thankful for. "*Pomegranate Passion*, that one is. We didn't have any goat's milk in, so I thought I'd make you something as tasty with low alcohol, since you're driving."

"It's good," Mydei nods his head.

"Just for you," Phainon grins. "How did you get into teaching?"

"My father, which I assume you won't be surprised to hear. He's been the headteacher at school for as long as I can remember, but before that he was on the school board. He wanted me to do the same—take over him, whatever, but… I just found passion in history instead, and nothing else mattered."

Phainon hums as he drinks, "It suits you. History. I had loads of fun on the school trip, but you… you *shine* when you talk about it. It's great."

"Shine? Hah," Mydei can't help but let out the half-laugh, half-scoff at that. "I think I lost my shine a while ago."

"Then you don't see yourself like how *I* do," Phainon retorts, and he looks almost angry, face creased and scrunched up. "Because you're amazing. I really admire you, actually, I—" He stops, blinking furiously for a few moments, then all the fight leaves him, clear in the way he droops and his shoulders sag. "Can I ask you something?" Phainon says, breaking the silence as he turns towards Mydei on his stool. Their knees brush against each other until Phainon's comes to rest on the side of Mydei's thigh, digging in lightly from being so close.

Mydei blinks at him, surprised at the change in topic. "Sure?"

"Do…" Phainon clenches his fists and then relaxes them again, his eyes fluttering closed before they open. He looks like he's steeling himself for something. "Do you have a girlfriend?"

Mydei stares at him in shock, and then bursts out laughing. He can't help it —not when he thought Phainon was going to ask him something *life or death* going by his reaction before even asking it. "No, I don't," Mydei says through chuckles. "I don't date women, Phainon."

"Oh… *oh*," He mutters, then his eyes are blazing hot as they land on Mydei. "A boyfriend, then?"

"Don't have one of them either, sadly," Mydei replies, the remnants of his laughter being lost in his *pomegranate passion* drink. "Last time was in university, but… things happened, and it went wrong before I could do anything about it. Then I was too busy with finishing my degree, and then working full-time to really care much about anything else but brief flings." Mydei hums, letting the alcohol warm his chest as he opens up. "Now, though… Now I'd like something. *Someone*."

"I see," Phainon says softly, looking downwards before blinking back up. "I think… I think I'd like someone as well."

"Really?" Mydei asks, voice lilting. "You don't want to spend your twenties rocking out and trying all sorts?"

"*Rocking out*, gods, it's times like these that I remember how old you are," Phainon says, laughing as he shoves Mydei's shoulder lightly. "Who even says that anymore?"

"I guess people who are almost forty do," Mydei sniffs and finishes his drink.

After that, conversation flows freely, darting around from topic to topic as they go. Mydei feels so warm, inside and out, cosy and safe here, and he finds himself laughing a lot more than he usually does. It's so *easy* with Phainon, so simple that they can go from chatting about the weather to politics, back to the weather, and then onto something completely unrelated and left field like sports. He finds out that Phainon loves football the most, whereas Mydei is more of a rugby guy if he really had to pick. Phainon asks him loads of questions about history, exploring more about the school trip and he doesn't even seem to mind when Mydei goes on about six tangents before getting back to the point. Instead, he watches on intently, sipping at his drink and nodding in all the right places. Mydei *swears* he's better when he's actually teaching—but here, sitting with their thighs touching and elbows brushing, he feels more flustered than usual.

They've both gone through at least five drinks each now, and Mydei is starting to feel the effects. He feels *light*, almost as though he's drifting, and his tongue feels looser than ever before. Phainon doesn't look much better off, as behind all the fruity based cocktails, there was a bunch of liquor lacing them. His pale skin shows off how easily he blushes beautifully, and his skin is flushed right now, staining it pink as he downs a glass from almost half full.

"Slow down!" Mydei says, reaching out his hands to wrestle the glass back down to the counter. "Why are you rushing?"

"Because—" Phainon begins, but then he shakes his head and never finishes. Instead, he sighs, and says: "Do you wanna get outta here?"

Mydei opens his mouth to object, but then he realises all their drinks are gone. He could ask Phainon to make him some more, sure, but he has to drive home and he's already erring on the edge of too much. His insides feel all warm from the alcohol, but thankfully he's still alert enough that maybe getting out of here for a bit will do him some good.

"Sure," Mydei replies. He glances at Theron and Dorian who, true to their word, haven't disturbed them all night.

"Don't worry about paying," Phainon says as he jumps off his stool, landing with a precarious wobble. "I think your tip was enough to pay for drinks for the next two weeks. Plus, I already covered it. They owed me a favour."

"I see," Mydei replies and follows after Phainon, who this time doesn't seem to wind around the tables with as much grace as he did earlier on. It seems like he's drank too much, and it didn't help that the alcohol was flowing freely for the almost two hours since they arrived.

He can't believe they were chatting for two hours straight with minimal breaks in between as they savoured their drinks, but he supposes it makes sense considering how much they still have to learn about each other.

As Phainon shoulders open the door, a gust of wind hits Mydei in the face unpleasantly. It feels even colder than it did when he first arrived, and he shivers against it as he wraps his arms around himself. He usually runs warm, but that only comes in handy when he's indoors and trying to settle down for bed. Phainon doesn't seem too affected by the changes in

temperature, which doesn't surprise Mydei. This is the same guy who still wears those tiny shorts to school when the temperature is in the single digits.

"I wanna sit on the beach," Phainon declares suddenly as they start making their way across the gravel paths.

"Right now?" Mydei shoots back, perplexed at the thought.

Phainon looks at him strangely, a little hazy around the edges as the alcohol has softened his gaze. "You've never sat on the beach at night?"

"Should I have done?"

"You're the one who's been here nearly all his life, not me! It's really calming, let's go," Phainon speeds off, leaving Mydei to have to jog to catch up with him.

The pavement leading to the sea front is extremely steep, the curve of the hill so severe makes it hard to see where it even ends. The dim street lamps aren't helping either, doing a poor job of lighting up the way as they make it further down. Phainon is—to Mydei's chagrin—undeniably *drunk*, no matter how many times he insists he isn't. But Mydei has to keep steadying him as they go, hands balancing him out quickly before he trips over his own feet. Phainon only giggles in response, waving Mydei off like an overly-concerned parent. It's knocking years off of Mydei's life span from

the worry that Phainon is going to face-plant the ground and go rolling straight into the ocean.

Phainon's laughter echoes around the empty street when Mydei tells him this, and he laughs even harder until he's wheezing when Mydei yells at him to be careful. Despite this, Phainon while drunk is undeniably *cute*. As soon as the beach comes into view, a child-like type of wonder spreads across his face, acting as if he's never seen it before despite literally visiting the beach earlier today with his sister. The beach feels eerily still now that they're closer, the continuous rolling of the waves feeding the uncanny feeling with how exact they are each time. The darkness engulfs everything, and in the end the only thing that brightens up their way is the full moon in the sky that casts the sand and water in a cool, ethereal light.

Phainon's laugh of pure delight rings out as he runs off from Mydei, not even the soft sand sinking beneath his feet slows him down. He skids to a stop just before the shore, the waves lapping only inches away from his feet. Phainon sways, flopping down onto the sand like a tonne of bricks. Mydei winces and rushes over as quickly as he can, careful to try and not get any sand in his shoes. He gingerly sits down next to Phainon, ignoring the way the moisture from the ground dampens his jeans.

Anyone else would've been washed out by the moonlight, their skin appearing sickly and sallow, but Phainon only seems to glow more with it on him instead. Mydei knows he's pleasantly buzzed, not quite enough to be tipsy now that the cool air has taken care of that, but the warmth of the alcohol still in his veins is helping him relax in ways he hasn't found himself able to do in a long time. He's not even sure what he was worried about in the first place—this not-date has gone so well already, having chatted nonstop as they downed their drinks, that he feels silly for being so anxious to begin with. It's just *Phainon*, after all. His friend.

The unnerving silence of the beach turns into a comforting one, what with the sound of Phainon breathing beside him and the sound of the ocean waves coming in and out slowly. There's faint music coming from the pier, but it's not enough to pierce through them. He's more than happy to sit there with the only noise being their breathing and the water coming and going as it pleases while they're both lost in their thoughts.

"I'm happier here," Phainon says, the night chill almost carrying his voice away into the water with how quiet his words are.

Mydei turns his attention away from the sea and onto Phainon, realising that he's already looking at him.

"I was so worried to move away from Aedes Elysiae. It was *nice,* comfortable being there living with my parents and my sister, Cyrene," Phainon breathes out and smiles. "She came to visit me today and brought loads of delicious homemade breads and cheeses that we make on the farm at home."

"I knew it, you're a farm boy," Mydei says, trying to keep his voice as low as possible to not break the quiet spell between them, their own little cocoon of privacy out in the open.

Phainon grins, a crooked little thing. It's hopelessly charming, and Mydei feels his heartbeat slowly pick up. "Did my accent give it away?"

"It sure did," Mydei says. "I suppose mine does too, giving away that I've always been a city boy."

"You sound so *regal*, just like a little prince," Phainon replies, laughing quietly. "So el— eloquent—"

"You said that correctly," Mydei comments, chuckling when he gets a glare in response.

"Anyway, it's what ended up holding me back. Staying there. So… Yeah, I'm glad I'm here, and I'm always gonna be grateful for what you did for me when I first started at school. I really thought I messed up and it was all over for me, but you got me through it. Then you defended me against your dad, and reassured me after… I definitely didn't thank you enough back then," Phainon takes a deep breath and stretches out his legs, wiggling his feet to dig his heels into the sand. "So thank you, Mydei."

Mydei feels his cheeks warm as the waves lick dangerously at their outstretched legs, but Phainon doesn't seem to care, so neither does he. He feels slightly embarrassed at such an honest thanks. "Of course I defended you against him, he was out of order, and we're… *friends*, so you don't need to thank me."

"*Friends*, yeah," Phainon sighs, almost wistfully, and Mydei wonders what he's thinking about. He almost feels like he's said something wrong. "I miss loads of things from Aedes Elysiae though. Like the fishing, the cows and the chickens… my parents, Cyrene… Even though it's better that I left."

"Is your relationship good with your parents?" Mydei asks, curious.

"Sure is! I love them," Phainon replies, beaming at Mydei. He can tell instantly that he means it—that he truly loves his parents, and they love him just as equally back, their darling son.

It makes Mydei wonder if he ever loved his father. Maybe as a child before he was old enough to understand his controlling ways, he did. Maybe before he could even say the word *father*, that's when it happened. He wonders if his father loved him, either. Maybe when he was easier to impress, easier to control and manipulate and mould. He wonders if his father loved his mother, too, or if it was always a complicated mess that was presented to him.

Mydei shuffles closer to Phainon, not caring if the sand beneath him smears across his jeans or as the wetness of it completely ruins the material. He just finds himself suddenly desperate for a point of contact between him and Phainon, so he forces their shoulders to knock gently against one another, bridging the gap and causing the pit in his stomach to ease up, especially when Phainon shoots him a confused smile.

"Did you have fun with your sister today?" Mydei asks, wanting to keep talking.

"I did! We spent hours on the beach today, I'm surprised I didn't burn. I don't tend to tan, so…" He trails off with a nervous laugh. "Maybe during summer you'll see me looking like a scorched lobster."

*During the summer*, Mydei thinks, when the kids are all off for the holidays and there's no school. Maybe then they'll still meet up, seeing each other as much as weekly to make up for the lack of seeing each other during school time. The thought sets Mydei's stomach a flutter, a thousand butterflies exploding as he gets carried away with the subtle implications. Phainon probably just meant in general—like, when he returns off the summer holidays and he's still burnt to a crisp, not having seen Mydei at all for the past six weeks. But he wants to see Phainon even when they're off, although weekly or anything less wouldn't be enough for him. He's been spoiled by seeing this man five out of seven days a week.

"I'll be sure to take plenty of photos of you looking like that," Mydei replies. "But Cyrene sounds lovely."

Phainon sits there quietly and searches his face, the moonlight reflecting in those blue eyes and illuminating them in a way he thought only possible in fairy tales. Mydei is completely enchanted as he looks into them, unable to tear his gaze away. They shine so brightly, brighter than the moon itself, and he can tell that Phainon is starting to smile just by the way his eyes are curving upwards, not needing to look at his mouth.

"You're a good friend," Phainon murmurs.

Mydei scoffs, his heart feeling as though it's being squeezed as he thinks about all the totally 'not friendly' things he's thought about Phainon. He glances away, staring down at his hands. "Hardly."

He *has* to look away briefly because Phainon looks at him like he's seeing right through his body and soul—peeling back every layer of protection he's built up over the years to actually see *him* in his entirety. It doesn't last long, he can still feel Phainon's gaze on him, so he looks back, connecting their eyes once more.

"You are. Even if you don't think so, you put up with me all the time," Phainon laughs as he sways to the side to nudge their shoulders together again. "So you're not allowed to argue."

"Not even a little bit?" Mydei asks, nudging Phainon back. Even though he doesn't agree that he's a 'good friend' in the slightest—he *can't* be with how much he wants Phainon in ways that aren't platonic, he doesn't say anything else, not wanting to ruin the tranquility that's settled between them.

"Being around you makes me happy. What else do you need to be good at when you're friends?" Phainon says.

Mydei stares at him, long and hard, letting the truth of the statement settle in as it finally makes everything click into place; being around Phainon makes *him* happy, too. With every glance, every touch, and every laugh that Phainon has given him over these past few months feels like nothing but a drop in the ocean compared to this moment. The ease they've always had when they talk, the conversations coming so naturally he's never had to scramble to find something new to bring up. The teasing, the silly talks, the way he lets Phainon run amok around him just *because*. Even the silences between them are comfortable, like there's no pressure to try and keep something going when there's nothing to say. He's more than happy sitting next to Phainon in the staffroom on the worn leather sofa as he does his

crossword puzzle all while Phainon taps away happily on his phone until the bell rings.

He'd been subtly hoping and praying that what he felt towards Phainon was nothing more than sexual attraction—or something that would wear off just as quickly if he waited long enough—but no amount of waiting will remove this feeling from his heart. He wants to do things he hasn't even thought about in years, like taking Phainon on more dates around Okhema, showing him all the niche tourist places that will hopefully stock a bunch of relics and antiques for him to look at. He wants to hold his hand, to hug him when he's happy or sad, to kiss him better when he's ill, to fuss over him until Phainon gets all huffy and tells him off. He wants to cook them breakfast, lunch and dinner—sharing stories and jokes and laughter as they eat. He wants, he wants, he *wants*.

Mydei wouldn't even mind being made fun of—about his age, the way he dresses, the way he speaks, all as long as it makes Phainon laugh, never taking his eyes off of him.

He'd do it all a million times over if it makes Phainon happy.

"What are you thinking about?" Phainon asks him, voice impossibly soft.

"You." Mydei replies without hesitating, sitting back on his hands, letting the sand hold his weight up even as it scratches against his palms.

Phainon's eyes only curve upwards even more as his smile widens, "Funny. I was thinking about you too."

Mydei's breath stutters, his heart pausing while also racing at the same time. The only sound between them is the gentle lapping of the ocean as neither of them speak, not even the sound of their breathing can be heard, as though they're both holding their breaths. Phainon blinks up at him slowly, those snowy white lashes fluttering so sweetly against the sudden gust of wind that Mydei can't help but be reeled in.

The tips of their noses bump against each other, but Phainon doesn't flinch back like Mydei assumed, nor does he tell him to stop. Instead, he keeps watching, gaze as saccharine as the drinks he made for them, even as their breaths begin to mingle from their close proximity. Mydei feels like he's in a daze, the fruity scent from Phainon's hair wax completely cancelling out the salty sea air between them. It's addicting in a way that he'd be happy to never have fresh air again if all he could smell was Phainon instead.

Mydei only needs to close in an extra inch or so and he'd be there, with his lips on Phainon's like he's been dreaming about and wanting ever since he first saw him, or in all those moments where he'd feel like a magnet was pulling them closer together. He can't make sense of it all—why Phainon hasn't shoved him away yet, asked what the hells he was doing, or started getting angry at him for being so close. Because instead of all that, he looks like he's *waiting*.

Swallowing past the lump in his throat, he feels his pulse even in his fingertips as they dig into the ground, the grains of sand getting stuck underneath his trimmed nails. Phainon tilts his head ever so slightly so that their noses slot against each other perfectly. It makes Mydei hesitate—the

air between them feels so hot and electric that it's almost stifling, his whole body rippling with goosebumps. He can feel Phainon shivering against him, whether from the cold wind or from something else, he's not sure. But it's enough to make him move forward to brush their lips against each other anyway.

Mydei's eyelids begin to fall shut so he can finally—*finally*—kiss him, the culmination of months worth of feelings overflowing, pouring out of him and through his lips as he kisses Phainon. Phainon surges the rest of the way and it's done, their mouths are fully on each other, encapsulated. The gentle press of lips makes Mydei gasp, and he can't move for a few moments from shock. Phainon goes to pull away, a horrid, disappointed sound escaping him as he does so, but Mydei immediately cups his jaw in panic to make him stay put. He doesn't want to hear that sound again coming from Phainon, not if he can help it.

Phainon doesn't move again, leaning into his palm instead. He's so dazed from the feeling of actually kissing him that he doesn't notice at first that he's getting wet sand all over Phainon's face until he feels the scrape of grains against his hand. It shocks him again then that this is *real*. He's really kissing Phainon, on the beach, out in the open with the moonlight as their only witness.

It's chaste, their lips not moving quite yet, as Mydei is too scared to deepen it as if asking for more will cause Phainon to pull back for good this time and then it'll be all over. But Phainon places his hand so gently, so delicately, over Mydei's on his jaw to steady the way it's shaking, the weight and warmth of it comforting against his skin. Mydei repositions himself, tilting his head even more so he can get the angle just right to slot his bottom lip between Phainon's.

Mydei presses firmly against Phainon's lips then at the assurance that he isn't going anywhere. They begin to move in tandem, not much unlike the ocean—ebbing and flowing against each other, pressing and pushing, biting and nipping softly as they gradually melt into it more and more. Mydei can't help but run his tongue over the seam of Phainon's lips, soothing over how swollen he's already made them, desperately wanting whatever he can have and take now that he has it. Phainon opens up quickly to let him in, and Mydei feels his whimper against their lips as their tongues finally touch. He's emboldened at Phainon's response as their tongues curl together, wet and slick and *addicting*.

The first thing Mydei can taste is something sickly sweet, like pure syrup with a hint of coconut, and he can't help but moan at how good it tastes as he swallows it down with each swipe of his tongue and pressing of their lips. His whole body feels like it's boiling over, the base of his spine tingling and his heart thumping wildly behind his ribcage. It's blazing hot inside Phainon's mouth as he explores more, needing to reach every crevice possible as he seeks out more of the lingering sugary taste. Phainon shudders, whining high and pitchy as Mydei devours him, shuffling his body closer as Mydei licks into his mouth, slotting his fingers in between his to press his palm harder against his jaw.

Mydei loses track of time, losing himself in the taste and feel of Phainon's mouth, the plushness of his lips pressing and pushing against his. He swallows it all down, wanting more and more, his fingers itching to push Phainon back into the sand and straddle him then and there, cupping his cheeks with both hands that are covered in sand, not bothering to dust them off as all he wants is *more*.

The sugary sweet taste in Phainon's mouth begins to dim slightly, and Mydei chases it even harder, but it leads onto something more acidic, something more unpleasant.

The taste of alcohol.

Mydei freezes instantly, and Phainon makes a curious noise in his throat and nips at him to try and get Mydei to carry on. He can't though, because Phainon is *drunk*—he's kissing him after he'd practically drowned himself in shots and cocktails, so much so that he couldn't even walk in a straight line twenty minutes ago. And no amount of cool, brisk ocean breeze can fix that.

They both pull back at the same time, lips spit-slick and swollen, their chests heaving as they look at each other. Mydei can see the realisation dawning on them both, and he can feel it in the way his hand starts trembling against Phainon's jaw where it's still cupping him gently. Phainon's expression—always so open, so beautiful—shuts down and his grip around him loosens until it falls away, and Mydei lets go along with him. Phainon still looks so lovely under the pale light despite everything, eyes blown wide and lips sore and parted. The intensity of Mydei's eyes on him as he takes him in makes him look away first, his face flushed and embarrassed.

"Sorry," Phainon says, his voice muffled from where he's now covering his face with both hands. "I think I'm more drunk than I originally thought."

"Yes," Mydei says, past the stinging in his eyes and the weight of guilt consuming him as reality sets in. "Me too." He lies. Because he's not drunk—not even in the slightest—but it's easier than admitting to the younger teacher that he kissed him completely sober.

Phainon nods into his hands and Mydei lets him have a minute to himself. He looks out at the ocean again, the tide still coming and going, and Mydei realises that the world didn't stop for them when they were kissing, even though he felt as though it had.

After a few minutes, Phainon pulls his hands away from his face, turning towards Mydei again. The air feels cold again, icy and breezy as it bustles by, rustling their clothes and hair. The atmosphere has turned tentative, unsure and prickly, and Mydei has no idea what he's supposed to do now.

He clears his throat, "You've got a bit of…" He trails off, gesturing to where there's still sand sticking to Phainon's face, grains and wet smudge marks all the way up to his cheekbone.

Mydei wants to reach out and wipe it off himself just to use it as another excuse to hold Phainon in the palm of his hands, but before he can even think twice about it, Phainon's eyes are widening as he dusts it off harshly. Mydei winces from how rubbed raw his skin must feel after that, little scrapes littering across his cheek that makes the lump in his throat feel more like a boulder.

"It's getting late. We should probably head back now," Mydei says, forcing himself to talk when neither of them make a move to do so. He offers Phainon a small smile, but it falls completely flat between them.

"Yeah, sure," Phainon says, his voice frustratingly neutral.

Mydei stands up numbly, brushing the sand off the back of his legs as he watches Phainon do the same. His jacket and white trousers are completely ruined, tinged ochre and damp from the sand and still covered in grains even after he brushes it off the best he can. Mydei doesn't say anything though, doesn't dare to, as they make their way back up the hill, the entire walk completely silent.

His brain is blank, completely silent even as he tries to conjure up something—anything—to think of. Not even the thought of kissing Phainon crops up, only focusing hard enough to put one foot in front of the other until they're back at the car park, standing next to Mydei's car.

"I had a nice time," Phainon says, bravely breaching the silence. Mydei nods in agreement, feeling as though all the strings in him have been cut.

Phainon rocks back on his feet, shoving his hands into his jacket pockets. He looks nervous, antsy in a way that Mydei has never seen him before.

"Let me know when you get home?" Phainon asks.

Mydei nods again and he's sure he can feel his brain rattling around inside his head from the movement.

"And I'll see you on Monday?"

Another nod.

Phainon looks distraught, and Mydei hates himself knowing he can't make it better. "Mydei, I…"

"I'll see you on Monday," Mydei cuts him off, not wanting to hear whatever Phainon has to say, especially if it's about the kiss. If anything though, his reply makes Phainon look even more crushed.

He doesn't want to hear Phainon say what a mistake kissing him was, how inappropriate it'd been to do something like that with his co-worker, or even worse—to hear Phainon *apologise* despite it being Mydei's fault that it happened in the first place. But Mydei can't stop thinking about it now, how Phainon kissed back, how he wanted more, too. Yet he was *drunk*, and if Mydei has to hear Phainon say that it was a one-off drunken mistake, he doesn't know what he'll do.

Phainon pulls his hands out of his pockets, balling them into fists so tightly that his knuckles turn white. He blinks a few times before he squeezes his eyes shut, letting out a long breath. The muscles in Phainon's jaw are jumping with how hard he's clenching down on his teeth, and all Mydei is reminded of is how that felt beneath his palm, feeling the way Phainon's jaw worked as they kissed.

Mydei waits, confused and subdued, and when Phainon opens his eyes again, they look like the colour of steel.

"Get home safe, Mydei," Phainon says, voice trembling as he leans forward to press a soft kiss to Mydei's cheek. Mydei's eyes almost fall out of his head as he stares at Phainon in silence. He's turning steadily redder and redder with the attention, until he looks like a tomato with white hair on top.

Mydei opens his mouth to ask him what that was for, but Phainon's whole body tenses up and he *runs*.

"Phainon!" Mydei yells, snapping out of his daze. He tries to reach for Phainon, but he's already sped off half way up the street within a blink of an eye.

Mydei shakily reaches a hand up to press his fingertips onto the spot where Phainon had kissed him, and he doesn't know what to think anymore.

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**Phainon [10:03 pm]**

home now

**Mydei [10:15 pm]**

I just got home too.

**Phainon [10:16 pm]**

night

**Mydei [10:16 pm]**

Good night ❤

Chapter End Notes

hehe..... whoops..... hope no one thought it'd be plain sailing for these two 😙 now is when that 'angst' tag kicks innnn!!!

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leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

let's be friends on twitter/x! (i'm back on there now! tentatively trying to get back into fandom bc i missed it so much lol)

# Chapter 7: chapter seven

Chapter Summary

> Mydei kissed Phainon.
>
> Phainon kissed him back.
>
> Mydei's hand suddenly shoots up to his lips, touching them lightly as if that'll explain anything that occurred last night; yet it doesn't help in the slightest. He remembers them talking endlessly over drinks, sipping at things sweet and tasty, and then Phainon suggesting they sit on the beach. The rest… Well, that's the bit Mydei can't get over.

Chapter Notes

> this is more of a transitional chapter in preparation of the finale!!!
>
> enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mydei wakes up on Sunday morning feeling like he has the worst hangover known to man—all despite not even being drunk the night before. There's a lingering queasiness in his stomach, and his head feels full of cotton. He hopes Phainon is faring better than him, considering how many empty glasses belonged to him alone, and—

Mydei kissed Phainon.

Phainon kissed him back.

Mydei's hand suddenly shoots up to his lips, touching them lightly as if that'll explain anything that occurred last night; yet it doesn't help in the slightest. He remembers them talking endlessly over drinks, sipping at things sweet and tasty, and then Phainon suggesting they sit on the beach. The rest… Well, that's the bit Mydei can't get over. The whole night replays on a constant loop inside Mydei's head, never stopping or slowing down for his heart to catch up to. It's pounding away in his chest uselessly as though he's still kissing Phainon and not just remembering it.

He's not sure how long he stays like that—fingertips touching his lips, his mind running at a thousand miles per hour—but he's shaken out of it when his phone on the nightstand starts buzzing. Mydei glances over at it, the vibrating finally stopping after a slew of messages coming through, so he braves unplugging it from the charger to see who's texting him so early.

**Phainon [08:09 am]**

i have something to show you

haha

[Image Attached]

mydei junior's first shopping trip

Mydei forgets his earlier panic and ruminating, and blinks at the tennis ball sitting in Phainon's shopping basket, its big eyes and red face tattoo staring up at him menacingly.

**Phainon [08:11 am]**

[Image Attached]

you better stock up on custard creams, they're his fave

Mydei taps on the photo to enlarge it, and it's of Mydei Junior placed precariously on a shelf, hidden amongst a large variety of biscuits. Phainon clearly has him turned towards the custard creams in particular though.

**Phainon [08:14 am]**

oh no

[Image Attached]

he likes pomegranate juice too

Mydei can't hold back his laugh anymore, but the sound comes out croaky from how dry his throat is. Mydei Junior is nestled up against a carton of pomegranate juice in the large fridge, and Mydei doesn't even know how to react or what facial expression he has on right now, but the ridiculousness of everything makes him feel hysterical as he begins to type out his response.

**Mydei [08:16 am]**

Like father, like son.

Wait, I have to stock up on his favourite food now? I thought I wasn't allowed to see him.

**Phainon [08:16 am]**

morning!!! :-D

also i changed my mind, we can have shared custody now

**Mydei [08:17 am]**

Good morning. :)

I can't wait to meet my son for the first time. Will he even recognise me?

**Phainon [08:17 am]**

lol dw he knows who his daddy is

Mydei goes slightly red at the wording. He wonders if Phainon is doing all this to smooth things over after last night, to put a line in the sand (although the mere thought of sand makes Mydei's stomach flip), and forget about it. He's not opposed to it, per se, as it's better than them not speaking at all.

**Mydei [08:19 am]**

Then what does he call you? We can't both be daddy.

**Phainon [08:19 am]**

he calls me qt

Mydei furrows his eyebrows at that one. He mouths the letters a few times to see if he can make sense of them, but it's not until he says it aloud that he realises what it must mean.

**Mydei [08:21 am]**

Cutie?

**Phainon [08:21 am]**

aw thanks ;-)

Mydei sighs, looking at his wall with a deadpan expression, but he's not angry. He's trying to keep a smile off his face. He glances back at his phone to type again.

**Mydei [08:22 am]**

Phainon. Seriously?

**Phainon [08:23 am]**

hahahaha got youuuu hahaha

did you say it out loud as well??? hahahaha

**Mydei [08:24 am]**

It's too early for this.

**Phainon [08:24 am]**

noooo don't be madddd hahaha

and it's way past your usual get up time!!

Mydei frowns, eyebrows furrowing.

**Mydei [08:25 am]**

I didn't sleep very well last night.

**Phainon [08:26 am]**

oh sorry

Despite the words in text form, he can practically hear Phainon's cautious tone—he slips into it sometimes when he teases too hard and he's not sure if Mydei is actually mad at him or not. Usually, he's never mad, although it's always good to keep the younger teacher on his toes after being victim to an onslaught of nonsense. Mydei realises how his message has perhaps come across; like what happened last night caused him not to sleep well. And while it did, it isn't Phainon's duty to feel bad about it. It was *his* fuck up, and Phainon has clearly forgiven him for whatever reason considering the

way they're chatting via text as if nothing happened. He doesn't want to ruin this now while he can still have Phainon in his life—romantically or not.

**Mydei [08:27 am]**

Maybe nights out aren't my forte anymore. :)

**Phainon [08:27 am]**

guess i wont be taking you bar hopping with me in the town centre then

Mydei's eyes widen and he panics, typing quickly:

**Mydei [08:28 am]**

No i still wanna go

**Phainon [08:28 am]**

omg

who are you

WANNA? LOWERCASE I?

NO FULL STOP?

**Mydei [08:29 am]**

>:(

**Phainon [08:29 am]**

new emoji unlocked too wow

i'm almost honoured lol

ok, so no bar hopping on our next date

*Phainon has unsent a message*.

Mydei could've sworn he caught the word *date*, but the message is gone before he can blink. His phone chimes again, signalling another text message.

**Phainon [08:31 am]**

ok, so no pub crawls when we next meet. got it

He huffs a laugh.

**Mydei [08:31 am]**

Not if I want to be functioning for Monday morning.

**Phainon [08:32 am]**

what about a tea party instead?

**Mydei [08:33 am]**

Now we're talking. I'll take you to my favourite afternoon tea place, I think you'd enjoy the cakes there like I do.

If you'd like to go with me, that is.

**Phainon [08:34 am]**

YES of course i wanna go with you!!!

Mydei smiles, something small and warm curling around his ribs, invading his heart as he reads that message. He can feel Phainon's youthful enthusiasm through the screen.

**Mydei [08:35 am]**

Make sure to bring Mydei Junior with you then.

**Phainon [08:36 am]**

pretty sure you've got that one covered ;-)

haha but seriously i will, it'll be the long awaited family reunion :'-(

**Mydei [08:36 am]**

Very funny.

**Phainon [08:38 am]**

you know it!

i need to go sort my shopping out now so ttyl

Mydei has to look up 'ttyl' on the internet.

**Mydei [08:40 am]**

TTYL.

Phainon reacts to the message with a blue heart, his signature.

Mydei sits with himself for a few moments—his heart racing from that quick glimpse of the word *date* before it was removed. At this point, he's convinced his brain is looking for anything to cling onto to give himself hope that there could be more between him and Phainon. *Wishful thinking*, he assumes, and locks his phone and hides it under his pillow. He spent the whole night tossing and turning—either the covers felt too hot and suffocating around him, or he was shivering with the cold and felt too exposed. He couldn't win at all. No matter what he did, how he lay, he was restless and uncomfortable and his brain wouldn't settle along with him.

Mydei flops back down onto his bed, shoving his face into his pillows as he tries to get the taste and feeling of Phainon's lips out of his head. He'd tasted so *sweet*, so addicting, and despite knowing it was from the alcohol he's consumed, a bad part of him doesn't care and would be happy to keep tasting that forever if it meant kissing Phainon again. The *noises* he'd made too as Mydei kissed him, the way he gripped his hand like a lifeline, as though he didn't want to ever let go. The way he opened up so easily for him, letting him lick straight into his mouth without any preamble—it all still feels so unreal that he can't process it.

The normality of their text exchange has settled the majority of his worry for now, but the clear avoidance of anything from last night being mentioned is as relieving as it is anxiety inducing. As much as the kiss itself won't leave his mind, the part where Phainon hid away and apologised stands out an equal amount. And what did the cheek kiss right before their parting mean as well? Mydei shakes his head, his grumbling muffled by the pillows he's still buried in despite the lack of oxygen making its way to his lungs. He eventually pulls back, lifting his head just enough to rest his arms underneath his chin, and he finds himself falling back asleep just like that.

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Mydei is rudely awoken from his sleep by the sound of his name being screamed through his apartment and the sound of someone banging incessantly against his front door. He groans, rolling over on his bed to stare up at the ceiling. He grimaces, wiping the drool from his chin that must've leaked out at his odd sleeping position. Mydei sits up, scrubbing a hand through his messy hair as he slowly comes back to reality after his dream—he can't quite remember it now, but he knows Phainon was there in it. He wishes he could recall it, as he wants to see Phainon again already, and

having him vividly portrayed in a dream is the next best thing to seeing him in person.

"Mydeimos!" A voice shouts from his front door, and the following banging scares him out of his thoughts. He sighs, burying his face into his hands in the hopes of suffocating himself. More banging and shouting commences. "We know you're in there!"

He tries to ignore the loud noises for a bit longer, hoping if he stays hidden away and quiet enough that it'll stop, but then the banging only gets louder and more frantic. He's blessed by being the only one on this level, but he's sure that his downstairs neighbours will be able to hear all of this going on at this point.

Mydei finally cracks when he hears a particularly loud shout coming from outside his door. "Stop it!" He yells, flinging the covers off of him before grabbing his glasses. He shoves them on his face and clambers out of bed, rushing towards his front door to rip it open almost off its hinges.

Cipher's hand is held half up, ready to knock again. "Oh wow," She begins, hand dropping. "You look like shit."

"Thanks," Mydei deadpans, but is thankful when Castorice smacks Cipher on the arm for the comment.

"Gonna let us in?" Cipher asks, although the question is redundant as she's already pushing past Mydei before he can answer.

Castorice pats him on the shoulder and offers him a supportive smile as she joins Cipher, albeit sliding past Mydei with a bit more finesse. Mydei sighs and closes the door behind him, listening out for the automatic clicking sound of the lock. He joins the other two, Castorice already situated at a seat around his dining table while Cipher helps herself to food in his kitchen.

"I regret giving you both permission to be let up now without prior knowledge," Mydei says, surveying the mess that Cipher is making of his kitchen. "What are you two even doing here?"

"You think we'd leave you alone after you went on a *date*?" Cipher scoffs, her mouth full of a croissant that she's stolen from the pastry basket on the counter as she sits back down with them.

"It wasn't a—"

"I don't want to hear you say that phrase again! Did Phainon secretly turn out to be a mass murderer or something? Why else would you look like this…" Cipher trails off and gestures to Mydei as a whole, clearly concerned even through her jabs.

"No, nothing like that," Mydei replies, rubbing his palm over his forehead as he weighs out his options. He could tell them everything that happened, play by play, and then make it end after they left the bar and as if they went their separate ways then. It'd still be technically true, after all, and they're not entitled to *all* of his personal business. Or he can tell them the full truth,

that he'd kissed Phainon while he was horrifically drunk and now he doesn't know what they're doing anymore.

Cipher squints at him, her fangs poking out. "Did you two fuck or something? What is it?"

Mydei shoves at her shoulder in a childish outburst. "No!"

"Oh, Mydeimos, you're blushing," Castorice says softly, pinching a bit of Cipher's—no, *his*—croissant to pop into her mouth.

"Stop eating my food!" Mydei grouses because he *is* blushing and he can feel how warm his face is at the thought of them sleeping together.

"So, not a date, and there was no fucking… What the hell did you two do then?"

"We had drinks and talked," Mydei replies plainly.

"Okay…? And…?" Cipher says, dragging each word out.

"And it was nice," Mydei replies through gritted teeth.

"You're being rather obtuse, Mydeimos," Castorice says lightly.

"You mean this is like getting blood out of a stone," Cipher says, rolling her eyes as she finishes the last half of the pastry in one bite. Mydei cringes at how many crumbs go flying when she speaks: "Did you get bored of him or something?"

"Of course not! No, never, I—" Mydei cuts himself off before he can get too carried away. Even the mere *idea* of getting bored of Phainon sends him into a tailspin, how would that be possible?

Both Castorice and Cipher are staring at him now, mouths slightly agape. "Oh wow, you're in deep," Cipher comments.

Mydei slouches slightly, his shoulders caving inwards as the weight of last night finally catches up to him. He sighs deeply, staring at the whorls of wood patterning on his dining table. "We… kissed," Mydei admits, trying to keep his words stable.

"What?!" They both yell at the same time, wide eyed and in shock.

"Not a date, he said!" Cipher throws her hands up in the air. "Did you also enjoy a nice long walk across the beach too?!"

"Gods, no! Let me finish!" Mydei clenches his jaw, a queasy feeling filling his stomach. "Phainon was really drunk and I *still* kissed him."

The kitchen is quiet again, but Castorice reaches a hand out to place over Mydei's knee and gives it a gentle squeeze. Mydei offers her a small smile in response. "Did he react badly?" She asks.

"He kissed me back," Mydei replies, hanging his head in shame, his long hair coming down in waves beside his eyes so he can't see either of his friends.

"Honestly then, not seeing the problem here," Cipher comments. "Has he said anything to you about it since?"

Mydei sighs, lifting his head. "Not yet. We were texting earlier though."

"Mydeimos," Castorice begins, managing to come across calm while also extremely tired at the same time. "Why don't you just talk to him about it?"

"Because!" Mydei begins, frustrated that they're not getting it. He can't form all his thoughts into words as they get stuck in his brain, muddling themselves up.

"He's not gonna scream in your face if you bring it up," Cipher says, leaning over to grab a red apple from the fruit basket in the middle of the

table. "He's a good guy, Mydeimos. Good for *you*."

"He is," Castorice agrees.

"But you're too scared to do anything about it now that it's getting serious," Cipher shrugs off the glare Mydei shoots her for that, instead chewing obnoxiously loud on the apple. "I'm just saying, yeah?"

"*Cipher*—" Castorice warns, but she's cut off.

"He is, Cas! He's finally made a move after all this time, but he's too worried about things that don't matter. You're too chickenshit to do anything actually meaningful."

"Alright, that's enough," Castorice holds her hands out, "We didn't come here to berate him, did we?" She finishes, speaking as though she's handling an unruly child. Cipher huffs and doesn't make any further comments.

Castorice turns to Mydei, her hands worrying themselves until her fingers are all linked together in knots, as though she wants to say something but is holding herself back.

"Just say it," Mydei says, exhausted and already expecting the worst. Being told off by his closest friends about his fuck-up isn't exactly how he wanted

to spend his Sunday morning—but the alternative was stewing more on the kiss that shouldn't have happened, no matter how much he wanted it to.

"It's just… We haven't seen you this happy in a long time, okay? We want what's best for you *and* Phainon. He's our friend too," Castorice says, and Cipher nods her head in agreement, still staying silent. "When you're around him, you just… Light up, like everyone else in the room disappears as soon as you see him."

"It's really obvious too, by the way. You're terrible at hiding it," Cipher finally speaks up, giving Mydei a teasing grin.

"We're only trying to help," Castorice finishes, looking at Mydei imploringly.

Even though Castorice's little speech sounded like something from her novels, he can't help but feel *supported* and *cornered* at the same time. He looks between them, lost. "I don't know what I'm supposed to do."

"What would you *like* to do?" Castorice encourages.

"But keep it family friendly! We can't be hurting little Cassie's ears so early in the morning!" Cipher cackles.

"You're the one asking me earlier if we'd fucked yet!" Mydei glares at both of them when they burst into laughter. He sits back in his chair, sighing loudly enough to cut them off. "I don't know. After we kissed last night, he said he was *sorry* and said that he was drunker than he thought. Sounds to me that if he was sober, he wouldn't ever have done it."

Even Castorice grimaces slightly at that.

"Yeah, ouch. I still think you're being a coward though," Cipher replies, finally continuing to eat her apple.

"What did I say to you earlier?" Castorice says, a frigid smile appearing on her face as she looks at her girlfriend.

Cipher groans, her expression flattening out to repeat the words robotically as though she's reading off a script: "We're your best friends. We will love and support you either way, no matter how stupid you're being right now. We may not agree on everything or make the same choices, but that's okay too."

"I never told you to say the *stupid* bit," Castorice sniffs.

"I added that bit of my own volition," Cipher grins, blowing Castorice a kiss across the table. Because everything and everyone seems to be mocking him right now, Castorice pretends to catch it and presses it against her cheek, blushing sweetly at the action.

"Thanks, you two. Really feeling the love here," Mydei says flatly and stands up from his seat to go put the kettle on. "I think the ball's in his court now, and it's up to him if he wants to talk about it."

They're quiet for a few minutes as Mydei prepares them all drinks. Tea for him and Castorice, and a strong coffee for Cipher. He waits until the kettle has finished boiling before he speaks: "If he's happy to forget it and move on, then I'll just have to do the same." He shrugs.

"But you need to promise me if Phainon *does* want to talk about it though, you hear him out— no matter *what* he has to say," Castorice says.

Mydei pours the hot water into three mugs, watching the colour change as it hits the tea bags and coffee grounds. He knows that with him leaving it to Phainon to talk about first, he may never get an answer, but it's the best way to avoid any confrontation. He can hope that Phainon never mentions it again, they both carry on as if they never kissed in the first place, but then there's no closure for him, and Mydei is left to pine away for the rest of his life. Yet, with the possibility of Phainon bringing it up and telling him it was a mistake, or that he wasn't *like that*, or that it was all just down to him being drunk and carried away in the moment, Mydei will just have to make that sacrifice of never truly knowing in favour of saving his own feelings and heart. Call him selfish, or *stupid*, as Cipher put it, but as he's gotten older, he's gotten more serious about protecting himself and his peace. The idea of Phainon upsetting that more than he already has—but in a good way, mostly—makes him more nervous than it should. Where did that courage go that he was famous for?

"Sure," He finally replies, feeling distant as he hands them their drinks, ignoring the pitying look that Castorice gives him that makes it clear she knows what he's thinking.

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Monday morning arrives eventually, despite how much Mydei hoped it wouldn't. Phainon hasn't texted him since Cipher and Castorice came over, and Mydei didn't reach out either, even though he wishes he did. He isn't sure how this will go now—texting is different to face to face, and he's nervous to see Phainon again. Mydei knows that he sounded normal over their messages, but what if that doesn't extend to in person? What if Phainon has changed his mind—that he thought about it more and he doesn't actually want to forgive and forget what happened between them? Mydei feels even worse than he did before their 'not-date', and it's starting to eat him alive.

Because he likes what they have now. Where Phainon grins when he sees him as he runs over and reties his scarf first thing in the morning even though he doesn't have to. He likes it when Phainon meets him in the staffroom and they chat while he makes them drinks. He likes the way Phainon laughs at his deadpan jokes, meets him halfway every time and teases him like no one has ever dared to before. He'd gotten so caught up in his feelings before he left for work he didn't trust himself to put his scarf on, so it's still hanging up on the peg by his door. It was only given a forlorn glance as Mydei left. He wants to, despite everything, still have hope that if he did wear it, that Phainon would see and things would be back to normal. But where would that leave him if that didn't happen? There's too many what-ifs, and buts, and contradicting thoughts to really make sense of it all.

A heaviness fills his heart, weighing him down as he reluctantly gets out of his car. He glances around the carpark, spotting Phainon's motorbike across the way, but no sign of the owner anywhere. Mydei heaves a sigh, leaning his hip against the car door to shield his face under the guise of pushing his glasses back up with his thumb and ring finger. He lets himself have a moment to himself as the message is crystal clear, that Phainon is here and yet he isn't, and it stings more than he thought it would. He checks his phone quickly to see if there's anything from Phainon there, but there's no texts signalling any delays or reasoning.

Mydei sets off towards reception even though he wants nothing more than to get back into his car, drive home and crawl back into bed and call in sick—except that in all his years of teaching, he's never done that—even when everything had seemingly been falling apart around him when his mother passed, even when things were at their worst with his father, and he felt he had no one left around him for support, he still soldiered on despite it all.

"Mydei!" A voice comes from behind him, making his blood freeze as he stops dead in his tracks. He hesitates to turn around, and he's so close to the entrance he can see his reflection looking back at him in the glass doors, showing him just how caught between hopeful and trepidation he looks.

He hears Phainon's feet slap against the concrete as he runs up behind him. "Where are you going?" He asks, making Mydei finally turn around.

Mydei isn't entirely sure what he was expecting when he first saw Phainon after Saturday. He pictured the world crumbling around him, shattering into a million tiny pieces that will never be able to be formed back together again—but instead, he's rendered breathless at how *beautiful* Phainon is. His windswept hair, his wide eyes and parted lips, and his cheeks flushed

unevenly from the cold air—yet he's still only wearing those tiny shorts of his and an unzipped hoodie. He looks the same as he always does, and the familiarity of it all comforts Mydei in a way he wasn't expecting to happen when he knows how Phainon's lips feel on his.

He feels relief hit him first, and then everything he'd felt on the beach before their kiss comes flooding back; all those deep, impenetrable feelings, so much so that it makes him feel like he's drowning. Mydei almost chokes on his words: "I thought you'd already gone inside."

"No! Not without you," Phainon says, far too earnestly. "I saw the neighbourhood cat and wanted to pet her, so I got distracted…" He laughs, rubbing the back of his neck.

Mydei's heart stutters in his chest with endearment. Everything feels like it's been doubled inside of him that he almost feels it spilling out as he speaks, his words far too fond. "Did you manage to catch her before she ran off?"

"Sure did!" Phainon replies, his face brightening, and it makes Mydei's heart soar. But then Phainon's expression completely falls. "You're not wearing your scarf today?"

Mydei glances down at his bare neck, his hand coming up to touch the spot in between his collarbones as though he's only just noticed it himself rather than it being a conscious decision. Phainon stares at the exposed skin where his scarf should be, and then looks away to the ground.

Suddenly, everything is stifling between them. Mydei halfheartedly chuckles, the sound forced even to him. "It was supposed to warm up today, so I thought I'd chance it," Everything feels like it's coming out all wrong. "I clearly made the wrong choice though."

Phainon nods sullenly, and still won't look at him. Mydei misses those blue eyes focused on him, and he wants to reach out and delicately cup Phainon's chin and guide his face to look back up at him, even if just for a moment.

"I'll make sure to wear it tomorrow," Mydei says, and he's glad that finally —*finally*—Phainon meets his gaze again with his assurance.

"You better," Phainon points at Mydei threateningly. He still looks a little downtrodden, his eyebrows pinched and the corner of his lips down-turned slightly, but at least he's looking at Mydei again.

Mydei rolls his eyes. "Never mind that, did you hear about the performance reviews today?"

Phainon goes stock-still. Mydei should've known better than to ask such a question.

"You have your school email set up, how have you not seen the notice yet?"

"I know!" Phainon says too quickly. "I just… Don't check it very often. Or at all."

Mydei sighs, "Make sure you read your emails as soon as you get in. I don't know what time or where yours is, but I don't want you to miss it. They're the end-of-year department based reviews."

"Already?" Phainon frowns. "I can't believe how quickly the time has gone since I moved here."

Mydei huffs a laugh and reaches up to tug at Phainon's earlobe to distract him. "Stop worrying or you'll get stuck like that and get wrinkles."

"What, like you?" Phainon jokes, frowning even harder in a clear attempt to imitate Mydei's serious face. Mydei is glad he's got thick skin against Phainon's jabs and he lets them roll straight off him.

Phainon bursts into laughter seeing his unimpressed face and tickles under his chin patronisingly. Mydei glares at him and tugs even harder at his lobe out of spite, which only results in Phainon taking his chin in between his thumb and forefinger so he can use the grip to shake Mydei's head from side to side.

"Don't sulk!" Phainon cajoles.

"I wasn't— Stop it! I'm not sulking!" Mydei releases Phainon's earlobe to swat at him instead, but Phainon is laughing in the way that makes it so he can barely hold up his own body from how breathless and giddy he is, his shoulders sagging forward.

Phainon finally lets go of his chin after making him feel extremely dizzy with all the shaking and falls into him instead, resting his forehead on Mydei's shoulder to try and hide his snorts and giggles.

"You're so *annoying*," Mydei groans but doesn't make any move to push Phainon off of him as he begins laughing too, both their frames shaking with it.

Phainon scoffs and pulls back, his eyes glassy and bright. "You're annoying too!" He says, rubbing a fist over his eyes to try and wipe away the tears, but he ends up wincing instead.

"Did you hurt yourself?" Mydei asks, his smile immediately wiped from his face. Phainon shakes his head and keeps rubbing his eye.

"No, I got an eyelash in it," He says.

"Come here," Mydei bats his hand away because all the rubbing isn't going to do it any good. He cups Phainon's face, pulling him in closer so he can get a better look. He tilts Phainon's head back to see if he can spot it, using his thumb to gently pull down his lower lid. He stands on his tip toes to peer

down to try and get a better view, turning and guiding Phainon's face in all different directions so he can check everywhere.

"I don't see anything," Mydei surmises after a few moments of looking, still intently trying to find what's causing the discomfort. His eye looks okay though, not even a little red after all the rubbing, but it's watering more than it should considering he can't see anything poking it.

Phainon's cheeks feel very warm under his palms, and when Mydei pulls back to see his whole face, he's staring at him in shock. Mydei can't help but notice how cute he looks, his cheeks all squished up in between Mydei's hands, enough to make his lips pucker slightly from the pressure.

"I think it's gone now," Phainon croaks out.

"Yeah," Mydei replies vaguely, staring down at his pouting lips.

Their faces are so close they're practically nose to nose, their breaths mingling from the proximity. Phainon's breath smells vaguely minty, probably from brushing his teeth earlier on, and Mydei swallows down the pooling saliva in his mouth at the thought of tasting it straight from his lips. Phainon's bottom lip *trembles*, and he presses them together before relaxing again, enough that Mydei can see his teeth and a flash of tongue. He feels that magnetic pull again, the one that begs him to come closer, to lean in and kiss Phainon stupid.

"Mr Krem— Oh, *oh*! I'm so sorry!" A young voice comes from behind them.

Mydei yanks himself away as fast as lightning, and takes a few steps away from Phainon so he can breathe again. He whirls around, almost losing his footing as he does it so quickly. His brain is completely frazzled from how close he was to kissing Phainon again right then and there.

"Alexandra? What's wrong?" Mydei asks, trying to clear his throat as his words come out pitchy and breathless.

"I…" She stares at them wide eyed, looking between Mydei and Phainon who's standing behind him. "I… um… Had a question about the test next week?"

"Of course," Mydei says. He turns back to Phainon, who doesn't seem to be faring any better than himself going by how red his face is, his mouth opening and closing like a goldfish. He can't even meet his eyes, staring off to the side. "I better go sort this out. I'll see you later Phai— *Mr Khaslana*."

Phainon nods at him, but they're practically both looking in different directions as they speak. "Lunch. I'll be there— uh, in the room. The staffroom," Phainon babbles, and Mydei is barely even processing his words as he agrees and hightails it out of there, into the building with Alexandra in tow.

Mydei doesn't have as much of a packed schedule anymore this close to exams, what with the students now being allowed free reign to either self-study or still attend whichever classes they wanted to. He's not surprised when none of his students show up to his early morning lesson, but he isn't too put out since it means he can clean up the room and create more revision worksheets for those who need or want them.

He digs around the filing cabinet to see if he can find the ones from last year to use as a basis, but no luck. He knows he left them in here though, which means he'd probably shoved them in between another folder in a rush and never bothered to organise it properly afterwards. Mydei checks his wristwatch and sees that he's still got forty-five minutes before his department meeting, so he grabs a bunch of the files in the cabinet and puts them on the nearest desk to flick through.

Mydei does this until his neck starts to ache and his fingers begin to get sore from all the page turning. He's also somehow managed to nick himself a few times while leafing through things, which just sours his mood even more. He sticks his finger in his mouth to soothe the pain slightly, but instead he tastes iron which causes him to cringe in disgust. Mydei sighs in frustration, collecting all the checked files and documents and shoves them back into the filing cabinet. He's not even sure why he's kept some of that stuff—a few pages date back almost ten years. He'll definitely sort that out later, when he's not on the brink of a headache.

As soon as he closes the drawer, listening to the aged wheels squeaking as he slams it shut, he remembers that this whole time he kept a PDF version of the sheets on his laptop for easier printing. Mydei's wasted almost half an hour at this point, and needs to breathe in and out deeply to keep the spike of frustration at bay. He storms over to his laptop, opening it forcibly until

he's able to type in his password, where he finally sits down heavily in his desk chair.

Immediately, Mydei spots in the corner a notification—an email. He brings up his inbox and looks at it quizzically, confused. It's a meeting request for the review, which is strange because he already accepted it the other week. He opens it, and the red line crossed throughout the date and time stands out against the white background as he quickly realises that this is a rescheduling offer. He follows the line until he spots the new date and time in italics, and his blood runs cold when he sees that it's now being held in the East Block hall, and started almost *five minutes ago*.

"Shit, shit!" Mydei yells, slamming his laptop lid shut with one hand as he uses the other to yank his suit jacket off the back of his chair with the other. He leaves as quickly as he can, not even caring that he's left his satchel behind with his notebook and pens in it. If all else fails, he'll pinch a pen and a sheet of paper off of someone else.

He reaches the East Block in under two minutes, but he ran so fast that he has shooting pains going up his shins, and he's sweating slightly around his hairline and upper lip. Mydei doesn't stop until he can see the hall doors, and then he slows down to a brisk walk. He rubs a fist across his mouth to get rid of the perspiration and runs a hand through his messy hair, soothing over his braid to make sure that it's still in place.

"Gods," He pants, coming to a complete stop just before the hall windows so no one can see him. He takes in heaving breaths, adrenaline getting him more than the exercise, and straightens out his jacket quickly.

"Oh no!" Phainon's voice rings out, even all the way from down the corridor. Mydei's head shoots up as he watches Phainon come hurtling out of the P.E office, his hoodie slung over one shoulder as he tries to shove his arm through the other arm hole. He sprints towards the hall, but when he spots Mydei he skids to a stop, arms windmilling comically so he doesn't fall face first into the floor.

"Mydei?!"

"Phainon?"

They stand opposite each other on either side of the hall windows, staring unblinkingly in confusion at the other's presence.

"What the hells are you doing here?" Phainon asks, assumingly not daring to take a step forward in case he comes into view of the other teachers already in there.

"I didn't realise my review had changed time and place," Mydei says through gritted teeth, finally having caught his breath enough to talk properly.

"It's here? Right now?" Phainon questions, pointing between Mydei and the hall. "Mine's supposed to be here now too."

Mydei squints at him suspiciously, "Are you late?"

Phainon sucks his bottom lip into his mouth and looks *extremely* innocent, eyes widening into a pleading glance.

"How are *you* late and it's in your own block?!" Mydei whisper-shouts, taking a step towards Phainon while ducking down to make sure he's still out of view.

"I got distracted and Cipher didn't warn me! Why are *you* late?!" Phainon shouts back, huffing.

"They changed the time without me knowing, I only received the email about it!" Mydei replies.

"I thought I heard two pests outside," Cipher drawls from the doorway. Mydei isn't sure when she appeared, but she doesn't look impressed, eyes narrowed and fangs sticking out over her bottom lip. "Are you going to come inside, or carry on your lover's spat?"

"Cipher!" They both say at the same time, and Mydei can feel his cheeks heat at the insinuation.

She rolls her eyes at them and holds the door open, "Just get in here already. You're being way too noisy and disturbing everyone."

"It wasn't a lover's spat," Phainon mutters under his breath, glaring at the floor.

Mydei frowns at Phainon's tone—even though the words were quiet, he still sounded upset. Phainon walks over to follow Cipher inside, but he gets caught in the doorway as Mydei tries to go in at the same time.

"Oh, uh, you first," Phainon says, gesturing for Mydei to go in.

"No, it's fine. You go," Mydei replies.

Phainon narrows his eyes at him, "I was just trying to be nice! Go in already!"

"And I said it was fine, you go!"

"Fine," Phainon states.

"*Fine*," Mydei responds.

They both try to go in at the same time again, but the same thing happens but more forcefully—Mydei's shoulder catches on the doorframe and he lets out a quiet exclamation of pain, the skin smarting at the jab.

"Sorry!" Phainon says loudly, taking a step back as Mydei does so they're back outside the door.

"Oh my gods! Open the other side of the damn door if you two can't even be separated for two seconds!" Cipher yells from across the hall from where she's currently sat.

All the teachers from the P.E, Art, History and Lang & Lit departments are turned around in their seats watching them, looking caught between confusion and irritation at the commotion. Mydei spots Castorice in the crowd, and instead of looking either of those things, she looks *delighted*.

Phainon peers around the door and points at the way the other door is bolted shut into the floor. "Oh," He chuckles nervously and stands up straight again. "Mr Kremnos, you can just go in first."

Mydei sighs and feels a twang of pain in his temple, but he doesn't bother arguing now. "Thank you, Mr Khaslana."

Mydei's shoulder aches, and he knows he'll have a bruise form later on. At least they've finally made it into the hall without any more yelling or bashing into each other, which Mydei is very relieved for.

"I didn't know you two got together?" Nikolas from the P.E department asks loudly once they're just about to sit down in the back row together. Every single pair of eyes in the hall turns back towards them, and Phainon looks downright terrified at the sudden attention.

"We're not together," Phainon replies before Mydei can placate everyone's clear curiosity and assure them that that's not the case. But the vitriol in Phainon's voice, something he's never heard before, makes him flinch. Even during the meeting with his father, he didn't seem this… *disgusted*. "We're just friends."

The word 'friends' is spat out, coming out spiteful sounding and degrading, as if he'd rather call Mydei anything *but* that. Phainon doesn't look at him at all as he speaks, but his fists are clenched, knuckles white, and Mydei feels his stomach bottom out.

"Oh, sorry," Nikolas replies tentatively, his face scrunching up as he looks between them. Phainon's face is pinched so tightly that he looks barely recognisable.

"Phainon?" Mydei can't help but say in bewilderment at the sudden change in mood from him. Mydei knows he probably shouldn't be showing so much emotion on his face or in his tone right now considering everyone is watching them like a soap opera, but he's so confused he can't bring himself to uphold any type of image right now.

"Mydeimos," Castorice calls softly when Phainon doesn't answer, and Mydei turns to face her. Castorice looks concerned and waves him over, patting the free seat next to her in offering.

Mydei doesn't move straight away, glancing back to check on Phainon, but he's gone—already walking away to sit down at the opposite end of the line of chairs, the furthest away from Mydei he can possibly get without leaving the damn hall. Mydei feels a lump form in his throat as he looks back at Castorice who's still watching him, and he makes his way over towards her.

Mydei goes through the rest of the meeting feeling like he's been trapped in a nightmare, or something equally as terrible. His mind can't stop replaying Phainon's words—the way he spat them out, the way his face looked as he said them. Mydei doesn't understand; they were doing fine before, weren't they? They had been bickering and laughing together as usual, and Saturday feels long forgotten between them, so why at the first sign of someone insinuating anything more between them, had Phainon lashed out?

It hits him then as he tries to listen to Miss Caenis discussing next month's targets that the kiss they shared between them must really have been a drunken regret from Phainon's point of view. *That's fine*, Mydei tries to tell himself, but as he catches sight of Phainon out of the corner of his eye still looking down, he knows that isn't true.

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The next hour feels like a decade, but as soon as their reviews are finished for each department and the individuals in them, Mydei leaves Castorice behind to rush over to catch Phainon before he leaves.

"Phainon—"

"I promised I'd help Nikolas with something, so I can't stick around," Phainon talks over him, not even bothering to turn around as he speaks.

Mydei swallows. "I was just going to ask if you were… Okay?" He says, each word wavering slightly with uncertainty.

"Yeah, I just need to go," Phainon says, and he can't see his face but his ears are turning pink. The lines of his back are tense even through his polo shirt, his hands clenched into fists once again, and despite him being only an arm's reach away, Mydei feels the width of the ocean between them.

"Oh, right. That's… fine," Mydei says.

Phainon doesn't say anything else and pushes through the hall door, leaving it to slam behind him.

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When the bell rings for lunchtime, he lets the two students who turned up go immediately so he can be left in peace and quiet for a bit. He contemplates going to the staffroom regardless of how Phainon acted earlier during the meeting because he said this morning that he would be there.

After everything, Mydei still wants to see him, hopefully this time in a better mood. Although, right now he's not sure he could walk in there with Cipher and Castorice waiting to swoop in on him at the first chance to check on him—it was obvious to everyone in there that *something* was up between them. Mydei isn't sure he can deal with Phainon waltzing in a few minutes later and pretend that everything is fine—maybe only showing up to force himself to be around Mydei for whatever reason. Is that what's going to happen to them now? Forced proximity or gradual distance?

Mydei would rather not find out. Paperwork it is. Mydei sits down at his desk, his eyes immediately glazing over before he's even started on anything. He groans, covering his face with his palms, still being mindful enough to not let them touch his glasses—he really doesn't want to have to pull out his whole cleaning kit because he's moping. His phone begins buzzing a few minutes later, and he already knows who it is without even having to check.

**Cipher [12:06 pm]**

where are you

mydeimos

OI

REPLY NOW

**Mydeimos [12:07 pm]**

I'm busy.

**Cipher [12:08 pm]**

liar.

get over here already

**Mydeimos [12:08 pm]**

I'm catching up on marking. I'll speak to you later.

Mydei turns his phone off once he sends that text, not caring if he makes Cipher mad for avoiding him. He shoves his phone into the top drawer of his desk, ready to be forgotten about. He knows that it'll only make things worse, but Mydei can't face this situation himself, let alone try and be therapised over it when he's feeling *this* out of sorts.

He feels a fragile sense of calm settle over him now that his phone is out of the way and he's truly alone, and focuses back on the task at hand, reaching for the smallest stack of papers first.

He's made his way through almost half of them when he hears a knock at the door. He swivels around in his chair to face the door, looking through the glass panel to see who it is. He assumes it's a student coming in for some advice, but when he sees who it actually is, his eyes widen.

Phainon catches his gaze and waves, "Mydei!" He exclaims, his voice loud even through the door. The smile on his face is wide and genuine in a way Mydei thought he'd never see directed at him again after what happened during the year review.

Mydei blinks a few times, unable to move and signal Phainon in from the amount of confusion and whiplash he's getting from the other man within the past few hours. He quickly looks at his wristwatch—it's now 12:32 pm, which means he probably went to the staffroom, saw he wasn't there, and immediately came to Mydei's classroom. His heart stutters at that thought, and he wills himself to take a deep breath before he gets up to let Phainon in.

"That's *Mr Kremnos* to you, especially around students," Mydei snips, sniffing haughtily as he opens the door.

"I don't see any students…" Phainon says, looking around conspiratorially. "Don't be a spoil sport, we're all friends here!"

'*Friends*'. That word again. It seems to be haunting him at this point, making a mockery of his feelings and only exists to rub salt into the wound. He ignores the way it makes his heart twinge painfully—how could that word have been so awful to Phainon only a few hours ago, compared to the jovial way he says it now?

Phainon leans in, nudging Mydei with his elbow good naturedly. Mydei allows it because it's better than the twisted expression that Phainon had on his face earlier on. Phainon ignores Mydei's responding scowl and barges his way into the classroom, shouldering Mydei out of the way. The younger teacher looks around, taking his time like he's window shopping and not purposely interrupting Mydei's work.

"Can I help you, Phainon?" Mydei asks, adjusting his glasses.

Phainon glances over his shoulder and grins at him, but goes straight back to snooping around. "I don't get to have my own classroom, so I wanted to see what yours was like," He says.

He wanders further into the room, combing over every inch he can see. Mydei stands up straighter with pride—he knows his classroom looks good; he keeps it clean and organised to a scary degree (minus what's been shoved into his filing cabinets), but the display boards at the back are where his true pride lies. He watches as Phainon catches sight of them, double taking, before he goes up to them for a closer look.

Phainon has a small, soft smile on his face as his eyes rake over the student's work—he's clearly just as charmed as Mydei is towards the crude but colourful mind maps and doodles of Dromases on there. There are far too many post-it notes on there than Mydei had originally wanted when making the display, but they're full of such great thoughts and ideas that he instead had painstakingly pinned each one up onto the boards. There must be at least a hundred he'd gathered across his multiple classes, and his fingers were sore and aching once he'd finished, but the excited looks his students gave him when they first saw it had made it all worth it.

Mydei sighs, giving into Phainon's curiosity about his classroom, and shuts the door behind him as the other makes it very clear he's not leaving anytime soon. He walks up beside him, eyes taking in the sight he's seen a thousand times before.

At this angle, he can't resist taking in how stunning Phainon's side profile is—from the way his nose gently slopes into an upwards curve that reminds him of the way their noses bumped against each other as they kissed, to his plush pink lips that look as soft as they feel against his own, and then to his full cheeks that he knows fit perfectly cupped in between the palms of his hands. Mydei doesn't know what to do with himself when all these thoughts come rushing in—he wants to reach out, maybe entwine their fingers together, or maybe run his fingers through Phainon's hair like he'd done when he'd fixed his helmet hair, or maybe something else entirely new. Maybe he'll press Phainon carefully up against the boards as to not disturb anything and kiss him until their knees turn to jelly.

Phainon suddenly meets his gaze, snapping him out of his useless daydreams, and the smile on his face is still there. Mydei can almost trick himself into believing that he's the cause of that smile—but it's hard to forget the coldness Phainon had showed him earlier on, and the reminder of it turns his stomach into knots as his heart sinks at the same time. He's doing it again: falling into his own mind when the cold, hard facts of what they are has been spelled out multiple times for him—

*Friends*.

The harsh way Phainon had said it echoes in his head.

*Just friends*.

"You said it was your dad who got you into teaching?" Phainon asks quietly, clearly not wanting to break the quiet atmosphere that's settled

around them.

Mydei breaks their gaze and looks up at the display boards, eyes going over the work again and again so as to not be tempted back into staring at Phainon beside him. "Yeah, I didn't have much of a choice."

Mydei can still see Phainon—albeit only out of his peripheral vision as he nods along.

"I resent him for a lot of things, but never this," He reaches up a hand and smooths his fingertip across a sticker of a Dromas that one of the kids had brought in. Its skin is bright purple, and its eyes are googly and comical. It's cute. He shrugs then, faking nonchalance, but this topic always makes his skin crawl—especially when there's no alcohol to dull it. It had taken him too long, literal years of his life, to realise that his father was not the hero he thought him to be, even after his mother died.

"I don't know why he's so obsessed with me taking over the school. I've never managed to figure that one out," Mydei says honestly.

Phainon huffs a laugh, "Your dad's kind of awful anyway."

Mydei side-eyes him, "Pretty sure you're supposed to add 'no offence' somewhere in that sentence."

Phainon tilts his head in feigned innocence, a smirk playing across the corners of his lips. "You didn't say I was wrong though."

"I didn't say you were right, either."

Phainon hums, "Do you think you would've been in a rock band if you weren't a teacher?"

Mydei laughs, the sound shocking even himself. He shifts his weight over to his right leg, making him sway away from Phainon.

"Don't clam up on me now! Cipher told me you used to play electric guitar," Phainon says after Mydei makes it clear he's not going to answer. Not because he doesn't want to, but because he doesn't have an answer. Teaching is all he knows, all he wanted to do, that being in a *rock band* seems preposterous.

"What about you? Would you have stayed on the farm working with your family if you didn't go into teaching?" Mydei asks, turning the question back to Phainon. Phainon scowls at him pettily for being ignored, but the expression disappears soon enough, turning contemplative.

"Yeah, probably," He admits, taking a deep breath. "I love the farm and my family, and I wish I could help them out more. But they told me I was 'wasted' there, and destined for greater things, or whatever." Phainon waves his hand around, as if dismissing his parent's words. "But I found that I

enjoyed running around far too much, and then I got into teaching the local kids how to swim in the lake."

Mydei hums, letting Phainon know he's still listening.

"I just found another passion in life, y'know? It doesn't make me love my parents, or their work, any less. I wanted other things, but they wanted what *I* wanted, and that's how it worked out. I never thought I'd pass in university, let alone make it so far as to land a job here!"

"You should be proud of yourself," Mydei says quietly, realising his voice has gone impossibly gentle. It's so easy to let himself be sucked back into Phainon's orbit when he talks like this, offering up information about his past that Mydei soaks up like a sponge. He wants to know everything that Phainon has to offer—the good, the bad, the ugly—and every detail and thing that's happened to him.

Phainon spins around on the ball of his feet and flops back against the wall next to the boards, the action causing a puff of air to lift the post-it notes up slightly before they float back down flat. He tilts his head back, letting it thunk against the wall.

"I couldn't have done it without my parents and Cyrene, they're my biggest supporters. And also Theron and Dorian—they're actually the ones who told me about the teaching job here."

"That doesn't mean that you didn't do most of it with your own strength," Mydei says, watching as Phainon's bangs get caught between his eyelashes.

"I know," Phainon beams, and Mydei's hands tremble from where they're by his side, the dire need to touch him becoming too much. "But their strength is my strength, yeah?"

He can't stop himself. Phainon is so honest, so *earnest*, so open with him that his hand lifts up, brushing away the soft locks out of his eye to the side. He freezes when he realises what he's done, and Phainon looks shocked from the touch. They watch each other for a few moments until it's too much, and Mydei clears his throat and quickly removes his hand, clenching it into a fist by his side instead.

Phainon blinks a few times, as if coming out of a daze. His cheeks are slightly flushed, he blushes so easily, and Mydei hates that he knows how that'd feel against the skin of his hands. He hates how warm Phainon is, how beautiful he is, how funny and charming he is, he hates it. He can't stand how much he wants him, wants to tell him how much he likes him, how much he cares for him, how much he *needs* him now. He hates, he hates, he *hates*. But he wants, and wants, and *wants*.

"You still haven't answered my question, by the way," Phainon reminds him.

Mydei can't bear to look at him any longer—he's too bright, too stunning, too much, and Mydei feels too exposed indulging in things he shouldn't be doing or thinking about. Never mind that they're co-workers, or the fact that

there's a 13 year age difference between them, and never mind that Phainon definitely regrets their kiss—Phainon has made it clear that they're just friends. No matter what either of them say or do, no matter how many things that makes Mydei wonder if there's anything more, there just *isn't*.

"Class is going to be starting up again soon," Mydei says instead of replying. He adjusts his glasses despite them not having slid down his nose at all, but the gesture soothes him nonetheless.

"Mydei…" Phainon begins, clearly noticing the beginnings of the shift between them. The way he says his name is pleading, but Mydei isn't sure what he's asking for. He doesn't know what Phainon *wants* from him.

Mydei turns away, walking back over to his desk and leaves Phainon on his own. He shuffles a few papers around to keep him from going back and carrying on their conversation, or spilling his guts up with all his thoughts and feelings he's been keeping deep inside his heart.

"Is that all, Mr Khaslana?" He asks, the title feeling like acid on his tongue. He hates it—hates putting up these barriers between them, but he needs to remind himself that this is their situation: teachers at the same school, friends, and certainly nothing more. He can do this—he can treat Phainon like a co-worker, and like a friend when the time calls for it.

He hears Phainon sigh in frustration, and he looks up in time to see the younger teacher scrubbing a frustrated hand through his hair. "Why are you acting this way? If I'd known kissing you would've made us like this, then —"

"Like what?" Mydei snaps, cutting him off.

"Like you don't wanna be around me anymore! You're acting all weird, like… Like whenever you see me, you're in pain."

Mydei feels anger erupt inside of him, and it's so consuming and scorching hot that he raises his voice slightly: "You couldn't even look at me after the mere *suggestion* of us being together, acting as if it was the most revolting thing you'd ever heard. I think *you're* the one who doesn't want to be around *me* anymore!"

"That's because I was *embarrassed*!" Phainon shouts back, his eyebrows furrowing as he places a hand over his chest.

"I see," Mydei says, and every ounce of fight leaves him. It feels like someone else is controlling his body, speaking the words in his mind and making sure his ribcage expands and contracts to ensure he keeps breathing. He already knew deep down that's how Phainon feels now, but having it confirmed directly to him doesn't ease the hurt.

Phainon's embarrassed of Mydei.

Maybe it was due to the way they shared something on Saturday night that he couldn't stand, and then he was reminded of it when someone pointed out that they might've had something more than friendship going on

between them. "I guess we shouldn't be around each other since it's *embarrassing* for you."

"Wait, no! Stop twisting my words, that's not what I—" Phainon takes a few stumbling steps forward, his expression so pained and open that it makes something in Mydei's chest *crack.*

Mydei grits his teeth so hard that his jaw aches. "If you're quite done, you should get back to your department. Wouldn't want to delay anyone's classes again."

It's a low blow and they both know it. It doesn't even *mean* anything either —a dig at something that happened months ago and was a one off, but he'd seen Phainon at his lowest with it—the fear, the way it'd shaken him up and made him think he wasn't worthy of continuing his career. So to use it against him… Well, Mydei never said he couldn't be cruel sometimes, even towards the person he likes. He regrets it as soon as it leaves his mouth though, and he wishes he could rewind time and take it back, but the impact of his words has clearly already landed in the way Phainon recoils like he's been physically hit.

"Fuck you, *Mydeimos*," Phainon spits out and storms away, slamming the door behind him so hard that the walls of his classroom tremble, just like what his hands are doing as he grips onto the stack of papers like a lifeline.

Mydei's chest heaves as he tries to calm down his breathing, his body shaking with repressed anger, frustration, and worst of all—*shame*. Because for the first time, Phainon had said his name *right,* and it was all for this.

He's messed up already, so soon after he now realises that Phainon had been the braver one and offered him an olive branch to carry on whatever normality they had left. It's like he can't stop the things he wants from crashing and burning right in front of him: his mother, his father, and now Phainon.

Mydei wants to catch up with him, to pull him into a hug and never let him go. He wants to whisper apologies and pepper kisses all over his face in hopes that Phainon will forgive him for lashing out—but the thought of being rejected again instils such a bone-deep fear in him that he can't move an inch from his spot.

Phainon just wants to be friends. But Mydei wants more. And no matter how much he wants that to be different, how much he wishes he was satisfied with being friends with the younger teacher, he can't find it in him to truly believe that. From their lingering gazes to the way they fall into each other so effortlessly, how can Mydei ignore all of that? Phainon makes him feel so *alive*, a whole decade younger, and he wishes it could change, but it won't.

Mydei isn't sure how he can fix things this time.

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**Mydeimos [12:03 pm]**

Come to the staffroom.

**Cipher [12:05 pm]**

i'm going to kill u.

Mydei sips absentmindedly at his tea, which is a touch too cold now to taste nice but he doesn't care. It's been over two weeks since he's last seen Phainon after what happened in his classroom, and it's clear that he's finished with him. Mydei isn't surprised. He hasn't texted Phainon, and the other hasn't reached out either—why would he, when Mydei gloriously threw everything back in his face?

He spent the first week after the fight in a daze, not able to ground himself as time passed. Mydei purposely came into work even earlier than usual to avoid him, and he hasn't worn his scarf since—the memories attached to it now are too much for him to deal with. Even his students noticed, their questions of 'Mr Kremnos, are you alright?' still ring in his head as they looked between themselves in confusion and worry as he slipped up again during his lectures. He heard a few of them whispering between themselves, saying that *Mr Khaslana has been acting weird too*, but he didn't bother telling them off for not listening.

The second week was a lot harder; where everything had set in and he realised that he wasn't sure if he'd see or hear from Phainon ever again unless it was an accidental run-in, but it's clear that they're both staying away from each other. Mydei combs through their texts every night religiously, reading every single exchange again and again until he has them practically memorised. He can barely look at the contact photo of him as he reads over their messages, the tiny circular image of Phainon sunbathing on the beach while looking calm and serene only makes him remember how Phainon had looked the last time he'd seen him—distraught, as if his heart

had been scooped out of him and he was standing there watching Mydei crush it in his hands right in front of him. The softness of the photo is too much, too soon, and it makes him feel like he isn't allowed to enjoy it anymore after how he'd hurt him so deeply.

The slamming of a tupperware box jolts him out of his thoughts. He watches as both Cipher and Castorice slide into the chairs opposite him, their faces sour and eyes narrowed. Even Castorice doesn't look pleased.

"What did you do?" Cipher hisses, voice low enough to not let anyone else in the room hear.

"Hello, you two," Mydei says plainly.

"Hello, Mydeimos. What did you do?" Castorice replies, and her voice is the flattest he's ever heard it as she echoes Cipher's question.

"I don't know what you mean," Mydei says, sniffing haughtily.

Cipher rolls her eyes and unpacks her lunch box, setting her food out in front of her. "We're grown-ups now, so just answer the bloody question. You've not shown up here in *weeks*, ignored all my texts, and then finally you say to meet us here and you're acting like this! We've given you space, but you better explain yourself. *Now*."

Mydei is tempted to remain silent out of spite, and just to see if he can outlast the cold war going on between him and Cipher now what with them glaring at each other, but with it all laid out in front of him he realises what a shit friend he's been. It's obvious they're both angry, but he's also upset with how everything went down. He can *talk* about it though, he doesn't need to keep it bottled up inside—these two are his best friends (his words now, not just theirs), and he wants to know what they think, even if it hurts.

"…I think Phainon hates me," Mydei replies eventually, immediately wanting to kick himself with how pathetic he sounds.

"You *think* or did Phainon actually tell you this?" Cipher asks, picking a grape off the vine and popping it in her mouth.

"His last words to me were *fuck you, Mydeimos*, before storming out of my classroom. I think it's safe to say he hates me," Mydei says forlornly.

Castorice sighs, her shoulders remaining tense. "He's not *angry*, Mydeimos. He's *sad*."

Mydei's heart stops at that—he doesn't want to imagine Phainon sad in general, he can barely even fathom it, but let alone knowing that he was the cause of it all. Having Phainon hate him would've made this a lot easier.

Cipher eyes him knowingly and sighs too. "I don't know exactly what happened, he didn't tell me, but all I got was that you both upset each other. So take yourself down a few pegs and go talk it out."

"What if it's better this way? For the both of us?"

Cipher growls at him and chucks the grape in her hand at Mydei, hitting him square in the forehead. "Don't you *ever* say that again. I'm not here to attend your self-fulfilling misery session, Mydeimos. You *love* him, so why can't you just admit that to yourself and go fucking do something about it already?"

"I don't *love* him!" Mydei says too loudly in the quiet of the room. He feels people turn towards him, their chairs creaking and their eyes burning into the back of his head. Castorice peers around him to glare at them all so they go back to their business. She's scary when she's serious, Mydei thinks.

"Fine," Cipher snaps, leaning over the table so she can whisper: "You *like* him. You *like* like him. Phainon and Mydei kissing in a tree, K-I-S-S-I-N-G!"

"Don't ever say that again," Mydei cringes, but the childish nursery rhyme makes him feel slightly shy about his feelings which are, despite everything, still very strong and real.

"That was the only issue?" Cipher replies incredulously. "Not the fact that I said you *like* like him? Or that you wanna kiss him?"

"We wouldn't be here if any of those things weren't true, would we?" Mydei replies, forcing a lightning fast sarcastic smile on his face, and Cipher mirrors it back at him before clicking her tongue in annoyance.

"I'm saying that you're mature enough to know better, and if you really want something then you actually have to put the work in. Phainon is human too — plus, he's moping all over East Block and it's killing the vibe. Go sort it out."

"So you're just mad that he's ruining the atmosphere in your block?" Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow as he sits back in his chair, crossing his arms over his chest.

"He's our friend too," Castorice pipes up, her voice a lot gentler now. "Neither of us want to see the both of you in pain because of a misunderstanding."

"Exactly," Cipher clicks her fingers. "And all I'm seeing is both of you being miserable bastards, day in, day out, and it pisses me off that this is happening when it doesn't need to."

Mydei holds Castorice's pleading gaze for a few moments before it becomes too much, and he stares down at his unfinished cup of tea instead. It's stone cold by now, but he still takes a shaky sip of it to wet his lips. "Would he even want to see me?" Mydei asks carefully.

"I'm going to pretend you're genuinely not stupid enough to ask that, and instead I'm going to *insist* you go and see him right now and talk."

"I don't know if I can, guys," Mydei admits.

"Sure you can, it's easy! Take your fancy designer shoes on a walk to the P.E office, fall to your knees and clasp your hands together and beg for another chance. There, done," Cipher waves her hand with a flourish, her grapes forgotten. "Actually, maybe don't drop to your knees. Phainon would like that too much, and I'm not sure your bones could take it."

"No, I mean…" Mydei trails off and adjusts his glasses in frustration, ignoring the last two crude comments out of Cipher's mouth. "I don't *just* want to be friends with him anymore. I can't do that."

"Okay…?" Both Cipher and Castorice say at the same time, their tone sceptical.

Mydei's irritation from that response skyrockets, "How is that okay? He's not interested and I clearly am, so it's not going to work!"

They're both so silent that Mydei chances looking back up at them to see what they're doing. They're both gaping at him in what can only be described as *horror*.

"Why the hells do you think that?" Cipher asks.

Mydei furrows his eyebrows, "Because he made it very clear."

"I wasn't going to say anything," Castorice begins, and she straightens up in her chair and leans over the table, grasping Mydei's hands in hers. "But I can't let this go on any longer."

"What do you mean?" Mydei asks.

"Mydeimos," Castorice says slowly, enunciating each syllable of his name. "Phainon is *very much* interested."

"What?" Mydei snaps, too brusque, but he's shocked. "No, he's not."

"Did he tell you he wasn't interested? That he didn't like you back?"

"No, but—"

"Then listen," Castorice says. "Phainon is an openly bisexual man. Which means he *likes men*, but more specifically, likes *you*. He's made that extremely clear to us, trust me," She pats his hand and pulls back.

"Don't act like you know everything when you haven't been subject to one of his insane rants about how beautiful you are," Cipher adds on, shuddering.

"He's bi?" Mydei squints at them. "Why didn't I know that?"

"Because he doesn't have to spell it out for everyone to just *know*, Mydeimos. He's not exactly been hiding his attraction towards you, right?"

Mydei sighs and pushes his glasses up again from where they've slid down slightly. He doesn't really know what to do with that—he can't play *entirely* obtuse and say that Phainon didn't give him subtle hints since they've known each other, but they weren't enough to fully signal to him any intent. But if he's friends with Cipher and Castorice, and they all hang out without him, then… Then maybe what they're saying is true, and he's opened up to them about his feelings for Mydei beforehand.

"Are you both being entirely truthful right now? You're not just trying to set us up?" Mydei questions, needing to know.

"Cross my heart and hope to die, if I have to hear another word about your *conspicuous body*, I think I might go insane," Cipher says, shuddering.

"But—" He starts, and then stops. He tries again: "But he said that he wouldn't have kissed me if he'd known it would '*make us like this*', and that

he was embarrassed! I know I'm not always… the best person to be around, but I—"

"He was scared," Castorice says. "He wasn't ready for his feelings, and he was worried you didn't like him back."

"What?" Mydei says in disbelief. "Did he tell you that too?"

"Sure did," Cipher says.

"Aren't you spilling too much of his private thoughts right now?" Mydei asks, suddenly feeling protective and defensive over Phainon.

"He has *feelings* for you, you dolt! That's no secret! Just… Go and speak to him so we don't need to keep 'spilling too much' about him," Cipher says, using air quotes.

Mydei knows that his and Phainon's… Whatever this is now, is hanging on by a thread, and he has the potential to either strengthen it or cut it off completely, but he's *scared*. He wishes it was as easy as they're making it out to be to just waltz over to East Block, do some grovelling and have Phainon immediately forgive him and sweep him up into a kiss to seal the deal.

"Do you trust us?" Castorice asks suddenly.

"Of course I do," Mydei replies without hesitation. He may not always believe them, per se, but if he's being asked to trust them, then that's something he'll never question.

"Then go and see Phainon and talk with him. Tell him everything, and I promise you, it will be *fine*," Castorice says, her voice warm and sincere.

Mydei nods, the words settling in as they give him courage and strength. He leaves the staffroom in silence after that. He can't just run over to East Block like he wants to, he still has two more classes left to teach before he can even *think* about it. But that's only two more hours, and then he'll be able to speak to Phainon, and maybe that will be it, their final conversation as Phainon tells Mydei he hates him and wants nothing to do with him anymore, or maybe—

Mydei doesn't let himself think about the other, more hopeful ending to that thought just yet.

Chapter End Notes

> icb the next chapter is the final one aaaah... it's already written and just needs me to go through the edits and okay them, but after that it's all done! hopefully i'll update it within the next couple of weeks as to not keep everyone waiting too long haha. i said at the start of this project i'd update every 1-3 weeks but ummmm... that turned into 1-3 MONTHS hahahahahah sweats ;;;;
>
> anyways, hope you all liked this chapter! like i said at the start, it's definitely more of a transitional one where they're figuring everything

out. but don't worry, the finale will be very epic and hopefully make up for all this pining/drama hehe!!!

-

leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

-

let's be friends on twitter/x!

# Chapter 8: chapter eight

Chapter Summary

Phainon grumbles, jutting his bottom lip out into a pout. "Gods, why do I even love a guy like you?"

Mydei can't even begin to wrangle down the sheer amount of elation that shoots through him then, burning so brightly inside of him that he's surprised it doesn't outwardly manifest and blind them both.

"*Mydeimos*," Phainon begins, sounding winded. This time, when he says his full name, it feels like a reward instead of a punishment. "I don't think I can take it when you smile at me like that."

Mydei can only laugh, the sound weightless and impossibly dazzling. Phainon lets out another pained sound at it. "I'm going to kiss you in five seconds, so if you don't want me to, you better leave now." Phainon warns.

Chapter Notes

gods i can't believe this is the end of their journey into becoming the most embarrassing boyfriends EVER!!!! omg. thank you so much for everyone's support despite my rocky upload schedule and other things, your comments and kudos have truly made it all worth it!

special thanks to nina once again for editing this lump of text HAHA, i really appreciate you!

anyway, i won't yap on too long since you're all here for one thing (
) (yes it's FINALLY explicit omg only took like 80k words to get there) HAHA

thank you so much everyone, hope you enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

At 3:15pm, the final bell of the day rings, signalling that it's home time. Mydei knows Phainon won't be gone until nearing 4pm with how he needs to pack away equipment and sort the changing rooms out, so he doesn't rush off just yet. He rifles through his satchel, grabbing a handful of lemon flavoured sweets that he keeps in there for quick pick-me-ups. Mydei definitely feels like he needs them now, especially considering what he's planning on doing very soon.

Steeling himself and checking the time on both his wristwatch and the clock on the wall, he finally decides it's time to make a move, even if Phainon isn't quite ready yet. His heart pounds with every step that he takes as he gets closer and closer to the entryway of East Block. It's the biggest one on the school grounds; housing the reception area, the art department which is upstairs, and then the school library as well. As he passes said library, he contemplates just hiding in there instead. It's not like he has to do this *today right now*, he supposes, but before he can chicken out, Phainon walks out the hall doors.

Phainon sees him immediately, standing at the opposite end of the foyer holding a tub full of badminton shuttlecocks. Mydei's heart leaps to his throat, and suddenly it's hard to breathe with the way they watch each other, both clearly too afraid to make the first move. Phainon's eyes are round and wide, lips parted and chest moving slightly erratically even from a distance. He also looks *small*, so tiny in his six foot frame as he begins to shutter, his body shrinking in on itself as he breaks their eye contact like he doesn't want to be seen.

Mydei can't believe that he's done that to him.

He casts away whatever fear is holding him back, imagining it falling off his shoulders and dissolving into the floor beneath his feet, and bolsters himself to approach first. He can't—he *won't*—let Phainon stand there looking like… like Mydei doesn't *want* him, when the actual truth is completely the opposite.

Within a few long strides, he's in front of Phainon. He has so much he wants to say, so much he wants to do, but being this close after so long instead makes him feel like he's choking on everything.

"Phainon—"

"Mr Kremnos—"

They both speak at the same time. Thankfully, for some reason, their small mishap causes a smile to bloom prettily on Phainon's face, like a flower budding after the harsh winter months.

"…Mydei is fine, Phainon. You know this," Mydei says softly, now worrying about wiping that smile off of Phainon's face again.

Phainon grips the tub of shuttlecocks tighter, his knuckles turning white as he looks up at him through his lashes, his gaze so open and hopeful that Mydei can't believe he'd almost given up on this.

He clears his throat. "Can we talk?" Mydei asks.

Phainon looks down at the tub he's carrying, and then to his left where the corridor to the changing rooms and P.E staffroom are before he replies: "I'll be done in about twenty minutes, if that's okay? You can go wait in the office, Cipher and Nikolas have already gone home."

Mydei nods and offers Phainon a weak smile of his own before he walks towards the office. It's not hard to spot Phainon's desk once he's in there—he didn't get a good look at it when he was in here before, but it's the only one that's just covered in *stuff*. Pieces of paper, notebooks and clipboards that definitely belong to someone else, a laptop half sticking out of its carry case, and a spare hoodie draped over the back of his chair. It makes Mydei chuckle as he approaches it—it looks chaotic at first, what with everything strewn everywhere, but once he's closer he notices that it's all organised into categories.

He catches sight of two photo frames and leans over to get a closer look, his face turning fond when he takes in the pictures behind the glass.

The young girl in the bigger frame must be Cyrene. She's standing next to Phainon, who's wearing a graduation cap and gown, and Phainon is grinning from ear to ear with his arm slung over Cyrene's shoulder, pulling her closer into his side. She's wearing a long pink dress that matches her hair, and even though there are clear differences between them, their smiles are practically identical. There are clear tear tracks down his face—Mydei can only imagine how relieved Phainon must've been when he finally graduated, especially after having determinedly fought his way through university and teacher training until he could finally do what he'd always wanted to.

It makes Mydei's heart sing with joy knowing that passion has always been so deeply rooted in Phainon; the desire for more, for always fighting against his circumstances to do what he could despite his whole life being planned out for him to stay in Aedes Elysiae. Mydei is somewhat happy that all of that led to him finding a job here, that it led them to become friends—even if their status as 'friends' is up in the air right now. Whatever happens, whatever goes on when Phainon is back and they begin to iron this all out, Mydei will *never* regret knowing Phainon.

The other photo frame on the desk is a lot smaller, and it's hidden behind the clutter. He daren't touch it—it looks old and fragile, but he can still just about make out what's on it. Mydei leans in closer, trying to peer over the mess to get a better look. He blinks, realising that it's a family photo. Phainon's parents stand shoulder to shoulder, Phainon in the middle in front of them as a small bundle of a baby is cradled in his mother's arms. Phainon looks just like his mother, Mydei thinks as he indulges in looking at how cute Phainon was as a kid. His chubby round cheeks and bowl cut can't hide how precious his features are—his mother's eyes, but his father's nose. Cyrene is nothing but a bundle of blankets with a tuft of pink hair sticking out, but they all look so happy.

The sound of the door opening from behind him forces Mydei's attention elsewhere. It's fine, he's had his fill of peering into Phainon's private life through these photographs. He turns to see Phainon standing in the doorway timidly.

"Did you wanna speak in here, or…?"

"No, I've been cooped up indoors all day. Let's go for a walk and get some fresh air," Mydei replies swiftly.

Phainon looks pleased with that idea—he must be feeling the need for fresh air too.

They exit the building, the silence of the empty school grounds as they make their way towards the grassy field is as peaceful as it is unnerving. It's very rare that Mydei stays behind this late, favouring going home on time to do his work there instead, so seeing the grounds as a ghost town is definitely different.

"Have you been able to come down this far yet?" Mydei asks, trying to make small talk—which he decides he isn't very good at—and gestures towards the long green expanse in front of them.

"Nah, it's been too cold for rounders, so we haven't used anything but the running track yet," Phainon replies simply.

Mydei hums but doesn't say anything else, focusing on leading Phainon across the field until they reach the pentagon shaped wooden gazebo that's right up against the metal fencing that surrounds the school's boundary. It's primarily for teachers, but it's barely used as it's fallen into disrepair over the years and is mostly used by unruly students who hide in it if they don't want to go to class.

It has one bench pushed against one of the edges that's seen better days, along with a black rubbish bin that hasn't been emptied in a while. The whole structure is probably about as old as the sixth formers are at this point, but it's private and that's all that matters. Phainon doesn't bother sitting down, heading straight for the wooden railing and leaning his weight on his forearms. The wind is starting to pick up now, the only thing that Mydei can hear is the faint sound of cars and the rustling of the trees that line the field border. He gets a waft of pine coming from the trees, and he inhales it happily as though it's cleansing him from the inside out.

Mydei digs into his pocket to find the sweets he grabbed earlier and stays where he is, not quite daring to approach Phainon just yet. "Do you want one?"

Phainon looks over his shoulder and seems surprised at the little wrapped treats. "What flavour?"

"Lemon," Mydei answers, unwrapping one as he pops it straight into his mouth, sighing with faint relief as the flavour bursts over his tongue. Phainon makes a grabbing motion with his hand, and Mydei rolls his eyes fondly as he hands one over to him too.

They remain in silence for a few minutes, both of them watching the scenery pass as the sky gets darker and darker.

"What did you want to say to me?" Phainon asks once Mydei's sweet is almost all gone, and he's crunching on the remnants of it in his mouth.

Mydei comes to stand next to him, leaning his hip on the railing so he can look down directly at Phainon. The wind bruises past him, ruffling his hair and making his braid whip around until he tucks it behind his ear.

"That I'm sorry," Mydei begins, swallowing down the final pieces of the lemon flavour. "About the beach. About the other week in my classroom. About *everything*. I didn't mean what I said that day, and I know I upset you and made you… uncomfortable."

Somehow, going by the way Phainon's expression twists, his features becoming warped and almost unidentifiable, he guesses he's said something wrong.

"What's the matter?" Mydei asks, a low roiling of worry settling in his stomach.

"How long did that take for you to come up with?"

Mydei glares daggers at Phainon, suddenly on edge. He brings himself to his full height as tension between them skyrockets, and he unknowingly sets his shoulders and puffs his chest out at the tone of the younger teacher's voice.

"Is that what you truly think of me? That I'd come all the way out here just to say words I don't mean?"

"I don't know, Mydei. You tell me! What do you even want from me?!" Phainon says, voice growing gradually louder in tone until he's almost shouting, his words echoing around them as if the wind doesn't try and damper them.

Phainon stands up straight too, their eyes meeting and their shoes touching as Phainon takes a step forward into Mydei's space. It brings with him so much, so much feeling and so much emotion, that when Mydei breathes it in he finds himself almost choking on it. He can smell Phainon's deodorant, clean and masculine, pine and citrus. He swallows it down, desperate for it, and he wants to cling to it as much as he can as he feels the way this situation is falling through his fingers like sand.

"Whatever you'll allow me to have," Mydei says, breathing in deeply. "But you don't seem to want to give me anything at all!" His voice begins to shake, and he hates what he's about to say next: "I *know* I shouldn't have kissed you, and I wish I could take it all back, but—"

"Please don't say that," Phainon cuts him off, voice trembling. "I *wanted* you to kiss me."

"What are you even saying? Before you made it very clear you didn't want it, but now you're saying that you wanted me to? I don't understand!" Mydei can't help but yell the last three words, his voice coming out gruff and thick.

Mydei is tired of them dancing around each other when all he wants to do now is sort this out—and if that means hashing things over with Phainon until it's five in the morning, or hearing him curse him out until he's blue in

the face, he'll deal with it. He isn't going anywhere, not until they finally come to a mutual conclusion; whether that's to stick together (as friends, or as nothing at all), or separate for good.

"You shut me out!" Phainon's accusation knocks him off centre. "I tried to fix it… but you shut me out…"

"Fix what, Phainon? Hm?" Mydei pokes at Phainon's chest, making the other flinch back. He sneers at him down his nose. "The way I feel about you? Of course I fucking shut you out when you rejected me, why the hells would I do anything else?"

"Rejected you— *What*?" Phainon sounds genuinely shocked, and looks it too.

Mydei rolls his eyes, but there's no fondness to the action. "Don't play dumb now."

Phainon gapes at him, shaking his head in what Mydei assumes is disbelief. "When did I ever reject you?"

"Do you want a list? How about we start with the way you reacted like that at the department review meeting?" Mydei says, arching an eyebrow as he folds his arms across his chest.

The lemon taste in his mouth turns from sugary sweet to disgustingly sour.

"I freaked out!" Phainon shouts, the words echoing around the empty field. "I— I lost it, okay? You have no idea what I… *how* I feel! I didn't reject you, I was just scared!"

"Then why didn't you say that?!" Mydei questions brutally.

"Because I didn't know how I was supposed to act after you pulled away from our kiss and you looked like you'd just made the biggest mistake of your whole fucking life!" Phainon's face scrunches up as he talks, his words coming out wobbly and unsure. "How could I listen to them asking me if we were together when all I could think about was how you regret everything between us?"

"What are you even saying?!" Mydei's voice sounds strangled as he begins to piece things together. "I don't regret anything that happened between us, I'm in love with you!" His hands are shaking now as they rise up to grab onto Phainon's shoulders. "You said that you were embarrassed, and I assumed you meant about *me*!"

"You… you idiot…!" Phainon yells, bright red from his collarbones up to the roots of his hair. He punches Mydei's chest, the force of it making him stumble back a step in shock, his hands still raised between them with nowhere to go. "I was embarrassed because I'm in love with you too. I just kissed my *crush*, for fucks sake, how else would I react?!"

"But…" Mydei's brain, while clicking things into place slowly, also feels like a jumbled mess that he can barely make sense of.

"Did you not hear me?" Phainon glares at him. "I was *shy*, okay? I didn't know what else to do. You wanted to pretend everything was normal, but —" He pauses, and it looks like all the colour drains out of him while he simultaneously gets impossibly redder. "Did you just say you're in love with me?"

Mydei feels like he's going to faint when everything catches up with him. "You said you're in love with me too?"

They stare at each other in silence.

Mydei's always heard the phrase 'now or never', but he realises in this moment it's never been more true—Phainon looks seconds away from splintering, not yet allowing himself to believe in their mutual confession. He can't let him go, not now, especially after finding out that Phainon this whole time has wanted him too. Mydei scrubs a hand through his hair in frustration, the words getting stuck in his throat.

"Have you ever lied to me?" Mydei asks as he tries to keep his cool.

"What? No! Of course not!" Phainon looks confused at the topic change, but shaken even at the thought of what he's being asked.

"And you don't care that I'm going grey, or that I'm thirteen years older than you? Or that I have a bad temper and like drinking floral teas?"

Phainon shakes his head, albeit still looking lost at the way this conversation is going. "What the hells are you going on about?"

Mydei sighs. "Then, Phainon," He reaches his hand out slowly so the other can see what he's doing. He grabs on of Phainon's hands and uses it to guide them closer together so that they're toe-to-toe again. "I *am* in love with you."

And it's true. He'd only just barely been able to understand it that night at the beach, but with Phainon right in front of him he can feel it radiating from both of them this time. He feels it in the way Phainon unlocks something inside of him that he thought he'd lost; in the way they push but then reel each other back in; in the way Phainon lights up his day with a simple glance; in the way he just *gets* him and he never needs to explain himself—Phainon already knows.

How could he not love someone who makes him smile so much when he scarcely smiled after his mother passed? How could he not love someone who makes him laugh so freely? How could he not love someone who pushes his boundaries, and who has made him trust again after so long?

Phainon looks as panicked as Mydei feels.

"You love me," Phainon repeats, voice devoid of any emotion.

Mydei's heart crashes in his chest as he squeezes Phainon's hand, "I do."

"Oh," Phainon says, wonder and awe filling his face as if he's finally figured it all out, all of the puzzle pieces slotting together like their fingers entwining as one. He squeezes Mydei's hand back, "I love you, too."

Mydei's heart explodes. He can't help it then—he wraps Phainon up in a hug, arms enveloping around his frame to pull them together. Phainon reciprocates immediately, and they both cling to each other in silence for what seems like hours. Mydei allows himself to do what he's always wanted: nuzzle into Phainon's soft hair and press a kiss to his temple.

Phainon laughs wetly into the crook of his neck. "This whole time you had feelings for me?"

Mydei laughs alongside him, feeling somewhat delirious as he admits: "I think ever since I first saw you."

"I think we've both been a little stupid then," Phainon says as Mydei gives him one last squeeze and lets him go, but neither of them go very far as they're still wrapped in each other's arms.

"Says you," Mydei jokes, feeling the weight on his shoulders disappear.

"I think Cipher will agree with my statement," Phainon says, then his expression turns glum. "Ah, shit. I owe her *so* many iced coffees now."

"Why? What did you get yourself into? You should know better never to bargain with that cat…"

Phainon laughs nervously, scratching under his chin as he looks to and from Mydei and the field. "I may have been using her as my therapist for the past couple of months…"

"Months?" Mydei asks in total shock. Phainon has liked him for *months*?

Phainon groans and buries his face into Mydei's neck again, his words coming out muffled. "Don't remind me! I didn't know what the hell to do since the first day we met!"

Mydei stares into the distance with wide eyes. "Okay, we've both been stupid this whole time."

"Hey!" Phainon yells, pulling back so he can kick his leg out to try and catch Mydei's shin with his foot. Mydei chuckles and easily dodges, only narrowly missing the attack. "You're not allowed to call me stupid now."

"Oh? Why's that?" Mydei goads, raising his eyebrows. "How about *annoying* instead?"

"No!" Phainon grumbles, jutting his bottom lip out into a pout. "Gods, why do I even love a guy like you?"

Mydei can't even begin to wrangle down the sheer amount of elation that shoots through him then, burning so brightly inside of him that he's surprised it doesn't outwardly manifest and blind them both.

"*Mydeimos*," Phainon begins, sounding winded. This time, when he says his full name, it feels like a reward instead of a punishment. "I don't think I can take it when you smile at me like that."

Mydei can only laugh, the sound weightless and impossibly dazzling. Phainon lets out another pained sound at it. "I'm going to kiss you in five seconds, so if you don't want me to, you better leave now." Phainon warns.

Mydei's grin slides off his face immediately at that, shock spreading through his features instead. Phainon doesn't even give him the five seconds reprieve before he shoots forward, flinging his arms around his neck and smashing their lips together. The force of it makes Mydei wince and knocks his glasses off centre, eyes wide and lips parted as his arms flail around until they finally find purchase on Phainon's waist, hauling him even closer.

He pulls back a tad so he can speak: "That wasn't five seconds," Mydei chides softly, their mouths brushing against each other with every word. "Already breaking promises?"

"It's been longer than that now and you're still here," Phainon replies petulantly. His eyes are hazy already, solely focused down to a pinpoint on Mydei's lips.

Mydei presses them into a flat line and he can hear rather than see Phainon's gulp with the click of his throat. He can't take it anymore—he rips his glasses off his face, chucking them carelessly onto the wooden bench beside him. He doesn't care where they land, as now they're only a hindrance to his plan of kissing Phainon until he's finally satisfied.

With a quick shuffle, Phainon has their positions switched: Phainon crowds him back up against the railing, and he takes a few moments to wriggle around so it's not digging into his lower back. He already has enough issues with it aching in the evenings—let alone if this added to it and made it worse. Phainon, like this, feels inches taller than him as he slots his thigh in between Mydei's legs as he edges his face even closer, their breaths mingling and foreheads knocking gently together.

Anticipation fills Mydei, from the roots of his hair down to the tips of his toes. He wants Phainon to lean in further, to take his lips with his own and *claim* him in some shape or form. He doesn't care how. Phainon already looks like he's gone a few rounds with how messy his windswept hair is, the strands dancing along with the wind that's blowing on by. His lips are already swollen and shiny from that chaste kiss before, and Mydei can't help but wonder what he'll really look like when he kisses him properly.

Phainon's eyes turn dewy, eyebrows upturning and lips pinched downwards. He looks *pathetic*, like a begging puppy who doesn't know how else to ask for what it wants other than holding up a paw and hoping for the best. Mydei can't believe how lucky he is to have this right in front of him—

Phainon, pliant and desperate, all after one tiny kiss. Mydei's imagination begins to run wild—picturing how Phainon will look over him, beneath him, beside him and how he'll react when he finally gets his hands on his bare skin like he's been dreaming about late at night for months when he feels most alone.

"I'm giving you ten seconds now before I kiss you again," Phainon says. He's still not quite looking at Mydei's face when he says this, just staring hungrily down at his lips instead.

Mydei rolls his eyes, but is sufficiently chastised for zoning out when he has Phainon right now in front of him. "So needy," Mydei comments, threading his fingers through Phainon's hair because he *can*—there's nothing stopping him, no barrier of 'friendship' and the benign rules that come along with that label. He's not sure what they are now—not lovers, not boyfriends—but definitely something *more*, and he hopes that it'll lead to something where he feels secure in knowing what they are.

But for now, he has this. Mydei carefully scrapes his fingernails across Phainon's scalp, relishing on how it gets a full body reaction from him. It makes Mydei swallow past the thickness in his throat, feeling slightly choked up from it as he flexes his hips, forgetting that Phainon's thigh is in between his legs. It knocks a gasp out of him at the sudden friction, and suddenly this is all too much and not enough all at once. Heat floods through him like magma, and he feels jittery and shaken. Phainon moves, arms around his waist, hands secured at the curve of his back to keep him steady. He allows himself a long breath outwards, the situation catching up to him and their current position.

"Later," Phainon mumbles and moves his leg backwards slightly so it's not pressed right up against him. It's as much of a relief as it is a disappointment, but then there's hands in his hair and a grip guiding him so surely, so frankly, forward and closer until their lips press together again.

Mydei melts against him instantly, his hands clawing over Phainon's t-shirt for purchase as his lips part in askance. Phainon doesn't waste any time giving in, licking straight into Mydei's mouth, swallowing each sound that leaves him. Phainon's hands keep *moving*, never settling—with one inhale, they're in his hair, with an exhale, they're on his shoulders digging into muscle, the next they're sliding over his back and down to his ass, grabbing at it and pulling their hips closer, clearly disregarding what he'd said earlier. The sudden pressure on his cock makes him moan, and they're so entwined that he can feel the way the sound causes Phainon's own to twitch in his shorts.

Mydei bites down on Phainon's lower lip in warning, wanting nothing more than to get bent over the railing right now and let the younger teacher have his way with him right then and there out in the open—but they're still on school grounds, and they're very much still at risk of a cleaner or a stray teacher finding them like this.

"HKS, we can't do this here," The curse falls out of his mouth like a pet name, his voice low and words slurring together slightly. He feels like he's a teenager all over again being kissed for the first time—the haze of desire clouding over his mind so thickly that he fears he might go crazy with desperation.

Phainon grumbles, fingers spread wide over his ass still, digging in and kneading, pulling and pushing until they're pressed together from chest-to-

chest, hip-to-hip. He's clearly not listening to what Mydei is trying to say, even though it makes perfect sense, and he dives back in for another kiss. Mydei can't help it; he feels weak at the knees as he lets Phainon get away with it, feeling him rut against him in tiny circular motions, only enough to tease but nothing more.

*Gods*, it feels so good—Mydei can't help but lean into it, arching his back and pushing his ass further into Phainon's grip just to see what he'll do with it. And he doesn't disappoint, a happy noise leaving him as he gropes him again and again.

Then, finally, a breath between them: "*Phainon*," Mydei whispers when they part, the name holding the weight of a thousand words.

His whole body feels on fire, and Phainon's tiny, delighted noises of pleasure only add fuel to the heat, purposely stoking it until it's roaring. He can't stop, the kiss getting wetter and sloppier as it goes on—each lick, each taste, each nip of teeth makes him tremble with pleasure. The feel of Phainon's mouth on his—properly this time, no drunken misunderstandings between them—and the taste of lemon sweets heavy on their breaths and in the nicks and grooves of Phainon's teeth have him wanting more and more and more. Their teeth clash every so often from how excited they both seem to be, but it's instantly soothed by softer kisses, a delicate flick of their tongue or a hum of apology. It only means that Mydei can readjust their angle and kiss Phainon some more, slightly to the left, slightly to the right, dead on centre.

Mydei savours it, each second that ticks by, the wind blowing past them in a way that should send goosebumps rippling across his skin from the cold but instead it's from how blazing hot they both are, Phainon's chest heaving

against his and his hips shaking with trying to stay still, to not fully fall into each other where they're still so exposed.

It's not until the railing behind him creaks ominously that he realises how harshly he's being pushed into it by Phainon's body, and it snaps him out of it as their setting comes back to the forefront of his mind. He pulls away from Phainon's lips, a trail of saliva still connecting them until it breaks a few moments later. His stomach flips when Phainon chases him without hesitation, clearly wanting more.

"Later," Mydei echoes Phainon from earlier, having to clear his throat a few times to get rid of the roughness.

Phainon pouts, but pulls his hips away and instead buries his face into the crook of Mydei's neck. Mydei sighs fondly, loosening his grip on wherever it was on Phainon's body to reach up to smooth through his hair, stroking over the soft strands in what he hopes is a calming manner.

Although…

"You can take your hands off my ass now," Mydei says flatly. Phainon huffs, the exhalation across his heated skin makes him shiver slightly. Phainon squeezes it one last time before he wraps his arms around Mydei's waist instead.

Mydei can't even remember the last time he'd been hugged like this—pressed so closely against another person and feeling like he has his whole

world and everything he'll ever need or want right within his arms. The more he thinks about it, the more terrifying it becomes as he realises he's never truly felt like this before—and that alone makes a black pit open up inside of him, filled with fear at the reminder that he'd almost thrown this away because he was *scared*.

"Stop thinking," Phainon says, his voice muffled from where he's still hiding away in the divot of Mydei's neck, "You have a nice ass, by the way."

Mydei barks out a laugh at that, not bothering to ask how Phainon knew he was beginning to panic. He supposes he'll have to get used to that—Phainon reading him like an open book in a way that no one else ever has. He hopes that going forward, he'll be able to understand Phainon on that kind of level too. Their misunderstanding that could've cost them everything was because they were too afraid, too scared of the unknown and how the other truly felt that it almost led to them breaking apart. But now there was none of that—so would Mydei ever be able to hide behind a façade ever again? He's willing to admit (to himself, at least), that it freaks him out a little bit, but it's also freeing at the same time to know that Phainon has seen all of him and he's still here—wanting him.

"Did you know," Phainon draws back and straightens up, making Mydei frown from the loss of contact. "That when you *really* smile, you have dimples?"

Mydei's suddenly focusing back on Phainon's plump, red lips to really hear what he's saying, but he vaguely recalls being told before about his dimples that show up when he grins really wide. He hadn't had any excuse or reason to do that until Phainon showed up, so it doesn't really surprise him that the

other had noticed, as he was usually the cause of it. Phainon rocks forward onto the balls of his feet, giving him more of a height advantage, and presses a quick kiss on either side of Mydei's cheeks.

He can't help the gentle smile that spreads across his face at Phainon's affection. Mydei feels like he could run laps around the entire world now that Phainon is *his*.

"I've been wanting to do that for ages," Phainon admits, grinning back at him.

Mydei feels his heart flutter delicately watching Phainon watch him back as they take each other in at such close proximity. He can hardly believe this is truly happening to him, and he can't help but reach out and touch—cupping Phainon's cheeks and chuckling as he nuzzles into it straight away just like he knew he would. He's careful not to squish them too much like he did last time when they were in the car park, but it doesn't matter either way because Phainon puckers his lips cutely in askance for another kiss. Mydei scoffs a laugh and ducks down, placing one chastely right in the centre. He rubs his thumbs over Phainon's cheekbones, back and forth again and again, the soft curve of them fitting perfectly into the palms of his hands.

"I think I like you like this," Mydei says quietly.

"Like what?" Phainon asks, wiggling his eyebrows up and down suggestively.

Mydei scrunches his face up playfully and shakes Phainon's head side to side, "I *mean*, I like you here. With me."

Phainon groans, but the way his cheeks flare with heat means that Mydei realises that he's getting shy over his words—not because he's disgusted or uncomfortable.

"Very cute. So, are you gonna wine and dine me first, or should we go back to your place?" Phainon questions, eyebrows still raised. Mydei knows he's going to have to work extra hard to get used to Phainon saying stuff like that to him because he has a feeling it's going to become a reoccurring thing.

"Acting like a dog with no manners," Mydei clicks his tongue in annoyance. "Why can't I do both?" He shoots back.

Phainon smiles at him, slightly dopey, and tilts his head further into Mydei's touch, pressing a quick kiss to one of his palms before swapping to do the same to the other. "Sorry, did I get ahead of myself?"

Mydei bites his lip and worries it between his teeth. "No," He finally replies. And he can't resist it this time—knowing he can finally allow himself to give into the gravitational pull between them, and he kisses Phainon again.

It's softer this time, their lips barely touching for the first few moments until Phainon gently presses closer. Mydei peppers kisses onto Phainon's lips, the

next one always sweeter than the last. Mydei pulls back once he's satisfied enough, nudging Phainon's nose with his own in pure indulgence and the gesture makes Phainon giggle.

*We must be feeling the same way,* Mydei thinks: giddy, and like his feet are ten feet off the ground in joy.

Phainon huffs like he has the whole world on his shoulders, "I guess you can do both, then. You going to spoil me? Take me to one of your fancy restaurants that has a dress code?"

Mydei takes a few moments to place what Phainon is on about, but when he remembers, he laughs. "Would you like that?"

"Which bit?" Phainon challenges, as though already knowing that Mydei will reply with.

"All of it," Mydei replies anyway, feeling his insides light up at the way Phainon grins, boyish and handsome.

"Hmm…" Phainon's eyes curve upwards with mischief, the shape of them so naturally seductive that it makes Mydei want to get on his knees and worship him. But then he's afraid of what that'll do to his knees, so maybe for now he'll stay standing. "If you want to take me to an expensive restaurant, I'll need something new to wear."

Mydei knows better than to fall for that tone of voice.

"I'm sure you have a nice shirt and trousers somewhere," He replies carefully, watching as Phainon pouts slightly.

"You don't want to dress me up?" Phainon asks, voice so coy it almost gets carried away with the wind. "I thought you wanted to see me in a suit?"

"But—" Mydei pauses, almost stuttering. "You're perfectly fine at dressing yourself."

"*Wrong*," Phainon replies, chuckling lightly. "I think I clean up nicely, but that was all Miss Aglaea's doing when we went on our… date." He sniffs haughtily, looking slightly put out. "If it was up to me, I would've worn something totally different. Yellow and purple, maybe? But I trust her judgement, so…" Phainon trails off.

Mydei can't help the face he pulls at the thought of yellow and purple being put together. "You're serious?"

"Deadly," Phainon replies, nodding sagely.

Mydei's mind goes wild then, running a mile a second with thoughts of *him* dressing up Phainon instead of Aglaea. Images of things he can put Phainon in flash before him: tight, fitted shirts with tailored trousers to show off his

thick thighs, a deep blue 3-piece suit, a black and white classic tux, maybe even one of Mydei's old band tee's that he still loves to wear. He wonders how they'd fit Phainon—if they'd be too tight around his broad shoulders but loose around his slim waist, or maybe they'd fit him perfectly.

"You're doing this on purpose, aren't you?" Mydei grits out, letting his hands run from Phainon's cheeks to grip at his waist instead. He digs his fingertips into the skin there through his t-shirt, not quite hard enough to bruise but enough to leave a lasting impression.

"Is it working?" Phainon teases, already looking like he's won as he tilts his head to the side as though he's an overgrown puppy. "Maybe I'll even try on your silk pyjamas, too."

"*Gods*, Phainon," Mydei groans—he hadn't even thought of that option, but now he knows he's going to dream about it until it happens. He can literally imagine right then and there how the silk would feel as he runs his hands all over Phainon, and he knows the rich navy blue colour of his favourite pair would look incredible against his pale skin.

Sighing, Mydei slides one of his hands down, taking his time feeling over the dip of curve from Phainon's waist to his hip, and then even further until he can grab under his knee, tugging his leg up so it hooks over his hip. It fits perfectly there, secure and snug, and he runs his hand up the length of Phainon's thigh until it's under his tiny shorts. Fingertips graze the hem of his underwear, and a thrill goes through him at the fact that Phainon is just letting him do all this without a sound or push back.

Mydei can't help but lean in again, nipping at the hinge of Phainon's jaw and extracting a pitiful whine, making him tilt his head back to give him easier access. *He* wants to take the lead for now, and he's going to make the most of it until Phainon inevitably turns the tables on him. He presses fervent kisses up and down the column of his neck, teeth trailing delicately over the skin where his sun tattoo is. It's completely smooth from what he can tell, not a bump or scar tissue in sight. Phainon's shivering—maybe even shaking now—in his grip, his thigh muscles trembling from being held up for so long as Mydei sucks bruises into the pale expanse before him, all so he can immediately soothe them over with his tongue. Mydei's other hand is pressed into his lower back to keep him steady, but he can feel sweat building up even through his t-shirt.

"I thought we decided on *later*," Phainon pants, clutching at Mydei's shoulder blades through his jacket.

"You have no idea what you do to me, do you?" Mydei questions rhetorically, sinking his teeth into the base of Phainon's neck.

That gets him the reaction he wants. Phainon shudders, and Mydei can feel it through his own body with how visceral it is. The younger teacher moans, loud and unabashed, eyelashes fluttering over those pretty, dewy blue eyes that shine even when half-shrouded by his eyelids. Mydei doesn't care that the sound echoes around the school grounds—no one's there at this time, anyway, and they're far away enough from the main building that they would only be seen as two pinpricks of colour in the distance.

"I'll spoil you, if that's what you want," Mydei says wetly into the other's skin, kissing upwards until he's back at Phainon's mouth. "I'll buy you all the fancy clothes and silks you want."

"Only if you let me spoil you back," Phainon replies, voice faint. "I have an idea how I can make that happen now, if you'll let me. You already spoil me enough with food alone."

Mydei's heartbeat kicks up a notch at the suggestion. "Oh? And how would you spoil me, Phainon?" His voice comes out gravelly, deeper than intended, especially when saying his name.

Phainon grins at him, all havoc and chaos. "Guess you'll have to wait and see until *later*."

Mydei rolls his eyes, but then he's being reeled in by fingers threading through his hair and tugging, pulling, guiding him forward until their mouths are connected once more. He shuts his eyes, allowing himself to be taken away in the ebb and flow of Phainon's incessant kissing. It feels as though they'll never end—and he can't decide whether he's happy or relieved about that. He doesn't want to be apart from Phainon ever again, if he can help it, so he doesn't so much as flinch as Phainon presses his torso even closer, hips aligning just *so*, the whole length of his cock pushing against Phainon's.

His eyes open against his will, mouth parting so he can speak: "You're so *big*," Mydei gasps out, wide eyes as he feels it against him. The heat between them is truly stifling.

Phainon snorts, raking his fingers through the length of Mydei's hair at the back of his head. "You're not so bad yourself." He says, rolling his hips

once just to make the fire burning lowly in Mydei's stomach flare up. Phainon's hands leave his hair, which makes Mydei's shoulders sag slightly in disappointment. He liked having them there, feeling them course through the strands delicately and scratch at his scalp. Instead, Phainon's hands move down to his shoulders again, digging his fingertips into the muscle before moving on quickly. He slides his hands down to circle around his biceps, and the intensity of his look makes Mydei almost preen.

"You like my arms?"

Phainon glances up at him, face thick with mischievousness, "Oh, you have no idea."

"Would you tell me if I asked?"

"Wouldn't wanna inflate your ego," Phainon says vaguely, licking his lips. Mydei follows his tongue dragging against his bottom lip slowly and he swallows. "You seem to like my legs."

Mydei smirks, "You have no idea," He parrots back, tightening his hold on Phainon's thigh. He basks in the way it makes his muscles jump and clench with it, a breathy moan leaving Phainon's lips at the sensation. The rush of power that washes over him at the reaction is almost enough to have his eyes rolling back into his head.

"Take me home, Mydeimos," Phainon begs, writhing in his grip. "You can wine and dine me later, yeah? I don't care." He finishes, pressing his lips

back against Mydei's desperately, but it's slightly off centre with how quick he flew inwards for the kiss.

The final thread of Mydei's sanity snaps.

"Meet me by my car in ten minutes," He rasps out, giving Phainon one last searing kiss before he sets his leg down and completely lets go. Mydei can't move backwards due to the railing, so he waits until Phainon steps back to give themselves some space in between.

Mydei's eyes immediately look downwards, and he spots the tent in Phainon's shorts, the shape of his cock obscene even though he doesn't have his glasses on. Just the mere outline of it alone is enough to have his mouth watering. All the things he wants Phainon to do to him and the things he wants to do to Phainon gather in his mind's eye, making his knees weak at the thought of now being able to *ask* if the other would say yes. It's really that simple now—there's no need to tread lightly, all their feelings spread out in the open between them. However, the ten minute wait to get to the car, and then the twenty minute car journey home will ultimately test him and his willpower.

Phainon heaves in a breath, gulping down as much fresh air as he can to help him seemingly calm down. He shifts his weight from one foot to the other, never fully settling as he shakes the energy out from his hands. His neck glistens under the setting sun with saliva that hasn't quite dried yet from the marks that Mydei left on him moments ago, and he can only think about all the other places he can leave more once they're back at his home.

Phainon finally has himself together with another exhale, and he gathers both sides of his hoodie and zips it up. Thankfully it's long enough to cover the situation in his shorts. Mydei isn't so lucky—his blazer is too short to hide anything, so he shrugs it off and drapes it over his arm to cover up his own bulge. He hopes that by the time he makes it back to his classroom, his cock would've softened up enough to not cause any disaster if he bumped into someone on the way back. He really, *really* hopes no one is around.

"I'll see you in ten," Phainon says, dropping one last kiss onto Mydei's lips before he sprints off, tearing down the field within seconds until he disappears back into East Block. Mydei huffs a laugh, and grabs his discarded glasses from the bench and sets off too.

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The drive back to Mydei's penthouse is agonising. Phainon can't seem to sit still in the passenger seat, shifting around constantly and tugging at his seatbelt every few moments. Mydei tries to focus on the road, especially when they reach the winding country ones that only have one lane for both ways, but all he can see out of his peripheral vision is Phainon watching him.

Phainon's eyes seem to roam over his entire body, lingering on his hands wrapped around the steering wheel. Mydei absentmindedly tightens his grip on it in response, the leather creaking beneath his hands.

"Eyes forward," Mydei orders, unable to take any more if they want to return home safely.

Phainon groans and lets his head fall back against the headrest sulkily. He seems to settle for only a few seconds before he's moving again, slumping low in his seat so he can widen his legs as much as the cramped space will let him. Mydei feels a sense of dread come over him when he realises that Phainon is looking at him and what he's doing when he palms over his own crotch, a high whine leaving his throat at the friction. He's like a desperate mutt that can't help himself.

"Phainon!" Mydei chastises, voice raised. "Stop it." He finishes, despite wanting to swerve over into one of the fields that lines the road just so he can get his hands on Phainon quicker, but thankfully the younger teacher heeds his warning and stuffs his hands under his thighs instead.

"You better start driving faster," Phainon mutters, pouting.

"You—! You're *incorrigible*."

Phainon just sticks his tongue out at him.

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They make it back in fifteen minutes instead of twenty.

As soon as they park up, Phainon jumps out of the car and drags Mydei towards the foyer. Mydei stumbles after him, barely having a chance to lock up the car behind him. His legs feel like lead from how hard he was tensing his muscles on the journey home. They ignore the receptionist who waves at Mydei and welcomes him back as they stand and wait for the lift to come down to the ground floor.

Once it arrives, thankfully empty, they stand on opposite sides of it, not looking at each other. Mydei tightly crosses his arms across his chest so he doesn't reach out and grab Phainon to shove him against the mirrored walls to kiss him. Phainon's leaning the side of his head against the cool metal, tapping his foot impatiently as they both watch the numbers on the lift screen creep higher and higher. To anyone else, they probably look like they're in the middle of a fight, but then within moments they'd realise the tension between them is so thick not because of anger, but because of something else entirely.

Once they reach the top floor, Mydei grabs onto Phainon's wrist, pulling him to a stop before he can storm out of the lift. He takes his time now, entwining their fingers together so they can hold hands as he begins to walk towards his front door. He shakily unlocks it, and before he has a chance to close it behind them, Phainon is on him.

Mydei manages to kick the door shut, grateful that it locks automatically, before he's suddenly being lifted up off the ground by Phainon's strong arms underneath his thighs. He immediately wraps his legs around Phainon's waist, hands on his shoulders to steady himself despite feeling completely secure in Phainon's grip. Mydei hears the clatter of Phainon toeing off his shoes, and he kicks his off too, leaving them in an unorganised heap by the doorway.

They kiss frantically as Phainon kneads Mydei's ass, only pulling away for a split second to let him wrangle himself out of his suit jacket and taking his glasses off to chuck them in the vague direction of his side table. They get in the way, and he can see well enough without them that the rest of the night won't be hidden from him in a shroud of mystery blurs. After all that, he can finally indulge in what he's been dreaming about for months.

Phainon is really here—in his home, hot and heavy and *real*. Mydei can't seem to stop moving, writhing around in his arms and he tightens and loosens his grip around his waist with his legs as though to test the younger teacher's grip on him. His hands are everywhere as if they can't decide what they want to do; first, they cup his cheeks as he licks across the seam of Phainon's lips, then they thread through his hair to yank at the strands and then they're tugging at his own collar to rip the first few buttons of his shirt open, neither of them caring when they go scattering around the hallway. Phainon watches him with eyes blown so wide and dark that Mydei can see his flushed reflection in them, his own eyes half-lidded and heavy with desire.

He finally wraps his arms around Phainon's neck when he's satisfied with his work, like he's sufficiently debauched them both before they've even really started. He's completely wrapped around Phainon—from his arms to his legs—but he still feels as though he needs to pull them closer together than what is humanly possible.

"Where's your bedroom?" Phainon asks, voice husky and shaking slightly from what Mydei assumes is anticipation.

He jerks his head over towards the direction behind Phainon's shoulder, "Right at the end of the hallway."

"Alright," Phainon says, setting off. It's impressive that he's able to hold Mydei so still as he walks, his arms not tiring in the slightest as he has Mydei's entire weight within his grasp.

Mydei feels overwhelmed in a way he's never felt before—he feels so out of control as he listens to Phainon shouldering open his bedroom door as he's still being kissed within an inch of his life. He's lightheaded with the lack of oxygen, and as soon as he's about to pull away for some air, Phainon beats him to it. Phainon pulls back and glances around the room, eyebrows arching when he spies the bed in the centre of the room up against the wall. It's huge, Mydei knows, but he takes his comfort seriously and when it comes to actually relaxing in his own home, he only wants the best of the best.

"You can fit at least four people in your bed," Phainon says, chuckling lightly as he steps further into the room and closes the door with his back, leaning against it afterwards.

"But I only want you in it," Mydei says rather earnestly, garnering a blinding smile in response from Phainon.

Phainon cranes his neck upwards and kisses the first bit of skin he can reach, which happens to be the middle of Mydei's jawline. He shuffles over to the end of the bed, letting Mydei down gently, cradling him with a hand between his shoulder blades and one on his lower back until he's safely lying down on the bed. Mydei's legs refuse to unwrap themselves from Phainon, not wanting to let go completely just yet.

"You're going to have to let me go eventually, Mydei," Phainon says softly, his eyes roaming all over Mydei beneath him. He's so hard it's all he can feel, the throbbing between his legs made worse by the vision above him—Phainon's hair, flopping down around the curve of his cheeks and over his forehead, crowning him in a gentle halo from the sunset coming through the french doors leading to his balcony. It's enough light where they don't need to turn one on for now, and it bathes them both in a serene mixture of reds, oranges and delicate purples.

"I don't want to," Mydei says—again rather earnestly—and wonders where his brain-to-mouth filter has disappeared off to.

Phainon laughs, the sound bright and boyish. He looms over Mydei, his hands now either side of his head. He leans down and presses a kiss to the spot between his eyebrows. Mydei can feel his eyes soften as Phainon pulls back, and it's almost funny how that was the thing that finally makes him feel somewhat bashful and not anything else they'd done.

"I want you so much, I don't know where to start," Phainon confesses, his arms rigid as though he's been rooted to the spot. "I've… I've never been with a man before."

Mydei's eyebrow arches. "You can start by kissing me some more," He says resolutely, watching as Phainon smiles sheepishly at him with the double confession while his hand comes up to cup at Mydei's left cheek, the other brushing back his braid that's beginning to fray from a busy day. Mydei nudges up into the touch like a cat, making Phainon's eyes crinkle with fondness.

"Alright, okay," Mydei pats Phainon's side and drops his legs onto the bed. Phainon stands up straight and moves out the way so Mydei can sit up properly. "We'll take it slow."

It physically pains him to leave Phainon standing there looking slightly bereft without Mydei being beside him anymore, but he stupidly keeps his condoms in the bathroom cabinet considering how little use they tend to get nowadays. Actually, he's shocked that they're still in date when he grabs the box and checks, but they'll do for now. He's sure they'll fit Phainon—even if it might be a little tight around the base, these things can stretch. Mydei doesn't dare look at his reflection in the bathroom mirror as he walks past it and back out into his bedroom.

Phainon is on his bed, sitting up against the headboard, cushioned by his collection of pillows, and the sight stops him dead in his tracks, almost dropping the box of condoms when it sets in.

"Phainon," Mydei says through gritted teeth, trying not to stare blatantly at the way Phainon is lying on his bed. He has one foot planted on the mattress, and his other leg is splayed out as open as possible as he lazes back on his elbows.

Phainon raises an eyebrow at him, and Mydei doesn't miss the way the corner of his lips are threatening to curve up into a smirk. "What's wrong, Mr Kremnos? See something you like?" Phainon asks, voice deceivingly innocent.

"You…" Mydei begins, but he stops as he watches Phainon lay down properly so his legs can widen even further. His shorts in his position are so hiked up that he has a straight view of Phainon's briefs, the stark black colour of the material an intense contrast to his pale skin. His inner thighs look so soft, the skin there delicate enough that even the slightest touch may leave deep rooted marks. It makes Mydei's mouth water at that thought, and with all the possibilities as well.

"Me?" Phainon says, pointing to himself while a look of faux shock takes over his face. "What have I done now?"

Mydei clenches his jaw so hard his teeth ache with it. He breathes harshly out from his nose, his nostrils flaring. "Close your fucking legs."

Phainon can't hold back his cheeky grin at that. "Stop looking up my shorts then, Mydeimos." He says flatly, but his eyes are narrowed with a challenge.

Mydei doesn't reply—he can't, not if he wants to hold onto the last tiny shred of composure he has. He wants to treat Phainon gently for his first time with a man and go slowly—he remembers how daunting his first time was, and despite everything it feels like his first time right now all over again because of how much Phainon means to him. But seeing Phainon sprawled out like that, laid out like a feast waiting to be devoured… Well, Mydei wants to suck him off so bad he might be going a little crazy with it.

Mydei storms forward instead of answering when he realises that just from his rapt attention alone, Phainon's hips are twitching and his breathing has

quickened, he suddenly stops caring. Phainon is grown enough to say *no* or tell him to slow down or stop if needed. Because right now, Mydei *wants him*. He clambers onto the bed to kneel between Phainon's legs, only widening them further. The sudden intense stretch of his muscles makes Phainon whine, fuelling Mydei on even more. He quickly shoves the box of condoms into the back of his trousers pocket for later, for now, he wants to focus on Phainon.

He grabs under Phainon's knees to lay them over his thighs, staring down at Phainon's bare legs over his clothed ones; the action pulling Phainon even further down the bed so he's flat on his back and completely on display beneath him. His arms are limp by his head as though he doesn't remember how to move them anymore as he watches Mydei place his hands over his knees before slowly moving higher until his fingertips graze the hem of his shorts. Phainon's whole body jolts like a live wire, the muscles in his legs already contracting.

Mydei can see where he's hardened up again, and the material of his shorts is skimpy enough that it doesn't cover or hide much, not even the tiniest of twitches.

"Mydei, *fuck*— don't… don't tease!" Phainon whimpers, jerking his hips to try and get Mydei's hands to move higher.

"I've had to watch you almost everyday for months parade yourself around in these little things," Mydei replies, voice low and accusing. He can't tear his eyes away from his hands moving underneath the material, so close and yet so far away from where he truly wants to touch, and where Phainon wants him to touch too.

Phainon's cock jumps, making Mydei smirk down at him with a sarcastic pitying look.

"They're…" Phainon gasps quietly as Mydei digs his fingernails into the soft flesh of his thighs, raking them down and leaving little red lines behind. Phainon marks up so *easily*, so quickly, so prettily, that if by the end of this he isn't covered in Mydei's marks and bruises, he won't be satisfied. "They're my uniform." He finishes.

"Oh? And yet, somehow, you're the only one with shorts this tiny," Mydei says, pinching the thin skin of Phainon's thighs between his fingers. He wonders if he's being too mean or dominant for a moment, but the second he thinks it, Phainon is moaning loudly, unbidden and unrestrained as if it was shocked out of him. Phainon turns bright red, covering his mouth with the back of his hand to try and muffle the noise.

"No, let me hear you," Mydei says, waiting for Phainon to remove his hand from his mouth. When he does, he says: "Good boy."

Phainon moans even louder after he says that, hips canting upwards harshly and almost knocking Mydei back from the sheer force of his body reacting to those two words. Phainon scrunches his eyes up in embarrassment as he's not able to hide it, as though shame has descended upon him and he can no longer look at Mydei again because of it. Mydei won't have any of that, not if he can help it, so he soothes his hands over Phainon's thighs again, feeling them up as much as he wants now that he has the chance.

Phainon's hands twist up into his pillows, creasing the material from his tight grip and he's bitten his lips red raw from trying to keep his noises at bay.

"You can be loud, Phainon. I don't mind," Mydei holds Phainon's hips down as they suddenly buck up, another strangled noise coming out of his lips.

He waits until Phainon settles down again and flips one of his hands over so he can slide his forefinger under the elastic of Phainon's underwear, hooking his fingertip under the hem. He follows the curve down from the top of his thighs, all the way until he's brushing against Phainon's balls, where he lets the material go and pings it back into his skin.

Phainon yelps from the sudden twang, but the way his whole body trembles shows he doesn't dislike it. "P-please, Mydei… Let me touch you…"

"Hmm," Mydei ponders on it for a moment. "Not quite yet."

Phainon's head falls back into the pillows as he lets out an anguished whine at being denied. "I wanted to be nice, but you don't seem too interested in that," Mydei comments offhandedly. He kneads his palms over Phainon's legs, revelling at how much strength is hidden beneath his skin as he watches the muscles flex and shift.

"It's not *that*," Phainon sighs. "I just… like it when people—*you*—boss me about."

Mydei arches a curious eyebrow at that. "Good thing I'm used to bossing around unruly youths."

"Don't lump me in with your students!" Phainon counters, although he's laughing as he says it.

"Do you want me to take the lead?" Mydei questions. He's not opposed to it—he'd quite like it, in fact, showing Phainon how to touch him, how to prepare him, how to *fuck him*. He gulps down the pooling saliva in his mouth at the thoughts.

"I just want you to do something! Why do we still have clothes on?" Phainon whines, attempting to sit up so he can wrestle himself out of his hoodie and pull his t-shirt over his head. Mydei reaches over to help, chucking the pieces of clothing somewhere across the room.

Mydei doesn't get much time to appreciate Phainon's naked torso when hands shoot out to begin undoing the remaining buttons of his shirt. Mydei tries his best to help out, but Phainon smacks them out of the way so he can get it done quicker. Phainon sits up properly then, eyes laser focused and his tongue sticking out slightly in concentration as he wrenches the shirt over and off his shoulders. He throws it in the general direction of where his own clothes went, joining his hoodie and t-shirt on the floor in a heap.

Phainon's hands immediately come up to his chest, cupping his pecs and squeezing them. Mydei gasps and jerks, gripping onto Phainon's wrists to steady himself from the sudden stimulation.

"These look even better than I remember," Phainon says in awe, watching as the flesh pools between his fingers as he squeezes them again. He grips even harder, clearly desperate to see how much he can hold in his palms. The action catches and pinches Mydei's nipples tightly between the joints of his fingers until they harden with the attention.

Before Mydei can say anything, Phainon shoots forward, almost folding himself in half so he can latch onto Mydei's right nipple. Mydei exclaims in shock, head falling forwards until his nose is pressed into the crown of Phainon's head. He inhales quickly, the scent of Phainon's sandalwood shampoo dredging his senses. He always smells so *good*, so masculine and strong that it makes Mydei want to eat him up. For now, though, Phainon swirls his tongue around, his teeth catching on the sensitive nub to worry it before he licks over it again.

Mydei's breathing speeds up, hands on Phainon's shoulders as if he's ready to shove him away when all he wants to do is bring him closer, to cradle him against his chest and allow the younger teacher to get away with whatever he wants to do. His chest is so *sensitive*, especially with Phainon's unabashed ministrations that are making him begin to tremble, his arms shaking and thighs weak at keeping him sitting up on them.

"Phainon," Mydei begins, his voice shaking. "Lean back and let me touch you too."

Phainon moans, the vibrations sending all sorts of signals through his entire body. Mydei mirrors the sound in tandem, fingers threading through the short hairs on the back of Phainon's head to yank him back. He looks *drunk*,

dazed and completely confused as to why he's still not sucking on Mydei's chest. His lips are red raw, tongue lolling out, eyes hazy and wet around the lash-line.

"Mydei…" Phainon whimpers, dragging out his name into a high-pitched whine that sends arousal shooting downwards, something behind his navel tugging.

"I *said* lean back," Mydei demands, taking his fingers out of Phainon's hair to shove at his shoulders instead. Phainon goes easily this time, flopping onto his back as his hair fans out across the pillows. He looks so angelic, face flushed and those beautiful blue eyes fixed solely on Mydei—he feels like he's on the top of the world, having this man in his bed.

Mydei swallows again as he tugs at the waistband of Phainon's dreaded shorts suggestively. Phainon nods enthusiastically, hair flopping into his eye before he shakes his head like a playful puppy. Phainon arches his back and lifts his hips, grabbing the sides of his shorts as he pushes them down until they hit mid-thigh, and Mydei does the rest by pulling them off and chucking them into the pile of clothing that's beginning to grow larger. Mydei's whole bottom jaw trembles when he sees Phainon clad only in his white socks and black briefs that, despite the dark colour, are clearly sodden where the tip of his cock is.

"C'mon, sweetheart, you can touch," Phainon goads, obviously relishing in how affected Mydei is.

Mydei glances between the smirk on Phainon's face and his briefs, and finally settles on his first course of action. He gets down onto his stomach, looping his arms around the tops of Phainon's thighs as he shoves his face right into his crotch so he can press his nose against his cock. Phainon shouts, the sound echoing in his bedroom, and he immediately threads his fingers through Mydei's messy hair for support.

Mydei lets himself be hauled in closer with the action, but he doesn't mind as he noses across the damp material and inhales the musky scent. He can practically already feel the weight of Phainon's big cock in his mouth, hot and heavy and delectable. Mydei wants it so *bad*, to peel off these tiny briefs and get his lips around the tip, licking the pre-cum up as it beads, cleaning Phainon up with quick, efficient swipes of his tongue. Instead, he opens his mouth so he can flatten the breadth of his tongue against Phainon's underwear, dragging a hot line up from the bottom of his shaft up to the tip, saltiness bursting across his tongue and making his mouth water as he swirls his tongue around the head.

"Mydei!" Phainon cries, his fingers tightening up painfully in his hair. His thighs are clenching so hard around Mydei's head that he feels like it's going to explode, but he carries on undeterred, wanting to taste him more and more until his tongue is numb and sore with the roughness of the cotton scraping against it. He untangles one of his arms so he can cup Phainon's balls at the same time he sucks at the tip.

"*Oh*, ah, n-no… Wait, I'll cum just from this!" Phainon exclaims, placing one of his palms against Mydei's forehead to push him away.

Mydei can't help the tiny pout forming on his lips as he's ripped away, but he backs off temporarily. He doesn't look at Phainon's face just yet, wanting

to watch the way his cock twitches and jerks beneath his underwear; clearly, he hadn't been lying about being close from that alone.

"What do you want then?" Mydei asks, voice husky and thick.

"T-take them off," Phainon stutters out. Then: "Please." He tags on at the end like an afterthought—a polite one, at that.

Mydei sighs and nuzzles one last time into the pre-cum and spit soaked underwear before he sits up to help Phainon gingerly take them off, careful not to let them scrape too much against his sensitive skin.

Mydei loses every ounce of breath in his body—he never considered that Phainon could get even more beautiful than he always is, but as his eyes trail over his bare body, he realises how wrong he'd been. He maps over everything he can—from his two tattoos in gold to his toned torso, between his pink pert nipples and down to the low deep cut of his pelvis, finally landing on his bare cock that's curved up enticingly against his belly.

Phainon shivers when Mydei shifts, his naked legs rubbing against the thick trouser material. Mydei smooths his hands over Phainon's legs again, partly to soothe himself and also just because he *can*. He doesn't think the novelty of being able to actually touch Phainon like this will ever wear off.

"What's your obsession with my legs?" Phainon asks, his breath hitching and muscles quivering right beneath his hands.

"They're very distracting," Mydei replies simply.

"I can tell. Can always feel you—*ah*—looking at them when we're together."

Something molten settles in Mydei's stomach at knowing that this whole time he was caught.

He realises then that Phainon's still wearing his damn socks. They've held up well against all his ministrations so far and not slid down his calves at all, but they've got to go. Mydei grabs one of Phainon's legs, hoisting it up to rest on his shoulder. Phainon looks feral, eyes wide and lips parted as he pants out staccato breaths, waiting to see what Mydei will do. The new angle doesn't even cause him the tiniest bit of strain, not a tremble going through his limbs at it.

Mydei wants to take his time with this. He slowly drags the sock down his leg, watching as more and more pale skin is uncovered with each inch until it's all bunched up at his ankle. He pulls it off the rest of the way and repeats the same process on Phainon's other leg until from head-to-toe, he's completely naked.

He doesn't put Phainon's leg back down just yet. He catches Phainon's gaze as he nuzzles into the inner dip of his ankle, nipping and sucking at the thin skin there. Phainon's leg only now begins to shake, but he remains silent, his eyes like the sun's rays as he watches Mydei swirl his tongue around the area suggestively. He works his way up the rest of Phainon's leg, taking his

time repeating his actions with each inch until he's reached his knee, a litter of red marks left behind in his wake.

"What are you waiting for?" Phainon asks, patience finally running out with Mydei worshipping his legs. He tries tugging it off his shoulder, but Mydei just wraps a hand around his calf to stop him.

Mydei hums, rubbing soothing circles over a random patch of skin with his thumb. "There's no rush. I haven't done this in a while."

"Haven't had sex in a while?" Phainon asks, head tilting to the side cutely.

"Yes," Mydei responds. He chuckles, maybe a little sadly. "Haven't had the time nor found the person I wanted to spend time with."

"Hey," Phainon says gently, reaching his hand out to cup Mydei's cheek. It's sweet, even if Phainon's palm is sweaty, he doesn't mind it. "We're here now. *I'm* here now. And you won't need to worry about finding the right person ever again."

"Because it's you," Mydei replies, and it isn't a question. It's an answer. Because it *is* Phainon, and he never wants to live in a world where they're apart from now on.

"Exactly!" Phainon beams at him, patting him softly on the cheek before withdrawing his hand. "Now, can we get on with it or should I leave you and my legs alone for a while longer?"

"Be quiet," Mydei scorns, but there's no heat behind it.

Phainon groans with petulance and wraps his fingers around his cock in retaliation, but he doesn't get a chance to do anything as Mydei immediately bats away his hand and replaces it with his own. He almost feels bad when he sees it—so red it's almost purple—and he's been leaking so much over his stomach that it's created a pool of clear liquid in the divots of his abs.

"You were complaining, but it looks like you were having fun," Mydei says, a smirk appearing on his face as Phainon yelps at his touch, hips shuddering as shivers wrack through his body. Mydei circles the tip with his thumb, relishing in the pained cries Phainon lets out.

"Wait! Stop!" Phainon slurs, but he doesn't try to shove Mydei's hand away.

"First you were telling me to hurry up, now you're telling me to stop?" Mydei asks flatly, raising an eyebrow at him as he slicks the new pearl of pre-cum down his shaft to make the slide even easier. "Is this all it takes for you to cum? A few kisses and light touches?"

"S-shut up," Phainon sniffs. "I'm usually a way better lay than this, it's just __"

Mydei cuts him off when he squeezes his cock at the base.

"Just what?"

"*Gods*, you're mean," Phainon laughs breathlessly. "Just… I have a very beautiful, stunning man in front of me touching my dick and I'm *not* supposed to cum within two seconds?"

Mydei feels his cheeks redden at the compliments. "What do you want me to do then?"

"I wanna—" Phainon also somehow goes even redder. "I dunno… *fuck you* sounds a bit crass, but then making love sounds a bit… ah…"

"Since when did you care about having any sense of decorum?" Mydei questions, rolling his eyes when Phainon splutters out a *hey*! in reply. "You can fuck me, Phainon. Or make love to me, if you'd rather."

"Let go of my dick then so we can get you naked," Phainon says, making grabby hands at him.

Mydei's lips twist into something not quite a snarl and not quite a smile either. "Okay," He says, and lets go, letting Phainon's cock slap against his

belly so he can stand up at the end of the bed. His eyes darken as he watches Phainon immediately reach for it again to give it a few loose strokes, but he doesn't say anything further.

His knees protest at finally being stretched out again, but he ignores them in favour of unbuckling his belt and then undoing the button and fly of his trousers. He takes his underwear off at the same time, not bothering to fold and put them away, but he grabs the box of condoms from the back pocket and chucks them onto the bed next to Phainon. He glances at them quickly and then goes back to staring at Mydei, eyes blown out so much that they're almost all black with a tiny ring of blue around them, his lips parted as he pants through his mouth. Phainon's hand curls around the base tightly when his eyes land on Mydei's cock. It stands proudly between his legs, red and swollen, the tip damp from leaking.

"I can finally see all of your tattoos," Phainon says breathlessly, "They're so pretty."

"Hm," Mydei doesn't thank him, instead nodding.

"And they really do reach all the way down, huh…" Phainon's eyes rake over him, leaving burning hot trails in its wake. Mydei shivers, the cool air of his bedroom contrasting with the heat from his body and the predatory look that Phainon is giving him right now.

Mydei gets onto the bed, crawling until he's straddling over Phainon's waist. He places his hands flat on Phainon's chest, feeling his pecs beneath his palms. He digs his fingernails into the skin there, raking down a few

centimetres just to see red marks bloom in its place. *Gods*, Phainon really does mark easily. Phainon gapes up at him while he's on his back, starkly reminding Mydei of the day he helped Phainon clean away the mats in the P.E hall.

Phainon looks even better than he did at that time—he's completely covered in sweat, rivulets of it sliding down his skin that makes Mydei want to lean down and lick it up. Phainon isn't looking at his face, though, but at their cocks lined up next to each other. Mydei isn't small by any means, but the new position gives a clear view to them both of how much bigger Phainon is.

"Gods, Mydei, look at you," Phainon says in awe as if he's in a trance, raising his hands to place on the curve of Mydei's waist. He closes his eyes so he can take a deep breath, and when he opens them again, he's looking directly at Mydei—even if Phainon's hands weren't pinning him to the spot, his gaze alone would've done it.

"You're so hot, gods, so—" Phainon continues to mumble under his breath compliments and curses, the words coming out so fast and jumbled that Mydei can barely understand what he's saying.

Mydei unconsciously begins to move at the words, preening and encouraged by them. He shuffles further up so he can sit directly over Phainon's cock, rocking back on it as it slips between his ass cheeks. The slide is easy with the slick covering his length, and they both moan loudly at the same time. Phainon has to clutch at Mydei's waist harder in panic to make sure he doesn't move anymore.

Mydei can feel his gaze change—it's still smouldering hot, but now it's mixed with curiosity as he stares at his hands cupped over Phainon's pecs. Mydei grabs onto them so hard he knows there'll be little crescent moon indents pressed into them, but he feels like a man possessed as he looks between the sun motif and the thin golden half-circle tattoos and then Phainon's chest. He kneads and massages at them like a cat trying to get comfortable, but all he's really doing is working Phainon up even more. He can barely catch his breath, as every time Mydei gets the angle just right over his nipples, it seems as though shooting zaps of pleasure go down his spine until he's writhing underneath him, arching up into the touch.

Phainon's cock is still nestled between his ass cheeks too, and he's pretty sure that the younger teacher is so wet that they won't even need lube later considering how much he's leaking.

"Mydei, what—"

Mydei's carnal thoughts overcome him, and he reaches up to his own chest, pushing his pecs together until a deep crevice in the middle forms. "Do you think you could fuck me here, too?" He asks, almost offhandedly with how flat his voice comes out.

Phainon stares up at him with wide eyes, watching as Mydei catches his shocked gaze and tilts his head in askance. He breathes deeply through his nose, eyes shuttering closed, and he counts from one to five under his breath before switching their positions suddenly. He slams Mydei back into the mattress, holding his wrists above his head as he looms over him.

"If I wasn't so desperate to fuck you, I'd do whatever the hells you wanted."

Mydei's mouth gaped, his eyes rounded at the sudden change in Phainon, but the other continues:

"I'd make it so you wouldn't be able to walk for the next week, or fuck your tits until they're sore and swollen, and I'd spend every single minute of every single day taking you apart from here…" He lets go of Mydei's wrists with one hand, but keeps them pinned with the other. He drags his fingertips featherlight down the line of his arm, watching ripples of goosebumps follow his path until he settles his hand at the base of Mydei's throat where he's bound to feel his pulse jack-rabbiting beneath, "To here…" Phainon keeps moving his hand—down, down, down—over his pert nipples, across the swell of his chest, over every notch of his abs until he rests his palm over the concave of Mydei's stomach from where he's breathed in so deeply and held it. "And then here, too."

Phainon smirks at Mydei's stunned silence and leans in, getting right up in his face. "Do you understand?"

"Yeah," Mydei croaks out. He wets his lips, "Yes."

"Great!" Phainon brightens immediately, patting Mydei on the stomach lightly. "What should we do next?"

"If you want to *fuck me*," Mydei begins, "Then you're going to have to prep me."

"I can do that," Phainon says quickly, sitting up to attention like some kind of boy scout. "I can definitely do that!"

Mydei huffs a laugh and rolls over to reach his bedside table, opening the drawer swiftly. It's a bit of an awkward angle, so he rifles around blindly until he finds the bottle of lube he keeps in there. He lies back and hands over the bottle to Phainon, blushing when the younger teacher raises his eyebrows at the half empty state of it.

"What." Mydei says flatly.

"Nothing! I just…" Phainon laughs oddly. "You get a lot of use out of it?"

Mydei purses his lips and kicks Phainon in the side, making sure it clips him rather than full on lodges into his stomach. "Yeah, on my own. I haven't slept with anyone in a while."

"Oh," Phainon says blankly. "Me neither."

"To which bit?"

"I haven't slept with anyone since I moved here."

It's Mydei's turn to raise his eyebrows now, curiosity spiking. "You came here over six months ago, though."

Phainon goes red. "Well, I was too busy pining over my best friend slash co-worker, so…" He shrugs, flipping open the cap to the lube. "Never really had any interest in seeking it out with anyone else."

Mydei smirks, although he can't help the way his elation grows at the title of *best friend*. He hopes now that they're more than that. "So you were waiting for me?"

Phainon swats him affectionately on the thigh, but he looks shy. It's sweet. "Yeah, yeah, whatever helps inflate your ego the most."

Mydei sighs and relaxes into the pillows, spreading his legs outwards and shifting his hips. Phainon gulps audibly, hands shaking where they're gripping onto the lube like a lifeline.

"C'mon then, show me what you've got." Mydei says, tucking his hands under his knees as he brings them up to his chest, no hesitance or embarrassment in sight.

It's worth it with the way Phainon gapes at him, eyes growing wider and mouth dropping at his new exposed position. Mydei has to bite down on the inside of his cheek as to not laugh because he's slightly worried it'll leave

him winded if he does. It's not exactly the most comfortable position to be in, after all.

"S-sure," Phainon stutters, and takes his gaze off of Mydei's ass to shakily pour lube out onto his fingers. He frowns, "This stuff is cold."

"Warm it up between your fingers," Mydei guides, nodding as Phainon follows his instructions. "Start with one finger," He says, watching while Phainon shuffles closer to him, placing his clean hand on his shin while the other drops lower, his fingertip prodding at Mydei's entrance.

Mydei shivers, swallowing quickly as saliva pools in his mouth. He's already excited, he can't lie, not with the way his body is reacting just from having Phainon look at him like he's the best thing in the entire world and having his hands on him and finger almost—*almost*—inside of him.

"I'm not some delicate flower," Mydei grouses when Phainon doesn't make a move after a moment.

"I know! I know, I just don't wanna hurt you, or make you uncomfortable."

"It's a finger in my ass, Phainon. I've done it plenty of times before," Mydei replies.

"Huh? But you haven't—"

"Just because I haven't been with anyone for a long time doesn't mean I don't have fun on my *own*, HKS," Mydei spits out, arching his back to try and get more of Phainon's finger inside of him. "This morning, I—"

Phainon splutters and presses the entire length of his forefinger inside in one swoop, making Mydei tense slightly at the sudden intrusion and cutting off the rest of his words. It doesn't hurt, it's just *odd* for a moment before it settles in. "There we go," Mydei encourages gruffly, clearing his throat afterwards.

"You're so *hot*," Phainon says, sounding slightly pathetic, and he grabs underneath Mydei's left leg to place it over his shoulder, kissing at his calf and nosing over it a few times sweetly.

It tickles, and Mydei shivers lightly in response. "Put another one in."

"*Bossy*," Phainon retorts, but he listens and slides another one in slowly, taking time to scissor them inside and swivel his wrist.

"*Ah*, there—" Mydei cuts himself off with a moan as Phainon's fingers brush against his prostate. He's so sensitive there it's almost embarrassing, his cock jumping on his stomach as Phainon grins at him.

"Now what did you do this morning?" Phainon asks, not stilling his fingers as he drives them in and out, the wet lube squelching with each thrust.

Mydei shakes his head, words failing him as Phainon's pace picks up, scraping his sensitive insides perfectly each time. It's still only two fingers, but he's already so relaxed and ramped up at the same time that he wants to shove Phainon away and take his cock in one go.

"N-nothing," Mydei answers eventually, hips undulating to meet every push and pull of Phainon's fingers working him open.

"Tell me," Phainon breathes out. "Or I'll stop."

"No!" Mydei exclaims, eyes wide in shock at the threat. "Don't stop, don't —" *leave me*, is what he wants to say, but can't quite bring himself to.

Phainon hums, slowing down the pace.

"I—" Mydei scrunches his eyes shut briefly before opening them again, staring right at Phainon. He's *beautiful*, he really is. His white hair is slightly matted to his forehead now with sweat, the little tuft of it in the centre still sticks up cutely though, swaying as he moves his shoulder in tandem with his hand and fingers. He practically shines, especially with the way he's flushed all the way down to his chest, his pale skin glowing with it. Mydei wants to kiss him everywhere, let his hands glide over the planes of his body and memorise everything that he can and keep it hidden away in his brain. "I already fingered myself this morning. In the shower. While— while thinking of you."

"What?" Phainon sounds shocked, in awe, and his face opens up like a petals in bloom as though he's been told impossibly good news.

Mydei's restless now, tightening up and wriggling on the fingers inside of him. "You think not seeing you for so long was easy for me? It made everything worse, and I didn't even know that was possible." He reaches out and grabs onto Phainon's wrist in between his legs, pushing and pulling his fingers in and out by himself, as if to show Phainon exactly what he did this morning on his own. "I— I wanted you so bad and I couldn't even *see* you."

Phainon whimpers, eyes going all shiny and wet, and he removes his fingers so he can swoop in and kiss Mydei. He drinks down each and every whimper and moan that pours out of him, and Mydei hopes that he can feel his apologies, his love and his promise he'll never do anything like that again through the kiss. Mydei winds his arms around Phainon's neck, hauling him in even closer even though it makes him wheeze slightly from the way Phainon is pushing down on his still-bent leg up into his stomach and chest. He doesn't care; the kiss is slow and decadent, a moment of quiet between them as they revel in each other's presence and feel each other. Mydei feels every second and minute and long, arduous hours of what he thought was futile pining pour out and wash away, cleansed by the gentle waves of Phainon's affection.

Phainon gives him one last press of lips and pulls away, looking down at him with warm eyes and a soft smile. His hair is framing his face, the sun long set by now but the moonlight is keeping them company instead. It reminds him of the night at the beach, where the moon was their only witness as they shared their first kiss—and this time, it bares witness again, but now with all their feelings out in the open.

"I love you," Phainon says, nudging his nose against Mydei's.

Mydei nods once, firmly. "I love you, too."

Phainon brightens up then, beaming impossibly wide at him. "Are you tired now? Maybe you should wine and dine me instead tonight…"

Mydei scowls at him, smacking the back of his head. "Don't you even *think* about it!"

"Alright, alright," Phainon grins, giving Mydei a quick kiss before he gets hit again for teasing. Mydei starts chuckling when he pulls away, and Phainon grabs the bottle of lube that he'd discarded earlier so he can reapply it to his fingers that've gone a bit dry.

"You don't even need to bother," Mydei drawls as though he's starting a bet, a challenge. He stretches out his body while Phainon fusses with warming up the lube again, but despite his own words, he spreads his legs so Phainon has access to do as he pleases. "I can take you, easy."

"I see," Phainon says, circling three lubed fingers around his entrance. "But did you consider that I'd still want to?"

Mydei scoffs, "Pervert."

"You're the one spread out over his own bed right now, leaking all over yourself when I've barely touched you."

Mydei growls at him, kicking him in the side—this time making sure it lands. "Be quiet, HKS!"

With that, Phainon pushes all three fingers inside him in one swift movement. Mydei can't help but react like he'd just shoved his whole cock in dry—he yelps, his hole tightening up instantly so Phainon can't get them in any further than the second joint.

"How are you supposed to take me when you're struggling with three fingers?" Phainon comments languidly, pushing them in further even against the resistance he meets.

Mydei moans, long and drawn out, head lolling back into the pillows as he feels so *good*, nice and full—but not too full, not like he knows he'll feel when he finally gets Phainon's cock inside of him. Phainon's knuckles rest flush against his skin, and he breathes in and out low and deep when Phainon drags them out slowly, making sure he can feel every bump and ridge of his fingers on the way.

"Gods, Phainon," Mydei pants out, "Please— please just fuck me, I'm ready, I am, I promise, I swear—"

"Shush," Phainon coos at him, smoothing a hand over somewhere on his body that he can't quite pinpoint, every point of contact flaring up with pleasure. "When I'm done, you'll get what you want."

Mydei whines, pitchy and broken at the threat, the *promise*, so he eases up into the feeling of Phainon's thick fingers inside of him the most that he possibly can. He wants to show that he's ready, prove that he can take whatever Phainon dishes out. He'll always meet him half way, always show himself, always prove that he can handle it.

Phainon barely grazes against his prostate, but it's enough to throw his head back into the pillows again, the tendons in his neck jumping. Phainon can't seem to get enough, playing with Mydei like he's a toy—every touch, every caress, every movement earning him a full body reaction. Mydei feels himself becoming addicted to it, mourning every time Phainon pulls his fingers out right to the tips before he plunges straight back in, not giving him a moments worth of peace or the chance to breathe in fully.

"*Oh*, do that again," Mydei pants out mindlessly.

Phainon obliges, using more intent this time around. Mydei is riding his fingers at this point, half out of his mind with pleasure that he can't control the way his body moves nor the sounds that are pouring out of him. Phainon leans forward over Mydei's body, pressing his folded legs into his chest with his weight. Mydei wheezes from the strain and peers at him through bleary eyes, accepting Phainon's open mouthed kisses easily. Phainon removes his fingers slowly, pulling back from their kiss just so he can peer downwards and watch as Mydei's empty hole clenches around nothing.

Mydei catches Phainon's cock twitching in response and snorts, "That get you worked up?"

"*You* get me worked up, Mydeimos," Phainon answers truthfully, grabbing the base of his cock and squeezing it. "I think I might cum the second I'm inside of you."

"What a let down," Mydei bemoans. "All that between your legs and it can't do anything?"

Phainon groans pitifully, "Don't be mean, that gets me worked up too."

"You really are a pervert," Mydei says, reaching over to swipe his fingertip over the head of Phainon's cock. He smears pre-cum over it and pops his finger in his mouth, licking up the salty taste. "Remind me to suck you off one day."

Phainon makes a sound as though he's been physically punched in the stomach, "Whatever you want, sweetheart," He says, although his voice is trembling as he speaks.

Mydei grabs the box of condoms that are next to him and ponders on them for a moment before chucking them onto the floor.

"Hey!" Phainon exclaims. "Aren't we—"

"I'm clean," Mydei states. "Are you?"

"I— I mean, yeah, I am, but—"

"Then I want to *feel* you," Mydei says, and his fingers dance lightly over his stomach, just above where his cock is lying curved up there, still hard and oozing pre-cum. "Want to feel you here."

Phainon gapes at him and puts a hand over his forehead, laughing almost hysterically. "Mydei, you really can't keep saying stuff like that!" He squeezes the base of his cock again as though starving off an orgasm.

"Hmph," Is all Mydei says in response, but there's a cruel smirk playing at his lips as he watches Phainon shudder.

Phainon wets his lips and grabs the lube, squeezing out plenty onto his fingers so he can slick himself up. "Are you sure?" He asks.

"Very," Mydei replies simply.

"Okay," Phainon says, lightly running a fist over his cock as to not stimulate himself too much, but coat it generously in lube. "It's so cold…" He whines,

shivering slightly. His skin must feel so hot to the touch, especially his cock where it throbs red.

Phainon finally—*finally*—lines his cock up at his entrance. Mydei's eyes roll into the back of his head immediately just from the pressure, biting down on his bottom lip so much that it hurts. Phainon waits, watching Mydei until he nods to signal that he can start. Phainon pushes against his rim, watching it give easily around the tip. Mydei moans, deep and long, half in relief and half in slight pain from the stretch. Phainon's fingers felt good, but they're nothing compared to his cock. Phainon begins rubbing soothing circles with his thumb on Mydei's hip bone, which makes him relax enough that the head fully pops in. Mydei gasps, his back arching upward sinfully.

"Fuck!" He curses, adding more and more expletives as Phainon continues to move in, the slide of it slick and easy despite the resistance. He's sweating so much that he can feel it gathering at his lower back and between his collarbones, some even sliding down his temples from having his arms wrapped around Phainon's neck like a lifeline, not daring to let go and wipe it away.

Mydei shifts his hips when Phainon is fully seated, his breathing thin and wispy, drool pooling in his mouth and dribbling out the corner of his open lips. He's already seeing stars and Phainon's barely done anything but slide his cock in all the way, not even having started moving properly.

"Are you—"

"Keep going," Mydei cuts him off, panting, his voice breaking half way through. He turns his head to the side and buries it into the pillow, eyes scrunching shut. The grip around Phainon's neck becomes lax, loose, his palms beginning to sweat that it's hard to keep a hold. He lets go, arms flopping down beside his head and instead twists his fingers into the soft material there, and he wonders what he looks like—if his hair is fanned out across the pillow in a mess or somewhat artfully, if his skin is as flushed as it feels so much so that Phainon wouldn't be able to tell his tattoos apart from his skin, and if his eyes are full of tears as he blinks them open against the fuzzy overlay. "Keep fucking me."

"Oh, Mydei, *gods*—" Phainon moans, and doesn't waste anymore time, obeying Mydei's demand. He thrusts in and out, unforgiving each and every time. It punches little noises out of Mydei, gasps and whines tumbling out of his lips that are drowned out by the slapping of their skin.

Mydei feels dizzy with it—the humid air between them is so dense it's like there's no more oxygen in the room at all. All he can think about is how good he feels, how good he's making Phainon feel by just laying there and letting the other do all the work, all bar an occasional squeezing of his hole that makes Phainon's hips stutter and his moans come out broken.

Phainon leans in, looming over Mydei as he winds his legs loosely around his hips, crossing them over his lower back. He arches his back up to meet Phainon's awaiting lips until he drags a wet kiss over his cheek, down his jawline and even further down to his neck, nipping and biting and sucking as he goes, mouthing over the marks he's leaving as if to soothe the sting.

Mydei whines like he can't get enough, pinned between Phainon's cock and his mouth. Phainon slips a hand that isn't holding him up in between their

chests, smoothing his thumb over a nipple. Mydei moans so loudly his voice cracks with it, and he seizes up so tightly around Phainon's cock that it brings his orgasm to the front of his mind.

"Mydei, Mydei— *Mydeimos*," Phainon chants into his neck, as if that's the only thing in his mind and he can't bear to say anything else right now.

Mydei reaches up with shaky arms and drags his nails down Phainon's back, knowing his leaving scores behind. Phainon bucks into him, smashing their lips together as his back undulates and shivers with the scratches. "You feel so fucking *good*, Mydei— Do that again—"

Mydei hums and caresses Phainon's back sweetly before he digs his nails in again and pulls them down, possibly even drawing blood in some areas with how deep it feels. Phainon doesn't yell in pain, but in pleasure, nuzzling into Mydei's neck cutely, sinking his teeth into the crook there like a mating bite. It makes pleasure zing and sparkle across his skin, his brain whiting out as his cock fills and twitches, and he wants to cum so badly that he'll do almost anything to get there.

"You're taking me so well, sweetheart," Phainon says softly, kissing back up his neck and slides their damp lips over each other but never truly kissing him, both of them panting hotly into each other's mouths instead.

"Feels— feels so good—" Mydei whimpers, his teeth practically chattering he can barely speak, but he hopes Phainon can fill in the blanks for him. Mydei presses his palm flat against his stomach and sighs dreamily as Phainon continues to fuck him, hips never slowing down or stopping, his

hole lax and wide around the girth. He feels as if he's not even on Amphoreus anymore, floating somewhere outer space. "I can feel you all the way here."

Phainon looks as though he's been struck by lightning, his pace shuddering to a stop as he squeezes his eyes shut and bites down on his bottom lip.

"What's—" Mydei never gets to finish his sentence because Phainon is on him again, biting and licking at his nipples with an intensity unrivalled. Mydei *wails*, his hands coming up to thread through his hair, tugging and yanking and yet simultaneously bringing Phainon even closer until his nose is smooshed up against his pecs. "Phainon, it's too much— I— I still haven't —" Mydei's speech is garbled as he tries to get his words out, but Phainon just picks up his brutal pace again as he bites down on the peaked nubs until all Mydei can do is cling to him as he cries.

Phainon eventually moves away from his ravaged chest, raking his eyes appreciatively over the purpling hickeys a few times as he straightens up, back to looming over Mydei. He feels bereft with the loss of Phainon mauling his chest and he tries to chase him, raising up onto his elbows and reaching out to grab him.

Phainon doesn't say anything, just gets this intense look in his eyes as he frames the base of Mydei's neck with his thumb and forefinger and uses the pressure to shove his head back down into the pillows so he's looking directly up at Phainon and nowhere else. It feels as though he has Mydei right where he wants him—pliant and focused. Mydei gazes up at him, eyes hazy and so, so trusting as he allows Phainon to slam back into him with his hand still on his throat. He's gasping for breath now—not because Phainon is cutting off his air circulation, but because the pressure alone is enough to

make his chest constrict and frantic pleasure flare. Mydei feels animalistic, eyes blown wide and drool smudging his lips and cheeks.

"There we go," Phainon says, almost too sweetly, too kindly, as he takes his hand away. He doesn't stop fucking into him, so hard that Mydei knows the impact points will be sore and bruised. But the way he's matching every single one of Phainon's thrusts, bucking up and squirming, he knows it'll be more like a trophy to him than anything else.

It doesn't take much after that for the pulling behind his navel to feel too much, his cock throbbing against his belly almost painfully despite being untouched and forgotten.

As though reading his mind, Phainon says: "Fuck, Mydei, I'm close," He gasps. He licks a stripe up Mydei's throat, tasting the salty tang of sweat and it's as though he can't get enough, suddenly parched and in need of more. He sucks more marks into the skin there until the amount of bruises rivals his clear skin.

"Touch me," Mydei begs, his own hand reaching down to feel his cock but Phainon beats him, grabbing onto his cock and he swirls his thumb around the tip. Mydei moans loudly, everything jumping to life, his orgasm so, *so* close, it's right there, right on the tip of his tongue as his stomach swoops dangerously and its coil tightening.

Then, as Phainon kisses him again, their teeth clacking and their tongues entwining messily, he digs his nail into his slit and that's it, it's enough—Mydei is *gone*. The heat between his legs peaks, and he's cumming, thick

ropes of it stripping up his chest and pooling on his stomach as Phainon works him through it with his fist. The sudden excruciating tightness and the noises and pleas of *more more more* are enough to make Phainon cum too, spilling into his tight hole as it convulses around him and milks out every drop.

Phainon flops down, still seated deep inside of him, as aftershocks ripple through the both of them, his hips twitching and thrusting slightly in and out of Mydei as a second thought. Mydei's whole body trembles with something other than pleasure—it's not anger, but it blazes through him and leaves him feeling jittery and shivery, and he's not exactly sure what it is. It completely consumes him until he can feel his body moving, but his brain doesn't feel like it's in control as he wraps his arms gently around Phainon's neck, pulling him in close until they're pressed chest-to-chest and hip-to-hip.

"Mydeimos—" Phainon says, but it sounds wet and thick, as if he's crying. Suddenly, Mydei feels panicked, and he's yanking Phainon's head back with fingers in his hair to see him, but the younger teacher won't budge.

"Phainon?" He asks gently, and then he feels a dampness gathering on his neck, Phainon's shoulders shaking. Mydei bites down on his own wobbling bottom lip, hiccuping a sob as his eyes well up and then they're *both* crying.

Mydei doesn't make a sound, barely even reacts as tears slide down the sides of his temples. He smooths his hand over the back of Phainon's head until it rests on his neck, and he gives it an encouraging squeeze.

"Are you alright?" Mydei asks.

"I am with you," Phainon replies, sniffling as he pulls back. *Oh*, how his eyes shine, even though it's with tears. He looks so pretty, all red and snotty and lips trembling as he cries silently.

Mydei's heart softens up completely and totally, irreparably and entirely. He feels it concave and open, fracturing as fissures begin to tear it apart at the sight. He tries to comfort Phainon as much as he can while it's all happening, but he feels as though his life has started anew.

"I love you," Mydei says because he can't think of anything else to say that will encapsulate his feelings in their entirety.

"Getting sentimental in your old age, hm?" Phainon replies, giggling when Mydei swats at the back of his head. "I love you too." He finally says after the laughter between them dies down. "I'm also gonna pull out now, so take a deep breath."

Mydei does as he's told and breathes in deeply, cringing slightly as the wet slide of Phainon's cock drags out of him, leaving behind it a flood of cum that seeps out. He feels strangely empty now, his gaping hole clenching around nothing as he wriggles his hips to try and figure it out. Phainon's fingers find his hole, pulling at the open rim of it as Mydei clenches, trapping the tip inside.

"What are you doing?" Mydei asks flatly.

"Thinking whether I have it in me to eat you out or to lick your stomach clean," Phainon says just as flatly, and Mydei's mouth opens in shock at how direct he is.

"Phainon!" He chastises, and goes to whack him with either his hand or foot but he realises that all his muscles have seized and he can barely move an inch without wincing.

"Shit, are you okay? Did I overdo it?" Phainon panics, hands coming up and waving about uselessly.

"You didn't *overdo* shit," Mydei snaps at him, sitting up gingerly as his back and thighs protest. "I'm fine."

Phainon sighs, "You don't need to lie to me, y'know? You can tell me if it hurts."

Mydei glances up at Phainon then, and realises that it's true. There's no need to hide anything from him anymore because they're—

Wait.

"Are you my boyfriend now?" Mydei asks, blushing up to the roots of his hair at how *juvenile* it sounds.

"Wh—" Phainon splutters, then laughs, and then subsequently stops laughing when he sees storm clouds take over Mydei's facial features. "Yes, Mydei, I was hoping… I was *really* hoping that we are boyfriends now. Or before, after we confessed. That's when I hoped we were boyfriends."

"Stop saying *boyfriends*," Mydei snips, but then he sighs, the fight leaving him. "Yeah, okay, we've been boyfriends since then."

"Yay!" Phainon exclaims, clapping his hands together once as he beams at Mydei. "Now that's all sorted, can I please help my *boyfriend* get all cleaned up?"

Mydei rolls his eyes and clambers out of bed, his knees almost giving out the moment he stands. He flops back down onto the bed, blinking owlishly at how weak he feels. "Phainon—"

"I'll do it," Phainon says, chuckling as he gets up off the bed. He presses a kiss into Mydei's temple before asking: "Where's your bathroom? I'll get us a wet flannel. It'll do for now while you… um, can't walk…" Phainon trails off, scratching his cheek sheepishly.

"I have an en-suite, it's just through that door," Mydei says, pointing to the half closed door across the room. Phainon nods and sets off, and Mydei appreciatively wracks his eyes down over his back, watching his plump ass

bounce with every step. Now *that* he can't see when Phainon is wearing shorts.

He smiles to himself privately and shuffles back onto the bed, cringing at the wet spot. It's probably ruined his sheets for now, but nothing a few washes won't fix. He watches as Phainon reappears with a white flannel that's dripping with warm water slightly, and he clambers onto the bed so he can situate himself in between Mydei's aching thighs once more. He gently swipes the flannel over his legs, washing away the sweat there as he wipes down the drying cum on his belly and chest.

"We're definitely going to shower later," Phainon vows as he finishes up cleaning Mydei of any sweat and cum for now. "Nap first, though?"

Mydei nods, his eyelids already feeling heavy as sleep begins to seep in through the edges. Phainon gives himself a cursory wipe with the other side of the flannel for now before he chucks it onto the bedside table. He gathers Mydei up in his arms and gets them under the covers where there's no wet spot to ruin their sleep. Mydei snuggles into him without hesitation, the smell of his laundry detergent lingering thinly on Phainon's skin after using his flannel. He smells so good, with the mixture of sandalwood and citrus.

"I hope you don't snore," Mydei says, his words slurring as he fights against the tide of sleep.

"I do—" Mydei glares at him, although it feels as scary as a kitten doing it. "—Not." Phainon finishes.

"Good," Mydei says, nuzzling his face into the crook of Phainon's neck, breathing him in. "Then I won't need to kick you out of my bed."

"Hmm," Phainon begins. "I don't think you'd do that even if I did snore. You can't even lift up your arm right now."

Mydei realises his eyes are closed when he cracks open one eye, raising said arm to flick Phainon on the forehead. "Don't push your luck, pretty boy."

"Ooh, you think I'm pretty?" Phainon flutters his lashes at Mydei, who only rolls his eyes in return.

"Go to sleep or you're sleeping on the sofa, with no blankets."

"Mydei!" Phainon exclaims. "You *wouldn't*."

"No," Mydei sighs in contentment, drifting off to sleep as Phainon combs his fingers through his hair. "I wouldn't."

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Phainon is helping one of the students get down off the trampoline when he hears the doors to the hall swing open. He waits until she's safely on the

ground again and running off towards her friends before he turns around.

Mydei stands there, watching him with his arms folded. They grin at each other when their gazes meet, eyes shining. Phainon feels himself blush immediately, just the sight of his boyfriend alone is enough to make him giddy beyond belief. He can't leave his position where he's spotting the next student on the trampoline, but he waves at Mydei enthusiastically nonetheless.

A few students turn around to see who he's waving at, their faces turning surprised when they see their history teacher looking so happy.

"Mr Kremnos!" One of them shouts, which causes the rest of the class to look over as well.

Mydei rolls his eyes, untucking one of his hands so he can wave them off. "Don't mind me, I'm just supervising."

Phainon laughs. "You mean you're skiving off from doing paperwork?"

Mydei sniffs haughtily, pushing his glasses up the way he always does when he's been caught out but doesn't feel an ounce of shame for it. "No," He grumbles, some of the students laughing with Phainon at his reply.

"Don't set a bad example for the kids!" Phainon jeers. "Go back and finish your work, stop distracting me."

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "And let you lose track of time again? I don't think so."

"That was *one time*! Ages ago!"

The class burst into laughter, remembering the lesson from all those months ago—almost a year, at this point. The reaction makes Mydei's lips curl up at the edges. He glances around the hall, spotting a stack of chairs. Mydei walks over and pulls one off the top, making a show of placing it down so it faces Phainon. He flops down onto it, balancing his ankle on his other knee and folds his arms over his chest, giving Phainon a very satisfied look.

"Don't mind me. You've got…" Mydei obnoxiously flicks his wrist out so he can glance at his wrist watch. "Fifteen minutes left until they have to leave."

Phainon puts his hands on his hips and glares at Mydei from across the hall. "Fine. Kids, let's give Mr Kremnos a show."

They clear off of the trampolines so Phainon can get on instead. He heaves himself up onto one with minimal effort, knowing the easy display of strength is one quick way of getting Mydei interested. The students all crowd around the edges, resting their forearms or elbows on the blue padding as they get themselves situated to watch Phainon's routine.

Phainon tunes them out, his eyes never leaving Mydei's as he tracks him with every movement, every bounce and flip. He's showing off and he knows it, and Mydei knows it, too—but he wasn't joking when he said he wanted to give Mydei a show. He finishes it with a twirl midair, landing on his feet with his back arched and arms outstretched over his head in a flourish.

Everyone claps and cheers, and even Mydei stands up from his seat to join in the clapping.

"Well done, Mr Khaslana. Impressive as usual," Mydei compliments, and it feels as though nothing could ever weigh down his shoulders again.

Phainon grins, bowing in all different directions before he leaps down off the trampoline. He runs over to Mydei, telling the students as he passes they can leave early and go get changed.

Mydei's eyes are bottomless pools of heat as he watches him approach. Phainon knows he's flushed, hair a mess and is sweating, but Mydei looks at him like he's the only thing worth it in the world. Phainon peers around Mydei to make sure the coast is clear from any lingering students before he swoops down a few inches to smack a kiss on his lips.

Mydei looks so affronted by the action that Phainon bursts into laughter. "You're a menace," Mydei says, chuckling alongside Phainon.

"Hmm, I think you like it though," Phainon replies cheekily, his body swaying closer to Mydei's.

The gravitational pull he'd felt when they'd first met as their gazes locked across the hall, when all Mydei had been to him was an angry looming figure in the doorway, has never lessened and has only gotten stronger the more time they're together.

Mydei smiles at him as if reading his mind, and it's so impossibly soft, so full of adoration and wonder that Phainon knows he looks the exact same when he looks at Mydei too.

"Yeah, I do," Mydei replies. He reaches out his hand to entwine his fingers with Phainon's, not caring if anyone does happen to see.

Phainon squeezes his hand, holds on tight, and never lets go.

**THE END**

Chapter End Notes

> aaaand that's a wrap!!! i'm so proud of myself for finishing this one, it took so much longer than i expected and i even left the fandom half way in between writing and then came back again LMAOOOO gods what a mess. anyways, really hope you all enjoyed the big finale with their shouted confessions and then the sex at the end hehe. hopefully it was worth all the yearning and nonsense

i AM tempted to write a sequel for these two idiots, so if you'd be interested in that, lmk in a comment below!

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leave a comment and/or kudos if you enjoyed! thank you so much!!! each comment truly makes my day and motivates me to write more

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